Preconceptions and Perseverance

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Preconceptions and Perseverance

by Jezmatron

Summary

A new tenant has taken residence in the estate at Thaymor - and all the local families of quality are looking to impress.

The Moons, a family of minor gentry of the Etherian nobility, are among those who wish to make an impression, to secure happiness and security for their beloved daughters.

But this new tenant brings a friend, the curt and reserved Adam. And Catra, the willfull, stubborn and much loved daughter of Mr and Mrs Moon, finds herself, completely against her normal attractions, drawn to this.... man?

A tale inspired by the art of: @adooboo1 on twitter.

Here's the tweet that inspired this:

https://twitter.com/adooboo1/status/1308809251565875200

Notes

I am shamelessly riffing off of Pride and Prejudice for this. YES this is a sort of "prologue" chapter to test my skills and the water. I will deviate, of course, but want to have a fun, chatty story along the lines of Lizzie and Darcy but with a TWIST (of course!)

So yeah... this one will update slower than my other ones, if only because its style is SO markedly different, whilst I try to retain their voices.

An Introduction

It is a truth held to be so overt as to be universal that a woman is forever wanting a man with wealth. Likewise, that an unmarried man in possession of even a moderate fortune is in want of a wife.

Thus do the political spheres of the nation orbit and wheel, driving the gears of heritage and social mores.

Rarely acknowledged is that, occasionally, wealth is the mere byproduct and there is merely the aspect of a woman in want of another to mirror her. A countenance reflected in like and symmetry, akin to the sun and moon in their endeavours, but forever in one another's circle.

Of course, these facts, theories and auspices are not to be even catalogued this early; instead we must focus on the fact that, regardless of the mores of the souls involved, a community will take a record of notables entering their neighbourhood. These facts, such as they are, are so well fixed in the mind that it is assumed any eligible man is as yet unannounced property of one or more of the eligible women of said neighbourhood.

It was with all this in mind that Angella found herself accosted during her morning letters and land survey.

"My dear Mrs Moon," said her love, her light, her one and only, "I have auspicious news."

She glanced over from her stack of papers and the ordnance survey maps, then drew a breath slowly and gently queried, with a faint smile, that she was all ears.

"Have you heard that the Thaymor Estate is let?"

She acknowledged that she had not.

“And, sad as I am to relate this, dear Castaspella has heard the news before us!”

Mrs Moon quirked a smile but glanced back at her current correspondence briefly.

“Do you not wish to know the news?”

She turned in her chair, away from her desk, then smiled up at her husband, “”You wish to tell me, my love and I have no objections to hearing.”

Micah smiled fondly back at her and clapped his hands before him. His hair was drawn back in a ponytail and his beard was neatly trimmed - his countenance and bearing were poised, but he positively vibrated with excitement. He sighed briefly then spoke, “Well, you must know that Casta divined from Mr Lashor that Thaymor is taken by a young man from the west of Etheria. He, apparently, came down with a full carriage to review the property.”

“Indeed?” Angella nodded indulgently.

“Yes, quite! I have it on good authority that he was best pleased with the place and he agreed with Mr Harris and will take possession before the Solstice. Apparently, the servants are already likely to be in place before the weeks end!”

That got an approving inclination of the head from Angella, “Well now, that is definitely news of import. And the gentleman’s name?”

“Mr. Archer.”

“Hmmm. Single?”

“To be sure! And a man of suitable fortune,” he sighed, “What a fine thing for our girls!”

“How so? How can this affect them?”

“Oh dear, you can be most vexing. You must comprehend I have designs of him marrying one of them?”

Angella twiddled her thumbs and smiled, maintaining her raised eyebrows and effected an expression of surprise, “Is that *his* design on settling here?”

Micah waved a hand, “Design! How can you talk so? But love! Ah love, it is not beyond the bounds of possibility. And for that reason, you must visit him as soon as he arrives.”

“My heart, my love, my life…. I see no victory from that! Surely better for the girls to call upon him? Or even yourself. You are the handsome one afyer all…. Though this Archer might like you best of the party…” he made a mock scowl and Angella’s smile broadened. Micah gave a long suffering sigh and leaned across the gap to tap his wife on the knee

“You flatter me as always, my love. But for a man who has raised five such daughters… it does wear on one. No, I am not as well to do now, surpassed by my own girls! And of course, outshone by you.”

“Nonsense. Not that our girls are not wonderful. But you, my dear, always draw the eye!”

“So you will call upon Mr Archer?”

“It is more than I could trouble myself for. The girls are grown, independent….”

“Ah, but consider them! What advantage, what establishment for one of them! Castaspella is taking Perfuma for just such a reason!”

“There you have it! Casta is going! So, follow her example, my love.”

“You know as well as I do…. That Casta does not have a... partner to accompany her.”

Angella smiled faintly, "Indeed not. You aren't scandalised by that are you? Still?"

"Well, it is…. Not as expected."

"The young women at the old rectory do not surprise you so much anymore."

"Spinnerella is… yes she is good company for Bridge. As is her… Friend", Angella smiled and rolled her eyes, and Micah chuckled, "You *know* I care not for that. Love is love… I just… Casta is a *single* mother, so must partake of all actions."

"So, why must I *partake* of a visit? I can write a missive, you may take it, providing carte blanche for any of the girls… save Frosta of *course* … should he find suitable appeal and they in him. Of course…" she winced faintly, "Catra may take some additional caveat… as well as persuasion."

Micah huffed, but not with irritation, "You worry overmuch. Catra is no better nor worse. She is… Catra."

"But she does share some… traits with your bridge partners, my love. That may make her *inimical* towards a marriage."

"Yes… well, she may have to… secure her future first, then consider her attachments second."

Angella couldn't help but smirk and covered her mouth, "My dearest, how scandalous to suggest our Catra both *obey* a stricture *and* then follow her predilections once secured! I scarce comprehend your turn here…" her smile became a cheeky smirk.

Micah swatted at her again, "My love, we are lucky. Many have…. Arrangements. We are in an enlightened age, to be sure. But you are belabouring the point!"

"If I am to barter for our girls, I must make an effort to sell them. They are headstrong, authoritative. A *challenge* for any man daring enough."

“How can you speak of our girls so, you vex my nerves, my love. No compassion!”

She snorted in response and swatted Micah back, “Not hardly, my dear. I learned long ago that yours are of *steel* . And my compassion for our girls goes beyond merely farming them off. I wish to see them *happy* .”

“Even if our own meagre finances dwindle?”

“Hardly meagre, my love. But, to ensure their contentment… yes.”

Micah reached across the gap and took her hand, “Capricious you are not, my love. I fear, should there be twenty such men as Mr Archer, we would see naught for you will not visit them,” his smile was teasing and Angella scoffed.

“I would visit them all to have that smile, my love. Also, a chance to finish my letters. Be assured, it is in my agenda. BUT I still think you are better presented to do the calling. You are always such a better first impression.”

Such a strange mixture: Micah Moon, with his gentle sarcasm and wry wit, along with a compassion and gentility that marked him as relatively unique among the landed men of the region. Angella, his beloved, a rock in a sea of changing gossip and household chaos that came with five young women; her care offset by her determination. Her certainty and sense of duty that pushed her to the fore of much of the region’s societal wrangling.

Their task was assured - to guarantee a future for their girls, as positive as they could make it, to ensure none met penury and disappointment.

A challenge beset by the very nature of their girls and their wilful disregard for propriety, decorum and any sense of normalcy.

Whilst Angella had every faith in her husband, she was well aware of his predilection for being *side tracked.* Or for wandering. His mind was attracted to the natural sciences and so, upon the following morning, with nary a sight of the man, Angella found herself pacing along the gravel pathway that led to their manor. A pair of serving staff stood by, awkward whilst the girls fretted over their clothing, whilst Angella fretted - she had every faith in her husband but now pondered whether she *should* have travelled to the Thaymor Estate to make the call. Either Micah would have gotten distracted or he would get enthused whilst there and might not be back for hours.

They were due to visit the local village of Brightmoon, which was on their estate - a minor affair by comparison to some, but still substantial to support their family.

Angella paused in her pacing to review her girls - a fine and wonderful collection as ever there was. The eldest, Mermista, with her brows pursed as if in intense thought, her arms folded as she regarded the gravel beneath her, the sun marking her teal dress like the shimmer of the ocean; Catra in her maroon dress with her thick boots clearly with a mind to wander as soon as her mother's attention was elsewhere; Entrapta with her nose in yet another journal, eyes glazed at the romance within. And young Frosta who glared at the servants as if personally affronted.

Angella frowned, "Dears… where is Glimmer?"

Catra bit her lip and coughed, "Um… well…."

Angella zeroed in on the girl, her own grey eyes fixed on the blue and gold of her daughter's own, "Yes?"

"She went on ahead," supplied Catra. Angella sighed.

"She doesn't wish to go to the village?"

Catra splayed her hands, her voice honeyed, "Of *course* she does, mama."

“And she asked you to cover for her?”

Catra grinned sheepishly. Behind her, Mermista smirked and rolled her eyes. Catra scuffed her boot, “I think… she wanted to maybe…”

“She’s still in bed.”

“She’s still in bed,” confirmed Catra as she melted under Angella’s fixed stare.

The tall woman sighed, then entered the double doors at the front of the mansion, then bellowed up the stairs, “ *Glimmah!* Get down here RIGHT now! If the other girls can muster the energy and poise, then you better bloody well do so too!”

Outside, Catra winced. That was likely one set of chores she now owed Glimmer. She was able to maintain her poise in *most* circumstances. But when fixed with the searchlight stare of her mother, nothing was achievable when consideration was given to falsehood.

A few moments later, with Angella rigid with irritation by the door, Glimmer emerged into the sunlight. She rolled her eyes at Catra, who managed a helpless shrug in return, then gestured to their mother.

For her part, their mother shot Glimmer a disapproving glance, “You may wish to apportion fault to your sister. She did *attempt* to waylay my suspicions, so do not fault her, Fault yourself, Glimmer. It is *important* we are seen, that we pay attention to our wards and charges.”

The recalcitrant daughter hunched and hiffed, her pink and blue dress and petticoats ruffled from the haste of dressing. Her hair was bedecked with purple and pink threads, to highlight the dyes she used. Angella spoke to them all about proper decorum, then turned. She was about to begin their walk when a figure appeared at the entry to the drive and began to saunter up. Catra smiled fondly and glanced at Glimmer.

“So, father looks smug.”

“Up to see the new fancy in his manor, so I heard,” vouchsafed her sister. She didn’t look impressed, “Another man for whom we must prance and fawn.”

“ *You* must dance and fawn, oh Sparkling one. I’m in no rush. Nor have I any particular desire to shackle myself to one of them. How *unsatisfying* . A shame no fair maid meets my exacting requirements,” hummed Catra.

Glimmer nudged her with a grumbled, “You are the *worst* ,” but she followed it with a fond smile, “And thank you for at least *trying* with mother.”

“Well, I’ll have to try harder next time.”

Truly, the pair were night and day - Catra’s caramel complexion in stark contrast to Glimmer’s paler skin, but not as defined as Mermista’s countenance. As mixed and marked a group as any in the region, yet none so beloved. Their familial connections not by blood, but by love and the determination and loyalty of their parents.

“My ladies! Off to the village?” Micah strode forth as his coattails trailed behind him, “Well, may i steal a moment of your time before you abandon me for greater things?”

Angella smiled and embraced her husband, which elicited a coughing fit from Frosta as she masked the work *gross* beneath her exhortations. Mermista slapped her hard on the back and Frosta wheezed. Micah chuckled and glanced past Angella, “I see the girls are in fine form.”

“Barring Glimmer’s attempt at truancy, I believe they are prepared for a morning’s exercise.”

“Well, I merely wish to inform you that a visitation has taken place. Good day!”

He bustled past and Angella blinked in surprise. Then, as one, the girls flooded after their father, exhorting for more information. Catra and Glimmer exchanged a glance, then followed the tide of women as they badgered their chuckling father.

Angella and Frosta were at the fore, chattering with questions, "So, what was his disposition? His contemplation of the possibilities?"

"Mr Archer is a fine gentleman… did you not have errands, my love? I feel as if I am keeping you?" smiled Micah. Angella huffed and shook her head, then waved at Mermista.

"Talk some sense into your father."

The tall girl pursed her lips, then shrugged, "Uhhhhhh, well, not that I *care* but… was he, at least, *polite* ."

"A gentler man I have not yet met, I must say," grinned Micah as he led his small coterie into the main drawing room. He flopped into his chair and reached for the gazette, but it was pinned in place by Angella's hand as she leaned forwards. Before she could speak, Entrapta flopped onto the floor in front of Micah's chair and pulled her gaze from her book, eyes wide.

"Does he have *passions* ? Hobbies? Was there *tiny food* ?"

Micah grinned and leaned forward, "Mr Archer, it appears, has a fascination with things mechanical, my dear."

"OHHHH! A partner perhaps! For exciting explorations of the *sciences* !" squealed the purple-locked girl. Her own clothing was more rustic, leaning towards *workmanlike* in its utility, a stark contrast to the rugged yet still presentable affairs of her siblings. Micah gently reached out and paused his hand near to Entrapta. She blinked and gave a faint nod and he patted her shoulder. She smiled, "I am the most mechanically able! Perhaps he will find me… suitable?"

"Mayhap, my dear. I think it is safe to say Mr Archer is a *gentleman* and deserving of a chance for *all* of you to engage upon."

Angella leaned back and sighed, "A relief. You did not tarry overmuch?"

"No, he is still in the midst of his relocation. A genuine fellow, however and a welcoming host. He also vouchsafed that he would be at the ball a fortnight hence. Perhaps an opportunity to formally introduce ourselves in a more strict setting?"

Angella arched an eyebrow, "Ever the socialite, Mr Moon."

He smiled up at her, "I merely learned from the best, my love."

At the rear of the room, Catra had sat and pulled her notebook from a side table. She began to idly sketch the scene before her - mother, ramrod straight, but smiling; Entrapta, sat at father's feet. Father, smiling up at his wife. A gentle scene. She glanced up as Mermista flounced into a chair next to her, "You seem… more vexed than usual."

"I am *not* vexed. I am *perturbed* ."

"Same difference, sister mine."

"I mean… I get why you and Glimmer are sick of these, but how do you think *I feel* . I'm eldest and *nothing* . You two, you don't *care* about love."

Catra sighed and lowered her notebook, then glared at Mermista, "I do care. I just don't care about love with a *man* . What do they have to offer?"

"Wealth, security, societal stability, duh… and the obvious," Mermista listed the options on her fingers and shrugged, "Plus…. Children," the eldest sister blushed faintly and shrugged. Catra snorted.

“That is hardly a list of positives, y’know? I can get that from a woman…”

“But… it’s *harder* Catra,” Mermista sat up and clutched her hand, “Yes, things are *better* now. But it’s still… difficult. We’re not the North, obviously, not as repressed. But, it’s a hard choice.”

Catra nodded curtly, “Then it must be worth making. Nothing worth having is easy.”

“Stop trying to persuade her. She’s made up her mind. And you know how she gets,” Glimmer sat on the chair’s armrest and draped an arm around Catra fondly, “Why shackle yourself to something just to make others happy?”

Mermista rolled her eyes and looked away, “Yeah… but what if it makes *me* happy?”

Her two sisters tilted their heads in sympathy. Glimmer spoke up, “It’ll happen, fret not. We *all* wish to marry for love, Mer,” Catra chuckled and Glimmer’s pointed gaze made her just shrug in response, “Those of us who *wish* to marry. This just all feels so forced. But maybe… maybe this Archer has a spare eligible man in his cupboards, should he not meet your fancy. Or if Entrapta doesn’t set fire to his home. ”

Catra snorted, “AH HA! Remember that time with Mr Lashor’s field?”

Mermista shook her head, “We said we would never speak of those events again.”

The sound of their laughter floated through the house, a merry sound to brighten an afternoon. Thoughts of village errands were forgotten, as discussion turned to the potential for eligible matches and the activity of the coming weeks.

A Gentleman Calls

Chapter Summary

Mr Archer receives another visitor.

A chance encounter in the woods for the young ladies.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Timing, as is so often posited among the learned class, is everything. Had Micah been a mere twenty minutes later in his calling, he would have chanced upon a second meeting that could have garnered further impressive information for his family. However, Micah, ever being an eager and enthusiastic sort, filled with love for his family, had made it a priority to call on Mr Archer early in the morning, as part of his morning constitution.

He had found Mr Archer to be an amiable fellow, a wit and gracious host. He had declined an extended luncheon invitation, begging his extensive family as a reason, but promised to return at a more agreeable time and with proper notice. He also extended an invitation for tea at Mr Archer's earliest convenience.

Mr Archer, being an agreeable soul, had answered that he would be delighted, but that he was expected in Elberon for the next weekend to finalise some familial affairs. However, he promised to visit the family a five days hence, to acquaint himself better with them and the area, the residents of Brightmoon Manor being well familiar with the environs, people and happenings of their community.

And thus, Micah departed, to be the bearer of auspicious news. He did note, upon his leaving the grand gardens of the Thaymor Manor that a rider approached at a sedate pace across the fields, but he paid it no mind - a bracing afternoon on horseback wasn't

an unfamiliar pastime and was even one he indulged in. A shame none of his girls were so enamoured of the activity.

And so, this was how Micah missed his first introduction, and perhaps perfect opportunity, to acquaint himself with one *Adam* De Gray.

Following the Mr Moon's departure, Mr Archer found himself with a morning free to pursue his favoured activity - archery. It was a rather archaic practice, considering the advent of the more advanced flintlock, but he felt moved to maintain the practice. He had several rational reasons for this, but primarily as it allowed him to indulge the fresh air. It was also one of the reasons he had acquired the rather daunting prospect that was Thaymor Manor

For one, the gardens offer ample opportunity for a range, moreso than his lodgings with his parents back in Elberon. Whilst he enjoyed the cosmopolitan bustle and the many *many* opportunities afforded a gentleman of means, he had felt himself unchallenged and, if he was truly honest, rather suffocated.

Being the near youngest of an eclectic collection of siblings had left him with few opportunities to distinguish himself; he was no academic, no great Officer of the military forces and opportunities within the clergy had not appealed.

And so, he had taken his not-insubstantial worth (4,000 a year, so the current local gossip ran) and had decided to make his mark. The grounds also had a number of vacant stables and outbuildings, which would allow him ample opportunity to indulge his other fascinations, which were seen as unbecoming of a man of supposed leisure. But here, in the countryside, among the working man and woman, such activities could be a *boon* rather than the oddity among the salons and cafes of Elberon.

With a spring in his step, Mr Archer walked from the tiled hallway and into the morning sunshine. His path led him to the main lawn, which was a vast affair, split from the main house by a small, ornamental garden made up of low hedges, topiary and flower beds. In all honesty, it was a calming place.

A bevvy of servants had established his range as per his morning request and he moved to remove his coat to hand to a waiting orderly.

After several warm up shots (All, he noted with no small pride, on target at one hundred yards) a voice jolted him from his focus.

"Beauregard!"

A figure advanced across the lawn, from the direction of the house. They paused momentarily to brush the gathered road dust from their cream jodhpurs, then swept forwards in blur of grey and red as their coattails billowed behind them. The approaching figure brought a smile to Mr Archer's face.

"ADO---" Mr Archer paused momentarily as he regarded his servant but he smoothly continued, "RRRM. ADAM, my goodness a *surprise* ! Your correspondence indicated at least a day hence before your arrival my friend!"

The figure drew nearer to reveal a set of mirthful blue eyes and hair cropped messily into a tousled mess. A face that seemed sharp, rather effete for a masculine countenance. That was offset by the rather solid build, which still seemed slight for the tall individual. They grinned at Mr Archer and glanced at the servant.

"I must confess, I found myself with little to occupy my mind. And my Aunt was pressing, once more. So, I thought it best to arrive ahead, before you summon your main party. Which, I assume, from the eagerness of your fathers, is imminent?"

"You called upon them?"

"I did indeed - I believe they are *still* awaiting a formal invitation!"

Mr Archer exhaled a rather ungentlemanly huff, “Upon my honour Adddd-AM. I have every intention of returning to Elberon to fetch the family. I explained as much to Mr Moon!”

The new comer arched an eyebrow, “Mr Moon?”

“A member of the local gentry and a most agreeable fellow!”

“And what was Mr Moon's rationale for such an early call?” the arched eyebrow graced Mr De Gray's face. Mr Archer laughed, then turned to the servant.

“Carlisle, would you be so good as to set up tea in the drawing room. Mr De Gray has had an arduous ride, no doubt. Also, if you would be as good to set up the second guest room,” he glanced at his companion for confirmation and received an approving nod as agreement to the suggestion, “We will be along shortly.”

The servant bowed and whisked away. Mr Archer, having retrieved his coat, gestured to Mr De Gray in a manner that indicated they should walk. His companion inclined his head and they paced the lawn. After a momentary pause, Mr De Gray pressed once more for the rationale of the visitation.

“Ad *am* , I am a newcomer to the area. It would be discourteous if they did *not* call. You are well familiar to your fellows in the vicinity of Greyvale House, such things are not in your agenda. Even if it would assist in your standing…”

The chiding note in his voice elicited little more than a derisive exhalation from De Gray who responded with an exhortation that such activities were pointless among the wheedling nobility of region. And the fact that the *locals* here might have nefarious designs upon Mr Archer's own particulars. Mr De Gray received a snort as Mr Archer continued:

“Even so, making time for others is not time wasted, my dear friend. And I would like to assess these people before besmirching their reputations! I trust you will be gracing my new abode whence we return with my entourage?”

Mr De Gray reassured Mr Archer that this was the case. Indeed, their purpose had been to accompany Mr Archer to and from.

“It seems excessive, a journey from town to here, back and forth.”

“My whims are my own, Beauregard,” mused Mr De Gray with a smile.

“I do wish you would use my nom de plume as in our correspondences. This overt formality is most disagreeable!”

“It is a vulgar abbreviation,” the expression upon Mr De Gray’s countenance could only be described as a smirk, indicating a lack of any real malice in the words, "And your breezy approach to structure is most disagreeable!" he continued with what was almost crowing mirth.

“You are a fine one to comment upon nomenclature choice, my friend.”

Mr De Gray waved a hand irritably and returned it behind their back, “Sheer necessity, what with the fancies of greedy men and women. My choices are pragmatic.”

Mr Archer vouchsafed that such decisions were not entirely of Mr De Gray’s choosing, which earned him a mild rebuke.

“All I am expanding upon is that we are an enlightened society. My fathers, for example! And I have it on good authority that there are a pair of ladies who are acknowledged,” and here, Mr Archer leaned in, “ *Friends of Mara* .”

Mr De Gray was a person of poise and bearing, so it could not be that they stumbled. Not at all. Nor that they flushed, whether it be via scandalised appreciation at this information or some other affectation.

“You jest sir!”

"Upon my honour, I do not. Mr Moon was confiding such truth to me this morning. He appraised me that I would likely receive several visitations *but* was decent in not colouring my opinion prior to their arrival."

"You still have not elaborated upon his purpose *sir* ."

"An invitation to call upon him. Though I find I am rather… intimidated."

"By a polite gentleman who advises you of local *Friends of Mara* ," once more, the expression of mirth lingered towards smirking upon Mr De Gray's features.

"By the fact that the gentleman has *five* daughters."

That drew a genuine laugh from Mr De Gray, who proceeded to slap his comrade upon the shoulder in a manner most unbecoming of polite gentlemen in a public setting, "I thought you were steering to be *far* from extended family, not to add to your collection!"

"Adam… do we *have* to use that ridiculous name?"

"Only within polite company. I have explained my rationale, *Bow* . I cannot be swayed. The honour of Grayvale and the maintenance of my family holdings is paramount."

"Surely the securing of…"

"No, my friend. The likelihood of skulduggery to ascertain and acquire my family fortune is a reality. And as long as I draw breath, I will not see it besmirched… as someone almost achieved. And likewise, with you! Beware, for these handsome ladies and their amiable father may not be bearing the kindness you expect."

Mr Archer raised a hand in quiet supplication, for there truly was little hope of changing the mind of his dearest friend on this topic, "I wish you would open yourself up to the possibility of love."

Mr De Gray gestured across the lawns towards the boundary of the property, "Is that the potential to which you tilt yourself with these myriad associations in your future?"

"Five daughters, Adam. FIVE."

"A gold piece says you will be danced to death before the solstice."

"Wagering upon my future happiness! You, my friend, are a villain!"

The smile Mr De Gray gave to Mr Archer was almost scandalous in its mirth. Adam pushed further.

"Will you not take the wager, sir?"

Mr Archer squared himself up next to his old friend and arched an eyebrow. The sunlight of the morning brought his neatly combed hair and dark skin into sharp relief beneath the rays that dappled a nearby oak.

"Not upon that. It is unseemly to make light of affairs of the heart. YOU should be more aware of that."

Mr De Gray studied his friend then acquiesced, "You have the right of it. My jest was merely at the *bevvy* of opportunity you apparently have before you."

"And dare you contemplate the possibility of your own entanglement?"

"Hardly. After the… incident, my foremost concern is the maintenance of the holdings and the security of my family. Any furtherance of romantic affectation is a mere *distraction* ."

"You sound like your aunt, my friend."

This accusation drew a minor shudder from Mr De Gray, "Unfortunately, even a broken timepiece can be correct twice a

day. On this matter, well, she has the right of it."

"But have you considered the possibility that… she will seize your holdings without you guaranteeing an heir?"

"And, given my nature, my friend, how am I to do that? We have conversed on this topic before.In my current circumstance I am not dragged by society into some unbidden arrangement *and* I am able to maintain an independence from the *Aunt* . Despite our society's *progression* some tradition still pushes its way forth. Also, I am able to protect the family from further scandal."

Mr Archer nodded slowly, "It merely strikes me as… deeply tragic, my friend."

"We do what we must, for family, Bow," Mr De Gray laid a companionable hand upon Mr Archer's shoulder. The smile upon their countenance was only marginally sad, "And let us not speak of melancholy things. You still have a Manor to show me! Also, I am rather parched and you did promise tea."

The heavy topic banished, the pair made their way back across the lawns, laughing as Mr De Gray relayed a description of an incident involving a mutual acquaintance, a butler and a large sack of flour.

Catra enjoyed walking; truly it was second only to climbing. Well, actually third. Second to climbing. And then THIRD to reading. And climbing was second to reading. Frankly, if it came down to it, she would prefer to walk to a tree, climb it and then read. True, her reading was naught so earnest as dear Entrapta's, nor her enthusiasm for hiking as ardent as Glimmer's, but it was an entertainment she was fond of.

The surrounds of their estate were not vast, but the expanse of fields and woods provided ample opportunity to exercise and take in the quiet of nature.

Currently, she was accompanying Glimmer on a tour of the local woodland, having decided that berry picking was an afternoon's entertainment worth their time. As they walked, Glimmer moaned at the possibility of the upcoming ball.

"Catra, I do not know what to *do* with myself. Why am I so *afluster* ?"

"The potential to court the newest gentleman in the neighbourhood appears to have addled your mind, sister Sparkle dearest," Catra's tone was gentle, teasing, with a slight chuckle to offset it. Glimmer's riposte was an eye roll.

"This is easy for you. You retreat and ensconce yourself with a bevvy and some affectation of a cold or some rot. Your airs maintain the distance! Such peace! I envy it."

"Just glare at them, Glimmer dear. Also, I could not countenance entertaining a man for some paltry dance."

"It is *expected* ."

"And I cannot fathom *why* ? To dance for their entertainment?"

"And yours! The dancing can be in and of itself, Catra."

"But still, it would involve the entertainment of a *gentleman* ."

A sigh from Glimmer drew Catras gaze from the bush that she was currently acting her own minor frustrations on, tearing the berries free as if they had personally affronted her. She regarded her pink-haired sister and exhaled. Glimmer, for her own part, placed her basket upon the bluebells that scattered throughout the woods.

“And why would that be a *bad* outcome? You would not be betrothed, nor have any expectations placed upon you. It is a manner similar to merely eating at a table adjacent to a man! You do so with father and there are no ill effects. You have not yet sprung up in boils from his affections!”

Catra’s laugh drew a genuine smile from her sister and the brown-haired girl nodded slowly.

“You make an excellent point. Even though…. We are not of blood relation, father has not yet reduced me to a wreck, so perhaps I can tolerate the attentions of some of the attendees.”

“It would certainly not commit you to anything. Although it may tarnish your reputation for surliness among the men of the county.”

“I am not surly. I am merely *cultured* ,” Catra’s exaggerated flick of her hair served to enhance this point and elicited another giggle from Glimmer, “Anyway, I may not dance, lest I draw Mr Archer’s attention away from *you* .”

“Well, as father said, he will call upon us for tea in four days! Post the weekend.”

“Careful, Glimmer. Lest your hopes rise to be stolen by Entrapta! She understands him to have an interest in things mechanical, she may have a plan!” Catra’s smile was jovial and her arched expression conveyed a teasing air. Glimmer merely sniffed in response.

“Entrapta is not a planner. We know this. Otherwise the fourth stable would not currency be firewood.”

“This is... a statement that is true,” conceded Catra, “But still! Her womanly wiles!”

The pair gazed at each other then erupted into peals of laughter. They collected their baskets and made for the main road back to

the village. They were startled by a clatter of hooves and paused as a rider drew near, fifty yards from the edge of the wood.

He was tall, and his jodhpurs and cream coat were marked with streaks of green from a clear encounter with low branches. And yet his top hat remained affixed, albeit at a faintly jaunty angle. His skin was the colour dark oak and he looked momentarily lost as he turned in the saddle. His face appeared startled as he regarded the two women. Catra took a tentative step forwards, which put her slightly between Glimmer and the stranger.

"Oh! My goodness, my apologies ladies! I am… *directionally embarrassed* ," the gentleman reached up and tilted the brim of his hat towards the women. After a moment they curtsied, "Mr Beauregard Archer, at your service. Or perhaps you would be kind enough to be at mine. I appear to have gotten rather turned around."

Glimmer peered at the man, who glanced at her and then froze. They stared at one another for a beat as Catra glanced betwixt them, momentarily lost. She managed a genteel cough and nudged her sister as subtly as she could. The pink haired girl harrumphed and nodded.

"Mr Archer, a pleasure to make your acquaintance. I am Ms Glimmer Moon, of the Brightmoon Estate. May I introduce my sister, Catra Moon."

"Oh my stars, my most humble apologies," the man covered his face for a moment and his horse whickered and backed up briefly, "Incredibly rude of me. A *pleasure* . I have had the pleasure of speaking with your father. Please do convey my thanks at his exceedingly kind welcome to the area. I am most looking forward to calling upon you in less harried circumstances."

Catra couldn't help but smile wryly, "Harried, sir? Whatever for? We are in a most peaceful enclave!"

“Ah! You jest, but I am mortally embarrassed. My friend will not let me live this down.”

The ladies exchanged a glance, confused, “Please, elaborate, sir,” offered Glimmer.

“I challenged my guest to a race to the main highway to Elberon, however I found myself rather turned about in the woods. I am not accustomed to so much greenery!”

“A cultured gentleman such as yourself is turned about by mere trees?” scoffed Catra. Glimmer elbowed her with a hiss.

For his part Mr Archer looked amused and a little contrite, “Living in a town where streets are easily marked and landscapes distinct, with clear landmarks does, I must admit, lead one to have a rather biased appraisal of things.”

Another set of hooves made the women turn partially. A large white horse cantered through the trees, the rider in similar attire to Mr Archer, albeit in grey and red, which seemed to clash dramatically with the surrounding green. A scarf was across their face but Catra almost flinched at the steel blue eyes as they raked across the pair. The voice was muffled beneath the wrap, “Really, Beauregard, gallivanting after local maids? A paltry excuse for losing if ever there was one.”

The tone set Catra’s hackles to rising. She tilted her chin and regarded the newcomer, “You have the advantage of us, *sir* .”

Those blue eyes locked back onto her, “Do I? I was not here for introductions.”

Mr Archer chuckled nervously, “Mr De Gray, may I present Ms Glimmer Moon and Ms Catra Moon. Two of the daughters of Mr Moon who, you will recall, called upon me yesterday in a most generous and kind welcome.”

“Indeed, I recall the conversation,” the blue eyes regarded Mr Archer, then turned back to the women, appraising. A gloved hand

tilted the rider's grey top hat, "Ladies."

"They were about to be kind enough to direct me to the road."

"Really, Beauregard. I've been here less time than you and I have already ascertained the lay of the land," the tone was light, teasing and the voice sounded slightly off to Catra's ear, though she couldn't ascertain *why* . The blue eyes regarded the women again, "Auspicious you should be out near Mr Archer's estates."

"If you wish to imply something, say it plainly *sir* ," Catra glared at the man, who still had not removed their scarf. The rider turned the white horse about and studied her for a moment, then looked back to Mr Archer.

"The road is half a mile *that* way, which you would know if you looked up from your books whilst travelling. Now, ladies, please excuse us. We are expected in town."

"You will *ride* there?" exclaimed Glimmer. The blue eyes seemed nonplussed and Mr Archer just chuckled.

"Mr De Gray garners an absurd level of enjoyment from punishing *him*self on horseback."

"A carriage is interminably boring," scoffed the scarf wearing rider.

"Only boring people get bored," challenged Catra as she glared at Mr De Gray. She felt herself scrutinised again and the rider nodded.

"Perhaps. Or maybe the bored person merely finds nothing as engaging in their surroundings to excite the mind? Such simple reductions do not indicate a measured assessment of what humanity has to offer. Mere aphorism."

Catra arched an eyebrow and snorted, "A cultured mind would find a way to excite itself without external stimuli. To expect entertainment is the height of arrogance."

"And to reduce the world to absolutes is naive in the extreme, madame," Catra huffed at the amused tone in the voice of the rider, "My thanks, ladies, for the unexpected *entertainment* . We will delay your afternoon no more. Beauregard."

The rider turned their white charger and cantered away. Mr Archer huffed and looked at the women, "My apologies. Mr De Gray is a rather impatient sort," he gazed after his companion and, thought Catra, appeared contemplative, "Though that was strangely conversational… yes well, my thanks, ladies, and my apologies for intruding upon your day. May I say I *am* looking forward calling upon you in less vexatious circumstances."

"I trust you will *not* be bringing Mr De Gray?" Catra challenged and Glimmer's hurried interjection overlapped the end of her statement.

"Of course, he would be welcome!"

Mr Archer laughed, a genuine sound, "My thanks, Ms Moon," his eyes locked onto Glimmer and his bearing became almost nervous, "I feel that would be a gross overstep of your father's invitation. Though I will allow Mr De Gray to make their own presentation should they muster the mannerisms!"

Glimmer smiled at that and Catra couldn't help but chuckle at Mr Archer's chiding tone, directed toward the departed Mr De Gray. They watched as the man turned his own horse and with a tip of his hat, cantered away after the surly rider. Catra spared her sister a glance then allowed her eyes to roll expansively.

"Goodness, you could replace the berries around here with your own rosy complexion."

"Oh HUSH! I could see you exchanging the eyes with Mr De Gray. A MAN no less!"

Catra's derisive snort could almost have echoed, "Hardly. A brutish and arrogant sort. Did you see the way he *inspected* us? Like meat at a market! No, I feel I will not be making *Mr De Gray's*

acquaintance. And not just because he is of the male persuasion! Such insufferable rudeness!”

“Well, you were hardly a picture of agreement yourself.”

“I believe you will ascertain that *he* started it.”

This elicited a smile from Glimmer who shook her head, “A shame. There certainly seemed to be something there.”

“Well, if there was, Mr De Gray will be in for a rude shock, won’t he? But enough about my unlucky paramour, let’s talk about *yours* . You practically SWOONED.”

Catra threaded an arm through Glimmer’s and together they headed towards the village, giggling as they went.

Chapter End Notes

Phew, all to the good!

Hope you all enjoyed this - wanted to get Adora introduced!

And I wonder why she's so surly about people courting or their motives...and who could the AUNT possibly be ;)

Also, is she DARCY ENOUGH in her attitude currently? And I hope Catra has maintained some of her snark in this iteration!

As ever, feedback is GREATLY appreciated!

Opinion and Intention

Chapter Summary

> The sisters deliberate on their fancies and Mr Archer pays them a visit.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Micah was not a *wreck* per se. Rather he was an agitated ball of anticipation as he paced before the fireplace. Angella sat in her preferred chair and merely arched an eyebrow at her ambulating husband.

"Dearest, your nerves will wear a trench into the carpeting."

"Are you not eager, my love? We stand at the precipice! The *potential, the cusp even,* of new love!"

Angella regarded him fondly then smiled, "Are you speaking for your daughters or yourself. I must say, you appear quite taken yourself with the gentleman!"

"Madame! My eyes are only for you! You jest, my lady, you jest, but I would be remiss if I did not state that Mr Archer is a man of fine bearing and excellent humour. I am eager to ensure he is quite taken with one of our girls."

Glimmer, who was sat with a mess of embroidery in her lap, frowned at her father, "Are chattel, to be palmed off on the first eligible gentleman?"

"Dear, no. And I thought *you* rather cordial to the idea at least," smiled Micah, "More my motivation is the security of your hearts. A gentleman such as Mr Archer is a man of means *and* bearing. Such a combination is rare."

Angella reached out and Micah took her hand. She chuckled and shook her head, "Right you are, my love. I was fortunate indeed to bewitch you."

"Truly, I was lost upon Castaspella introducing you to me. I thank the gods daily, my love," Micah bent and kissed her hand, which brought a faint flush to Angella's cheeks. Across the room, Frosta, who was engaged in some manner of puzzle, made a sound of disgust. Entrapta, idly occupied at the writing table with a complex mechanism blinked at the display of affection and shrugged. Mermista and Catra tried to hide their own smiles and merely exchanged a shrug.

Glimmer huffed and deposited her embroidery, "Well, one can judge a man by the company he keeps. And whilst it would appear Mr Archer has much to recommend him, his decision to associate with such an abominable and crude gentleman such as Mr De Gray throws my initial appraisal of him into uncertainty."

"Mr De Gray! Well, I have it on good authority that the gentleman is still ensconced in Elberon and will not be gracing us with their presence. Indeed! I will ensure that Mr Archer is aware that such

a gentleman is not welcome at our home after such an assault on the character of our dear Catra," Micah nodded as he pronounced his decision. Angella glanced across at her daughter.

"Was he truly so beastly, my dear?"

Catra looked up from her book and adjusted herself on the settee, "He was abrupt and apparently without bearing, but hardly *beastly* . Honestly, I could not appraise his countenance or intent, as he seemed eager to be elsewhere. I can only surmise his opinion of us *country* folk from his attitude. However, I have no desire to investigate further. If, however, such hostility is a barrier to my sister's advancement, then I will *deign* to socialise with the man," she shrugged then shot an encouraging smile at Glimmer.

Glimmer for her part, relaxed and nodded, "He was, indeed, an abrupt fellow. Did not even remove his scarf! He seemed to enjoy needling Catra."

Angella nodded slowly, "Well then, we shall not bar him from our halls. The name, however… De Gray. It is a familiar one, I am sure it will come to me. I may need to check my correspondances."

"I am sure he is of little consequence! After all, our focus is on establishing the intent of Mr Archer and hoping he finds favour with us and our daughters with him," Micah waved a hand dismissively. Angella hummed noncommittally, her face a mask of thoughtful contemplation.

Catra leaned over to Glimmer's chair and smiled conspiratorially, "So, what whiles do you have planned to outstep dear Entrapta? She will likely have her own contraptions to *literally* ensnare the gentleman."

Glimmer huffed and picked at the embroidery in her lap, "You and I both know that Entrapta's interest in the romances are academic, despite her eagerness. I will trust to fate and see whether it steers me well."

"Then you are a fool and a lazy one!" chided Catra, but her words were teasing, "Capitalise, sister dear! This is not fishing, but a *hunt* ."

"Oh and when were you so well versed in the arts of romance? Or have you finally fallen for Mermista's tales of budding passion?" Glimmer waggled her eyebrows and smiled broadly. Catra, for her part, rolled her eyes and gently shoved Glimmer.

"No, I merely take tea with Netossa and Spinnerella. They are a most informative pair!"

"Well, should my interest ever fall that way, then I will be sure to consult them. However, the whims of a man are most definitely different to that of a woman, I am sure."

Catra returned to her book, "I would not, nor do I wish to, know any more on the topic. I merely reinforce that this is a grand opportunity to pursue that which you espouse a longing for most greatly - that of love."

The gathering was interrupted by a servant who announced the arrival of one *Mr Archer.* The Moons stood as the man was ushered in, whereupon Micah approached and bowed, "Mr Archer, a pleasure and welcome to our humble home. I trust your business in Elberon was concluded satisfactorily?"

Mr Archer beamed and bowed in return, then stepped forwards to shake Micah by the hand, "Indeed yes. Most agreeably. All rather boring, of course and likely of no interest to your lovely family."

"Of course! Mr Archer, may I present my wife, Angella Moon," the tall matriarch curtseyed and inclined her head, "And my daughters, Glimmer, Mermista, Catra, Entrapta and Frosta. I understand you have already had the fortune to meet Glimmer and Catra?"

"A pleasure, ladies. And yes, I was most fortunate. They were kind enough to assist a lost man who was quite turned about."

Glimmer licked her lips and looked about to respond, but her eyes were wide and she seemed frozen. Catra glanced to her, then inclined her head towards Mr Archer, "You are most kind sir. But we were hardly of any assistance, merely a distraction for you and your companion. I believe he was the true saviour."

Mr Archer appraised Catra and smiled again, his expression warm and genuine, "Mayhap, but it was certainly an enjoyable and enlightening exchange."

Catra blinked in surprise, “Indeed so, sir?”

“Indeed! I was able to meet a pair of captivating and hospitable women who were forthright in their demeanour and welcoming. It is a refreshing change from the mores of city life, I must say! Even if the greenery is a bit overwhelming! And Mr De Gray, well, yes. My friend is not normally so…”

“Charming?” Catra smiled again and Micah turned with an arched eyebrow, as if not moments before *he* had not been besmirching the character of the same gentleman.

But Mr Archer simply laughed, “Indeed not! Normally he is of a surlier disposition and quite aloof. Truly, I believe you charmed *him* .”

Catra blinked and frowned, “Then I am afraid he will be sorely disappointed, to be blunt sir. He did not remove his scarf! It is bold of me, but I felt him uncouth.”

“Ah but he had the right of that. Shortly after departing, I enquired as to why he had done so but ended swallowing a fly in our haste!”

The image drew a titter from Frosta and a grin from Catra. She nodded, “A wise *travel* decision, maybe, but he was not travelling

at the time. My apologies, I am speaking ill of a man not here to defend himself. And of course, we are not here to discuss your friend, we are here to welcome *you* to our part of Etheria."

Mr Archer's smile was smaller but had an *inkling* of something else. Amusement perhaps? He had a certain knowing countenance to him. He nodded and looked to Glimmer, "Ms Moon, a pleasure to see you again. Once again, may I reiterate my thanks for your welcome. And indeed, a pleasure to meet you all."

Angella nodded, then clapped her hands and a servant entered, "Emily, is the tea room ready? I feel Mr Archer bust be in want of refreshment?"

"You are too kind madame! Please, lead on!"

The company filed through, during which time Entrapta took the opportunity to present her small, whirling mechanism. With refreshments to hand, Entrapta then went about demonstrating the way her device hovered and buzzed, like a floating corkscrew. Mr Archer looked enchanted and complimented the enthusiastic girl on her talents.

"I myself have a penchant for mechanics. If you are interested, I would be happy to give you a tour of my workshop?"

"A workshop! AMAZING!" Entrapta's ability to control the volume of her exhortations was not being exercised and Mr Archer leaned back. Across the room, Glimmer fumed and clenched her fists against her dress. Catra leaned over and nudged her.

“I told you. Now, are you willing to entertain my opinions?”

“What is the use? He has a *penchant* for such things, does he not?”

“And he made eyes at you in the woods. So, either he is a gadabout who plays with the affections of women *or* mayhap he has merely found a shared interest. I know I lean towards the cynical, Glimmer, but let us try to ascertain his *intent* . Even if it is just to protect our sister.”

Glimmer nodded, “True. If Mr De Gray is any measure, then there is potential that Mr Archer is merely putting on an air of affability.”

“Quite so. So, shall we?”

“We shall.”

The women rose and approached the enthusiastic pair, but were interrupted by Micah’s own interest, “Mr Archer, I took note of your devices near your stables, quite the array for a hobbyist!”

Mr Archer looked at his host and nodded, “Indeed. My fathers wished for me to pursue a study of academia. But my strengths

do not lie with dusty tomes and buried relics, rather they are with the science of movement and forces."

Entrapta beamed, "Truly, what other forces matter? What is more important than the pursuit of knowledge above all things?"

Mr Archer glanced over at Glimmer then appeared to blush, "Some things, I find. One must keep balance, which is the true lesson of engineering I find. Too much focus in one area can lead to misfortune. Forget to counter it and one will fall foul of fickle physics!"

Micah clapped his hands, "A poet too, sir! I must confess, I am more on the side of academia and research. But still, a fascinating topic."

"Oh indeed. And, if it is of genuine interest, I would be more than happy to host a tour of my workshop… if such a thing might be of interest? I know it might seem frightfully boring to ladies of learning such as yourselves, such base activities, but… still."

Glimmer had paused in her advance, likewise Catra. But the pair had halted for different reasons. Glimmer spoke at the same time as Catra.

"I would love to visit!"

“Did you say *fathers* ?”

Mr Archer glanced between them then grinned, “Well, let me answer. I will first clear my estate to ensure it is suitable for visitations, then I would be most honoured to entertain a visit, at your convenience,” he made eye contact with Glimmer, then nodded to Entrapta, who seemed now once more preoccupied with her whirling device. Then he looked at Catra, “And yes, my fathers.”

She opened her mouth, then closed it and frowned, “My apologies, sir. I did not mean to offend.”

“I know, it is a rare thing. In some circles it offends *others* , but not so in Elberon. Marriage equality has been achieved in the civilised cities, but I know some more *traditional* regions hold a bias. I was most pleased to make the acquaintance or the Telae’s.”

A smile broke out across Catra’s face, “Ahhh so you have met with Netossa and Spinnerella?”

“Indeed so - I chanced upon them before your father called upon me. A most welcoming pair and full of advice!” Mr Archer chuckled, “Good advice too, which was refreshing. Mainly on ground maintenance, but I will leave that in more capable hands!”

Micah nodded slowly, “It is a relief to be in such an enlightened time. Our local parish does its best to be welcoming. Any and all

of good intent are a welcome sight.”

“Most excellent. For they are currently in attendance at Thaymor Manor, rather insistently so,” Mr Archer picked up his cup and supped, “You will excuse me for saying so, Mr Moon, but one does occasionally wish to be free of the shadow of one's parents, no matter how doting.”

Angella laughed from next to her husband, then stood to open the double doors that led onto the lawn, “Mr Archer, we quite understand. My girls are, I am sure, most impatient to find their futures. Wherever that may take them.”

“Indeed. The world is a challenge, though a rewarding one. For those of us not shackled by duty at least,” a brief cloud passed over Mr Archer’s features, his dark skin seemingly grey for the barest moment, but he brightened, “I am lucky, however - of comfortable means and not the first of my family.”

Angella turned from where she stood at the doors, “Oh? You have siblings?”

“ *Twelve* , Mrs Moon, though I am not the youngest. So, I can empathise with the fine women of this household!”

That drew chuckles from around the room and Glimmer seemed to relax. She and Catra still stood as they listened, though Glimmer seemed more fixated with staring at Mr Archer. Catra

decided to nudge the conversation along, “So you are not in want of company having spent so much of it surrounded, then sir?”

Mr Archer laughed, “In many cases yes, but more I am after companionship of my own *choosing* . My fathers wish to assess the local area, I am sure, to ascertain the reality of opportunity here. But I am content to make acquaintance and see wherefore it might lead.”

Catra arched an eyebrow, “Bold, sir!”

The man spread his hands and smiled, “I am in no position to enforce anything. I am a guest, a newcomer and I will go where fate leads and hope my countenance and deamour are pleasing. I am not heir to a vast fortune, not a princeling. I am a man of means but, I feel I must import, not a man *seeking* someone of means. I am, perhaps, a romantic. For I believe in acquiring the affection of someone, not merely a contract.”

Silence fell on the room as Micah and Angella exchanged a glance. Glimmer swallowed and looked at Catra who smiled back at her. Angella spoke up first, “A noble confession to make, Mr Archer. Are you in the habit of grand declarations at all introductory meetings?”

Mr Archer smiled back at her, seemingly not intimidated by the curiosity in her face, “I find that honesty in my dealings is the best approach. Too often we dally and miss an opportunity. I have seen what comes of dishonesty and ill intent and prefer to be frank,

Mrs Moon. I must present what I am, what I offer, to better set aside any who would assume more of me."

Catra nodded slowly, "You have a low opinion of others? To assume ill intent?"

"Ms Moon, hardly, I merely seek an equitable understanding. I have seen others who have set out false interest and led others astray. Or attempted to do so. As such, I prefer to state who I am and hope that it is enough. And, I must say, I feel I am in good company, for I feel free to do so!"

That drew a smile from Angella and Micah, the latter of whom slapped Mr Archer's shoulder companionably, "You flatter us, sir, with such trust. We hope we can ensure you of our own noble intent."

Mr Archer raised his cup, "Well, the tea is most *certainly* agreeable. On a note, are you attending the ball this coming week?"

"We are!" that was from Frosta, "Dancing is most enjoyable!"

Mermista decided to contribute her own thoughts, "It's an agreeable enough activity. To pass the time."

Mr Archer smiled, “Well, that will be most enjoyable then. I will know some people there at least! I will be in attendance, with a small company. It has been a while since I danced, so the opportunity is most welcome.”

“You don’t have parties in Elberon?” that came from Entrapta, who frowned at Mr Archer with a focused intensity. He waved a hand.

“I have been distracted, I must admit, settling some affairs in order and helping Mr De… well, that is a topic for another time. I have only attended a few in the past year, so am somewhat out of the art.”

Micah chuckled, “Well, I am sure there will be ample opportunity to reintroduce yourself.”

“Indeed! And, may I be so bold as to request… two dances, from Ms Glimmer, should she be agreeable, upon the evening?” Mr Archer turned in his chair and smiled hopefully. Glimmer blushed and nodded mutely, “Most excellent. Thank you.”

The conversation continue amiably, with the company then taking a turn around the gardens, with Frosta pointing out various birds to Mr Archer and Mermista explaining her particular efforts around the manicured water-features. Glimmer and Catra trailed, whilst Micah and Angella took their own turn walking the lawns. Catra couldn’t help but notice how Mr Archer would pause to glance towards Glimmer with the faintest of smiles. She leaned closer to her sister, “I don’t quite know what you did, but apparently it worked.”

“Hush, you will jinx it.”

“So long as Entrapta doesn’t produce some device from her bodice you should be fine.”

“His invitation was for *all* of us, so his intent is still unsure,” whispered Glimmer, fiercely. Catra snorted.

“He asked, before the ball has even convened, for *two* dances. I think we can ascertain his intent!”

“He could be being polite!”

“Or maybe he wishes to make an honest woman of you, My Sparkly Sister, difficult as that might be.”

“You are the worst.”

“And yet you still love me.”

“Heavens knows why.”

Catra hummed happily and jostled Glimmer's shoulder with a smile. After another hour, during which the conversation moved easily and even involved Glimmer *and* Mr Archer exchanging a few words together as they took their own walk through the gardens, their guest had to depart. He mounted his horse at the front of Brightmoon House and tilted his hat to the gathered family.

"Many thanks for your most gracious hospitality. I was, honestly, merely expecting a cordial exchange of words with Mr Moon, but I am most pleased to have been hosted so warmly. It was truly wonderful. And I do hope you will visit Thaymor, even if it is just to see my wasted efforts at contraption construction," his gaze settled on Glimmer.

Glimmer managed to speak then, "I would be delighted."

Entrapta looked up from yet another device she had cradled in her hands and grinned, "As would I!"

Mr Archer kept his gaze upon Glimmer as he spoke, "Wonderful."

And with that he set off, spurring his horse to a gentle trot down the gravel path. Glimmer let out a shuddering breath and smiled stupidly. Micah laid a hand on her shoulder, "I say, I think there might be a look of *tolerance* there from you, dear."

Entrapta turned about and smiled too, "What a nice man! Do you think he'll let me look at his devices? I'd really like to look at

them!”

Angella tapped her chin as she looked between her two daughters, “And what of your thoughts on Mr Archer, Entrapta?”

“He seems very clever.”

“And?”

“He talks a lot about things. But I really just want to see those devices! He has a *workshop* !”

Glimmer blinked and Catra watched her frown at her sister. Angella spoke before Glimmer could, though, “And you have romantic intent, dear/”

Entrapta frowned, “Do I?”

“Well, you seemed quite taken with him.”

“He’s an agreeable man. But he has a *workshop* .”

Angella smiled, then looked at Glimmer, “And you dear?”

“He… he’s… very *kind* .”

Angella hummed and nodded, “Well, I suggest we retire and consider. Entrapta dear, can you reassure your sister as to your designs?”

“Which ones?” Entrapta looked genuinely confused for a moment, clearly a thought having bypassed her somewhere. Angella folded her hands in front of her.

“On *Mr Archer* .”

“OHHH! Well, as I said, he has a workshop. I’m interested in *that* . But… he likes Glimmer,” she said it very matter of factly. Everyone stared at her, “Why is everyone staring at me?”

Catra stepped forwards and reached out a hand gently. Entrapta nodded and Catra laid her palm on her sister’s shoulder, “It did look like you were talking an awful lot with him. Showing an interest.”

“Mermista talked to him,” Entrapta steepled her fingers, “Water features and the most optimal layouts for water flow… he seemed interested. Is… is Mermista also….?”

Mermista brushed a lock of dark, curled hair out of her face, "Um, *no* , I was being polite."

"Oh. Well. I think I was? I was being polite too? But I know he likes Glimmer. And Glimmer likes him. I got that right?"

Catra smiled and let go of Entrapta's shoulder, "But do *you* like him?"

"Yes? I mean, he has a workshop. But do you mean romantically? I'm not sure what that means. I know father talks about us wanting something romantically but…" she gave a helpless shrug, which made Glimmer sigh and step forward.

"Come here silly. Mother, you've gotten her all a tizzy now."

Angella frowned, an apology clear in her sad expression, "Oh dear. I merely wished to avoid a row. My apologies Entrapta, I do forget that for your enthusiasm, some things are still opaque to you, you beautiful girl."

Entrapta's purple pigtails bobbed as she smiled, "It's all about learning, mother. I feel I have ascertained a fair few things! For the scientific arts! Namely, I *enjoy* Mr Archer's company but I am *not* attracted to Mr Archer," she turned to Glimmer, "When you get married, can I use the workshop?"

Catra couldn’t help but laugh. Glimmer blushed, then grinned, which caused Frosta to dance around the group, singing *“Glimmer is getting mar-ried, Glimmer is getting mar-ried”.* Mermista even cracked a faint smile.

Behind them, their parents shared a relieved glance, then headed indoors, their children jostling and excitedly questioning a flustered Glimmer on what sort of wedding she would prefer. Catra, for her part, only had a passing curiosity for a certain blue eyed gentleman and their circumstances that had Mr Archer smiling in such an enigmatic fashion. Such thoughts she filed away, eager to focus instead on the fact her sister now appeared crimson and joined her siblings in chasing the blushing girl into the gardens, whooping as they ran.

Chapter End Notes

A definite differentiation from the Book. As I said - it's a GUIDE not a transfer ;)

I wanted to setup a more innocent and fun intention for Bow and Glimmer, plus explore the burgeoning Bromance between Micah and Bow. Not huge here, but at the ball we shall see him move between the two!

Also, a bit of Entrapta being oblivious and NOT so oblivious :)

Don't worry, we'll get some Adora / Catra back and forth at the ball in a chapter or so.

A shadow of a man

Chapter Summary

> Adam muddles through life in preparation for a return to Thaymor.
>
> What is he avoiding? What ails his soul?
>
> And why does the thought of a ball bring such curmudgeonly thoughts?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The commitments of a gentleman about town demanded a certain level of visibility and presentation; namely, the need to present oneself at societal functions. These could range from idle dinner parties, to theatre gatherings or to shooting parties, though the latter activity was restricted to the country estates of the Gentry.

It was due to such commitments that Adam de Gray found himself forced to attend a rather dour function at the club that he frequented. Aged gentlemen espousing upon the importance of *family* and *loyalty* . Little gentry, men of maybe a hundred acres that felt that constituted the right to lord over others. And it was all Adam could do to hold a relatively civil tongue. To ensure the continued survival of the other attendees, Adam withdrew to the grey marble mantle, within which burned a low fire. He nursed his brandy and studied the room.

Poppinjays and portly men, the lot of them, scraping and bowing. The proper decorum, yes, but truth be told, it was the doldrums.

Unbidden, a memory of mismatched eyes amidst the bluebells of a woodland assailed Adam’s memory. It drew an uncomfortable frown.

“Mr de Gray, a surprise to see you here.”

Adam’s grip on the brandy glass tightened imperceptibly. He turned and gave a curt head tilt to the approaching figure. Pale, sallow features coupled with bloodshot eyes and a ramrod posture.

“Captain Hordak. I see you are still ambulatory.”

A ghost of a sneer pulled at thin lips, “And I see you continue with your pointless charade.”

“Hardly pointless. I trust you are still enjoying your inheritance. The brocade appears *new* .”

The Captain smoothed down the black of his military tunic and sniffed, “The purchased commission was certainly fortuitous.”

“Though I doubt it will aid you in your particular goals,” Adam frowned, “To what do I owe your company, Hordak?”

The Captain peered out at the crowd and huffed, “Truly are we so far gone, *Adam* ? That we cannot exchange niceties?”

“Considering our prior parting, I feel this is an appropriate level of exchange. Were it not for your current attire, I fear things would be tremulous *indeed* .”

The Captain pursed his lips and nodded, “I see. Well, I shall not darken your precious mantle. If I see you at the club, perchance you will grace me with a duel. Perhaps that will allow you succour for your *theatrics* .”

Adam’s jaw tightened and he inclined his head and watched Hordak stalk away through the crowd of velvet coats and tight-buttoned shirts. Suddenly the brandy tasted bitter and unpalatable. Adam tossed the dregs into the flames and set for the balcony. The air of Elberon was hardly cool, but it was fresher than a stuffy entertainment room - the high walls and wide windows did little to quell the feeling of oppression within.

Adam drew a gulp of air and gripped the balustrade, eyes focused on the cramped buildings and flickering lamplight of the city. The sounds of townsfolk at labour echoed through the air and, oddly relaxed Adam's grip on the stone. He heaved a sigh. Perhaps a trip back to the estate was due.

But he had promised to travel back to visit Beauregard. And Adam was particular about his appointments. One had to be, given the situation. A misstep could be catastrophic.

The evening's entertainment had served its purpose - Adam had been seen, had exchanged words and now could safely retire to his lodgings. Thus decided, Mr de Gray exchanged polite goodbyes with the host, some idle city loafer, and departed for the set of rooms he retained for such stays in the city.

The carriage ride was an uneventful occurrence, as was the short exchanges he made to the landlady of the premises, with instructions to not be disturbed. It was important that Adam was left alone - important business, writing, things of that sort demanded privacy.

In truth, Adam ceased to exist once he stepped beyond the threshold of his private rooms; the mask and *ties* that *bound* cast aside. Another name returned to reality beyond. His true name. A name he had to conceal for propriety, for duty, for *honour* .

The following morning brought overcast skies and the gentle set of drizzle. Mr de Gray rode to the town house of the Archer family and rapped upon the hardwood door. The face that answered was not the butler, but rather the bespectacled and dreadlocked framed face of Mr Lance Archer.

"Addddd….AM! Adam! So wonderful for you to be here. You will be joining us for breakfast, of course?"

Adam rolled his eyes but offered the faintest of smiles, "I trust George is cooking?"

"Mr Archer is indeed in the kitchen. We have given the housekeeper the day off, as we felt remiss retaining her for such minor distractions."

"And the rest of your kin?"

"The other boys and Beatrice have already departed for Thaymor, with Beauregard. We felt you might appreciate more sedate company."

Adam offered a wider smile in gratitude, "Most welcome indeed. Much as the ride to Thaymor is invigorating, it can be murder on the thighs. A chance to regard the countryside and contemplate with good conversation would be appreciated."

Lance nodded and tried to hide a smirk, "And you will entertain us with your *scholarly* ways."

Mr de Gray snorted and swatted a glove against Lance's forearm, "Hush, sir. I was in my cups and trying to make a good impression on behalf of Beauregard."

"You nearly broke a vase."

"Truly it was luck I failed to do so then!"

"You did not attend the club? Not gotten a chance in with the blade?" Lance paused as they moved through the tiled hallway, past the vast library and into the kitchen itself. Adam shook his head.

"No, unfortunately an… *acquaintance* was present and I did not fancy being hauled before a magistrate under a charge of manslaughter. Best to avoid the fencing club for now."

"Probably wise, my dear," Lance paused and glanced around, then smiled apologetically, "My dear *Adam* . GEORGE! Adam is here. Mr

de Gray! Are the eggs prepared?”

The kitchen itself was, for want of a better word, *regimented* . George, despite being master (or one of the masters) of the house, tended to treat the kitchen as more his domain. The cook ruled in his stead, but ultimately, George was at home there. Another slight oddity to add to a pile of oddities that comprised the Archer family.

Ingredients were lined up, pots and skillets hung in size order and shelves were neatly stacked with pewter and china. Near the hearth and stove stood George himself, the rolled up white sleeves of his dress shirt providing a pleasant contrast to his caramel skin. He glanced over his shoulder and nodded to Adam.

“Mr de Gray. Your timing, as ever, is impeccable. Please, draw a chair. I trust you will not object to the impropriety of taking sustenance in a meagre kitchen?”

Adam removed his top hat and placed it next to his riding crop on the table, “Not at all, Mr Archer. A sacrifice necessary to enjoy the culinary adventures of your experimentation.”

George scoffed and turned fully to spoon a hearty spread of bacon, sausage and egg onto plates. Hardly the finest of dining, but enough to set one up for a long journey in the back of a carriage. George placed the pan into the sink and pumped the water handle, then sat down next to Lance. The pair clasped hands for a moment then smiled at Adam.

Mr de Gray eyed their hands and then shrugged. Lance chuckled, “Still so stiff.”

“The bearing of a lifetime is not something one shifts easily, Mr Archer,” Adam set to his meal with gusto, but managed a modicum of restraint. After all, he wore a white collared shirt and cravat. It would not do to meet people on the journey and look *greasy* .

George and Lance made idle conversation, tentatively asking about Mr de Gray's dealings. In return, Mr de Gray enquired after the wider family and ascertained Beauregard's siblings had experienced success across their ventures, bar a slight issue with Beatrice deciding she did not wish to attend finishing school.

"Mayhap you should… advise her as to her options?" hazarded Mr de Gray. That merely elicited a chuckle from George.

"And how successful can any man be at restraining the fancy of a woman? Surely you know this better than most *Adam* …"

Mr de Gray attempted a glare, but gave up due to the lack of conviction behind it, "Regardless, Beatrice should understand the limitations…"

"Mr de Gray, what limitations? The city is progressive. The colleges accept women, albeit with some negotiation; businesses are more accepting of the station and role of women within their walls. We are moving forward...." he left the implication hanging. A fruit. A temptation of thoughts.

The cutlery clattered onto Adam's plate and he managed a thin smile, "Such wondrous news for Elberon. For those unencumbered by conditions and commitments. I will not lecture you on parenthood, for you hold far more in the way of doctrinal knowledge on that front. But I can countenance that obligation is a fickle mistress and will be a burden should this not be taken in hand. But! But… I will not rage. It is not my place. George, I thank you for the breakfast… are we to depart shortly?"

The pair watched as Adam stood. Lance laid a hand over George's and smiled, "Adam, we do understand your conviction. Forgive us for speaking out of turn."

"No, sir. Forgive me for commenting on what is, entirely, a personal matter for your family. I am sure Ms Archer will be most satisfied with any vocation of her choosing. Perhaps I am merely… envious of the opportunity. Gentry, despite our rank, rarely have

the privilege of choice. May I make use of your library until you are ready to depart?”

The pair nodded and Adam clicked his heels together and bowed lightly. He recovered his crop and hat, then moved to the library where he sank into an easy chair and stared at the empty fireplace, lost in thought.

Carriage rides were, after the first hour, interminably boring. Being jostled and bounced; the inability to truly write or read, with the only recourse being idle chatter or a discomfited sleep, it was a disatisfying experience. Albeit easier on the thighs.

Adam watched as the countryside rolled by and contributed to the back and forth between the couple in the carriage. George and Lance clasped each other’s hands tightly and Lance came alive as he pointed out various trees and features. George, for all his stiff bearing and short-cropped hair (A habit of his military days) softened and spent most of the time merely regarding the animated countenance of his husband. Adam watched their exchange and felt a faint aching envy. An experience both familiar and alien.

Such dalliances and futures were naught but a beautiful wish that was not within his future.

After a couple of hours of fitful sleep, the carriage rolled down the long gravel drive to Thaymor Manor, where it was promptly surrounded by a throng of chattering figures. Adam grumbled as he roused himself and fought the smile as Lance and George were pulled bodily from the carriage by eager hands and chattering faces.

The Archer siblings were, to put it politely, an event in and of themselves. A throng. A horde. An army. Implacable, relentless and far too enthusiastic to be good for anyone.

They were also the kindest people Adam had had the pleasure to be acquainted with over the years. He met the eye of Benjamin, an accountant by trade. The eldest Archer sibling nodded and grinned widely at Adam, "Mr de Gray! You grace us with your presence!"

"And you are clearly angling for my accounts, Benjamin."

"Ach! A man must drum up business by the best means. And best to be honest and up front. You still retain the services of the Star Associates?"

"They have not done me poorly these past years."

"A fair assessment. They say measure a man by his competition, in which case I must be a mighty sort indeed!"

Adam smiled and shook the man's hand, "A true statement. Should I have further ventures, I will look to include you. Your advice on the southern investments was invaluable, I must say."

"Well, then, I look forward to your patronage, Mr de Gray!"

Adam moved through the group, greeting the vast family, as they alternated between mobbing their fathers, whom they had actually seen only a few days prior, and exalting at Adam's presence.

Their family was a close one and one where Adam had always felt welcome. Accepted. *Seen* . Beyond the trappings and the necessity of his current station. They knew, of course, the reality of his duty and the background. But they bore the burden with him.

Some days it made it easier. It was certainly easier to be in the south. A strange dichotomy - to miss the beauty of home and the

freedom of roaming the halls, but to also fear the judgement and expectations of those around it; to seek solace among family not his own, whilst wearing the mask they knew to be fake.

He pushed such thoughts from his head and made for the house, the servants unloading the carriage, one leading Swift Wind to the stables. The horse had ambled alongside the carriage quite happily, not requiring a guide-rope. He was like that - loyal to a fault, if a tad boisterous.

Adam hoped that another stable door would not become a casualty of the horses' enthusiasm.

He took a moment to regard Thaymor. Red brick with grey cornerstones; arch, white rimmed windows. An impressive split stair leading to the front of the mansion. Black tiles on the slanted roof. It sported two wings and he knew it to be in the shape of a squared off horse-shoe, with a large courtyard behind the house and between the wings. Around, the grounds and manicured gardens stretched like a cultivated dream.

Compared with the cramp of the city, it was a pleasure.

But still not *quite* home.

It would do for now.

A bark of a laugh drew Adam's attention and he grinned as Beaurgard strode out of the front doors, arms spread, "WELCOME! Come, come! We have *lemonade* ! I tell you, the locals hereabouts are *geniuses* with fruits! Pressed apples! CHERRY JUICE! Come on, don't dally! I imagine you all could do with soft cushions and refreshments!"

Adam chuckled and strode up the stairs to meet his friend, who embraced him in a bear hug. Adam winced at the pressure on his chest for a moment, but slapped Beauregard on his back, "Good to see you. Despite it being barely a few days. I trust you have behaved?"

“On the contrary, I ignored your advice and called upon several of my neighbours in a most honest fashion.”

Mr de Gray tutted, “Well, I hope your foolhardy leap is worthwhile.”

“Oh you certainly will not approve, I think,” Beauregard grinned and patted Adam on the shoulder, “Come, let us *refresh* your palette. We do have a ball to plan for!”

Behind him, the Archer family trooped along, sharing excited stories of their explorations and the charm of the rustic surrounds. Adam groaned as he was led towards the promise of lemonade and (The worst of all worlds) the possibility of *dancing* several days hence.

“A ball, Beauregard? Am I not allowed to just go and shoot and fish and maybe… enjoy the lack of tall buildings hereabouts?”

Beauregard hummed, “Well, it is important to me, so I would be indebted if you would attend. Mayhap you can teach the locals some of your decorum?” he smiled and winked, “Though I feel you would have to hand out the requisite poles for them to sit upon to achieve your demeanour.”

Adam huffed and shouldered Beauregard, “Uncalled for sir. I am… capable of charming.”

“Ms Moon thought so… in a more roundabout manner, I believe.”

“Ah, your intended paramour? She has her hooks in you.”

Beauregard ignored the implication and smiled archly as he paused to regard his friend, “Oh no. Ms *Catra* Moon.”

Mr de Gray’s foot caught the edge of a flagstone and he stumbled slightly, but corrected the misstep momentarily, “Pardon, sir, I appear to have developed an affliction in my ear. What was that?”

“Oh, your attempts at apathy appear to have caught her rancor. A fine start. But I dare say you have her attention. If I am any judge of these things, of course.”

Adam harrumphed, “Well, we all know how *that* would turn out… if I was even the least bit inclined, which I may assure you sir, I am not.”

“Of course, of course,” Beauregard smiled placatingly and gestured to a set of tables and chairs arrayed on the veranda beside the western lawn, which rapidly filled with his chattering family. He gazed out across the gardens and added, as if musing upon the weather, “She will, of course, be at the ball as well. I am sure you more than capable of taking the measure of things and putting any… nagging thoughts to bed.”

Adam sat down carefully and glowered at his friend, “You, sir… are a frightful sort.”

“Indeed I am. Indeed I am,” he turned and clasped his hands behind his back, flicking the tails of his light brown coat, “And for that, you will ever be grateful, I am sure.”

Chapter End Notes

A bit of a traversal chapter for all of you to see some hints at Adora. Much like Darcy, we won't find out MUCH about Adora's truth just yet.

Oh and we're going to meet the Mr Collins insert next chapter.

Along with our Charlotte Lucas insert....

I do hope you like ;)

A dance to remember

Chapter Summary

> Catra attends a function most enjoyable and makes an acquaintance.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Preparations for social events were a rather involved activity, requiring the attendance of two maidservants at least. The addition of excitable siblings made the endeavour an undertaking of epic proportions.

Catra sighed as Glimmer helped her into her gown, the shorter girl fussing as she buttoned the back. The brunette frowned at her reflection in the mirror atop the dressing table, "Must we? These affairs are frightfully dull."

Glimmer, her hair more sparkly than usual to her latest acquisition from the Brightmoon General Post Store, glanced at Catra's reflection and rolled her eyes, "We must. For I require someone to converse with, should the dance with Mr Archer go awry."

"Awry she says!" Catra rolled her eyes in turn, then peered over her shoulder, "The man would tolerate you stamping his toes, Glim. You best have him fully bewitched by eve's end, else Perfuma may have her way!"

Glimmer grumbled, then frowned, "Perfuma… wouldn't, would she?"

Catra smirked and shrugged, "Best you don't give her the chance, my dearest. Stick to him like glue. Though I doubt that will be a problem for you."

The smaller of the sisters managed a derisive snort before shoving Catra gently. This, in turn, elicited a rasping cackle. Glimmer produced a brush from the dresser and mock glowered at her sister. Catra, for her part, widened her eyes in shock, "You wouldn't."

Glimmer's grin was like the devil possessed, "We need to make you look presentable, after all."

Scant minutes later, a sullen looking Catra (All a facade, as truly she was eager to see her sister safely reassured as to Mr Archer's clear affections) descended the stairs to join the family, Glimmer's arm hooked around Catra's own. Mr Moon paced, impatiently, his waistcoat of light pink and pastel coattails a match for his wife's own flowing, high bodice gown.

Catra felt the odd one out; her deep red dress and black gloves (which stretch to above her elbow) were certainly a brighter statement, compared to the muted blue of Frosta's dress; or the purpble and grey of Entrapta's. Mermista in her teal gown was almost a mirror to Angella's, save the shading. And Glimmer, of course, was a rainbow that seemed to not be a clash of fancies. Pink and purple, with a white under-skirt that complimented the whole ensemble.

"Well, we are still in time. Excellent. Excellent," Mr Moon clapped his hands, then fetched his top hat and cane from the table nearby. He gestured to the front door, "Well, my girls, let us not dilly dally! Mr Archer may have his mind set upon Glimmer, but my nerves will not be satisfied until all of you are suitably partnered," he quirked a grin at Catra, "Whomsoever that might be, of course."

Catra couldn't help the faint smile that graced her face, her canines peeking over her lip, "I am afraid no man shall bore me into such a predicament, father dear. I leave that luxury to Glimmer."

“A father can hope. Perhaps a lady might woo you? We are in an enlightened age and such an event would still do us proud.”

Angella reached across and grasped Mr Moon’s hand, her eyes crinkled with mirth and tender affection, “A man with the right words. Such to melt an icy heart.”

“As if yours was ever so imperilled, my love.”

“Are we not going to a ball? This is all rather *ikky* ,” grumbled Frosta, “I want to *dance* !”

Glimmer stepped over the last stair and smiled at her youngest sister, “But you are not even ten, surely?”

“Eleven! I am eleven! More than old enough to be dancing!”

“Well, should any young officer take a fancy to you, I will be having *words* ,” harrumphed Glimmer. Catra stepped up alongside and arched an eyebrow.

“And I too. We have our eyes on you, little one.”

“I’m not *little* .”

Entrapta, who was perched on one of the hall chairs, glanced up, “Observable evidence would disagree on that point.”

Frosta stomped her foot and growled, “I *hate* you all.”

This did not elicit a round of apologies or sympathy. Merely a group nod and sighs of amused acceptance. Micah stepped forward and laid a hand on her shoulder, “My dear, I will ensure you have a dance this evening. It would be my honour to ensure no vagabonds attempt to dishonour you.”

That just drew out another grumble from the diminutive girl, but the family was at least able to board their modest carriage and rattle down the lanes to the Town hall at Thaymor Village - not too much larger than Brightmoon, it still had more in the way of

amenities: two taverns *and* a coaching in, as well as several boutiques. That term might be stretching the definition, but for villagers, they were certainly of a refined taste - carrying silks and more class-appropriate dinnerware.

The hall was relatively modest - a main hall for town meetings, which had been set up to entertain the gentry. Outside, carriages lined up down the main street, their drivers gathered about the horse trough with warmed wine to keep the evening chill at bay.

Micah helped the family from the carriage and escorted them through the double doors into the gathered throng. It was quite the collection of local society, bolstered in no small part by the attending Archer contingent. By themselves, they appeared to have occupied a whole quarter of the room, having sequestered themselves near to the string quartet. Glimmer started, the intimidation clear upon her face. Catra stepped alongside her and squeezed her hand, "Worry not," she whispered, "If they are akin to Mr Archer, you might find yourself with *several* options."

She giggled as Glimmer swatted at her arm, then frowned as a tall figure detached themselves from their position near the door, close enough to potentially eavesdrop. Catra noticed the dark hue of their coat, lined with a red velvet; grey trousers, shaggily cropped blonde hair and a very well defined profile of the face. She wasn't able to gain a good measure of the gentleman (Nor did she feel inclined to do so) but their sudden departure across the room irked her, as if they wished to be *away* from the Moon contingent. She was distracted as a few of the other families approached to welcome them and found herself swept along to a small collection of chairs set to the edge of the large room.

It wasn't *grand* , perhaps by comparison to some of the major salons or halls of Elberon, but the layout was sufficient for the gathering - a musical quartet playing gentle music in preparation for the more involved pieces for the dancing; the pair of mirrors that flanked the hall midway along, themselves flanked by back-to-back seats; the canapes and flurrying serving staff; it certainly

gave the appearance of a cosmopolitan gathering and to-do event.

Truly, Catra did not *despise* these events; she merely found them disappointing. Especially so since her awakening to her true nature and personal leanings; there wasn't easy opportunity for her to really *meet* anyone. And the dancing was, despite societal shifts in Elberon and beyond, rather staid and traditional.

She glanced about the room and spied Mr Archer. She frowned, however, as she noticed the gentleman from the door, back to her, conversing with him. For his part, Mr Archer had a rather skeptical look upon his face. The taller gentleman raised both hands in the universal expression of *I despair of you* and stalked away behind another crowd. Catra wondered at the fuss, but was distracted as Glimmer pressed a glass of sherry into her hand, "Ah! I see you have seen him? Any of the other ladies circling?"

Catra shook her head, then peered about the room, "None as yet, dearest. We shall see if he holds true to his word on the promise of dancing, shall we not?"

"Ladies! Oh you look lovely!" the pair turned and their grins broadened as a familiar figure practically skipped towards them. Her long, frizzy blonde hair was tied into a neat bun behind her hair and she wore a floral pink dress with matching white gloves. Glimmer spread her arms and grappled the girl.

"Cousin Perfuma! Oh it has been an age!" Catra stood and embraced the girl once Glimmer had let her go, then stepped back to hold her arms.

"You turned out quite well this evening, though no floral bonnet?"

"Oh Catra, you know that's for *outdoor* parties… but I couldn't resist…" Perfuma turned her head to show a single flower pinned above her right ear, "And I hear through mother that you have already *snagged* the most eligible bachelor?" the blonde hummed

and arched a thin eyebrow, her tanned features split in a conspiratorial grin.

Glimmer blushed and jutted her chin slightly, "He may have called upon us and he *may* have asked for several dances before our attendance here."

Catra smirked, then arched her own eyebrow at Perfuma, "Is it to be war, cousin dear? Are we to have fists at dawn or some such rot over the potential suitor?"

Perfuma smiled and shook her head, "Whilst I did have my eye on the gentleman…. I will not press my case. In spite of mother asking me to do so… no, unless he pursues me first, in which case we shall have counsel as to whether he is a cad or a bounder, no?"

Glimmer seemed to relax visibly; for though pretty Catra knew her sister always felt somewhat inferior to the willowy cousin. Their introspection was interrupted by a piercing and commanding tone, as a tall, raven haired woman approached.

"Ah Glimmer! Catra dear! I am disappointed you are not wearing the shawls I knitted for you!" the woman, who might have been Micah's feminine doppelganger, stepped up beside Perfuma, a fan in hand, "Regardless, it is good to see you attending society functions and being… seen."

The sisters shared the briefest of glances before Glimmer spoke, "Aunt Casta, it is a pleasure. We have not had the pleasure of you to tea for so long?"

"Well, since Mr Lucas' passing I have felt bereft these past two years. Dear Perfuma has been most patient *of course* but still. I have *barely* had time to compose my letters!"

"Yes mama dear, barely any time between your repose in the drawing room, to wandering the gardens, to maybe, perhaps, talking overlong with that new tenant … what *was* her name?" Perfuma smiled sweetly and tapped her lips with a finger tip.

Catra had to prevent herself from goggling in a most unladylike manner at the sudden *flush* of Aunt Casta's face. The older woman hushed her daughter and tapped her on the shoulder with the fan, but her face had the smallest smirk, "I cannot imagine what you mean, 'Fuma dear. She is merely doing a wonderful job and I wished to compliment her efforts to restore the gardens thereabouts."

Perfuma's face, as she locked eyes with Catra, was so earnest as to be painful, "Truly, she has masterful grasp of gardening. Talented hands to be sure, which I am sure you are most appreciative of, mother dear, for the maintenance of your properties."

Catra had to hold her sherry glass before her face, to hide the grin. Aunt Casta nodded sagely, "Truly. I cannot be more grateful for such an attentive tenant," she smiled at the girls, then leaned close to Perfuma, "And she has a very silver tongue, wonderful for… conversing."

The blonde blinked and whipped her head to regard her mother, but the raven haired woman was already waltzing away to engage another group. Glimmer chuckled, "'Fuma dear, I do believe you have been outplayed."

The blonde shook her head, then smiled, "I have learned much, but clearly, I should not assume an oblivious air from others. Truly, I still have to be taught. She is incorrigible."

The girls tittered and Catra led Perfuma to sit with them, "So, do tell of your mothers newest fascination? She is now, what… a *friend of Mara?"*

Perfuma gave a genteel shrug, "I would not wish public discourse on my mother's partnering… except I feel this is no dalliance. The tenant, one Miss Juliet Honore, is lately returned from a sojourn overseas. She is of stern countenance, save when she and mother exchange pleasantries, whereupon she is a tongue tied schoolgirl! And mother, well… she seems enchanted. I feel, at the least, this

is a deep acquaintance," she adjusted her hands in her lap and looked between her two cousins, "But I hope it is more. Mother has been lonely since father passed. Truly, she loved him, deeply. But, perhaps, it was not the *same* sort of love; a fondness, a kindness… but when she talks with Juliet? It is the sort of gaze I can only wish to receive from someone. And that I hope to one day cast upon another."

Glimmer and Catra exchanged a look that was wet with emotion and fondness. Glimmer reached over and squeezed Perfuma's hand, "It will happen, 'Fuma. I pray that you find it."

"As long as it is not with Mr Archer?" teased Catra. It earned her a faint, but half hearted scowl from Glimmer and a broad, freckled grin from Perfuma.

"Miss Moon?" the tentative query broke their small circle for a moment. All three women turned and answered at the same time:

"Yes?"

The object of their amusement was, of course, Mr Archer. He looked momentarily stunned then grinned, "I rather stepped into that one, did I not? Although you, my dear, are Ms Lucas, are you not?"

Perfuma, inclined her head slightly, "Just so. But my mother is a Moon and so I would be remiss to not take advantage to guarantee at least one amusing anecdote?"

"Very droll indeed! Capital!" Mr Archer clapped his hands and grinned, then looked to Glimmer, his smile becoming almost bashful, "Ms *Glimmer* Moon, as promised, may I steal you away before the dance? I would like to introduce you to my sister, if you would be so kind?"

Glimmer stared, then nodded rapidly. She stood and took Mr Archer's hand, then let herself be led across the room towards the gathered family. Perfuma glanced at Catra with a faint frown, "Rather overwhelming, surely?"

Catra merely shrugged, “She wishes to partake, she needs to accept all the accessories as well. Notably, a lot more siblings. Of course, she *is* well versed.”

“True. They do make an adorable couple too.”

“Hmmm, quite.”

“And are you on the lookout for a potential prospect?” Perfuma leaned over and nudged Catra gamefully, her smile suggestive. Catra huffed.

“I doubt any here fit my particular aspirations.”

“Well, a dance is just a dance, not a promise, cousin dear. Enjoy it for what it is. Though there is a gentleman who appears rather curious.”

Catra arched an eyebrow, “Where? And what?”

“Some tall fellow - I am not familiar with him. Strange, he was over by the Archers momentarily… but appears to have absconded. Truly, he was regarding you most closely it appeared. But such a countenance! Disagreeable, stern.”

“Well, I will certainly not dance with one who *scowls* at me. A waste of time to be sure. And what of your, Perfuma? Anyone caught your fancy?”

The blonde sighed and shook her head, “None; I may see whether the Archers have a bachelor… available? But I think it unlikely with the cavalcade of ladies with them. Truly, though, the prospect does not *excite* me. I’d rather dance and be merry than be concerned with the prospects of acquiring a suitor. It rather detracts from the whimsy, does it not?”

Catra eyed her cousin and gave a half smile, “Oh so impractical of you, Perfuma.”

“You are a fine one to jest; limiting yourself… but I am proud that you have become *yourself* , Catra. Envious, perhaps,” Perfuma sounded almost wistful for a moment, then shrugged, “But mother dear would so like me to be secure. I know she worries. So, I must consider my options, as the sole Lucas heir.”

“A hefty burden. But do not wish away your whimsy for the sake of duty. More than enough of that to go around,” grumbled Cata. She saw her drink was finished and placed the small glass onto the tray of a passing server, then stood, “I will take a turn, speak to the others of repute… and try to ensure Entrapta has not ignited a conflagration beneath a table.”

Perfuma smiled, “Again?”

“Indeed. *Again* . Come with?”

“Indeed so!”

The pair stood and took a walk around the room’s perimeter, making small talk with the various well-to-dos of the county. Catra caught glimpses of Angella making light conversation with other matriarchs of various families, whilst Micah was in an enthusiastic exchange with a tall gentleman with dreadlocks and a face that was akin to an older Mr Archer - one of the fathers, perhaps?

They found themselves at the food table, where a servant was arranging a platter of small cheeses. Catra plucked one with a skewer and frowned at the taste, “Rather tart.”

“Indeed; apparently brought up from Elberon by our new neighbour. These city delicacies are rather too much for my palate I fear.”

Catra nodded slowly; the food wasn’t bad, just not what she was used to - simple fare (Though, perhaps, not quite so simple as to be found in a tavern); much of the food here had *olives* or *oranges* involved in their preparation. Solid meats and minimal vegetables was her preferred dish and this was all so *varied* .

The pair picked at the food and took a refreshed glass of sherry each, before retiring to the chairs beside the mirror. Perfuma paused then huffed, "Mama dearest is gesturing to me, do excuse me for a moment Catra."

The brunette chuckled and adjusted one black glove, "I fear you are about to be promised to some rake!"

Perfuma tutted and smiled, "I don't think she'd *dare* . But I do spy Ms Juliet loitering at the entrance, so perhaps she merely wishes me to save her from her current conversation for better fare?"

"Always the knight, aren't you Perfuma?" Catra gave her a cocky smirk and Peruma returned an elaborate shrug.

"Well all play our parts. Mine are just more exciting at times!"

Catra watched her cousin go and shook her head, then stole a glance to the double doors where there was indeed a rather handsome woman. Her hair was a rich brown and her gown a deep silver design, laced at the front, with shoulders covered. It almost looked like armour as the light caught it, but it flowed well. She looked commanding and yet had an air of discomfort about her; as if the surrounds of the ball were awkward and alien. It was a feeling Catra remembered well, from her young days; to be surrounded by strangers and unsure.

It was interesting to watch as the woman's face shifted from awkward reservation to sudden, unbridled joy as Aunt Casta approached. Catra observed and felt a twinge; a pang of *longing* so sudden it made her twitch in surprise. The woman - Juliet - schooled her features but Catra could still see the way the women regarded one another; the gentle way that Casta took her arm in her own and let her, confidently, into the throng.

She felt the presence of others sitting about her and smiled when she recognised the rather *preeminent* Friends of Mara - the Telae's. Netossa had a rather large plate stacked with food, held carefully in one hand. The other smoothed her purple and grey

dress down as she adjusted herself. Her hair was done up into a braid, the silver highlight of the strands neatly confined - a far cry from her usually unkempt and wild appearance.

Her partner (For truly, Catra was uncertain as to their arrangement) sat down on Catra's other side, her deep purple gown hugging her curves well; she wore a lighter purple shawl about her shoulders, which she twitched into a more comfortable position, then smiled at Catra.

"Ms Moon, lovely to see you. We had hoped to call on you for tea last week, but found ourselves waylaid!"

Netossa snorted, "Accosted by a *gentleman* no less!"

Spinnerella huffed and gave her partner a frown, "Oh you; you rather enjoyed his company, if I recall!"

Netossa's scowl split into a genuine smile, "Actually, true. Mr Archer is a very game fellow! A bit awkward and unsure at first but not at all unpleasant. He has even invited me to go *shooting* with the gentlemen this coming week!"

Catra blinked in shock, "Shooting? But surely that is a gentleman's occupation?"

"Rubbish," snorted Netossa, "And it's his land, he can do whatever. Though he did warn me he is a rather good shot. Very vague on that though when I asked about his favoured calibre… said something about *yew* wood. Never seen a blunderbuss made of yew!"

The brunette smiled, "And do you intend to attend in your finery?"

"Whatever allows me to yomp about in the mud will suffice! And I dare say my better half would down right murder me if I ruined her latest creation," she gestured to her dress and Catra nodded slowly, eyes wide as she appraised the gown. She turned to Spinnerella.

“I did not realise you were a tailor, madam!”

“We all have our talents, Ms Moon; I was graced with one befitting societal expectations of a woman… insofar as I can create. Establishing my own business, well.. That took more in the way of force. For which I am grateful that my wife is as persistent as an avalanche,” Spinnerealla smiled and tossed her hair, currently dyed a grey-purple, over her shoulder. Her gentle face shifted into a soft smile and Netossa *blushed.*

"Well, I couldn’t very well let those dingbats in Elberon throw away talent like yours, my love. But at least things are changing. Fifteen years ago, yes it was *scandalous* . But, we’re rather past that now. They were more offended at my dear Spinny running things in town without a man at the helm than they were at us being an item.”

The women chuckled at that and the trio exchange pleasantries. Catra felt the chair behind hers adjust slightly as someone moved, but was rather caught up in the minor gossip from the elder women; the comings and goings, the fashions coming from Elberon and Spinnerella’s own business - how they were in the country for an extended break, as her tailoring firm was now a rather large and profitable concern!

After an appropriate amount of small talk, Spinnerella peered about the room and then leaned into Catra, “So, any young, available ladies that have caught your fancy?”

The person behind Catra coughed slightly, as if sputtering on their drink. It made Catra smile slightly; despite the understanding of the locals, and in fact their eager attitudes to embrace the *new* and maybe-not-so-new, some were still a bit perplexed by the idea. She glanced about the ball and sighed.

“I fear not; a true curse of the country life; especially as many are looking for husbands. I am not here to garner an *alliance* or some sort of contract. I hope, one day, it will be of my own volition, not of pretty fancy or an undignified flirtation.”

The elder women exchanged a knowing look, “Ahhhh romance,” Netossa murmured, “An aspiration to be sure. But how can you be sure there are none here? Have you even looked?”

Catra shifted uncomfortably, then shrugged, “Glimmer and Mermista are more the talk today and… I do not feel I am able to garner the interest of one who might be a *friend* of Mara; how would one even begin that conversation? How to progress or probe the inquiry? How to advance my affections beyond mere friendship without risking it?”

Netossa patted her shoulder, then smiled at her wife (*Wife!* Truly, such things were possible), “Well, we managed my dear. It wasn’t easy, it wasn’t quick… but no things in this life are truly simple if they are worth having. And you are a beautiful young woman, who likely has shattered the hearts of men across the county; take faith that a heart beats for you somewhere, in the form you wish it to be.”

A change in the tempo of the music made Spinnerella perk up, “Ah! Dancing! Catra my dear, would you excuse us?”

The young brunette smiled and waved at them, “Off you go, prance away. It will do me good to imagine this as my future, rather than spinsterhood.”

“Pish posh, Catra,” admonished Netossa.

“Ahh but how could I compete with so many fine ladies?” grinned Catra, “Truly, I am outmatched! Now, off you go, before Glimmer steals *all* the space. She is all heels and toes with dancing.”

The married coupled chuckled, nodded, then stepped away, arm in arm. Catra sighed and watched as they took to the floor, opposite one another. The dancers, arrayed opposite one another. Glimmer and Mr Archer faced each other, ridiculous smiles on their faces as they began the back and forth in time with their partners. Netossa and Spinnerella were laughing as they moved back and

forth in time with their line, hands coming up to clasp briefly as they swayed.

“M’lady,” came a voice from behind her, “I could not help but overhear. I think, should you glance to your left that you will find the most lovely woman of all at this very ball.”

The voice was soft, calm, with a halting, feminine edge to it. It was faintly familiar. Almost without thinking, Catra glanced to her left and found herself regarding the mirror. She frowned, seeing no one else sat there, then her gaze fell upon her own reflection. She chuckled and shook her head, “Well now, such forwardness I am told is unbecoming from a lady.”

“Well I find it peculiarly charming, paired with such a striking countenance as yours.”

Catra chuckled, “Oh so I am the one who is forward? Pray elaborate, for I find myself at a loss,” she smirked and sipped at her sherry.

“Well, a lady with such a striking gaze and equally bold attire must surely command attention and intend to do so,” came the easy reply, “Truly, a boldness that sets others aside and shows no fear. How can that be anything other than forward, confident and commanding?”

The voice was amused, but flattering; their tone genuine and even, unless she was quite mistaken, a little halting. Perhaps more nervous than she had assumed? What fair flower was this, so bold, so unabashed, yet also so tremulous?

Catra adjusted her gloves one more, “Well, you yourself are hardly a shrinking violet in your pursuit. I wonder whether your own forwardness is likewise paired with a supposedly pleasing visage?”

There was a faint stutter of breath, “Well, I believe it is not worth your bother, my lady. I merely wished to ensure you were aware that you are, indeed, the belle… and it would not… I could not hold a flicker...”

The sudden shift made Catra roll her eyes, "Come now, such modesty is unbecoming after so confident a thrust! Such boldness must stem from a true…."

She turned in her chair to regard her admirer and faltered. Scruffy blonde hair and a dark coat with red lining. She blinked, her azure and gold set eyes fluttering in mild confusion. She stuttered out her last word.

"...beauty?" The figure tilted their chin back and stiffed ever so slightly. Catra's face set in a *firmly* neutral expression and she sighed, "Ah. A man."

And then those cold, sharp eyes locked onto hers and she felt *something* jolt within her, a strange stifling feeling.

Deep deep blue, set with a faint hint of grey steel. Like stormclouds upon a peaceful sky. The blonde stranger inclined their head and a thin lipped attempt at a smile crossed their face, "Ms Moon, a pleasure to make your acquaintance again. I apologise for disturbing you. And also for my… abrupt manner the other day."

The gentleman stood and gave a short bow. Catra blinked, dumbfounded and coughed, "Sir, you have the advantage of me. Doubly so for your rather uncalled for attentions."

The man nodded abruptly once more, "I merely wished to make amends for my earlier… rudeness? And I could not help but overhear your… concerns. Mr de Gray, at your service. I will leave you to enjoy the ball, madam. Good evening."

She watched as the man executed another stiff bow, then saw him stalk towards the Archer crowd, where he seemed to vanish into their throng.

Catra blinked and shook her head. Another *man* trying to press his suit? The audacity!

And yet why had that look touched her so?

She huffed and stood, then headed for her family. What she needed right now was another drink and, perhaps, a chance to set the world to rights. A glance told her that Glimmer was *still* dancing with Mr Archer, though the latter appeared to be distracted by something momentarily. With a huff, Catra circled the dance and found Mermista, who was sat with a book in hand. Catra sat down heavily next to her, which drew a gaze of both irritation and concern from her sibling.

“So, bad encounter?” murmured Mermista.

“Mr de Gray appears to want to engage in *discourse* with me.”

“Oh? He seems conspicuous by his absence?” chuckled Mermista.

“Well! He came over, flattered me in some sort of womanly tone, then apologised and stormed off!”

“Ohhhh is he the one who looks as if he’s eaten something bitter?”

“The very same!”

Mermista shrugged, “Not bad on the eyes and I hear he is worth…”

“I do not care for his stipend, his holdings or his britches!” hissed Catra, “Only that he… was so… so… *forward* . And *charming* . And… not…”

“A lady?”

“Exactly!” Catra folded her arms and growled, “I wish to dance, but the thought of it makes my skin itch.”

“It is just dancing, Catra. Not betrothal. Get up, take a turn with some partners, you might find a young lady of confused countenance whom you can persuade?” Mermista nudged her and Catra coughed in disgust.

“I am not some… temptress!”

“Mr de Gray maybe believes so!”

“Then he is a perfect example of the lack of bearing in men. He should know better.”

“Regardless, go, dance. Let me finish my book in peace.”

Catra nudged her and huffed, “Shant.”

“You sound like Frosta.”

“Ugh. You make a point so valid it pains me. Very well. But you must partner with me for the first steps? To ensure my card is not taken by some cad.”

“If I must…” grinned Mermista. Together they stood and made their way to the floor. As they danced, Catra felt eyes upon her but dismissed them. It irked her, being approached so. Yet the apology, the confusion of emotions upon the face of Mr de Gray; the strangeness of their countenance: somehow it served to mollify her irritation to merely a mild confusion.

The gentleman was new to the area, he was not to know of her aversions. And yet he had been so forthright, so forward it was bordering on scandalous. In truth, she had wished for a woman of such bearing; truly the universe played a cruel trick to immediately deliver a man of such focus and attitude.

She pushed Mr de Gray from her mind and spun and danced with her sisters and even several of the Archer brothers; married men all, it turned out. And that, she did not mind as much. Cavorting and losing herself in the music and the set of steps between partners, she relaxed.

Truly, she would not think on Mr de Gray and his sour countenance. His tense bearing. His sad, blue eyes.

She would not.

Catra was exceedingly good at lying to herself.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the delay on this one - Part 1 of 2 of the BALL!

And it's just their first ball ;) have to have some frisson for their first PROPER meeting. We will get Ad...AMs view next chapter ;)

This is the scene I wanted to pay homage to:

https://twitter.com/adooboo1/status/1308809251565875200/photo/2

A glimpse

Chapter Summary

Adam partakes of the ball.

Assumptions are made

A risk is taken... and promptly failed.

(The ball from Adam's perspective)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The evening was a tumultuous one, this was a proven fact. Social events were always a precarious balancing act of socially acceptable decorum and frustrating irritation. It was one reason that Adam made sure to only attend for the minimum *acceptable* amount of time. High society demanded one be visible; not *approachable* of course - there was a way to things of course.

Three people had approached Adam *directly* to introduce themselves, which was *quite* improper - decorum demanded that (as they had not presented themselves in a more formal method via the House) the host of this…. Soiree present the guests to those of a higher station. Perform *proper* introductions. But no, apparently local gentry went about just *saying hello directly* .

It was most confusing and had left Adam with a rather stern set to their brow.

It didn’t help that the binder was being very constrictive this evening and the room was approaching unpleasant in its warmth - a side effect of a roaring fire at the side of the room and the presence of so many bodies in such a confined space. It being a local hall it was hardly grand by Elberon standards. In reality,

Adam could have fitted this one room into the main ballroom at Greyskull Manor with room to spare.

Of course Adam was not so crass as to point that out.

It was quite surprising at the sheer number of moneyed individuals in the shire. Some awkward conversations had indicated that many of the individuals were *Sirs* - Merchants who had procured a title or merely managed to accord themselves a facsimile of gentility via the acquisition of wealth.

Whilst Adam respected the work ethic, there was a certain vulgarity of the assumption that being rich meant they believed themselves *cultured* .

Or even with a dim awareness of social mores.

Of course, Adam had accompanied the Archers who had a very loose approach to all that anyway, but they got away with it by being both affable *and* cultured. Their enthusiasm was infectious. Of course, they were in full flow, overwhelming the room with their charm; indeed the clan appeared to have occupied a full third of the small ballroom.

Adam had retreated to near the main door, where a faint draft provided some measure of relief from both the warmth of the room and the stifling air of the company present. The respite was short lived as a commotion from the entryway beyond drew Adam's attention.

A *circus* practically fell into the room - a whirlwind of femininity that gave a pulse of faint resentment and interest breath within Adam's chest. A tall, regal woman with a noble bearing - her angular features were striking and she immediately dominated the room. Her presence was slightly under cut by the shorter man on her arm - still of proud countenance, he had an air of excitement about him.

They were followed by said circus - a bustling, rustling collection of young ladies. At this angle Adam barely got a decent regard of

them, beyond one with purple pigtails who practically bowled into the room, alongside a smaller one in a blue dress - the pair practically dashed into the crowd, heading for some manner of refreshment. Not even awaiting their own *announcement* .

Practically *feral* .

The other three were more mature - a tall girl with darker skin and a teal dress, and a bored expression; and two who seemed vaguely familiar - or rather the one with outrageously sparkling hair was - Adam could not take the measure of the brunette on her arm, dressed in a striking red dress.

Adam did, however, overhear their eager conversation.

"Worry not," the girl in red whispered, most salaciously, "If they are akin to Mr Archer, you might find yourself with several options."

Adam's grip tightened on their brandy glass. A cold sense of anger settled in Adam's gut - a familiar recognition. Glory-seekers. Ladder climbing, perhaps. But it did not *quite* match the nerves that were clearly apparent on the pink-haired girl's face.

This must be the Moon family, Adam surmised. A middle tier collection of ill-mannered, chaotic country gentry. And with ambitions, no less!

Adam stalked across the floor, only catching the briefest glimpse of the brunette as she turned her face to watch their passage. Adam got a brief glimpse of a fine jaw line, a faint frown and a flash of faint recognition. But instead Adam powered towards the Archers and singled out Beauregard.

"Mr de Gray, enjoying yourself?" Mr Archer grinned at his companion. Adam sighed and shook his head.

"Nary a decent proposition in sight," they managed.

“I bet you haven’t even tried to review your options. I know from a brief survey of the room that many have reviewed *you* .”

“And you know the challenge *that* presents.”

“Perhaps. And your expected object of attraction?”

Adam grimaced, “I believe she has arrived along with her clan. And I use the word with all meaning - a bunch of reavers and raiders intent on the Archer name and fortune.”

Beauregard shot Adam a very skeptical look, “Oh, indeed? You believe them intent on dishonouring me or attempting to acquire station?”

“Indeed, sir.”

“And what, mayhap, has brought this asinine conclusion?”

“I may have overhead them considering multiple prospects from the Archers at the door.”

Beauregard shook his head, “You are being a tad overwrought *Adam* . You see treachery everywhere,” he inclined his head and arched his eyebrows, dark skin flushed as he smiled, “I am capable of surviving my own affairs.”

“Affairs which you will walk into without your eyes open to the possibility of *betrayal* .”

“Such is the risk of love, my friend. I… I know you yourself are no stranger to these risks. But I cannot and will not hold myself back on the basis of misheard *poppycock* .”

Adam gave an exasperated gesture, “Fine. Just do not be surprised at the shock should things fail to fall into place. I merely ask for you to be more *cautious* . Do not make my mistake.”

Beauregard softened his expression faintly and nodded, “I understand… now, if you do not mind.”

With a harrumph, Adam turned and stalked through the crowd to where the servants were serving more brandy. He plucked a glass and supped at it, back against the wall, eyes scanning the throng. Adam watched as Beauregard exchanged a few words with his parents, the two fathers slapping his shoulders in encouragement. Lance even shook a fist and grinned. Adam bit at their lip and winced at the paternal display something so familiar, yet also so far removed now.

With a shudder, Adam swept their gaze across the room once more - eyes landing upon the Moon women once more. Or rather, upon two of them. They appeared to be in conference with a third, whilst a fourth woman with raven locks moved away from their little huddle.

Mr de Gray took a moment to study the group. The object of Mr Archer's affections - Ms Glimmer Moon, if Mr de Gray remembered correctly - was certainly nervous and appeared to be shooting glances towards the Archer party. Perhaps nervous her ruse to ensnare such a noble man would fail? Fear of the task ahead? Nervous she would miss her chance and someone else might step into her path to glory?

The blonde of the group was a willowy sort and Adam recognised her - she had been *properly* introduced, at least, by her mother and the host of the event. Ms Perfuma Lucas. Certainly a homely sort and she had appeared confused at Adam's countenance. It had induced a fear in Adam - a sense of being *seen* that they had not, heretofore, experience. But Perfuma had just smiled and curtseyed and made polite conversation before Adam had excused themselves.

The third woman…

The.

The third woman.

Was a woman.

Yes.

Very much so.

She.

Yes well.

Woman. Third part of the group.

Lady.

Lady .

Adam's grip on the brandy glass would possibly have shattered it had they not set it down. Why was it suddenly so *unbearably* warm.

How had Adam *not* realised sooner? The proud countenance, the confident smirk, the straight set to her posture? And, even from here, a scant twenty feet, Adam could see the fire in her eyes, although not the colour.

Without the confusion of movement Adam could now take in her all. Her shape, her standing, her protective gestures towards Ms Glimmer Moon. This was the girl from the woods; the one who matched wits and looked like she had lost a fight with a bramble bush. And *now* she looked like she had stepped from the pages of some printed page of a particularly fantastical tale. The set of her arms, encased in those gloves; the hang of the dress, laced at the back, revealing a modest amount of cleavage. The flow of her hair set into a messy and yet almost provocative weave.

Adam blinked as they realised Perfuma had glanced across the room towards them. Adam turned to refresh their glass and took a deep draught.

This was ridiculous. A sole encounter in woodland. A minor exchange of verbal barbs. And now a barely coherent view across a crowded room and they were *smitten*? Not hardly!

It was clearly the warmth. The room. The pressure of all these local gentry and their fawning ways. Adam was merely off-centred, of course. This was the most logical explanation. Light headed. Frustrated for Beauregard who did not see the danger.

It was likely this was not a deep attraction, but a fear response? Recognition of another threat to his dear friend?

Yes. That was logical.

Adam took another brandy glass and sunk it, then turned to see Beauregard escorting Glimmer towards the Archers. They noted Lance in conversation with Mr Moon and frowned. Lance was usually an excellent judge of character but he seemed genuinely enamoured with the bearded Mr Moon.

Fortified with sufficient alcohol Adam managed to navigate through the Archers and caught sight of the raven haired woman - Mrs Casta Lucas, that was her. She seemed deep in conversation with a new arrival. Adam faltered, mid stride and stared: the *look* the pair of women exchanged, the tentative touches. Adam watched as the new arrival practically sagged with relief as soon as Mrs Lucas reached her. Behind them, Adam could make out Ms Perfuma Lucas engaging a rather red faced gentleman in polite conversation and felt a short pang of empathy as she considered the blonde's forced smile. A stark contrast to the almost tender expression on the face of her mother.

It was confusing. They understood that, in Elberon, these sort of things were acceptable and, frankly, long overdue. But here? Truly? No one seemed to be accosting the women, so perhaps it was merely a deep friendship?

And why had these thoughts manifested? Adam had hardly given a consideration to the inter relational trajectory of the other guests. Why was this so noticeable?

Truly vexing came Adam's thoughts. They continued through the throng, arms clasped behind their back and then took in another

sight - the *other* Ms Moon.

Catra?

Yes.

She was sat alone on one of the set ranks of chairs, face a mask of contentment. Adam was on the opposite side of the row now and, on a whim, moved to sit as well. They took the chair behind Ms Catra Moon, just as another pair of ladies sat next to the bewitching brunette.

A servant handed over another glass as they sashayed past, which Adam took gratefully. The conversation behind was interesting. And incredibly enlightening.

Of course Beauregard had charmed them - he was that way inclined after all; a friend to all. He had missed a trick in not joining the Governmental departments concerned with overseas relations, a missed opportunity of course!

Adam barely repressed a grin at the woman's commentary about a *yew* blunderbuss. Truly the ladies were in for a shock. Beauregard could do wonders with an arrow. True to his namesake, of course.

Adam was stunned at the admission that, not only were these ladies people of *business* and *capability* but they were also *married* . It should not have been such a shock, but the fact they were here and none commented on it was both amazing and also heartbreaking. Adam adjusted the chair, which squeaked faintly and took a sip of the wine - mixing drinks was, perhaps, a poor idea.

Then came the question, *"So, any young, available ladies that have caught your fancy?"*

Adam practically spluttered and had to fish for a handkerchief to dab at the speckles of wine down the front of their waistcoat.

Mind a blur, Adam managed to refocus on the chatter behind: the profession of a union not for alliance, but for…

Love?

Cruel irony, to be sure. To be afflicted with aspirations of romance that were so counter to expectations of duty and familial bond?

And it called into question the Moon's motivations. Were the parents setting their children on acquisitive paths and this one merely a rebel? Or were they all likewise charmed by the prospect of love? The latter prospect seemed fanciful.

Love was a lie. A fabrication. A thing invented to explain momentary attachment for gain.

It was vulnerability. It was the release of control. It was a surrender to forces not within the bounds of ones own mind.

And in that moment, addled with a small amount of imbibed courage, it was something that called to Adam. Or rather called to something that *Adam* was forced to conceal.

For Catra raised some pertinent points as she spoke - how did one *explore* the possibility, surrounded by circumstance and decorum? Adam listened as the young woman outlined the difficulties of exploring and identifying; of broaching that most delicate of topics. Which was of course met with a brusque, knowing response, from those who had made it already.

That was almost as infuriating. Adam knew from experience that there was little more useless in life than well-meant platitudes. Pleasant as the women were, there was a naivete in their couching - that things would be *well*.

The world did not operate according to that design, Adam knew that well enough.

But the wistfulness in Catra's tone chimed at something within Adam's bound breast, something close to recognition and care. A

longing for *something*. To be seen, of course. To be reminded that others *saw* you. As you really were. And so the words spilled forth as Adam stared at the woman in profile, set in the mirror to their side.

"M'lady," Adam began falteringly, their voice not as deep as normally affected, "I could not help but overhear. I think, should you glance to your left that you will find the most lovely woman of all at this very ball."

Adam watched in the mirror, their own visage obscured by the angle, as Catra stared into the glass. From here, Adam could see the mismatch of her eyes, the dusting of freckles across olive skin. Could see the elfin shape of her features more clearly, her demure nose and dimpled face, framed by rebellious locks and streaked hair. Catra's laugh, when it came, was a squeaked chuckle that tickled something in Adam's soul.

"Well now, such forwardness I am told is unbecoming from a lady," the voice, filled with the same heat, but banked, as from the woodland.

Adam tried to parse the meaning, however. Was Catra assuming that she would not be so forward? Admiring the approach? "Well I find it peculiarly charming, paired with such a striking countenance as yours."

"Oh so I am the one who is forward? Pray elaborate, for I find myself at a loss," again Catra chuckled and Adam pondered a moment more. Had Catra assumed that Adam was a *lady* ? Their heart skipped for a moment, whether in joy or fear they could not comprehend.

Well, a lady with such a striking gaze and equally bold attire must surely command attention and intend to do so," came Adam's easy reply, "Truly, a boldness that sets others aside and shows no fear. How can that be anything other than forward, confident and commanding?"

Adam watched as Catra adjusted her gloves in the mirror as she responded, "Well, you yourself are hardly a shrinking violet in your pursuit. I wonder whether your own forwardness is likewise paired with a supposedly pleasing visage?"

That made Adam pause as the alcohol failed to dull the realisation. Adam's eyes widened and they stuttered for a moment as logic *finally* shouldered *idealism* aside. Catra was a Friend of Mara and not interested in gentlemanly advances. Adam was a gentleman. In *theory.*

This was liable to go poorly.

Adam attempted to deflect, their usual standoffish demeanour flummoxed, "Well, I believe it is not worth your bother, my lady. I merely wished to ensure you were aware that you are, indeed, the belle… and it would not… I could not hold a flicker..."

Catra was, it seemed, rather forthright, however. And that was entirely too interesting for Adam to parse in that moment, her voice almost impatient, "Come now, such modesty is unbecoming after so confident a thrust! Such boldness must stem from a true…."

Adam turned and leaned away, a lump in their throat. And then Catra's words sliced through the air like a honed blade.

"...beauty?" Adam stiffed and Catra's face set in a firmly neutral expression as she sighed, "Ah. A man."

It had been inevitable, but Adam's one attempt to bring some measure of *pleasure* to another had, once more, fallen foul of fate. But then slate grey-blue eyes met gold and ocean blue. The world seemed to silence for the merest moment, but also seemed to stretch to an eternity.

Strike me down, for I have seen the eyes of heaven , came the words to Adam's mind.

Adam's very self felt tense, primed. It took all Adam's effort to stop their face breaking out into a ridiculously broad and frankly addled grin. Instead, Adam marshalled their thoughts and managed to speak, "Ms Moon, a pleasure to make your acquaintance again. I apologise for disturbing you. And also for my… abrupt manner the other day."

As Adam stood and managed a bow, a confused and hostile expression briefly floated across Catra's face. Then she blinked and coughed, "Sir, you have the advantage of me. Doubly so for your rather uncalled for attentions."

The words stung but Adam could not fault them. Discretion was likely the better part of valour here, and so Adam pressed on, "I merely wished to make amends for my earlier… rudeness? And I could not help but overhear your… concerns. Mr de Gray, at your service. I will leave you to enjoy the ball, madam. Good evening."

With a haste that bordered on improper, Adam gave a curt bow, then turned and moved away. Through the crowd, breaking eyeline, to safety.

A door.

Breathing heavily, Adam pushed through and found themselves in a cool, dimly lit corridor. With a sigh, Adam leaned against a wall and pressed their forehead to the cold plaster. A single word was all that could really sum up the issue.

"Bugger."

It took a few moments along with an adjustment of their cravat, but Adam rolled their shoulders and stepped back through and into the throng. Beauregard was having a whale of a time, cavorting and moving in time. Adam couldn't help the grimace that snuck across their face as they moved among the Archers. George glanced their way and frowned but Adam waved away the concern. Instead, they watched as Catra spoke to another of the

sisters, the one in teal. Adam saw the girl glance their way, then turn to talk to Catra once more.

That made Adam grimace all the more and they moved out of eyesight and to the room's edge. Perhaps it was best to retire early, to scrub the entire sordid evening from ones memory and… then what?

And that was indeed Adam's intent, until they spotted Catra move to dance. And that froze Mr de Gray to the spot.

She moved through the formal steps with a barely restrained energy, the quirk of her hips and the toss of her hair like some fey thing of myth, set to ensare a passing Knight errant. Adam's eyes could not tear themselves away.

But how? Adam barely *knew* the girl! This was infatuation. A cruel jest that there existed a woman in the world who was amenable, in a part of the nation that was *tolerant* . And not, apparently, in the business of merely settling for a title or monies.

But the stark reality was the true irony of the situation - Adam could not give a prospective suitor what they desired: family. Adam was, after all, *lacking* in the ability, somewhat, certainly for the suitors of a feminine persuasion. The twist being that Adam was, of course, attracted to women. Very much so. But the situation meant that such a match brought the aforementioned issues along with other revelations that would be problematic. After all, why wouldn't a gentle*man* be attracted to the fairer sex?

Of course Adam would sight and fall for a young woman who, under other circumstances, would perhaps have been the correct match. But the world was full of cruel irony.

So, for now, Adam contented themselves with watching Catra dance and laugh. The morrow would bring reality and formality, but a return to the back and forth until a solution presented itself.

Duty, after all, was paramount.

If only it didn’t sting so.

Chapter End Notes

Not much momentum here, of course, but wanted Adam's view before we jump to the next exciting bit. A reverend will make a call and Glimmer will catch a cold.

Then Catra can MEET THE DADS as well as a certain Mr de Gray.

Unbecoming of a lady

Chapter Summary

A discussion over breakfast

Glimmer makes a visitation

A cordial exchange perhaps.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“You should call upon Mr Archer.”

Glimmer regarded her father across the breakfast table, teacup halfway to her lips. She frowned faintly, “Would that not be terribly presumptuous.”

Mr Moon lowered the letter he was reading, along with the other hand which currently help a pair of spectacles halfway between his face and the parchment. He smiled fondly at his daughter, “Call it taking the initiative, my dear.”

Mrs Moon’s exhalation was loud but tinged with the fondness of years, “Dearest, there is an art to this.”

“And I am not a well versed creative in such endeavours?” Mr Moon made a gesture with his spectacles and huffed in indignation, though clearly feigned, “My dearest, you wound me! My earnest and forthright approach won your heart, did it not?”

Mrs Moon maintained a stare across the table that drew out the silence to an almost uncomfortable level. Mermista, buttering her toast, bit her lip to muffle a snigger. Catra hummed and studied the ceiling of the dining room, then nudged Glimmer. Frosta and Entrapta shared a confused glance and spared their attention between their parents.

“I don’t understand,” frowned Entrapta, her brow furrowed in deep consternation. Mr Moon huffed again.

“My darling, your mother is being a cruel thing to her long suffering husband. Torturous, I say. My nerves are frazzled, bewitched and strung like a viola.”

Mrs Moon cracked and smiled, “And one I am adept at playing, I know. Forgive me my love. Your earnest efforts were… endearing. A little bit unnerving, I grant you but I admired your persistence.”

Glimmer groaned and leaned back in her chair, “Please, not the story of him serenading you…”

“...in that rainstorm! With a violin! Ah! What a memory.”

Mrs Moon sighed again, “You know I couldn’t hear anything over the rain, don’t you dear.”

“I know. But the *ambience* . The setting! It was magical. And seeing you framed in the window, lit by the fire…” Mr Moon’s voice became soft, reverent, “The most beautiful sight I had ever seen. And your beauty grows each day as I see you anew.”

The girls rolled their eyes with the collective familiarity of seeing parents who loved one another. A tired attempt at dismissal, but in reality couched with fondness and faint envy for the state in which Micah and Angella found themselves. Mrs Moon bit her lip and blushed, then looked to Glimmer.

“There are worse plans. You *could* wait for him to invite you…”

“Or, you know, just walk there, take in the grounds of Thaymor… free county and all,” Catra dabbed a napkin at her face and grinned at her sister, “And if you happen to cross his path, well, what a wondrous coincidence.”

The sound of the bell distracted the family momentarily and the butler entered shortly with a note, which he dutifully placed next to Micah. Mr Moon smiled and nodded, then thumbed open the

seal. He read the note, his expression neutral. It shifted to the countenance of a man appraising an interesting specimen, then to a frown, then to a purse-lipped musing.

"Well, it would appear our various anticipations and thoughts of skullduggery are for naught! The man is eager I will grant him that. I'm minded to grant him more! With your blessing, of course, dearest," he smiled over at Angella, who folded her napkin and gestured to the note.

"Husband dearest, you tease the girls. Speak plainly."

"Of course. Glimmer, it would appear Mr Archer cannot abide to be parted from you and has requested your company for tea. Though that might be a happy coincidence as he also mentions a shoot… so you'll be tagging along?"

His manner was aloof, but an affectation. Glimmer squeaked and snatched at the note, much to Catra's amusement. She cackled, a sound which drew a frown from her mother, but a frown that could not be held for long as Angella had to bite her own lip, lest she fall to the same merriment at Glimmers frantic reading.

"Tomorrow? So soon! The ball was but yesterday! It… it's improper! Isn't it?"

"Weren't you just so eager a moment ago?" chided Catra. She knocked Glimmer's shoulder, then forked a large helping of bacon into her mouth.

"Catra, that is most unladylike," admonished Mrs Moon, "Also, your sister is clearly… enamoured. Be kind."

"Will you come with me, Catra? I feel… unnerved," Glimmer frowned, clearly ill at ease at requiring a chaperone. The thought was not a comforting one to Catra - the memory of piercing blue eyes and a strange countenance warred inside her. A desire to avoid such an awkward confrontation coupled with a curiosity about the owner of such a piercing gaze.

Her father interrupted before she could voice her discomfort, "I would not be so cruel as to subject your sister to that. Mr de Gray was of a most ill-concieved bearing and his forwardness and disregard for Catra was most displeasing. Frankly, I was minded to have words with the man."

Catra blinked and coughed, "You did not!"

"Well, I would have. And your mother was so minded, also, is that not the case, dearest?"

"For one so elevated, he seemed uncouth and boorish indeed, but perhaps he was too discomfited," as ever Mrs Moon was harsh but diplomatic, "I did not see him however. He appeared to flit about the place. He did seem a rather focused gentleman."

Catra looked between them, "You concern is comforting but I assure you the matter was well in hand and is not a topic of analysis. So, please may we move on? I have no wish to be spending my morning considering the intent of Mr de Gray and his lumpen antics."

Mermista chuckled, "Hardly one you'd go for? A shame, he seemed quite… interesting."

"Well, mayhap *you* should travel with Glimmer to sound out his intentions and settle yourself?" Catra waved a hand dismissively. Mermista cocked her head and shrugged.

"Maybe I should."

"Ah… We do have a guest to expect as well, remember."

The girls exchanged looks, "Guest, father?" ventured Glimmer.

"Oh yes. Ah, did I not mention? Due before the week's end, according to the last missive..."

Angella fixed her husband with a tolerant smile, "I believe you did not."

“Ah. Well. Reverend Collins is due to…”

The collective groan from around the table was likely heard in the next county.

After a prolonged back and forth, it was decided (After much urging from Mr Moon) that Glimmer should take the carriage to the Thaymor estate, as there was a likelihood of rain. Catra pleaded off, citing that the presence of an insufferable and overbearing bore in a Mr de Gray would be more than she was willing to tolerate.

And so it was that Ms Glimmer Moon found herself rattling through the country lanes in her family’s carriage, feeling rather obtuse. A single woman of not so imposing a size riding alone in their open carriage felt far too ostentatious for a journey that would’ve been a simple hour walk. A glance at the greying sky did make her pause at that.

The young lady peered around the driver and saw the grand mansion in the distance, along the boulevard of trees. However, her attention was caught by a spur of motion and she turned to see a white horse canter forward, until it came to a trot next to the carriage. Ms Moon looked up at the rider and frowned inadvertently.

Mr de Gray peered at her from the saddle, then reached up to touch the brim of the top hat, “Ms Moon. You make good time against the storm. What brings you to the estate?”

“Are you in the habit of accosting women on their travels, Mr de Gray?” Glimmer blinked as the words slipped out. Truly, her affront at the man’s presence was on behalf of her sister, whom she felt she owed some form of debt, having not been there to denounce such an uncouth gentleman at the ball.

The gentleman in question arched a dark eyebrow and Glimmer blinked as cool blue eyes regarded her, “Accosting? I must consult my attorney for a consultation on my criminal behaviour.”

Glimmer snorted and blinked, “A jest? You are capable of such?”

“I fear you have the advantage, my lady. I am unsure as to the origin of your animosity and I frankly care not for it,” the words were curt, “You appear to have formulated your opinion, so I will leave you to your ride, good day.”

Ms Moon felt a wash of sudden shame; to be so abrupt, to be so uncouth to another without true cause? But surely she did? “You upbraided my sister!”

“Which one?” Mr de Gray levelled their gaze back to Ms Moon with a sigh.

“Sir, I speak frankly, you know which one. You conversed with no one else at the ball.”

“I paid her a compliment and then excused myself after she made her disapproval of my presence well known. If that counts as upbraiding within your limited experience of the world I fear for your sanity.”

“How dare you!”

Mr de Gray huffed, “Dare, my lady? I merely greeted you. And received a *scolding* from someone *elsewhere* in the social hierarchy to myself.”

A feeling of shame mingled with anger at the arrogance of the man, “Manners are not inherent to the nobility and…”

“Thus far you have exhibited *none* . If your sister has issue with me, she may make consultation herself.”

“You have judged….”

“Do you intend to petition Mr Archer for his hand? Or endeavour to attract his intent to petition you?”

Glimmer’s countenance was comparable to that of a fish for a moment as she gawped, “Sir! Such questions are… you are not in a position to…”

Mr de Gray watched as she sputtered, then snorted again, “I see my appraisal was correct then. Good day Ms Moon. I trust your stay is a pleasant one, I will vex you no further.”

With a kick, the white horse sped up to a canter and Glimmer had a sudden sense that she had perhaps been rather too hasty. She sagged back into the carriage seat and chewed her lip for a moment, then squared her shoulders.

A Moon did not waver; the family stood by their principles and beliefs. She had merely spoken her mind; out of turn, perhaps. But who was this Mr de Gray? He was nobility, such as herself. Surely not so far above them in the way of things? He had attended a country ball! And the Archers themselves seemed approachable. Truly she could not reconcile the sheer difference in their attitudes and bearing.

She watched the white horse in the distance as it veered back into the woods, taking with it the enigmatic rider. Another wave of anxiety flooded through Glimmer - she had been abrupt and, as ever, had allowed her manners to fall to her emotions.

The carriage rattled onto gravel and she found herself frozen in the seat, suddenly unsure whether she was welcome. Would Mr de Gray have denounced her to Mr Archer? Broken a thing before it was even born? Was he that cruel?

“Glimmer! Ah I… I mean *Ms Moon!* ” Beauregard… *Mr Archer* practically bounded down the steps of the mansion, “I am overjoyed to see you! I had hoped you would answer, but I thought it would be a day hence… I am NOT complaining, may I reiterate!”

The footman had no chance to open the door before the exuberant man had his hand on the handle. Glimmer could not mask her smile as Mr Archer offered his hand. She took it and immediately relaxed, "Beau….. Um.. *Mr Archer* ."

They both stared at one another, frozen. Then Beauregard shook himself and, grinning, helped her from the carriage, "Welcome. I see you are alone?"

"Did you wish me to bring my whole family?"

"Honestly I am *somewhat* relieved. But perhaps they can join us tomorrow?"

Glimmer almost stumbled, "You.. wish me to stay the eve?"

"We have rooms a-plenty and I would be a beast to dispatch you when foul weather threatens. Now, come inside. My siblings have mostly departed so I do hope you will not object to my parents and Mr de Gray joining us?"

Glimmer paused and placed a hand over Mr Archer's, "I fear I have been… hasty with Mr de Gray."

Mr Archer raised an eyebrow, "Oh? Adam seemed a tad rushed at the stables…"

"I am afraid I was… a tad outspoken?" Ms Moon winced at the words, "Hasty. It was said in the heat of the moment."

She watched the man's face. Mr Archer nodded slowly and searched her eyes - it was an oddly intimate gesture. Glimmer found herself unwilling to break the stare from those brown orbs. So gentle, but intense. Full of mirth. A soft smile broke across Beauregard's face, "Well, I am sure it is a bridge that can be mended."

"May… may I speak with him?"

“If Adam wishes to speak with you. I cannot command Adam - I can certainly request. What was it you said?”

The pair ascended the stairs, “I… it was an assumption of his approach towards my sister.”

“Ah, Catra, yes?” Ms Moon frowned and looked at Mr Archer who gave a playful shrug, “Mr de Gray mentioned something of crossing paths with her in some small way.”

“He did?”

“Indeed.”

“And he made no mention of having accosted her?” she felt the righteousness take hold once more but bit it back. Mr Archer paused as they walked into the hallway. He turned slightly to regard her.

“Do not be so quick to judge Mr de Gray. I will ask Adam to speak with you. Now, shall we move to the salon?”

Again Glimmer felt a sense of disconnect - such kindness and gentle chiding from this man. Not one to rush to the defence of his friend; or at least not in so brazen a way as Glimmer had rushed to assume fault. She handed her shawl to a maidservant, then allowed Mr Archer to lead her into a room off of the expansive hall.

Three men lounged within - Mr Archer’s parents, who seemed involved in a chess game; and Mr de Gray, still in his riding attire. He leaned against the mantle and seemed focused on the flames within the hearth. Glimmer saw, for the barest moment, Mr de Gray’s face in profile: unobserved, quiet, the man looked so sad.

Desolate, even.

Her heart clenched with guilt. She moved without thinking and strode to the hearth, bypassing the two men who had risen from their seats. Mr de Gray turned at the movement and stiffed, that

expression of sadness hardening into the familiar impassive stare. Glimmer ploughed on.

"Sir, I am… so sorry. I was brash. Uncouth. And thoroughly out of line. I have come into the home of your dear friend and insulted your integrity, your bearing and without a whit as to your motivations. I hope you can forgive an impulsive sister who wishes only to protect her family. And if not, I will of course understand. And if you wish for me to take my leave…. Then I will of course understand. Should you wish to impress as such on Mr Archer."

Mr de Gray looked *stunned* . Those blues eyes slid away from Glimmer and fixed on Mr Archer who seemed to give a thoroughly confused shrug, followed by a slightly disgruntled arching of his own eyebrow. Glimmer had her face down, waiting for a dismissal it seemed.

Adam ran a hand through tousled blonde hair and made a helpless gesture with a free hand, then shot a beseeching look at the two older gentlemen in the room. For their part, they seemed content to observe, small smiles on their faces. Mr de Gray's gaze fixed on Glimmer. She coughed and straightened, then swallowed. She looked flushed, embarrassed by yet *another* impulsive outburst.

The pair stared at one another, then Mr de Gray blew out a breath, "Madam, your apology is… accepted. I admit I… may not have made the best of first impressions. I can certainly understand the desire to protect family, wholeheartedly. Truly."

Glimmer met those blue eyes and saw sincerity there. A faint crack in the impassive mask. She nodded slowly, "Thank you, Mr de Gray. May we start afresh?"

The gentleman looked down at her proffered hand then squared their shoulders and gripped it in return, "Indeed we may. But please do convey to your sister I had no intent to cause offence.

My words to her were sincere, even if not reciprocated. I endeavour to be forthright."

"As do I sir. To my detriment, perhaps."

"Ever is it thus," a faint smile graced Mr de Gray's face, "But please, you are not here for me. Mr Archer, I have monopolised your guest."

There was a clap as Lance, one of the present father's, slapped his hands together, "Well, that was entertaining. Ms Moon, a pleasure to see you again! My boy has barely ceased his descriptions of your last dance."

George chuckled and patted his husband's shoulder, then stepped around the chair to bow to Glimmer, "Apologies, decorum completely out of the window. Welcome."

"Sir, that was entirely my fault," blushed Glimmer, "But hopefully we may proceed? I hope I have not interrupted a pleasant evening?"

"Not at all. Just my dearest here trouncing me once more at chess. You would have thought *him* the soldier and I the cloud-headed romantic!"

Lance chuffed and waved a hand, "You, dear, are just a sore loser."

Mr Archer the younger stepped in at that point, "Ms Moon has barely a moment to collect herself. My dear, would you care for a drink?"

Ms Moon smiled as she was led to a couch, then sat gratefully. A manservant entered shortly thereafter with a tall glass of something chilled and sweet, then returned again with a tray of tea. Mr de Gray returned to the contemplation of the fire, whilst the fathers queried her on the area; Lance about the history and development, George more on matters of business and likely notables.

For his own part, Mr Archer seemed content to sit next to her and regard her. And, truly, that was not an unpleasant thing, although she felt a blush creep up her neck. Outside, the rain began a drumbeat against the windows and gravel pathway.

Truly, a not unpleasant way to spend an afternoon.

Her glance towards Mr de Gray did raise questions though - the man was certainly capable of more than cold countenance and seemed to have a depth beyond awkward conversation. The companionship of Mr Archer and the affection of the man's family indicated that there was something in Mr de Gray to be admired; they seemed not a gathering who would tolerate impropriety or callousness for its own sake.

A lull in the rain gave the group cause to venture outside to take in the gardens. Mr Archer seemed particularly enamoured with the space, "Truly, a luxury. I was predominantly exposed only to the city, so having this expanse to do with as I wish? Truly a gift."

"I must say, it is… well I never gave it much thought, Mr Archer."

"Beauregard."

"Um… but…"

"No, that is reserved for dusty halls and ballrooms. When we are out here, nary a soul to judge… Beauregard, Ms Moon. Please. Or… Beau."

"Well, in that case. Glimmer. I insist."

"And I would be foolish to resist! I must say, no one has stumped Adam in such a way for many a year! I think perhaps once during a fencing match, but beyond that? Hardly ever."

Glimmer laughed and sighed, "But truly, it was my own fault. He deserved an apology. And… was more humble in his receipt than I had credited him to be capable of."

“Mr de Gray has… well, Adam has not always been *thus* .”

Glimmer saw a shadow of melancholy ghost across Beauregard’s dark skin; a sadness eclipsed his eyes for a moment. She looped an arm through the crook in his own, “What happened? Money? Family?”

Mr Archer sighed and gave her a bittersweet smile, “That is not for me to say. Adam is a dear dear friend. One who has steered me through trying times of my own. And my family’s own. We all owe Adam a debt. A friendship hard won. I will say you will find no one more steadfast and loyal. But once that trust is broken it is lost forever. So, I will not break it.”

Glimmer nodded slowly, “I understand. We are but new acquaintances. And it is his place to tell me, should he ever wish to broach the subject,” she smiled, “He is lucky to have one so steadfast in you as well.”

“Mayhap. I just wish I could see a smile more often. It happened recently but I fear we cannot recapture it…” Beauregard trailed off and shrugged, “Apologies, you came to have tea and enjoyable company, not this melancholic prattle!”

Glimmer smiled and squeezed Mr Archer’s arm, “Your company is not melancholic. How can conversing on our thoughts, our own honest selves be a bad thing? The world is full of such superficiality and foolishness, it seems a waste.”

The pair paused and Mr Archer turned to regard her. He smiled and shook his head, “Truly, madame, you are a wit and a wonder. Such insight.”

“Ah, I am a woman of whims and flights of fancy…” she shrugged and turned away.

“Are you in the habit of doing yourself such disservice? What would your sister say?” chided Mr Archer with a laugh. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“She would smack me and then chase me through the rose garden no doubt.”

“If… if I may be so bold….” Mr Archer mused for a moment, “No, my apologies… it is a thoughtless and rude query.”

Glimmer smirked and tilted her head, “You wish to understand how such a bevvy of ladies appear so different? You doubt the integrity of my mother? Her predilections?”

Mr Archer *blanched* and sputtered. Glimmer folded her arms and pouted, then laughed. Beauregard lowered his head and shook it, “That was not at *all* ….”

“Oh I know *that* . No, it is a fair curiosity. Not exactly *proper* . But I will offer it freely. I am of blood related to my parents. My sisters, and they *are* my sisters… they were wards. Taken in from families who were unable to care for them or whom had… gone. My parents *care* . They are full of love and would not compromise. They are *family* .”

They regarded one another and Beauregard smiled, “The more I learn, the more remarkable your family becomes, Ms Glimmer Moon. I hope, perhaps, one day, you will regard me with such fierceness,” he swallowed and his smile faltered, “Ah, that was… presumptuous.”

They had wandered beneath another tree and Glimmer giggled. Then she stepped forwards and took his hand, “I believe I may already be on that path… Mr Archer.”

They stared at one another until a sudden boom echoed across the sky and the heavens opened once more. Glimmer shrieked - her clothing was *not* suitable for a torrential downpour - a dress and a shawl.

With a single movement, Mr Archer divested himself of his longcoat and hat, the former of which he draped over Glimmer’s small frame; the hat he almost rammed atop her head. With a grin he grasped her hand, “Are you up for a small jog?”

“But… it’s… you’ll be soaked!”

“What’s a little rain! Hardly going to catch a cold am I?”

Laughing, they sprinted through the grounds, towards the distant house.

Not an unpleasant way to spend an afternoon after all.

Chapter End Notes

PHEW I feel you all deserved some.

As you can PROBABLY tell - Glimmer is NOT Jane in terms of her manners. So we're going to see some rather blatant shifts in plot - I will be keeping the plot BEATS, so you can imagine I will be having to twist things.

And REVEREND COLLINS will be along shortly. Now.... who ELSE would likely propose to Catra I wonder.

As ever, feedback is always appreciated! And let me know if you spot any issues in the text!

An unfortunate affair

Chapter Summary

A pleasant and surprising invitation.

An entertaining evening.

And a scandal in the making.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra! CATRA!"

The excitable voice of her father drew her eyes away from a particularly scintillating paragraph, but she could not help the fondness that crept onto her face as she glanced up at him. The man was a-flustered as he strode into the reading room, his smile nervy.

"You seem vexed, father. Too much tea?" she teased, her eyebrow arching carefully as she regarded him.

"Not enough! I have two letters, *two* ! You sister stayed overnight with Mr Archer!"

Catra sighed, "Yes father, I know. The messenger last night…"

"OVERNIGHT! Surely this is fortuitous! A promising sign. Your mother must be told!"

"She *knows,* father," Catra tried again but had to suppress the urge to roll her eyes in a most unladylike display of exasperation. Mr Moon paused for a moment and blinked.

"Your mother knows?"

“You were there when the messenger ARRIVED, father,” Catra blinked at him, “Were you unaware?”

Mr Moon stared at her, then adjusted his waistcoat. He glanced at the letters and sucked his teeth, then smoothed his goatee and nodded slowly, “I may…. Have some recollection. But I *may* also have been particularly entranced by..”

“Your latest writing piece, father?” Catra smirked and shook her head, “We *know* . How goes your endeavour?”

“ *Wonderfully* ! I feel I have reached an apex of engagement with the audience and will be dispatching the manuscript to Elberon within the next week!”

Catra nodded then gestured at the letters, “And the two missives today? Any particular reason you are after my particular attention?”

“Oh! Of course! Well… first, your Cousin, Reverend Collins, will be arriving….” That set Catra’s eyes to glaze in a mild panic, “And your sister has written to request your presence at Thaymor.”

And *that* set Catra to frowning. Nay, *scowling* , “Why am I requested?”

“Ah… it would appear Mr Archer has become ill with a head cold and she feels she cannot leave his side. She has requested that you attend and bring some minor items and keep her company…?” Micah winced and shrugged.

“And what of the ghoul, Mr de Gray?”

Mr Moon flicked the small piece of paper back and forth as he studied both sides, “Ah, no mention. But a chance to attend the house? And, well, your sister would likely appreciate the company. Especially if that dour fellow *is* present.”

Catra flopped back in her chair, “What about…”

“Would your rather *Mermista* attend? Can you see that going well? Or what of Entrapta? After last month’s silo explosion, I fear letting her anywhere unsupervised. Or near a naked flame. And Frosta simply cannot go. No, this, I fear is a requirement for you, my dearest.”

Truly, the world was an unfair place, wrought with assignments, duty and pained obligation. She was but a simple heroine, who would save her sister from the tedium of manor-life.

“I suppose I better remember how to play *bridge* or some rot,” grumbled Catra and Micah smiled.

“Indeed!”

“I know who’ll be the dummy in it at least,” with a huff, Catra stood and smoothed her red dress down, “Can you have the carriage deliver the cases once I’ve packed them? I feel a *walk* will be necessary or else I am liable to be… *acerbic* .”

A gentle chuckle came from the door as the willowy form of Mrs Moon paused at her husband’s shoulder, “Oh dear me. Catra attempting to avoid a battle of wits? You are vexed, dear. Micah, what have you requested our fiery little one subject herself to?”

“Not I, dear heart! Glimmer!”

Angella frowned and glanced at the letter, then pursed her lips, “Hum. She is besotted. A good sign, I hope. Provided Mr Archer is as true to his morals as we believe.”

Catra huffed as she closed her book and marked the page, “I am fond of the man, in spite of the company he keeps. However, I am ever at my sister’s service. And she will be *indebted* for this, mark that.”

Mrs Moon smiled softly at Catra’s attempt at indignation, “Indeed. Please keep your mockery of her infatuation to levels that don’t rouse the local militia.”

Catra harrumphed as she trudged through the muddy fields. She knew that had she taken the carriage, her ire would have grown, and this way she was able to stamp out her minor frustrations; truthfully, seeing Glimmer was no hardship. But if Glimmer was cooing over a bed-bound Mr Archer, she would be left to make *small talk* with whatever excuses for company resided in the Manor.

However, it was a pleasant day and the air was crisp.

She emerged from the wood-line and huffed 0- the last mile had been across a rather muddy field of grass-tufts and puddles. Her walking boots were saturated and her dress a mess of grime and grass. She smirked as she took it in, then lifted her scarlet bonnet. She slicked her hair back, then shrugged and strode onto the more stable path that led towards the manor.

The grounds were well kept and she found that it had a rather pleasant woodsy appearance - not overly manicured, not at least until you got closer to the house itself.

It was only as she stepped out from behind a willow that she found herself face to face with a familiar blonde figure.

"Oh! Ms Moon, good day. I… ah I had not expected to see you?" Mr de Gray was a strange shade of red about their cheeks and those blue eyes were widened in surprise.

Catra lazily took in the long coat, cane and top hat - the man had clearly been for a stroll. She smiled thinly and gave a short curtsey, "Mr de Gray. Clearly Mr Archer does not keep you informed. My presence was requested. Should I have informed you."

Mr de Gray's jaw appeared to tighten and Catra watched as the gentleman tapped the cane against the turf, "I see confrontation

is a familial trait. And not at all, madam. This is not my abode, I merely remain here at the pleasure of my friend. I welcome you and will trouble you no further."

Catra blinked as the gentleman offered her, of all things, a sad smile. Then Mr de Gray touched the brim of the top hat, then strode off towards the woods, away from the house. She watched the figure pause briefly, then saw a shake of the head, before the gentleman continued on their way. She felt suddenly uncertain, but schooled herself and made for the main entrance. A maid met her at the door and indicated her belongings had been delivered. Catra noted with some small satisfaction that the maid appeared discomfited by her more muddy attire.

"I will present myself, then if I might trouble you for some appropriate area to change?" she prompted; the maid curtseyed and led her into the drawing room, where a pair of older gentlemen stood to greet her.

"Ah ha! Ms Moon… or rather, *another* Ms Moon! Truly, you are in one another's orbit!" the taller of the men japed. The other a more compact man with shorter hair, sighed and bowed.

"Please excuse my husband. He is… a man without limits. It is a pleasure to see you again, Ms Moon."

Catra smiled and curtseyed, "I trust my sister has been in good health and you are not put out by her concern? Is Mr Archer well?"

"Beauregard is a tough sport. Merely over exuberant and a little prone to dramatics," the shorter man smiled, "Please, call me Lance. Otherwise the whole Mr Archer business will get confusing."

"Likewise, George for me. Such formality is for the city. And frankly it's stuffy there as well. As for Beau, well… I think he is also rather enjoying the *fussing* ."

Lance swatted his husband, "Sounds like someone I know."

“But you are so *good* at it!”

The pair were charming and Catra found she was enjoying the little play-by-play. She winced as she brought about a more uncomfortable ask, “Is… Mr de Gray joining us?”

The pair shared a glance and Lance spoke up, “Mr de Gray tends to keep their own counsel. Adam will likely join us for tea later. I think Mr de Gray misses the moors at times - from the county where the Greyskull estate sits.”

“Far from home? Will Mr de Gray be spending much time here?”

George chuckled, “It depends on the business of the estate. Currently, this visit is to ensure our son is not… overextending himself. I believe Adam has a rather protective streak of late. I can’t say I blame them.”

Lance gave George a strange look, but the taller man shrugged. Catra frowned, “Protective? Forgive me, he seems… more abrupt.”

The two men shared a smile, “Mr de Gray has had an interesting time in society. The Greyskull estates are situated in a less than tolerant area, and is a little remote. Mr de Gray needs respite from that now and then. Anything else, it is not for us to really say.”

Catra nodded, “I can understand that. I still feel his attitude to be brusque and dismissive, but I understand I am speaking out of turn about a family friend. My apologies.”

The men shared another look and smiled, then gestured for her to sit, “Not at all. It is good to see such forthright behaviour in the next generation. Far too many with easy airs in the city at times; someone with an opinion and conviction? Well, it is *good* . It is why we approve so much of your sister! Beauregard needs that sort of attitude. And it is wonderful to know she has such support closer to home as well.”

The conversation was charming and idle, until Catra excused herself to prepare for the eve. Atop the stairs she was met by an

effervescent Glimmer who practically sparkled with glee.

“Is this house not *amazing* ? And what did you think of Mr Archer’s parents? So nice? SO NICE!”

Catra studied her sister carefully, then presented a deadpan response, “Yes. So nice.”

“Come, COME! Your room is *here* . Next to mine.”

“How is Mr Archer?”

“Um.. he is… convalescing. Yes. Convalescing. Very ill. Head cold. Rain,” Glimmer smiled, but it seemed to be edged with a blush. Catra arched an eyebrow.

“And how did he get wet enough to contract a cold in a single *day* sister dear?” Catra folded her arms as soon as Glimmer closed the bedroom door behind her.

“Well. We were… taking in the grounds. Then he took off his jacket. And we ran and… we… *may* have… endedupkissingoutsideforawhile.”

Catra rocked back on her heels, “WOA! Sparkling one! That is…. I am *shocked* ,” she stepped to the bed and patted the space next to her, “Tell me *everything.”*

The evening presented something of a challenge; dinner was pleasant, if a little bit surprising: Glimmer and Mr de Gray appeared to have a rather eager accord and Catra found herself confused and faintly distressed.

Mr de Gray was actually rather *amusing* .

The gentleman described in very dry detail a particularly embarrassing moment regarding Beauregard, where the man had somehow removed his trousers via the incorrect use of a sabre, during a banquet. Glimmer clasped her hands to her mouth, "Oh gracious! And then?"

"Well, the Contessa merely raised a glass and queried the age of the meat being served."

George and Lance rocked in their chairs and laughed, with the taller of the fathers leaning forwards, "Poor Beauregard did a valiant recovery and managed to extricate himself. He returned in a kilt and merely told the room he would be taking up archery instead. And he told the contessa that the meat had been replaced with beets."

"She took it in stride, but then she is the sort who prefers parties to go a little awry."

Catra looked between them all as Mr de Gray took a slow sip of their wine. She frowned as the gentleman's eyes fluttered - *Fluttered* - at the taste. Then she realised she was staring at Mr de Gray's eyes. And they were staring *right back.*

"Ms Moon…. Do you have any anecdotes? I'm afraid mine are…. Paltry," Mr de Gray winced slightly as they extended a tentative verbal olive branch.

"You mean they are at someone else's expense?"

Surprisingly, Adam leaned back and pursed their lips, "A fair assessment. Let me describe one involving me, then maybe you would share one with us? If you feel comfortable doing so, I mean?"

No challenge, just… caution. Oddly, this lack of challenge irritated Catra further. She arched an eyebrow, then saw Glimmer's warning expression and deflated somewhat, then challenged: "Wax lyrical, please, Mr de Gray."

"Ah, well. So, as you are aware, I am a rider. Suffice to say, this was not *always* thus. In fact, there was a time that horses and I… did not get along. My first interaction with a horse… indeed, my first interaction with *Swiftwind* was not… exactly easy."

George practically giggled into his wine, "Tell them about the wagons…."

"And the farmers…"

Adam shot the pair an indulgent look. It was strange seeing such a fond expression on a face that had, prior to now, been predominantly set in a harsh demeanour. Adam supped at the wine and continued, "So. I had just purchased this fine and *noble* beast. And, well… of course I knew *exactly* what to do."

"Adam did not," drawled Lance. Adam waved a hand to shush the elder gentleman.

"Anyway, I set to saddling the beast. I believed him to be… trained. And he was. Just… not to me. So, I throw the saddle over having failed to both *secure* the stable door *and* rein the horse to a bar."

Glimmer's eyes widened and Catra couldn't help the faint smirk on her face. The pink-hair sister gasped, "Oh no…"

"Oh yes. So, on goes the saddle and *off* goes the horse. Just as I've finished tightening the belts, too. Of course, being a very professional rider, I held on. I managed to clamber atop the saddle, after the horse had escaped the stable and was set on his course down the main road of the estate. Of course, my second issue was then readily apparent - I lacked reins."

Catra actually snorted, but covered it with a cough. Adam arched an eyebrow, but didn't smile. Glimmer shook her head, "And?"

"Well, Swiftwind decided to take a tour of the town near my estate. Via a farm. He got stuck in a pen and I tried to get him to calm down. Whereupon he kicked open the pen and let loose a

score of hogs. Which he promptly led to freedom. I'm there, clinging to his neck, wondering why no one thought to install some form of breaking mechanism on a horse, when the beast decides this is the opportune time to head into said town and knock over several carts in the market, along with leading aforementioned hogs into further exacerbate things."

Catra stared at the gentleman. George and Lance were holding their sides.

"Then Swiftwind decided that he objected to the enslavement of several cart horses and kicked the wagon traces. This did not, of course, free them, but it *did* send a large haycart into a tavern garden. A haycart filled with manure. Swiftwind *also* decided that this was the opportune time to divest himself of *me* . Into said haycart."

Catra snorted and the wine went up her nose. She coughed as she laughed, "You… you were in the shit!"

Mr de Gray smiled. George and Lance paused and stared. Mr de Gray's eyes were fixed on Catra as she sputtered and giggled a squeaky, rasping laugh. And the smile on the gentleman's face was something they had not seen in many years.

Glimmer watched too, then looked at the two men and winked.

Dinner had been illuminating. Catra shared her own story - about how she apparently spiked a punch bowl at a ball one year *by accident* with several large bottles of whisky. She had thought it was some sort of "fill the glass bowl game".

" *I was EIGHT!"* she had protested.

That evening, they all retired to the drawing room for a brief respite. Catra read and found that Mr de Gray was also enamoured with a book, which was splayed open on the small writing desk they were currently occupying. She managed to *not* ask what it was. Lance, however, approached and queried her on her choice. Glimmer interjected, "Catra is always ensconced with some form of book. Truly, she is a scholar in the making."

Catra answered demurely that she was content with mere classics to pass the time and that she partook of *several* activities, of which Glimmer was well aware. Her identity as a well rounded woman was well known. That merely elicited a smile from her sister.

"Ah! Well, such a shame that Thaymor's library is so ill stocked currently, but Beauregard has more inclination to the physical arts rather than the literary," lamented Lance, "Our own home is quite the extensive archive. Rivalled only by the collection at Greyskull, I believe?"

Mr de Gray glanced up and offered a polite nod, "The work of several generations. Knowledge has value, especially in these trying times. Give me a lever of sufficient length…"

"And I may move the world," finished Catra with a small smile. She arched an eyebrow and then returned to her book. Glimmer took up the conversational baton.

"You are a collector, then, Mr de Gray?"

"Hardly, Ms Moon. I feel it is merely prudent to ensure the preservation of things. My… sibling is fond of such things."

George coughed, "Indeed so. How is A...dora? These days? I trust well? The last we saw she was… well versed with the piano?"

The scratch of Mr de Gray's pen halted and the gentleman regarded George for a moment. Catra saw the sudden shift in demeanour and found it curious.

“She continues well. Her situation is, of course, limited due to her status and bearing.”

“Ah,” interjected Lance, “But young ladies are all so talented and full of skill. Look at us - George here can catalogue a series of appendices but is quite useless with more robust tasks. I am capable with a rapier, but frankly, am bamboozled by the inner workings of a kitchen! Or anything of skill, really.”

That, for some reason seemed to irk Mr de Gray further. Glimmer chuffed, “Beauregard is skilled with menial things! And a woman is not limited by tasks within a household, may I remark”

“Precisely! It sets him apart from his peers; and we oft neglect the skills of our feminine colleagues, who are likewise accomplished," George smiled at Glimmer, an open and honest expression.

Mr de Gray tapped the pen against the table, “I wonder at that.”

There was a bitterness to the statement that drew Catra’s eyebrows up, “You feel that women are not capable?”

Mr de Gray turned a pain expression upon Catra, “I feel that women are not in a position to present such capability. Truly, I know of few women who have advanced or deserve the term *accomplished* . I hazard know but a dozen.”

Glimmer once more stepped in, “A woman, and really, anyone of bearing, should understand the arts - dancing, music, writing. Intellect is important, as is the desire to improve upon it. But also a need to be forthright,” here she smiled at George and Lance who returned the expression tenfold. She turned to Catra, “ She must possess a certain something in her air and manner of walking, the tone of her voice, her address and expressions, or the word will be but half-deserved. Something I think *we* master, would you not concur, Catra?”

“Indeed I must, sister. I am interested to understand Mr de Gray’s position, however."

"Just that a woman should read extensively, to improve her limited lot and advance over her natural and social restrictions. All those things that Ms Moon has expressed, she must possess, to then add things more substantial. And yet it is still often not enough."

At this, Catra bristled somewhat, but was stalled somewhat by the sadness in those blue eyes, "I am surprised to hear you claim a dozen in your awareness, with such a mark to achieve, I would imagine you barely count *one* woman in that vaunted field."

She closed her book and tilted her chin. Mr de Gray watched her for a moment longer and then smiled, "I have offended you. Please, do excuse me. I am… tired and though I speak from bitter experience, I see I am a burden upon these proceedings. Ms Moon, I will check in upon Mr Archer. I shall see you all upon the morrow."

Catra watched as the man stood, then took his leave after a polite bow. She turned to find Glimmer's disapproving gaze fixed upon her, "Catra that was an uncalled for slight."

"Glimmer, the man denigrated our ability to achieve and aspire! You may find such charming peccadillos as were put forth over dinner enough to mask such things, but I feel it is… condescending."

George sighed across the room and sat up from his arm chair, "I fear you may have misunderstood Mr de Gray's perspective. A singular circumstance of misfortune relating to… well, it is a painful topic that is not ours to broach. Suffice to say, there is a rationale and reason for Adam's words. But not the motive I fear you attribute to them, Ms Moon."

Their chatter returned to more relaxed topics but shortly Glimmer also decided to retire, which spurred Catra to likewise retreat. After thanking the Messers Archer and Archer for their company and erudition, the women withdrew. Glimmer paused but a moment to check in on Beauregard, in spite of Mr de Gray's

assurances. She did so with a muttered commentary of *needing to be sure* .

In the quiet of Catra's room they prepared for bed and Catra huffed whilst Glimmer sent a particularly irritable frown towards her errant sister.

"What prompted all that?"

"Mr de Gray is a man clearly with opinions that are base and objectifying to the manner of womanhood."

Glimmer made a gesture that conveyed her thoughts on the matter very eloquently, "Balderdash. You are confused by your errant engagement with Mr de Gray's particular charm."

"And that is all it is: charm. There is no foundation upon which to build a proper accord."

"Did you even try? You merely took offence at a throwaway comment; one, I might add, did not seem all that malicious."

"Glimmer, sister dear. I love you most of our rambunctious lot, but sometimes you are far too *trusting* . Mr Archer appears a fine fellow, but Mr de Gray is a man cast in shadows and grimness. A singular story, no matter how humours the anecdote, does not a good friend make."

"Have many good friends to measure against, sister dear?" teased Glimmer, which elicited a snort of a laugh from the brunette.

"Get the hence to your own room, you besotted vixen. Consider, perhaps your doting upon Mr Archer will garner a promising result for your fortunes and prevent the bemoaning of father at the impending calamities of the world."

"You know he could happen upon a chest of Guineas and make a drama of it," Glimmer chided gently, "Much as I love the man, he has an air of a dazed rabbit on occasion."

“Another good reason for Mother, then!”

“You say that only because you do not partake in conversations of a rigorous and fraught nature with the woman.”

“Well, if you will insist on *disagreeing* with her *GLIMMAH!”* Catra could not help the mirth on her lips. Glimmer swatted at her.

“Do not *do that* ! It makes my skin shudder so - she has me in a tizzy with my own name!”

“Alright, be off. Some of us require *sleep* and are not fuelled by rampant attraction and literary lust.”

With a smile and a dramatic flutter of eyelashes, Glimmer departed, leaving Catra to her contemplation as she blew out her candle. The house was warm, welcome, even in the dark of night and, full of food, wine and the memory of good company, she began to drift. As she slowly slipped towards rest, words clicked like knitting needles and Catra frowned, sullen for the merest moment. Her mind approached the statement of Mr de Gray from another angle: to view the words not as condescension and patronising, but rather as frustration and resignation.

A strange perspective for a man of means and wealth. Many would not hold forth on such a view, save as a fair point of flattery. Now, upon reflection, the gentleman had not appeared relaxed in his posture, nor dry in his delivery. This was most puzzling.

The sound of footsteps stirred Catra as she rested on the edge of sleep. She sat up and spoke, “Glimmer?”

The footsteps paused and a voice spoke up: nervous, uncertain, but tremulous and feminine, muffled by the door, “Um, well… *no* ma’am. Sorry for waking you. Just… putting out the candles.”

A serving girl then. But the voice stirred a memory which, in Catra's soporific state, felt familiar: the cadence, certainly, but *more* womanly. It was like a lucid dream where one could imagine

changing oneself as easily as changing clothes, or changing the appearance of another, or their sound, “Oh, oh, of course.”

“Sorry for um… disturbing you, Catra… I mean Ms Moon.”

The voice sounded so nervous, it made Catra smile. She was not one for dalliances - they were a trivial and bothersome thing, but she wondered what the voice looked like suddenly. It reminded her of the flattery of the ball - a voice unseen. Spoiled by the vision of *masculinity* that lay behind it. Her brow wrinkled further upon the contemplation of this comparative experience and she found herself suddenly out of bed, and grasping for a shawl from the linen box at the end of the four poster bed. The footsteps had retreated and Catra fumbled for the door handle as she attempted to be less-than-overt.

She peered into the hall and saw the light of a candle vanish around a corner. She noted that the wicks of several candelabra were cool and not smoking - long since extinguished. Most curious.

Catra crept along the hallway, past her sister's room, where the faint drone of her distant nightly-susurration could be heard. Carefully, she inclined herself to peer around the corner.

A figure stood at the door to Mr Archer’s room - *Beauregard’s* room. Catra saw the silhouette of a feminine body - tall, wearing a white nightgown. She could make out the defined shape of athletic arms that protruded from the short-sleeves and the ankles indicated a solid but not portly build. It seemed a strange stature for a chambermaid. She knew farmers wives would be capable of manhandling livestock and their broods of children, but again they trended towards a bulkier set. This was a womanly form of a classical sort. Catra found herself strangely entranced. Her mind, still fighting the edges of sleep in spite of the sudden rousing jolt of curiosity, seemed to find the form familiar; coupled with the words and the cadence of the voice.

The door to Mr Beauregard’s room opened and Catra expected the maid to hand the candle over, or perhaps to receive a chamberpot or tray.

She did not expect the woman to dip her head, nor to observe the look of concern upon Mr Archer’s face in the candlelight. And she most certainly did not expect to see the *embrace.* The maid stepped into the room and Catra caught a flash of blonde hair underneath a shawl pulled high over her head. Mr Archer smiled as he led the woman inside, then glanced about the corridor, before closing the door. Catra heard the lock.

She was now roused. And incensed.

Her thoughts doubled back on Mr de Gray - perhaps his words *had* been an insult, couched in mock outrage! And Mr Archer! A cad! A bounder! A man who it seemed was reflected by his choice of companion. An accurate match for the condescending, objectifying tone of *Mr de Gray*, as Mr Archer appeared to be a gentleman of low morals and high charm.

And Glimmer, entrapped by his whiles!

But now was not the time for rash action, unbecoming of a woman of her bearing. No, this would require careful handling to preserve the honour of her sister and their family. It would have to wait until the morrow and then she would pay a second call upon Mr Archer. No one, but no one, would besmirch her sister's reputation.

Chapter End Notes

Oh, that BOUNDER! That CAD!

Of course, Bow must be the bad guy here, of course! He MUST BE, can't see any reason for a blonde to go to his room... after a stressful evening. Staring at a woman.

None at all.

And of course Catra is going to have a fair, balance and rational response to all of this.

A lady of the cloth

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer take their leave.

A visitor makes a proposition.

Catra has much to consider.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Breakfast was a cordial affair, at least from the enthused perspective of the Senior Archer pairing. Glimmer was entranced by the fine selection of pastries, meats and multitudinous egg offerings.

"Sister, they have scrambled, poached *and* fried offering."

"Yes, sister dear. I can see. I am sat, currently, *right next to you* and thus can purvey the same."

"OH! Salmon also? Truly this is a most generous spread for a mere breaking of the fast!"

Lance chuckled across the table, "Hardly! This is, arguably, the most important meal of the day - it establishes you, sets your course for the remainder. Your mind becomes focused and full of energy! Well, it is so for us at any rate!" he smiled broadly and nudged his husband, who was idly buttering a slice of toast. The shorter man glanced up and smiled.

"Quite."

Catra managed a smile that didn't feel quite so brittle. How two such honest, kind and apparently forthright gentlemen could have produced a cad such as *Beauregard* she could not fathom.

Perhaps he was merely a bad sort among a plethora of decency; his siblings were likely cut from the better part of the cloth? She turned to her sister.

“Glimmer, did you look in on Mr Archer? Will he not join us as a good host?”

The question drew a faint blush and an admonishing smile to Glimmer’s face, “I knocked, but he said he was still ill. I asked one of the servants to take a tray. He should not strain himself, but I will call upon his room before we leave, to ensure he is on the mend.”

“Which servant?” the question fled from Catra’s mouth before she could marshal her emotions. Glimmer blinked in surprise and Catra managed to rally her erstwhile reactions, “I mean, to ensure it has been delivered.”

Truth told, she had been trying to spot the sneaky creature she’d espied the night prior. But none of the servants appeared to have the broad physique nor blonde hair she’d followed through the mansion. She hadn’t seen Mr de Gray either, but the gentleman was furthest from her thoughts at present. Or had been. Certainly was not a persistent presence in the back of her mind.

Mostly because she felt vindicated in her opinion of the man - for clearly, Mr Archer was also of poor manners and thus she had been correct to assume Mr de Gray was a blaggard also. If Mr Archer had been a good man, then her assessment of Mr de Gray would have been strange, anomalous. But with this revelation of his tawdry approach, it made sense that he should associate with so brash a gentleman.

Glimmer huffed and arched an eyebrow, “So concerned for his well-being, should I find myself with a rival now, Catra?”

The tone was ribbing, the smirk upon Glimmer’s face a gentle tease. Catra rolled her eyes, but felt irked and appalled at the same time. Her knowledge of the truth warred with her desire for

propriety. To damn the man in front of his family would be scandalous and mortally embarrassing for her sister. Preservation of Glimmer's pride and honour was paramount, "Hardly. I merely worry for you fawning so seriously that we fail to make it home! It would be a disservice."

The conversation remained light until the sound of boots in the hall echoed through the open door. Mr de Gray entered and Catra found herself surprised. The man appeared wan, blue eyes dim and drawn with bags beneath them. He glanced about the room and managed a tight smile, "My apologies, all. I am called away on urgent business. Ladies, it was a pleasure and… I hope we might reconvene at some future date. Your dialogue, company and engaging wit were… appreciated."

Catra managed a small smile, but it felt difficult. She also felt a twinge of concern on her part for the gentleman, "Sir, you appear pale. Are you afflicted as Mr Archer?"

He appraised her and shook his head, "No madame. I assure you this is no ill tempering of my humours or such. This is… a personal matter of some dreary note that should not concern such carefree souls such as yourselves."

The words felt sincere, but Catra still stung at the implication, "I am no frivolous being, sir," she bristled. Mr de Gray closed his eyes and swallowed.

"Indeed not madame. Again, my tongue appears dull and ill suited to our normal exchanges, for which I am deeply sorry. Do excuse me and I pray you have a most pleasant day. I am sure Beauregard will appreciate such company when he is recovered and not so whimperingly convalescing."

There was the ghost of a smile on Mr de Gray's face - a faint fondness and Catra once more felt herself conflicted - was Mr de Gray aware of Mr Archer's dalliances? Did he support them? If so, he was a worse bounder by far! And if not, then what *was* he? A fool? A socially inept buffoon? An oblivious blonde idiot? The man

plucked the hat from under his arm, then bowed to the table. George and Lance offered their best wishes and Glimmer gave Mr de Gray a warm smile and a request that he *travel safely* . And with that, the gentleman was gone.

It was puzzling that Catra felt irritated by the man's absence. Perhaps he could answer these pressing queries as to the honour of Mr Archer.

Breakfast completed shortly thereafter and the two ladies made their way to the drive, where their carriage awaited. They turned to regard the mansion's frontage and waved at Mr and Mr Archer who stood at the entrance, then boarded the carriage. Glimmer huffed, "I am saddened that Beauregard is still unwell. Perhaps I should have… called upon him more ardently?"

Catra didn't meet her sister's gaze and merely offered a shrug, "Perhaps. Maybe a good shock is what the man requires. We shall see…"

She had not espied the blonde servant, which likely meant that she was still ensconced in the blaggard's bedchamber. The sheer nerve and affrontery of it! Perhaps *that* was the reason for Mr de Gray's shocked demeanour? Perhaps he was unaware of Mr Archer's underhand and lascivious dealings and had quit the house, without wishing to embarrass the family and the women?

For some reason, that interpretation warmed Catra; she found it harder to fault Mr de Gray, even if her original thoughts justified her treatment of him via the apparent actions of Mr Archer - two cads, flocking together. And yet, she found it hard to maintain the image of Mr de Gray as a *cruel* man. He struck her as lonesome, distant. Rude, yes, but not cruel.

The concept that he might be appalled at Mr Archer's behaviour seemed *right* ; for on analysis, the gentleman's commentary on women seemed to shift and became a lament on the station of womanhood; the restrictions and uncertain expectations; and,

yes, their limitations as defined by many in society and the pathways available.

She pondered this as the carriage trundled away. Her gaze took in the frontage of Thaymor Manor and, as Glimmer chattered excitedly about the future, she pondered the steps she would have to take to ensure her sister's security.

It was not mama or papa who met them at the door, but rather Mermista. Their sister had the look of one who had been through a trial- her gaze distant and her demeanour flat. Catra descended the steps of the carriage, then assisted Glimmer down, whilst the footmen unloaded their meager cases, "Mer, whatever is the matter? You look like one of your books fell on you," chortled Catra.

Glimmer peered at their taller sister and frowned, "Did that Lieutenant Hawk call? Did he set aflame a candelabra or something?"

Mermista shook her head and shuddered, "I… we have *company* . I managed to get away. I think we need to save Mama."

Catra and Glimmer exchanged a nervous glance, "Who has come to call…?"

"DEAREST CAT-OF-THE-WILDS!" The voice was rich, enthusiastic and *loud* . A figure stepped from within the entrance to Brightmoon House, clad in a black clergy robe. Short cropped platinum hair and a figure that looked like the individual herded cattle *personally* , rather than shepherding a more human flock.

Catra paled and Glimmer tried to hide behind her, but to no avail. The towering figure swept Catra up into a bone-crushing hug, entirely without care for propriety. Glimmer exhaled in relief, but happy eyes locked onto her and the pink-haired lady was suddenly yanked in as well.

“It is good to see you have… welcomed my daughter’s home, Reverend. Perhaps a moment so they may respond appropriately?” came the soft and mildly perturbed voice of Mrs Moon from the doorway.

“Oh of course! How forward of me! And our engagement not even properly organised or established!”

The Reverend stepped back, showing herself to be a woman of statuesque proportions and an effervescent personality. She smiled broadly and clapped her hands happily in front of her. Catra blinked at her but managed a smile. The Reverend was a cousin of the family, via some entangled root and branch of the tree; she now served a community parish somewhere in the north. She was about to greet her, when an aspect of the Reverend’s statement clicked into place, “Wait… engagement?”

The broad woman beamed, “Quite so! Well, I heard that Aunt Angella was in quite the pickle with Glimmer coming up for presentation and the fears of inheritance and losing the home from the family line. And, well, my patron, Lady Shadow d’Weaver, she has always advised that a pairing must be *established* . And she is a very well to do woman, a lady of means. Of course she holds with tradition in many respects, but I believe that, with the locale of the parish under my purview, a bond between two eligible ladies could be countenanced, especially given my position within the Clergy! All covered at Theological Orientation, of course!”

Catra looked at Glimmer and smirked,”Congratulations Glim,” the comment drawing a shocked sputter from the paralysed young woman. The Reverend laughed breezily.

“Well, now, I have unfortunately been disabused by Uncle Micah! I am to understand the dear Glimmer is likely to be expecting a caller with joyous news? And a viable offer?” the large woman grinned with genuine excitement, then looked at Catra, “Truth told, much as I adore Glimmer, I was heartbroken it was not *you* , dear cousin, who I should approach. HOWEVER, with this exciting

development, this now opens up the possibility of our uniting our families and cementing the future! Happy! Together! Just like when we were children! Although, not *quite* like that of course. More grown up. Of course that means we must discuss where we shall live, what with my Parish duties and, well...” the big woman rambled, her thoughts clearly getting lost in the details, but her face was lit with happiness.

For her part, Catra’s vision tunneled and she blinked in surprise. It was Glimmer’s turn to nudge her. The shorter girl chuckled, “Congratulations *Cat* .”

That jolted the brunette who held up her hands to forestall the Reverend, “Rev… *Scorpia* . Can… can we get inside? This is… all out of order. Propositioning me on the gravel outside my home, when I am dusty from the road?”

“Oh! Gosh! Yes!” lamented Scorpia, suddenly embarrassed, “I was just so excited and, well, I know it’s sudden and I was *just* discussing it with Angella and Micah, but they hadn’t said yes. Oh goodness, I am rather getting ahead of myself. I, oh.. Tea! Tea, yes. Angella? Is there tea?”

The tall Matriarch of the Moon family sighed theatrically in the door, then beckoned all to step inside, “I believe so, dear. Do follow us to the drawing room.”

It was excruciating. Absolutely agonising. Reverend Scorpia Collins had a *plan* and a presentation. She had a folder of notes and an enthusiastic determination to ensure all her proposals were laid out. Literally.

She had a backup one for Mermista as well; even a tentative one for Entrapta!

Which, to be honest, even though Catra had honestly considered it, still was somewhat irksome.

She sat, hands in her lap, as the good Reverend espoused the benefits of a union: the maintenance of the estates within the family, for example; the continuity of ownership; her own connections to one Lady Shadow d'Weaver, a most *generous* patron. Well, not generous, but certainly attentive. Well, maybe not *attentive* but active. After a fashion. Certainly vocal. Maybe judgmental.

Scorpia appeared to have lost her particular train of thought after that digression but Micah, begrudgingly, pulled her back into focus, "So, you wish for our Catra to be… beholden to you?"

"Ah! Well! I have always held her in the highest esteem! We write, regularly!"

Truthfully, Scorpia did write regularly. Catra made a point of only replying to one in every ten letters, lest she *encourage* things - apparently that had still displayed an *enthusiasm* on her part, regardless. Give the woman an inch and truly she would annex the next county. She sighed and shot a pleading glance to her parents. Angella hid a smile behind her teacup and Micah bit his lip to suppress a grin.

She would have to deliver the first parry herself then, "Dearest Scorpia..."

"Yes, my cat-of-the-wilds," Scorpia's smile was open, honest and kind. This felt rather like kicking a small, defenceless animal. For the barest moment, framed by the window, Catra's mind saw another blonde head, hair shorn short, their masculine features still somewhat bordering on feminine. Why, put Scorpia in trousers and she possibly could pass, at a distance, as a rather *masculine* figure! Like Mr de Gray could perhaps pass for feminine when one did not see his face! She smiled briefly at *that* awkward memory. If only the voice and countenance had matched!

The thought amused her and, strangely, saddened her - Mr de Gray and Scorpia were worlds apart! Something in her mind jostled for her attention - a nagging thought, but she dismissed it

to focus upon the present. At least Scorpia *was* a woman! Surely this was what she had wanted?

Except it felt *wrong* . It felt a compromise. And she knew she would not be able to countenance such a union.

"Reverend, I must… consider this. You cannot simply deposit such an announcement and expect me to simply capitulate! I must consider, deliberate, engage with my parents on the… engagement."

"Ahh! That's my cat-of-the-wilds. So perceptive. Perspicacious! A font of knowledge and negotiation! Truly, should you accept, which I am sure you can envision the benefits of doing so, we will be a force!" Scorpia beamed and clapped her hands, then stood, "I must away to my chambers! I was on the road a fair bit today before my arrival and, even though the carriage granted by Lady Shadow d'Weaver was comfort itself, I was most tuckered out! Do excuse me!"

And with that, she departed. The other sisters, who were sat on a settee at the side of the room, gawked at Catra, like some chorus. She scowled at them, "What?"

"Like, I trust that's a solid *no* ?"

Glimmer glanced at Mermista then chuckled, "Well, if she decides she has a fondness for the more masculine traits, then she could cry of Mr de Gray as a reason to refuse? But she is stubborn!"

"My proclivities and heart are not *choice* sister - I am beholden to what and who I am!" scolded Catra. Glimmer looked suitably chagrined and nodded. Frosta glanced up and shrugged.

"At least you're getting offers. Though the Reverend is… intense."

Micah chuckled, "I know, right? Oh… sorry dear," he shrunk slightly as Angella shot him a rather pained look, then turned to her daughter.

“And what are your thoughts on the matter my dear?”

“I… I don’t wish to let the family down; we do need to secure advantageous links and… well, we have no guarantee that Mr Archer will follow through!” her gut twisted at the thought and she pondered whether accepting the engagement might be best - to allow some security for the family. But her mind rebelled against the thought of compromise.

“Darling…?” Angella frowned, then turned to address the other girls, “If you would be so kind as to amuse yourselves *elsewhere* .”

The other women huffed and Mermista rolled her eyes, “But *mom* this is, like, the most interesting to happen to Catra *ever* so…”

“Out!” scolded Angella and the quartet of women scuttled away, with only Glimmer pausing at the door to offer a sympathetic wince to Catra.

The brunette sagged in her chair and grimaced but when she looked up at her parents she saw only sympathy and tenderness, “What,” she coughed, “What do I do? What do you… need of me? I don't. I am torn, I am so so so confused.”

Angella tilted her head, “This is quite unlike you dear.”

“Let’s just say I’ve… had a reality adjustment as to circumstances and our position within them. If Glimmer does not…” her stomach twisted with knowledge that she could not, for the sake of *honour* and propriety divulge. She inhaled, “If Glim cannot wed, or if circumstances change, then the family’s success rides on me.”

Her mother’s frown deepened, “To do so would compromise you very being, Catra…” she murmured. Micah watched his daughter, quiet and thoughtful. That alone was abnormal!

Catra sighed, her initial reaction tempered by an unfamiliar lump in her chest, a strange sense of obligation, “I know! And the thought fills me with dread. And yet... perhaps it would not

compromise *everything* . Scorpia is a decent enough woman, I suppose. And she is a woman, after all. I could take up bridge?”

Her parents regarded her in silence. Then Micah rocked back and guffawed. Angella covered her mouth and looked away. Catra huffed and glared at them as Micah fanned himself with his newspaper, “B...BRIDGE! Bridge she says! Maybe you shall also partake in embroidery? Take high tea and share the finest gossip of Lady Shadow d’Weaver?”

Catra snarled, “Why are you mocking me? I… I could not forgive myself if my inaction lead to the destitution of the family. I would not be able to bring myself to… to see you for the shame of it.”

Angella hummed with amusement and leaned forwards to rest a hand atop Catra’s knee, “And we would not choose to see you if you *did* accept,” she said with a twinkle in her eye. Catra tilted her head and swallowed, her heart suddenly tight with affection as her mother gazed kindly at her.

Mr Moon sat up and planted his hands on his knees, “Dearest, tempestuous, firebrand. One thing we all learn in life is compromise. Sometimes it is necessary - to avoid dispute, to find harmony. But *never* to one’s detriment, if at all possible. For to compromise oneself leads to many more steps in that direction and an ultimate reduction of the whole. You take the *easy* path? What next? And whilst you could grow to care for, beyond your already cordial attachment to the Reverend, would you deny yourself an opportunity to learn more of yourself?”

Catra flinched and cast about the room, her eyes suddenly filled with tears. The emotions of acceptance warred with a strange new sense of duty. A sense that drew a strange recollection of blue eyes that seemed to *see* her in a way she had never known. Her heart and head warred but over what she knew not, “You see accepting the engagement as the *easy* option?" Angella and Micah nodded, "But… but I could learn happiness? Many do! The entire of society is *based* around such arrangements!”

Angella and Micah exchanged another glance, then stood and gathered Catra up in an embrace. Mrs Moon squeezed her daughter's shoulder, "If you truly wish to choose this path, we will support you. But think on it, dearest. Think *hard* . We are not destitute - we live in an enlightened county, with inheritance and law on our side. Yes, a marriage would secure futures, but property? Women may own without the purview of a husband. Or even a wife of a senior station!"

Catra snorted at Angella's slightly arch tone, the gentle wryness of her mother's voice calmed her and she exhaled, "I suddenly find myself… surprised. Ambushed, even. Maybe that is why I am suddenly so conflicted."

"Indeed, we had not expected so forthright a declaration from the Reverend. But then again, Scorpia has always been an outspoken sort. You could do worse, but truly could you spend a lifetime with her? Love her? See her for who she is? If so… get to know her first, my dearest. Do as Glimmer has with Mr Archer."

The words lanced into her, but she found a bitter truth to them - if only Glimmer knew the truth; and yet to do so would break her. Far better for Mr Archer to be convinced of alternative options and to do the decent thing. Of this she was sure. But as for Scorpia - perhaps time to know the woman would prove informative. She might be a decent option - she was a woman, after all, which fell in line with Catra's aspirations along one particular track at least. And she knew that, even with the confused intent of one Mr de Gray.

She sighed and nodded, "I will… ponder the matter. And not rush in. To be honest my reaction is... no."

Mrs Moon gave her a fond smile, "Very good. I understand there is another ball to be held at the Casta's this week. I have it on good authority that Mr Archer will be there, along with several of the Regiment! A good opportunity to dance, to see the Reverend in a more social setting away from the domestics here. Take these

days to… meet with her, understand her. Then you will be informed."

Micah squeezed her shoulder, "And, whilst I am sure she will be an insufferable in law should you decide to leap feet first into that challenge, we will love and support you whatever your choice!" Angella shot him a glare and he met it with a smile, "I am merely vocalising your own internal ranting, my love. Dare you deny it?"

Mrs Moon sighed, "I dare not, love of mine. As ever, your perceptive eye is a blessing and a curse. I do wonder how I put up with such an insufferable man!" her smile was gentle, to take the sting from the words.

"See, Catra dear, this is what awaits you - consider you patience and your tolerance for vexatious teasing! How well does your wit exchange, how ready is your tongue…" Angella actually blushed for a moment and Micah coughed, then rallied, "to deliver fine points meant in kindness but with enough cut to challenge and invigorate!"

Catra laughed and sat back down, her parents following suit, "Surely it is more than just conversation?"

"It is, my dear," admonished Angella, "For any love, you must partake of each other's presence, their beliefs, their very bearing. A house may allow you solace should some aspects of their being be intolerable, so you must school yourself to that. It will never be plain sailing at all hours of the day. You must find solace where you can."

As her gaze moved between them, the Moons shared yet another smiling glance. Catra frowned, "But you are barely apart."

Micah chuckled, "Indeed not. For we are lucky that we do find solace in each other. However, we still mark our own time - that is key, vital even. To become dependent on another is a dangerous thing; for you risk losing yourself and that irony can cripple an attachment. Slavish devotion is *not* love. To a person, to an idea,

to *anything* . This is something you have always expressed - that challenge, that fire. So, for us, please do not extinguish it. Nurture that flame, for it will draw others to you. And it will consume those unworthy. But someone will come who can feed that fire, and not be burned by it."

Angella regarded her husband and arched an eyebrow, "Wisdom does spill forth occasionally from my nerve-wracked love. Enthused as he is, he does counsel you well. Scorpia is a woman of enthusiasm, but… is she a moth? I feel her temperament and yours are not well matched, but it is for *you* to decide. For you, not for some sense of duty to us."

Catra nodded, then stood, "Thank you," she swallowed and blinked away tears, then practically fell onto her mother, embracing her tightly. She straightened then smoothed her dress. Her father stood and opened his arms and she collapsed into them again, "Thank you."

With a breath, she turned and pushed open the door. She heard a thud and smirked as she found a pile of ladies on the other side. Mermista groaned under Frosta and Entrapta, whilst Glimmer lurked to one side of the door. Catra flashed her sisters a roguish grin, "Well now, gossip mongers the lot of you."

"What did they say?" hissed Glimmer, "We only heard murmurs!"

"That is for me to know, my Sparkly haired sibling, and for you to ponder upon 'til judgement day!" Catra smirked, then gestured to the sprawled siblings, "So… a wander to the village? I feel the need for air."

She chuckled and darted towards the door - the chance to clear her head of cobwebs and the strange and unfamiliar melancholy that had threatened her with the weight of expectation. Her heart and mind said *no* to the very concept of Reverend Scorpia Collins beyond a polite acquaintance. But the fear at Glimmer's likely abandonment and the pressure that would be foisted on the family pushed her mind towards something greater - if she could

spare her siblings the fear? The shame? Was a compromise not better? Her heart could wither and die, after all, denied a partner. She saw the folly, in a way, of Glimmer's approach - to wish for love and be entranced by charm.

Perhaps love was just a fools game after all. Pragmatism and the hardening of oneself? Perhaps that was the safest recourse. Her parents had advised she consider; without pressure. And yet it was pressure of her own making that haunted her. They talked of love, of desire and consuming flames; but also that compromise was necessary? Truly, she could envision a life with Scorpia. After a fashion. In a manner of speaking. If one squinted at the future. She would likely have to partake in long walks. Maybe visit family. Alone. A lot.

But it could be worth it?

If only she could cease the invasive thoughts of intense blue eyes. If. Only.

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, some marked differences! For once, the Bennetts are in accord! And Catra is confused. Crimson with embarrassment, would such an Engagement be a Waste...
>
> (Yeah parallels to Scorptra kiss here! Or getting there... teasing the POSSIBILITY) but i wonder who Scorpia could POSSIBLY meet at the ball held by Casta...
>
> And the Regiment? Wonder who else could be turning up.
>
> So - did I get the slow hardening of Catra right as the weight of it all begins to bear down? Will she meet some entertaining sorts at this ball who might engage her in gossip and shared stories?
>
> I'm trying to show a slight difference to Lizzie in that she IS now willing to compromise a little - a slight twist on the Collins issue, buuuut I think an interesting twist (To capture

elements of Catra's in-show slide into colder pragmatism... more of which we shall see NEXT chapter as she speaks to a certain Beauregard)

AS ever - feedback GREATLY appreciated. This chapter I like, but it could be trimmed, perhaps? Let me know what you think, if you liked the Moon's and their encouragement and attempts at advice that, maybe, haven't gone across as they'd hoped!

A Promenade

Chapter Summary

Catra contemplates a revelation.

Scorpia makes her intentions known.

Mr De Gray wrestles with reality.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The days preceding the upcoming ball were fraught. For Catra at least. The rest of the Moon contingent were content to promenade about the village or take tea with the rather earnest reverend. Truly, she was not a bad sort, but she had the most awkward habit of taking an interest; and not a polite one to engender conversation. No, rather her interest led to near monologues of recollections that left the company rather glassy eyed with the sheer amount of knowledge deposited within the conversation.

Of the cohort, only Entrapta seemed to be unaffected, capable of engaging the Reverend on equal footing, despite the fact that their conversations appeared to be, in actuality, twin monologues, delivered in parallel.

And yet that worked.

So, whilst the enthusiastic Reverend and the sharp-minded sister continued their badminton conversation, the remainder of the

Moon family were able to entertain themselves with other distractions.

Catra had withdrawn to the rose garden of the house, to contemplate her limited options, alongside the wider ramifications of any potential action. Truly, her options were not pleasant and she was, currently, uncertain as to how to proceed. Glimmer had noticed her melancholy, but had attributed it to the impending potential nuptial proposition by the good Reverend.

Her reverie was disturbed by an enthusiastic greeting - evidently Entrapta had wandered off and left the Reverend unsupervised.

"Ah! My dearest cat-of-the-wilds!"

Catra schooled her face into a pleasant smile, only slightly strained at the edges. She turned, framed by two waist high ornamental hedges and waved, "Ah, Reverend."

"Pish posh! Scorpia to you, you know that!" The Reverend drew level and nudged Catra's shoulder, "Or should I be referring to you as *Ms Moon* , oh wife-to-be?"

Catra blinked at the forwardness, "That is… presumptuous, is it not?"

Reverend Scorpia waved a hand and chuckled, “Well, as my patron, Lady Shadow d’Weaver is want to say, *no victory without commitment!* And, well, she may have some edges, but that lady well, she knows her history, boy does she! And, well, I am not one to brag, but I do like to commit to things in earnest and follow through! I mean, honestly, Cat? I’ve always held a bit of a candle, y’know? Since we were running around the fields hereabouts, when you came to the family?”

The memory made Catra smile - Scorpia had been a tomboy and a half. She had vague recollections of Scorpia’s mother, a shorter, blonde thing; and her apparent governess. That woman had been *tall* , with black hair and a soft smile.

“Ahhh, halcyon days. Your governess was quite imposing! Almost as much as Angella. I was so intimidated by Angella, another tall woman was… too much!”

The Reverend furrowed her brow, “Governess?”

“Your memory all there, dear Reverend?” Catra smirked, “The tall woman? Black hair?”

Scorpia blinked, then snorted a laugh, “Oh Cat… that was my *mother* .”

“No… no, your mother had the blonde hair - like yours!”

“Also my mother,” Catra stared at the Reverend, who smiled back gently, “My parents are from a more… carefree part of the country, where such social mores as ‘ *natural* pairings’ are not forced on you as dogmatic truth! ANd, well, I was brought up with that in mind. And it is also why this is a perfect match! Now, not a bad word, really, to say about Lady Shadow d’Weaver, but she isn’t entirely supportive of that. More… tolerant. However, she is a shrew follower of the social movement of the day and as such has not opposed my own desires in that department, for which I am grateful. And not just because my own holdings at the Rectory would be in jeopardy if she had taken against it…”

Catra held up a hand, “Well, um, this is… a sudden and unexpected shift. But, please, Scorpia, a moment. Why is this perfect?”

“Why, because I come from a family that is already accepting of the choices of Mara! And my patron is not politically or societally opposed to it! And, well, we are a good match! You would be the belle of any social event in the North! Able to run laps about the dizzy old men there! And because I love you!”

That made Catra blink in surprise, the earnest declaration a strangely offensive barb. Scorpia was a friend, but they had barely exchanged more than passing notes or polite conversations in their adolescent years, “Reverend, I do fear that is yet another *presumptuous* statement! We have not yet courted, not yet… truly gotten to know one another!”

"Well, we are amending that state of affairs, are we not?" Scorpia beamed widely, "Come! Let's, um… let's walk hereabouts and you can… tell me about your particulars!"

"My… particulars?"

"Your distractions! Hobbies! Acquaintances! I understand your stay at Thaymor House was eventful. A nice place, we passed the grounds on our way here. Not nearly as grand as Lady Shadow d'Weaver's holdings, all told. She has thirteen bedrooms, you know? And *two* conservatories."

"Gosh. Two, you say?" managed Catra weakly. They walked and, in spite of Scorpia's idea, they talked little of Catra's ideals; no, rather Scorpia prattled. The brunette had a sudden insight into the woman: she was nervous. But still she waffled on, asking a question, then interrupting before Catra had a moment to interject.

"And of course, we have ample space in the gardens for you to read in, to dabble in activities of your choice. Oh! And several rooms for expansion for when children are…"

Catra thudded to a halt and turned her irate gaze upon the Reverend. The woman had her hands in something of a prayer position and her eyes widened in surprise at Catra's incredulous stare, "We are not betrothed and yet you talk of future attitudes and attributes as if it is a mere formality that my opinion will be a factor!"

The good reverend looked nonplussed, then blanched, "Oh, um, no! I mean, of course not, I just, um, well, because we got on so well I thought…"

"Scorpia, we correspond in the most paltry on manners - I do not wish to be *abrupt* but our exchanges are sincere, robust, but *lacking* ."

"Not true, Cat! Your writings are of the most passionate expressions! Every word leaps from the page and into my heart!"

"I wrote about *the weather* , Scorpia. Or about the latest minor tidbits of gossip from Mr Lashor's latest bridge tournament."

"And what a gripping tale it was! How he flew into a funk over having accidentally forgetting he was the dummy that one round!"

Catra stared at her, "It was *dull* , Scorpia."

The blonde smiled and for a moment there was a calm on her face. A tranquility of affection - honest, earnest and true. Scorpia had always been the responsible guest, helping Catra when she had scraped a knee, or misplaced a journal. Ever helpful. But they had not been *close* for many years; and even back then it had been a closeness of playmates and forced socialisation. Clearly, however, it had led to a form of infatuation; whereas in Catra it was mere fondness, flattery at the appreciation.

She pondered that, for a moment - was that so bad? Her choices were sparse, after all. Even in this more understanding of shires, it was hardly a bountiful crop of opportunity.

A Reverend's wife had cache, had status and would guarantee a line of inheritance for her family; it would allow her to secure the holdings against any more solid relatives with a formal legal tie; would avoid all legal challenges as she would be in a formal arrangement with another solid family.

And yet there was something missing from Scorpia's earnest expression. It was infatuation, yes. A deep, almost burning enthusiasm - yearning, perhaps. But those eyes lacked the piercing set to them; the ability to strip past her walls of sardonic commentary and her thrust of sneering barbs.

Also, they were not *blue .*

Catra found that particular thought to be an intrusive one *at best* . She rolled her shoulders and raised her chin. Scorpia smiled wider and shook her head.

"Perhaps dull for you, but to me it was the sunrise. I am just so *fond* of you, oh Cat-of-the-wilds. Such a tempestuous soul! I come alive around you, find myself driven to be better! You are a whirlwind!"

And then it settled onto Catra the issue. She tilted her head to regard the woman - attractive, kind, friendly. And yet that missing thing.

Scorpia was better for knowing Catra, yes. But was Catra better for knowing Scorpia? And, truly, was Catra a positive influence, or merely an invention within the mind of the Reverend?

“Who am I, Reverend?”

“Oh, why… Catra Moon!”

“What is my favoured text?”

“Oh, um… gosh, you said in a letter you had read a treatise on um… oh gosh what was it?”

“My favoured musical piece?”

“Oh, well…”

Catra smiled, “And what is your position on what I should be doing in your household?”

“Well, you would want for nothing, after all! I would… I would look after you! And with my patron, well, we would have… respect and protection and…”

“A gilded cage? Benign domesticity? You think that is what I aspire to? To simper on your arm, to be naught but a bauble?”

“No! No! I… I want you to be HAPPY, Cat. You made me so happy, so… I wish to repay the sentiment.”

Catra flung her hands in the air, “It is not so simple! I could not countenance being in a partnership so unequal. So flawed in its sentiment. You list how I make YOU happy yet you seem to not understand my own whims and wishes! You waffle and wind on, not even thinking before you speak, madam, and it is vexing!”

Scorpia recoiled, though in truth Catra’s rage was not at all stoked by the Reverend herself; she had merely fanned the flames of ire, as Catra’s own frustrations boiled over the pot of her inner self. The situation with Mr Archer, couple with her fears for the future of her family.

Catra uncoiled, realising she had quite overstepped the mark. Her face fell into a schooled, neutral mask and she opened her mouth, but was beaten there by Scorpia’s quiet rebuke.

“I feel you have made your feelings on the subject clear. I am… disappointed I was not able to convince you at this juncture and, honestly, I wish you had been as forthright from the start of our

correspondences. It is… it is my honest appraisal that you are not a particularly decent confidant nor acquaintance."

"Reverend…"

"No, it is… it is quite alright…"

"Scorpia. Be honest. You want me, but you do not *know* me," Catra reined her frustrations in and smoothed her dress, "I would be poor company and I feel I am ill suited to your aspirations."

A faint flicker of hope crossed Scorpia's face, "But see, we can learn! This time is a gift to do so!"

In response, Catra held up a hand, "We shall attend the ball. As acquaintances. Let us converse more, Reverend. But for now, please would you leave me to my thoughts? I am aware I have wounded you and wish to be no further a burden upon your pride. If I am honest… this is why I could not be your wife… the idea of depriving you of happiness by miring in my own melancholy? Disatisfying."

Scorpia pursed her lips, then nodded with finality, but a smile tugged at her face, "ANd that is why I find you so…. Wonderful Cat. Considering me! Even know! I hold out hope! Indeed. Well. Goodness, quite the emotional exultation! I will retire to the drawing room. Perhaps you would… join me there later?"

“Perhaps,” smiled Catra, faintly, still mildly exasperated at the woman’s dogged enthusiasm and determination. She had no intention of heading to the drawing room, and yet felt somewhat beholden to due the emotional turmoil clearly within the Reverend. But to agree to a life of dissatisfaction to resolve a momentary heartbreak? That was a compromise she felt would ill serve them both.

A moment later and Catra was alone once more with her thoughts.

The situation with Mr Archer would need resolving; a decision regarding the Reverend would require a clarification of her position; and then what of the future?

Shrouded in melancholy, Catra found herself back inside the house. She headed for her room and breezed past Glimmer. The woman seemed to be obnoxiously cheerful, in the manner of any in love. That fact alone merely soured Catra’s mood further.

“You appear to be dining on lemons, sister dear,” chided the smiling girl. Catra shook her head and darted into her room, emerging with gloves and bonnet.

“Hardly. Merely… a state of ennui that shall pass with a constitutional walk.”

“No romantic rendezvous planned with the amorous Reverend?” Glimmer’s voice was laced with scandalised anticipation. Also, no

small amount of glee. Catra froze on the stairs, then turned to give her sister an incredulous stare. So incredulous that one of her eyelids twitched.

"NO!"

"Well it might do you good. To perchance hold hands and enjoy a private promenade!"

"I am agog," Catra's voice dipped to a flatter register, "You held hands. And now you are the expert on all things romantic and lustful in the world?"

"We… well, I… a lady does not kiss and tell!" Glimmer squeaked. She folded her arms and tilted her chin, which made Catra snort.

"My sparkling love, you are too perfect. Also, clearly a lot to learn. No, the Reverend still wishes to press her suit but I desire some solitude… to contemplate the future," Catra's voice creaked a little at that last moment and Glimmer rushed forward to clasp her hands.

"Sister, the weight of the family is not on you. Father and Mother are in rude health; the Reverend, whilst in the line of inheritance, is not stipulated in the will, and no doubt the bylaws will allow for us to inherit the property. And my pending engagement will secure things, so fret not!"

Catra stiffened, " *He* has propositioned you thus?"

The blush that crept up Glimmer's neck was deep, "Not as yet. But his intention is clear. I know it. Beauregard is a man of dedication and focus, albeit nerves and shyness as well. He will do so soon, I have no doubt."

Within her chest, Catra's heart felt like it would tear anew - the cad would likely get his jollies and move along. Like with that serving girl - some poor slip of a maid (Albeit a tall, well defined slip, but still) Glimmer would be another notch on some bounder's bed post. This intention or belief had to be quashed, but also had to be done in a way to minimise the harm to poor, sweet Glimmer.

She managed a smile, "Well, I hope it all turns out well."

"Where is your enthusiasm, sister? I thought you fond of the man! Or has Mr De Gray fully annoyed you to make you so vexatious towards Mr Archer?"

"Put it from your mind, Glimmer," Catra squeezed her sister's hands and shook them gently, then released, "I am in a funk of sorts. It will pass."

She turned and descended, then strode from the mansion.

Town was a mixed bag of experiences for Adam. The conversation with the ladies that morning, days ago now, had been partly true - business had called the gentleman away, but it was really business of the heart. The heart that had driven Adam to leave the room as their true namesake.

Adora had stolen across the landing of Thaymor house and frozen at the sound of Catra's sleepy voice. A stumbled response and an affected accent had enabled her to steal onward to Beauregard's room. He was still peaky but had welcomed her in with a look of concern.

She rarely tread the halls beyond her rooms in her natural state. Free from the trappings of duty, status and expectation, she had sunk to the floor at the foot of her friend's bed and wept.

"Adora…" Beauregard had sat next to her and pulled her into a side hug, "It's Catra, right?"

She had not been able to talk, only to weep. The viciousness of the irony - to find a woman so perfect, so matched to Adora's own mind: quick of wit, wry of humour, and with the tenacity of a lioness. Her beauty was merely an added layer on the pattern of the woman's perfection.

At least according to Adora.

And yet, as Adam, she was as distant as the stars.

"You fell, hard, am I correct?" Beauregard's words were a whisper of sadness. Adora had nodded at them.

"I… how? I barely know her! Three meetings, Beauregard! THREE! What am I, some soppy milkmaid?"

"No, you are a De Gray. And we both know how stubborn and wilful your family are."

Adora had tipped her head back against the end of the bed, "Curse Adam for absconding. Leaving me with this… this mess."

"You don't know that he had a choice. The seas are treacherous. And your opponents opportunistic. But… perhaps the truth would be the best course in this endeavour?"

"Are you mad? She would think me a deviant! Or… a coward," Adora had folded her arms across her knees, then rested her chin atop them, "A shadow. It is all I am now. A shadow, a signature and a sorrow."

Adam sighed as Swiftwind slowed to a canter amidst the trees. *Adora* had left Beauregard's rooms before dawn, having found no way forward. Well, no way that Adora could sensibly take without much risk. And *Adam* had descended the stairs to plead off.

It had been hard, as those eyes had stared through Mr De Gray's words, had taken the gentleman in. *Harden your heart,* came the words, *if you wish to continue this charade. It can brook no distraction* .

Poison, yes. But a challenge, also. And the one who spoke those words would seize on any weakness, any chink in the armour of Adam's ruse.

A snap of twigs drew Mr De Gray's attention. A pull on the reins and Swiftwind turned with a whinny, to face a startled figure emerging from one of the bridleway paths. Brunette hair spilled out from a hastily bound bonnet and a familiar pair of mismatched eyes stared up at Mr De Gray. The expression on Catra's face was tense, almost hostile.

Bugger was the word that immediately sprang to mind. Also, words pertaining to the curve of the woman's lips, the tilt of her brow, the way she held her shoulders…

"Did you knock your head sir, considering how high your elephant raises you?" and of course, her acerbic attitude was a pleasure to be balmed with. Mr De Gray smirked leisurely back at her. Banter, crude though it was, was a safer recourse.

"Swiftwind would object to so mismatched a comparison. I was merely shocked that a woman of aspiring means would drag herself through a hedgerow."

"Some of us are unafraid to get our hands and feet a little muddy."

"Some of us would say that foolish when a perfectly serviceable horse is available."

"Please, sir, one does not wish to hear of you servicing horses at this time of day."

"Which time of day would you consider appropriate for such a topic? I am friends with several notable stable owners, should you

care for a boringly long lecture to be arranged at a time of your choosing?”

Catra stared up and a smile actually crept across her features for a moment. It dulled and the frown returned, but it seemed more confused than angry. Mr De Gray huffed, then swung off the horse to land easily on the soil. Reins in hand, the gentleman approached Catra, but paused a respectful distance away.

“My apologies. The first time we conversed, I did so from an assumed position of authority and intimidation. That was… mostly for my benefit. I am better with a distance between my conversation partners.”

“Hardly, your engagement of us at dinner seemed well practiced,” Again that shrewd assessment with a narrowing of those vibrant eyes.

“That is only because I… was among friends. And, well… I do hope we are at least pleasant acquaintances now, Ms Moon?” Mr De Gray swallowed, then held up a hand, “Though I am sure you are able to pick and choose your desired acquaintances… I would be honoured to be counted among them.”

Catra regarded the gentleman, her face now almost stricken, “What manner of fellow are you? Such contradictions and queer concerns. Ice a moment, then a summers breeze, then steel. You are a strange one sir.”

Mr De Gray chuckled, “Fellow, eh? True, I am an… odd duck? Yes, I suppose that’d fit.”

“And yet friends with Mr Archer,” the words seemed strained, odd, “Your characters seem so at odds.”

“I am perhaps a balance for him. And he I. We offset each others flaws, allow us to be better.”

“You know the man well then?”

“As well as any, I suppose. Better than most. But can you really know a man, truly? We all have our secrets, our parts of ourselves we save for someone special,” Mr De Gray smiled, knowing that Catra clearly wanted reassurance that Glimmer was the soon to be North-star in Beauregard’s sky. Yet her expression seemed, if possible, more troubled.

“Indeed. How can one truly know someone after mere moments…” her voice was still strained, thick and thoughtful.

“You seem troubled, Ms Moon. Is there… would you walk with me? Would it help ease your concerns?” the troubled expression touched Adam in a way not expected. A sudden, intense desire to wipe away the frown, to caress that cheek and promise that *all would be well* suffused Adam’s being.

Catra moved and tilted her head, then nodded slowly, “A walk would be good. Though I regret I may be a poor conversationalist.”

“As long as we do not discuss horse servicing, I feel any topic worthy with you as its orator.”

The woman flushed and swallowed, her face now screwed up in a confused expression, “Sir, you are too familiar.”

“Hardly. We are acquaintances. We have shared wine. And I will not patronise you with topics pertaining to weaving, washing or wist.”

“Ah, the gentleman feels himself a poet!”

“A term of penmanship that left its scars upon me. Do not ask for a sonnet, pray. I will mangle it.”

They walked, Swiftwind plodding beside Adam on one side, Catra the other. They discussed all manner of topics - the wars, the nature of the village, the livelihood of the city. Ahead, the grand grounds of Thaymor manor loomed and Catra paused. A frown on her face once more, she turned to Mr De Gray.

“You are perhaps the last person I should ask this of, but… you appear an honest gentleman. Your brusqueness and lack of decorum indicate a forthright attitude.”

“And your honest appreciation in pointing that out states likewise,” Adam returned. Catra spread her hands in acceptance, then pressed on.

“I am faced with a choice. Neither particularly pleasant.”

“Are you at liberty to divulge this?”

She regarded the gentleman and sighed, “I cannot elaborate on the detail, for it is a private matter. Part of it. However, I am likely to be forced to choose between allowing someone to make a mistake in the name of happiness… or to harm them in the pursuit of longer term joy… and if I choose the latter, I may have to agree to other further arrangements to ensure some security."

Mr De Gray frowned and swallowed, “So, a choice? Between a rock and hard place, it sounds like.”

Catra nodded quickly, “It is a matter of honour and avoiding a scandal on behalf of someone I am very fond. And the decision there would likely impact my second choice…. To be married or not.”

The words made Mr De Gray tighten the grip on Swiftwind’s reins, “Married you say? I thought….”

“A Reverend is calling. An… old friend. A distant cousin by marriage. She is… at least aligned in my orientation and not at all unpleasant. Albeit I have reservations,” her mismatched eyes turned to Mr De Gray, “So, what options do I have?”

The gentleman met those gorgeous, glinting gems and swallowed. Adam… *Adora* … felt her heart tearing once more, “You choose the *right* thing. The thing that helps the most. That is… what I have endeavoured to do.”

“And what of what makes me happy?” huffed Catra.

“Do you know which choice does that?”

“Neither!”

Mr De Gray swallowed, “Then… perhaps… there are other avenues to consider. Must you choose now?”

Catra smoothed her skirts, “No… no, I have time.”

“Then do not rush rashly. Consider and plan. You are a shrewd woman of means; a formidable mind. Do not… do not make a choice that you will regret, that will trap you into a life not of your choice, if you have a chance to avoid it.”

“You speak as if you understand the notion well,” Catra’s voice was soft and curious. Mr De Gray gave a short nod, but did not meet her gaze.

“Quite so. I did not choose this life.”

“A life of leisure and wealth?” snorted Catra and *Adora* flinched at the derision there. Mr De Gray shrugged.

“A landlord. A master of the house. Duty and responsibility are not things one can take off like a shift at the end of the day.”

Catra laughed and shook her head, “Says the gentleman out riding and likely going shooting later. Life comes easy to the male, we know this.”

Mr De Gray looked up at the trees above, then at Catra. The woman stilled, surprised at the intensity of the expression on the gentleman’s face. An expression that smoothed into a colder tranquility momentarily, before it returned to an easy smile. One that did not reach the gentleman’s pained, blue eyes.

“True. It is easier, you are right. What would I know of chains and the like? I am, I know… privileged.”

The gentleman turned and patted Swiftwind on the flank. Catra coughed and glanced about, "I fear I have offended you, sir?"

"Oh… fear not, Ms Moon. I am… used to the commentary. I am privileged. I cannot shirk that, nor would I wish to. It affords me opportunity," Adam turned and offered a shrug, "I do hope you are not vexed overmuch by this choice of yours. Should you find yourself in need of a retreat, I am sure Mr Archer would not hesitate to offer you sanctuary."

"A kind offer, sir… but I am more than capable of making this choice without charity."

Mr De Gray sighed, "Quite so, Ms Moon. Of course, should you call I would be most honoured by your visit. But I do hope you do not feel that *charity* ?"

Catra folded her arms and looked everywhere but at the gentleman, "No. Your conversation is passable."

That drew a laugh from the gentleman, "High praise. Well, I must bid you good day, Ms Moon. Thank you for a most entertaining walk and for gracing me with your company."

With a single swift motion, Mr De Gray mounted the white charger and touched the brim of the top hat atop blonde locks. Catra gave a small curtsey, "Good day to you sir. And… thank you. I have much to ponder."

Adam nodded, then turned Swiftwind and cantered away towards Thaymor manor. For Mr De Gray's part, the thoughts were a mess of disappointment and sadness - disappointment in Catra's easy dismissal of the achievements *Adam … Adora* had made. Sadness because that emotion stemmed from her lack of understanding of the nature of those achievements. But knowledge that to let her into that locked part of *Adora's* life would be a step too far, perhaps.

And the conversation on the *nature* of Catra's choices niggled and grew, like a seed, a weed within Mr De Gray's mind. What could

such a choice entail to worry such a stalwart and determined creature as Ms Catra Moon?

Perhaps the ball would reveal the trouble.

Of course, Mr De Gray was not the only one pondering.

Catra's own steps were slow and steady as she made for home, turning over Mr De Gray's comments in her head; as well as the look of pain on that handsome face at her teasing of his *struggles* . Truly she did not know his past, save the possibility of a sister. This *Adora* that had been mentioned?

But Mr De Gray had said to do the *right* thing. The upstanding, moral thing. And what was that?

Another thought skated by, almost unnoticed, but it made Catra's brow furrow ever so briefly in mild confusion.

A shift? Womans-wear…

A thought, just out of reach, nagged but she pushed it away as her other ideas scrambled for notice. She needed to do the right thing. Pain was immaterial if it prevented immorality and agony for one she loved. And Mr De Gray had, after all, also said that to choose to be unhappy would be a losing game.

She rolled her shoulders, mind made up.

The ball. It would have to be at the ball. To firmly push matters into place.

For her sister. And for her own peace of mind.

Chapter End Notes

Ok, the ball was supposed to happen here, but this expanded and, well, gotta set up that DRAMA.

I promise, some HORDAK next chapter. As well as ULTIMATUMS!

As ever, feedback is appreciated - did this work for you? I'm trying to keep Scorpia SWEET but also point out that... she loves Catra, but doesn't KNOW Catra. Save on wanting to LOOK AFTER HER. Did that come across?

And Adam / Adora... finding it a lot harder to keep things separate right now with Duty versus Cute girl.

A dance: Part I

Chapter Summary

The Moons (And Reverend) attend a ball

Catra plays matchmaker.

A certain Captain drops a bombshell.

Chapter Notes

This is a two-part chapter for the ball!

Expect Glimbow drah-mah in Part II

I reckon I may need to up this to... 17 chapters. We shall SEE.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra, dear, your gloves?" Angella's tone was calm, but held a hint of apprehension. Usually it would be Micah fetting, but the woman seemed a little more agitated with the Reverend's endless effervescence permeating the household. The woman was tenacious and seemed outright oblivious to any form of external critique, guidance or attempt at moderation.

It would have been an admirable trait if it did not border on obsessive.

Catra had ended up returning to the drawing room after her promenade with Mr De Gray. She had sat with the Reverend and found herself the object of the tall woman's terrifyingly enthusiastic focus. And she had explained to Scorpia that, at this juncture, marriage was not her objective. That she would be

unable to commit, to be the best self she could be. That her temperament, due to external factors would be unable to truly grant Scorpia the measure of affection she deserved.

And the Reverend had responded, with “So, not quite a no then?”

And once more, Catra had reiterated her reluctance. The Reverend had wrung her hands and responded with, “So, more a *not yet* ?”

This had caused Catra to twitch in a most unladylike fashion and she had managed to grind out a reply of, “I intend to marry for love, Reverend. And whilst I am *fond* of you, my heart does not lean that way. And I feel you deserve that. So, please do not twist and twitch my words. Understand I have no desire to, nor the wherewithal to marry you.”

Scorpia had appeared confused, mildly crestfallen, but had rallied and stood. She had taken Catra’s hand and kissed it, then smiled, “Well, I hope we can remain cordial and friends. I will not take this rejection to heart. May we still dance at the ball later?”

And then after that things had actually settled into a more acceptable air/ Of course, it actually meant that the Reverend shared her intense enthusiasm and the remainder of the family, previously spared, were now subjected to her terrifying keenness.

Mermista had hidden in her room, whilst Glimmer had decided to remain in town with Frosta. Entrapta, on the other hand, proved a fantastic occupier of the Reverend's time - her own enthusiasm and propensity for indulging and explaining found a welcome audience with the Reverend who, in turn, pressed Entrapta for further detail. Whilst not a romantic match, there was a definite kinship there. Oddly, Catra found them a soothing background noise whilst she read, even involving herself in their conversation.

Of course, all that had left everyone a little bit socially overwhelmed by the time the evening of the ball arrived, a scant two days after her walk. It had been illuminating and she had taken note of Mr De Gray's stance when she'd mentioned the possible nuptials. Honestly, it was another strange sense of melancholy that she almost regretted revealing that. As if, on some level, she had wanted the gentleman to say something.

Except that made no sense, as the core fact was that Mr De Gray *was* a gentleman! Key observance on the word man in the moniker.

She felt very out of sorts, all told. But to avoid the ball would be unwise - she needed to at least begin the work on Mr Archer, to set out her intent and her observation. A place in public, but with discretion.

Angella's words pulled Catra back to the here and now. She nodded to her mother, then darted to the stairs, intent on her room. A maid, however, descended and handed the red, elbow length gloves to her, "Have a pleasant eve'n ma'am," the maid nodded and curtseyed, demurely. She was a pretty little thing, although her eyes were brown, not blue. For a moment, Catra

pondered the actions of Mr Archer - he was not beholden to anyone - was there a sin there? Were his actions indicative of future intent?

And yet she knew she would not take advantage of the help. There was a disparity there, a thing that felt *wrong* .

It was only as she clambered into the coach with her family that her mind flickered to the pondering of the colour of the maid's eyes.

Very strange.

The Lucas's own home was only slightly larger than the Moon's. Myst Corner was a deceptively large home, its size masked by the way it was built into a slope and with a large pond curving about one of its wings. Mrs Casta Lucas was an artist and had encouraged her husband to expand the home using the natural flow of the land. Her daughter was a little more focused on the integration of the natural world and the gardens were a thing of beauty, spoken of across the county - pergolas and gazebos constructed from trees and roses woven together; wild-flower mazes; beautiful, intricate flower arrangements that bedecked the whole home.

This of course meant that the ball was also part garden-party. A small series of marquees had been set up outside to provide

warmth and light for any who desired air from the ball-room, which opened up onto a stone patio.

The Moon's, plus the Reverend, descended the carriage steps, then moved towards the entryway where they were greeted by a butler. Immediately Glimmer fanned herself and squeaked, "Mr Archer he... He is by the window…"

Catra flinched but managed to school her runaway emotions. She glanced across the hall and spotted Mr Archer, through the open double doors into the ballroom. Mr Archer was indeed visible - but only just - by the entrance to the patio. And it appeared that Perfuma was holding his attention.

This led to somewhat of a dilemma - was Catra to allow the potential courting of the cad by her friend? Surely that would doom another dear to her? But it would spare Glimmer and, in the balance, family came first, surely.

"Who… is that?" murmured the Reverend, at Catra's other arm. The brunette blinked at the quiet, almost reverent term. She filed the comparison away, mildly amused at her own internal humour, but turned to regard the tall blonde.

"Who is… who?"

Scorpia flushed, suddenly intensely aware of whom she was talking to, "Oh, who? I meant… who is… Mr Archer? I was asking

Glimmer! Yes, yes I was indeed!”

Another possibility presented itself in Catra’s mind, a way to perhaps save her friend as well. She smirked at the Reverend, “Well, I suppose you aren’t guilty of idle hands or the sin of apathy, Scorpia. Never let it be said you waste a moment.”

The Reverend flushed slightly then tilted her chin, “Perhaps. So, shall… we go find some… sustenance and, *mingle* ,” of course, Scorpia pronounced it ‘Min-gelay’. Behind them, Mermista snorted and Frosta groaned. With a sigh, Angella led them into the fray.

This was merely the pre-drinks - there would be a dinner, or at least a rotating table for people to drift in from the dancing to sit and be served. Catra scanned the attendees and found it to be the usual crowd of local well-to-do’s. She nodded at Spinnerella and Netossa, who were in quiet conversation with Casta herself. It appeared that the tennant, Ms Juliette, was also in attendance. And on Mrs Lucas’ arm no less! The woman looked self conscious, but proud. And, for her part, Catra noted that Casta Lucas appeared to have a firm, reassuring grip on the woman’s arm, with their hands grasped together. She smiled, as a strange sense of envy swept across her form. It left her skin flushed and her thoughts uncomfortable.

Catra would not begrudge that which others had found. Especially as she *had* had the opportunity. Even if said opportunity felt very *incorrect* for a whole encyclopedia's worth of reasons. As she walked, she engaged in polite conversation with several others from the area, moving carefully around the more idle gossip mongers and to a few of the more personable sorts.

She saw Mr Lashor, his once-muscular frame now portly; his skin flushed near pink with port, making conversation with a gaunt gentleman across the room, bedecked in some uniform of one of the Regiments. The taller man was striking - firm, austere, not unlike Mr De Gray. Except *this* gentleman appeared to have a following of gasping young ladies lurking nearby, hiding their faces behind their fans. She pondered at that - the man appeared aloof, certainly. But was that an attractive trait? Some seemed to think so of Mr De Gray, but that man was reserved. She had assumed arrogance but saw now a certain hesitancy. This gentleman looked like he should own the room. Or at least felt it thus.

She turned and found Mermista at her elbow, "Who is the gentleman there?" inquired Catra. Her sister gave her a sideways glance.

"Really? First Mr De Gray, then a proposition from the dear Reverend and now you're back on *our* side of the garden fence?"

Catra slapped her wrist and grimaced, "Hardly. But I have not seen him here before."

"Pay attention, Cat. There's a few Officers here."

"So, a uniform and everyone fawns?"

Mermista shrugged, “It helps. Maybe masks their other unpleasant traits. But good tailoring goes a long way. And, you know, reserved and *mysterious* - always a good draw. Too obvious and a woman might see right through you!” The woman snorted, “I hear a few of the younger gentlemen are trying to appear more cultured than they are, to appear charming. And what better way to mask shortcomings than by saying nothing at all?”

“What, indeed,” smirked Catra. They trailed the outside of the room and Catra noted that Glimmer was now at Mr Archer’s side, with Micah and Angella nearby. That would make things much trickier.

“I see your secret admirer.”

Catra froze and glared at Mermista. The taller girl grinned and gently turned Catra to face into the room. Near the ornate mantelpiece Catra spotted Mr De Gray. The gentleman had on a glorious red coat and white dress-shirt. A grey waistcoat and matching britches made the man look *almost* regimental, save the lack of any brocade and rank buttons. And yet it fitted Mr De Gray better than the tailored getup of many of the officers present.

She frowned, however as she noted Mr De Gray’s expression. There was a scowl there. Catra followed the gentleman’s gaze and realised it was directed towards the gaunt fellow.

Most curious. Mermista watched as well and glanced at her sister, “Well, there’s something. The normally collected Mr De Gray all

hot under the collar… and not for you, for once!" she nudged Catra who merely hummed in reply.

There was something there and she decided it worth exploring. Mr De Gray and Mr Archer were, perhaps, not as clean as they claimed - so one for whom they held open animosity was perhaps a good avenue for information or, at the very least, insight.

Their traipsing brought them to where Scorpia stood. She had a glass in one hand and a sizeable collection of empty glasses arrayed on the table next to her and had, apparently, managed to find Casta and Juliette. Catra stared at the glassware, then up at the flushed Reverend, who was celery holding court, whilst Casta stared with glassy eyes at the woman.

"And of course, your garden is most amazing. Lady Shadow d'Weaver, of course, keeps a garden of several hectares, but it's mostly dense roses and rhododendrons! And a full hedge maze, she had that commissioned. Do you have many rooms? Lady Shadow d'Weaver, she says that the expanse of a property shows the depth of authority in a region. I'm not quite sure what that means, but she is *very* well to do. Oh and your sconces for the torches are most lovely! I have one of the candelabra's from the main house in my dining room, a gift you know, from Lady Shadow…"

"Fascinating," managed Casta, weakly. Juliette had Casta's hand in a white knuckle grip and appeared on the verge of laughter, her eyes bright and wide. Spinnerella and Netossa shared a look of surprised and entranced horror as Scorpia continued.

"And of course if you are ever in the region, I would be most pleased to host. We have *two* guest bedrooms! Modest, perhaps, but very well to do for a rectory! Recently renovated by Lady Shadow d'Weaver… not… quite to my tastes, but still! Very generous!"

Spinnerella managed to interject, "You have… lived there long?"

"Oh, well, only a few years now. It is a bit strange being far from home, but my mothers always said I needed to stretch my wings, you know? Find someone to watch for me as I went out into the world. And, well, I was most lucky to find such a gracious patron who says she… overlooks things."

Catra noticed a faintly pained expression cross the Reverend's face, but it was gone a moment later. Spinnerella pressed, gently, "Mothers? Oh, um, sorry, most rude."

"Oh, no not at all! My mothers are overseas currently. Ophelia is a seamstress, from a mercantile line. Not viewed as… fondly here, I know. And Imogen is, well, she *is* from a good line, but um… the pairing was…" Scorpia coughed and smiled, "They are so happy though. I think they find it strange I'm under the patronage of Lady Shadow d'Weaver, but honestly, I am most grateful for her generosity."

This was certainly all new to Catra and she shared a confused glance with Mermista. Trust Spinnerella to tease out the truth. Or part of it. She smiled at the tall woman, "Scorpia, perhaps some food will be agreeable? I am sure Casta needs to greet her other guests. Are you well?"

Scorpia blinked and stared at her, whilst behind her, Netossa grinned broadly. Casta shot Catra a grateful nod and tugged Juliette away, the woman still desperately trying to conceal her giggles. The Reverend coughed, glanced at her collection of empty glasses and blushed

"ME? Oh, never better! Just, you know, well… been a while since I've been to an event like this. Lady Shadow d'Weaver doesn't really do large functions. More personable, smaller. Intimate? Makes you feel *seen* . And, well, it's all so much and our hostesses are so kind and lovely and Perfuma looks so amazing…" Scorpia's mouth appeared to shut with the speed of a bear trap.

Mermista blinked and shook her head, then glanced to her sibling, "You are seeing this, right?"

"Indeed I am. Come Reverend?"

The brunette glanced about, trying to spy Perfuma. She appeared to have moved away and Catra grunted in frustration. That would have to wait. Instead, she and Mermista guided the Reverend from the ballroom towards the dining area, across the hall. The room was fairly full and Catra froze for a moment as she saw Mr De Gray, seated at one of the tables. The gentleman appeared to be making polite conversation with a young woman. Long blonde hair, clothes fair too tight on the body and, frankly, what sort of woman laughed so hard at not even a *joke* .

“Catra… are you ok?” Mermista’s voice jolted the brunette from her focus and she glanced sharply at her sister. The taller girl smiled faintly and nodded towards Mr De Gray, “Jealous?”

The word landed like the kick from a horse. Catra actually gasped, “What? Why? NO!”

The laugh that Mermista barked out drew some attention from the room, but not overmuch - many were used to the antics of the Moon sisters. The blonde next to Mr De Gray turned and Catra was struck by the strange blandness of the woman’s features. Androgynous in the extreme. The blonde met her gaze, then *smirked* . Catra felt her blood boil for some strange, alien reason. Her jaw flexed as the strange blonde turned back to Mr De Gray and Catra fixed her gaze back to the blue eyed fop.

The man appeared indifferent, however. She could see that the gentleman’s jaw, sharp and firm, was clenched. And then he rose and Catra exhaled with some strange sense of *relief* . She watched the gentleman give an almost impertinent, barely there, bow to the blonde at the table, then turn.

Right into Scorpia. Who had somehow moved forward without either sister knowing. Mermista groaned with dread, “Oh no, she’s going to talk to him…”

Catra felt frozen, “She hasn’t been *introduced!”*

Etiquette was everything; a guest had to be presented by a mutual acquaintance; to simply accost another, beyond one's host, for conversation was most impolite and reeked of assumption and, to some, of *social climbing* .

"Mr De Gray, a pleasure sir, a real pleasure!" around the pair, the room slowly fell to silence. Mr De Gray stared at Scorpia as she loomed above him. The Reverend clutched her hands together and grinned, "Sir, we share a common acquaintance, although I overstep my assumptions slightly. I am the Reverend on the estate of Lady Shadow d'Weaver…"

Catra was shocked once again at the sudden tightness of Mr De Gray's expression. The man's throat seemed to constrict and she saw hands flex into fists, then back again. But the gentleman merely stared back at Scorpia. The Reverend seemed surprised at the lack of response.

"You… you are of course acquainted with her ladyship? I understand she was something of a family friend. She was in the best of health… twelve days ago."

Mr De Gray arched an eyebrow, "Indeed. That is your understanding?"

The gentleman's voice was calm, but had an edge to it. Scorpia, of course, seemed completely unaware and ploughed on, "Of course! Such a generous woman, considering my own… well, obviously my background was not to her normal acceptance, but

she was most kind in offering me her parish as my first installment."

Mr De Gray stared at her for a moment longer and even Scorpia seemed to realise that there was something amiss. Then the gentleman spoke again, "And what is your name, Madam?"

"It… I am Scorpia Collins, sir."

Mr De Gray nodded and then smiled sadly at the Reverend. With a nod, he stepped away from her and walked away, headed for one of the other doors. Scorpia blinked in surprise and bit her lip, then turned to give Catra a confused stare.

"I see *Mister* De Gray has lost none of their charm," came a clipped voice from next to Catra. She arched an eyebrow and looked to her right to find the gaunt man stood next to her.

"A slew of assumptions there, sir," she responded, cautiously.

"Indeed?"

"First, to assume I am aware of any such charms the gentleman could possess. And for you to assume charm on the man's behalf. And then to assume I am interested?"

A slow grin crawled over that pale face, a strange expression. It appeared alien and yet also intriguing. The man looked at her, then bowed, “My apologies, madam. I have also been impertinent in engaging you in conversation without properly introducing myself. Please forgive me. Captain Hordak of the First Infantry.”

Catra pursed her lips and sighed, “Ms Catra Moon. And my sister, Mermista.”

Hordak bowed again to Mermista, “A pleasure. I apologise for intruding ladies. I will trouble you no further.”

And with that he withdrew - no proposition, no attempt at smarmy small talk. Catra found it oddly refreshing. Mermista, however, frowned, “Who was he? Seemed… intense.”

“What, his air of mystery not appealing?”

“Just… not even an attempt to really engage us?” Mermista shrugged, “Eh, not the uniform I’m paying attention to anyway…” Catra followed her sister’s gaze and snorted as she spotted another officer who appeared to be eyeing the pianoforte with no small amount of relish. She nudged Mermista.

“Go, regale us with a song, before *he* does.”

Mermista gave a half-hearted groan, but practically skipped across the room towards the instrument. Catra smiled at Scorpia as the Reverend slumped down into a chair next to the brunette, "Wow, well, that man was *rude* ."

"I think you'll find, dear Reverend, that you hardly observed the social niceties yourself…"

"I mean, all I did was say hello…"

"And would you do that to Lady d'Weaver?"

"Well… I… I suppose not," mused the Reverend. Catra sighed then smiled as she spotted a familiar face.

"Scorpia, have you had the pleasure of Ms Perfuma Lucas' company as yet?"

The Reverend looked up, shocked, as the willowy blonde approached/ For her part, Perfuma seemed to have her gaze firmly trained on the Reverend. Catra stood and gave her friend a small hug. Perfuma arched an eyebrow, then looked at Scorpia, "Catra?"

"Perfuma, this is my good *friend* , Scorpia Collins. Reverend Scorpia Collins. She has a Rectory in the north, no small amount of land and apparently her patron has some wonderful gardens…"

Perfuma gave Catra another sideways look, “Indeed?”

“Also, she is for want of a wife.”

“ *Indeed* ,” smiled Perfuma, “And I had heard that Ms Collins had come to call on *you* ?”

Scorpia looked wild eyed as she looked between the two women, her face flushed. Catra rolled her eyes and patted Perfuma’s arm, then looked at Scorpia, “Excuse us for a mere moment, Reverend,” she led Perfuma a little way towards the door and leaned closer, “Scorpia has done so. But I feel that, perhaps… she could do with someone more patient than I?”

The blonde cocked her head and leaned in, “And what makes you think…”

“Dearest Perfuma, I may not wish to marry the poor woman, but I have eyes. She is a fine specimen, is kind, sweet and supportive. She is not, however, right for me. She *is* , I would argue, entirely the sort of freedom you crave. You crave to be away from here, with a woman you could learn to care about. She has not been able to tear her eyes from you all evening, even when talking to your *mother* . She spotted you as soon as we entered. As you fumbled with Mr Archer, no less.”

Perfuma sighed, "I am doing no *fumbling* with that man. He is besotted with your sister, as you know."

Catra pursed her lips and that drew Perfuma into curious frown. Catra just shook her head, "I am unsure. I feel there is more to Mr Archer than we realise."

"What has brought on such… cynicism, Catra? Has the Reverend soured you to romance so much you suspect it corrupted everywhere?"

That made Catra wince, "Hardly - she is sweet, kind and frankly, sickeningly determined. But I do not and can't envision love with her. Even love built over years of cohabitation."

Perfuma giggled, "So I am to have your cast offs?"

"Really, dear friend? How about you talk to her, make your own decision. She is monied, has prospects *and* has two mothers. She just requires… patience, I think. And if anyone is patient, it is you."

The blonde sighed, but she had a smile on her face. And, in truth, Catra had noticed that the freckled girl hadn't been able to stop the furtive glances over Catra's shoulder at the well-built Reverend. With a gentle pat, the brunette sent Perfuma across to where Scorpia sat, the statuesque Reverend looking akin to a deer caught in the sight of a hunter's blunderbuss.

Catra almost felt bad setting Perfuma on the woman. But, to be honest, they were quite the match. She glanced over to where Mermista was now playing, her voice rich and surprisingly deep. Next to her, the officer was providing a surprisingly high pitched accompaniment. Coupled with his rather ridiculous moustache, they were quite the picture.

With a huff, Catra turned and left the dining hall. Her feet took her back to the ballroom and she espied Mr Archer for the briefest moment, heading to the patio, Glimmer in tow. She chewed her lip, then spotted the Strange Captain Hordak, back over by the canape table. The man had a strangely focused expression on his face and, as Catra approached, she noticed that Entrapta was engaging him in conversation. No, that wasn't right; Entrapta was clearly lecturing the man.

"Entrapta dear, have you imprisoned this gentleman in a snare of your contraptions and fancies?"

"Oh! Hi Catra! I was just explaining to…" Entrapta turned her face to Hordak and chewed her lip in thought, "this man…"

"Captain Hordak," prompted Catra with a smirk.

"Yes. This man. I was explaining my notes. I've been taking *notes* , Catra. Social dynamics, who knows who, who does what. It's *fascinating* . Did you know Mr Lashor and Mr Grizzlor are, actually, indulging in…"

“I think that is *not* the right sort of conversation for polite company, dear sister. Now… isn’t there a fountain you can go deconstruct and improve in the garden?”

“IS THERE?” with a giggle, Entrapta pranced away, her purple dress flapping as she ran, braided pigtails bouncing. Captain Hordak watched her go with a slightly dazed expression.

“I am sorry. She is a dear, but I know she can be overwhelming,” Catra cringed at her apology. She felt bad explaining her sister’s attitude. Hordak turned to her, his expression one of frustration and irritation. But only for a moment, before he masked it with a smile.

“Honestly it was… illuminating. A vibrant mind should not be wasted. Potential hidden is a sin, I find.”

Catra tilted her head and shrugged, “If one can pursue that potential.”

The Captain tapped his thigh and nodded, “Quite. Limitations do abound. But all it takes is the will to push beyond them. All else is noise and excuses.”

“A bold statement, for a man.”

Hordak chuckled dryly, “Indeed. But, I must say, I am not a man of independent means; we must all strive against our own limitations. I do not doubt that those that afflict you are equally as challenging.”

“I am afflicted?” queried Catra, an eyebrow arched.

“You are a woman, so you must be. Society batters you, has you hemmed in. Or at least it used to. The seasons change.”

“Oh, I am to be lectured on this, am I?” Catra started. Hordak shot her an amused look.

“You approached me, madam. And I would not presume to lecture. I assume you came here for a reason, not just to alleviate me of the company of your sibling?”

Catra gave the man an appraising look, “Shrewd, sir. Honestly, I had come with a rather abrupt query. You seem a man, perhaps, more aware of my frustrations than others.”

“I do doubt they are true frustrations, considering the sheer number of women with partners of the same inclinations. Perhaps you see it as a problem when in actuality it is merely the *quality* of your options.”

“Presumptuous, sir.”

“You did ask, Ms Moon. Or rather, you left the option open. Please, ask.”

He was brusque, not dissimilar to Mr De Gray. But those eyes, faintly bloodshot and with hints of green in the iris, held no true warmth. They weren’t what she wanted to see, deep in herself.

“Mr Archer, are you well acquainted with him?”

“I cannot say that I am. I understand he is an acquaintance of… Mister… De Gray.”

“Please excuse my own presumption, but you appear to hold the gentleman in low regard.”

“Are you so close? You seek to defend the *man* ?”

His tone held a note of derision, some aching animosity that piqued her curiosity, so she pressed further, “I know him. He is a man of contradictions and aloofness.”

“He is a man who does not hold to his arrangements. I am… well acquainted with *Mister* De Gray,” red-green eyes met hers, “I was, after all, betrothed to his sister.”

Chapter End Notes

HOO BOY I DO LOVE THROWING THEM CURVEBALLS ATCHA.

Well, have to get the Wickham stuff in there, don't I?

As ever... feedback feeds my soul. Let me know your thoughts ;)

A dance: Part II

Chapter Summary

An insight into the past of a Mr De Gray

A dance occurs

A decision as to confrontation is made

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had never been one for gossip - not the spread of it, nor the malicious cultivation of information with the intent to weaponise it. That wasn't to say she was averse to idle teasing - she preferred to deliver such commentary direct to the individual. Verbal sparring was, after all, one area where she could engage and flex without real repercussion. Outwitting some boorish man with her rapier delivery of a jibe had made her a young lady to be feared by the drooling oafs of the county.

And, yes, she was happy to engage in the idle tittering that came from observing buffoons at parties and their drunken japery.

But to hear such a scandalous accusation in the centre of a ballroom, with who knew how many idle ears listening in - it was unheard of.

And yet she felt compelled to know more. Her eyebrows rose and she blinked, "Sir, we are barely acquainted and yet you divulge

such… personal things. That… that impugned the gentleman's honour!"

"I can say with the utmost certainty that *Mister* De Gray is no gentleman," Captain Hordak huffed and rolled his shoulders, then looked across the dance floor, "And I only say this because I am aware you are a… young lady in want of a good match. I am, perhaps speaking out of turn and for that I…. apologise. My grievances with Mister De Gray should not concern you."

There was the ghost of a smile there. Catra frowned up at the man, her intrigue overcoming her shock, "And was that how he wounded you? The denial of a betrothal? Was the woman *willing* ?" An arranged marriage felt an anathema to her - the ultimate removal of choice, with the requirements it entailed. Her voice echoed this sentiment, taking a slightly stony edge.

Hordak plucked a pair of glasses from a passing tray and offered one to Catra, his expression thoughtful, "Partly. My father, Primus Wickham, and Mister De Gray's father, Randor Gray, were business rivals. I was… unfortunately severed from my father's good graces and was taken in by the Gray's. If you can fathom it, Adam, Adora and myself… we were stalwart companions. My bitterness stems from that former close connection. Forgive me, madam. It is merely difficult to revisit such memories."

Catra's eyebrow arched and she nodded, "Indeed, Mr Wickham. Or is it… Captain?"

"Either suits, Ms Moon."

“So you know me?”

“I am aware of many of the county - it is always wise to understand the social waters in which one swims,” Hordak’s smile was again faint, “Also, your sister was most… generous with her sharing of information.”

Catra’s laugh was breathy and she shook her head, “My dear Entrapta is… precocious. I hope she was not a menace?”

Mr Wickham looked wistful for a moment and he shook his head, “No… no not at all. A charming young lady. So unconcerned with the vagaries of the little dance we do.”

“Quite so.”

“Are you dancing, this evening, Ms Moon?”

“If you are aware of me, you understand my position on dancing with men.”

“Quite so. But let me be clear - I have no designs upon you, in the first instance. In the second, I have experience with women who do not wish to share a future with the male of the species.”

That tidbit Catra filed away for later. Perhaps it was related to Mister De Gray and his family. There was some strangeness there, a scandal perhaps, that would explain the duplicitous nature of Mr Archer and Mister De Gray's relationship perhaps. Still, she could not quite envisage Mister De Gray as a vile person, but certainly as a rude one. Perhaps even stubborn or unobservant - that would explain his inability to perceive the flaws of Mr Archer! Catra smiled at the officer and waved a hand airilym, "Truly your command of language does you credit, sir," she drawled. Hordak shrugged, an expression of discomfort on his face.

"I do not believe I am comfortable with preamble or subtlety. Frankness is the only method. Forthright displays. It has led to many embarrassments, but I would rather be in that situation than compromised."

"A man of principle. Truly a rare thing!"

The words made the man twitch slightly, "Hardly. I am but a humble gentleman looking to make his way in the world. Direct conversation removes all sense of duplicity and reduces time wasting."

"You find conversation a waste of time?"

"I find pointless conversation a waste of time."

Catra grinned, “Well then sir, the military may be your true calling. Hardly a font of pointless conversations.”

“You have not been subjected to a Colonel’s soiree, then; nor the endless meetings and paperwork. Truly, the military prides itself on the ability to generate all number of pointless activities.”

“So why a commission - it is a costly enterprise, is it not?”

Hordak swirled his drink and took a sip, “It is something of an investment. Connections, meetings such as this. I am able to see beyond the trite platitudes and engage with individuals who may be of benefit.”

“Ah, so noble,” smirked Catra.

“Merely pragmatic,” shrugged Hordak, “Our society is a machine that one must move with in order to survive. I am not one who would do well in the poor house, Ms Moon. I am not afraid to admit this. As such, to ensure an income, given my lack of title or estates, I must find myself a profession and a means to support myself. The military offers me a salary, connections and a roof.”

The young lady regarded the frank gentleman with an appraising stare, “You were not incorrect with your assertion of your forthright nature.”

"To what end would it serve to dissemble? You now know me and my motivations and we are the better for it. I seek stability and a future. It is not so different from the trials you must face as well?"

Catra nodded slowly, "Presented and destined to secure something, lest we fall to spinsterhood."

"Indeed. Indeed. My… short lived engagement, I must say, was one of compromise. Adora would have wanted for nothing. It was not love, but it was *security* to allow us both our pursuits and the… well, the specifics matter not, for it was not to be."

The man looked distant once more, eyes flicking across the crowd. Catra sipped at her own drink, "You were fond of her then?"

"I was an elder sibling, to her and Adam. She was a wilful girl. No marriage would have satisfied her, nor her desire and forceful personality. A pairing between us would have solved much."

Another vague statement. Catra frowned and shrugged, "And the rift has never healed?"

"I find the manner of the refusal to be churlish and unnecessary. But… to elaborate further would be improper, as we have only just made one another's acquaintance, Ms Moon. And I would not have you think of me as some idle, bitter gossip."

“Just an idle, bitter officer?” smirked Catra.

“Quite so. As I said, frankness and accuracy,” he raised his glass and Catra actually laughed. She raised hers in return.

They conversed for a while longer, until another officer approached. The man was inebriated, so Captain Hordak was forced to take charge and chapperone the man away from the dance floor. Catra paused before Hordak left and bade him farewell, “Captain Hordak, it has been a pleasure. I may indeed partake in a spin on the floor, now knowing your motivations and your desire to avoid *pointless* activity. For what is the point of a dance with no objective?”

“The objective is to find satisfactory movement in line with the music. I have found this pleasing. At least on a mechanical level.” The Captain had smiled back and nodded at her.

“Sir, perhaps you and Entrapta have more in common than I believed. Thank you for the distraction.” Catra nodded, whilst Captain Hordak Wickham bowed, with a small smile on his face.

“I hope to meet you again, Ms Moon. You have proved an interesting divergence.”

“You flatter me, sir. Though I cannot ascertain why.”

They parted and Catra moved idly about the room. She spotted Mr Archer, separated from the rest of his party, idling near a table of canapes. Catra inhaled a fortifying breath and made to head towards the man, but found her way barred by a familiar, tall blonde.

"Ms Moon."

"Mister De Gray," it was the strangest sensation to meet that severe, tight gaze. Catra felt her cheeks flush faintly. In response to the unexpected sensation, she adopted a faint scowl, "Accosting young women again?"

"I had believed we were past that particular issue with our relationship?"

"A relationship, sir? *I* believe that is the second time you have overstepped the mark with your assumptions," her scowl shifted to a smirk. Mister De Gray, however, remained stoic.

"Perhaps so. But we do correspond," the gentleman glanced about the room, "I met your reverend. An irreverent sort."

That got Catra's dander up, "She is hardly *mine* …" after all, Scorpia was still a friend, one she had known longer than this

confusing mess of a man, “Not that it is your business.”

Mister De Gray’s expression did not change. Not even a flicker, “No. No it is not. I merely wished to see how you were… faring. Considering you were somewhat out of sorts when we last spoke I was concerned. I apologise for troubling you, Ms Moon. I wish you well in your forthcoming engagement.”

There was the briefest flicker of something there. Pain? Sorrow? Mister De Gray gave a short bow and turned to move away. Catra surged forwards and grabbed the gentleman’s wrist. A few people nearby stopped talking and one woman gasped. Mister De Gray froze, then turned slowly. Catra blinked and coughed, then slid her hand down from Mister De Gray’s wrist to the gentleman’s hand. She held it for a moment, then released it, “Um… wait, Mister De Gray. Are. You? Well. Can we dance?” it came out in a rush and part of her mind was a tizzy with confusion.

Mister De Gray looked at her and that stoic expression became faintly cracked as the gentleman’s mouth twitched into a rare smile. When they spoke, their voice was cracked but warm. And that warmth stirred a feeling in Catra she was both afraid of and fascinated by, “I would be honoured, Ms Moon.”

Catra nodded, then turned to step onto the dance floor as the string quartet began to ready for another piece. She glanced behind her and noted Mister De Gray regarding the hand that Catra had grasped, fingers flexing faintly and a strange expression of what could, perhaps, have been wonder of that stoic face.

Around them, the party seemed to slip away. Mister De Gray stepped up, lined up with the other gentlemen, Catra opposite with the women. A few of her compatriots shot her quizzical looks as they noted Mister De Gray move to join the company. Then a cheerful tune was struck by the quartet and the dancers came together.

Several steps forward, then to one side, then another. Each line in sync, mirroring their partner's motions. A spin, a slow spin, or a small rotation about one another. Then they moved down the line and passed to another partner in a small figure eight, before they came back to their original partner.

Catra felt eyes on her and saw Glimmer at the edge of the dance floor. Her sister had a look of glee on her face and was biting her lip. Angella stood not far off, a happy, if slightly curious expression on her face. Micah just looked perplexed. She saw Frosta easily, the girl with a grin that was almost obscene upon her countenance.

She turned her attention to Mister De Gray as they settled into another pairing. The gentleman stepped forward, "I would have assumed you would have saved your dance for your fiancee?"

"She is not my fiancee, sir. Again, you seem to assume much."

"Is it now a criminal enterprise to enquire after the well-being of one's friends?"

“Oh, we are friends now are we sir?”

“Dour and austere I may be, but a complete ninny I am not,” chuckled Mister De Gray, “What else are we if we have traded stories and quips?”

“Rivals?”

“In what, pray? I am your superior in social standing, wealth and…. Wit?”

Catra bridled but saw the faint smile was still in place on Mister De Gray’s face. A challenge, then, “As I believe we have already established, your wit leaves much to be desired. And you merely found me in a moment of weakness. I have made a decision based not on paltry economic factors but in accordance with my heart.”

“Then you deserve all due credit, Ms Moon,” Catra almost stumbled at the weight of sincerity in the gentleman’s words, “Ownership over one’s fate is no small thing and you should be proud of charting your own course.”

“Fine words for one who is socially and monetarily my superior and has not the concern over risking one’s future,” retorted Catra, but she did so with a slight levity to her voice, her intent being to perhaps draw something out of the reserved gentleman.

“Indeed so. And as I have explained, such things come with their own obligations. But still, rivals?”

“We are, after all, moving in the same limited pool for our prospective partners.”

That actually drew a snort from the gentleman, Mister De Gray’s face adopting a strange mixture of pain and amusement, “Indeed?”

Catra chuckled, “Truly, you cannot already have forgotten our first… no… *second* disastrous encounter.”

“It pains me to be reminded of my faux pas, but I was, I must reiterate, only intending to compliment a lady with no intent of receiving reciprocation of any sort.”

“You make a habit of propositioning eligible ladies without any hope of response?”

“Only the beautiful ones,” Mister De Gray retorted, face stoic but for a faint half smile on their pale features.

“Sir!”

“Are you not enjoying the distraction?” remarked Mister De Gray as they passed Catra again, arms linked at the elbow to spin briefly. Catra huffed then rolled her mismatched eyes.

“Hardly, I am having a *fabulous* time. As Entrapta might say… a blast.”

“A blast?”

“A sudden expulsion of energy.”

“I understand the term, Ms Moon. I just don’t quite understand the relevance to our current social endeavour.”

Catra stared at the blue-eyed buffoon and giggled. She checked herself at the noise as Mister De Gray suddenly grinned. Catra tried for a glare, “Do not say a word.”

“What, that you are capable of such endearing noises? I would advise you not let Beauregard hear you.. He might make insinuation that your acerbic exterior is an affectation and that you are, in fact… adorable.”

“I am no such thing!” Catra felt a momentary dip at the mention of Mr Archer, but the gleeful expression on Mister De Gray’s face was so unexpected and alien it threw her for a spin. Again.

“The lady doth protest overmuch,” returned Mister De Gray, “But I will maintain my silence.”

“You are infuriating.”

“Likewise, Ms Moon.”

“What is your intention here, sir?”

“As I said, the ongoing support between acquaintances. Is that so objectionable?”

“You are supportive of all your friends in such things?”

“I endeavour to be as much a loyal companion as I am capable.”

Catra regarded the gentleman, “Regardless of their moral failings?”

Mister De Gray smiled, “You have moral failings, Ms Moon? I sincerely doubt it. And if you did, be assured, I am a most discrete individual and would not besmirch your good name.”

The words sent a shiver of disappointment through Catra - it would appear that Mister De Gray was not unfamiliar with obscuring the conduct of his friends if he counted them as such. She was currently in that party; but that also confused her. If she was a friend, then why would Mister De Gray conceal something that would harm *her* or her family?

Or perhaps he merely maintained a distance so that he was not overtly aware of the shortcomings of his acquaintances? Also, his prior dealings with Captain Hordak implied a disinterest in fulfilling obligations. And yet this jarred heavily with the character of someone weighed down by burdensome pressures.

She managed to stutter a breath and put forth a faint smile, "My character is without reproach."

They did another turn and Mister De Gray frowned, "Your potential paramour is currently in rather intimate conversation with the Lucas daughter…"

"Ah yes. My own machinations."

Mister De Gray blinked, then raised an eyebrow as the pair drew close, then parted in another rapid dance step, "Truly you are a woman of shrew social grace and a ruthless approach. May I ask what drove your choice?"

"A simple strategic view of things."

“Oh?”

“Long term benefits. I could have been comfortable, secured. And that is the lot of many a woman,” they passed one another again and Catra swore she saw Mister De Gray twitch and swallow, “But that is a life half lived. A future of spinsterhood but with the freedom to pursue my own whims? I fancy that more.”

The cheery expression on Mister De Gray’s face clouded, but they nodded, “And as I have said before, an admirable aspiration. I hope you achieve it… and a… good partnership that you deserve.”

Catra chuckled, “Deserve is a long way off. I need to identify a suitable candidate. And these little affairs are hardly a prominent opportunity.”

The music drew to a close and Catra met those deep blue eyes once more. They held something within them, the way that Mister De Gray’s face had lines at the corner of the eyes, the crinkle of a happy frown between dark eyebrows. That damnable smile, the half smirk that hinted at self assurance coupled with a self conscious vulnerability. Mister De Gray bowed low, one foot forwards, “A pleasure, Ms Moon. Thank you, you have honoured me.”

Catra nodded and curtseyed back, “Indeed, sir. It was a distraction to be sure. And I will permit you to being an

acquaintance, provided you commit to honesty with me. Full frankness, as I believe you posited?”

Mister De Gray straightened and nodded, “Indeed so. You are deserving of such, having been equally as forthcoming and unreserved in your challenges.”

“Wonderful. Then as an acquaintance, would you be willing to enlighten me as to why a Captain Wickham holds you in such stern regard?”

Mister De Gray’s smile faltered a little, but they nodded. Catra wondered at the speed of such a change in demeanour. If anything there was an almost womanly blush on the gentleman’s features, “You have spoken with the gentleman?”

“Indeed, sir. He painted less a picture of loyalty than you claim.”

“Mr Wickham is eminently capable of engaging in friendships. He is less capable in keeping them,” harrumphed Mister De Gray, “For loyalty, one requires a reciprocal element to the endeavour.”

Catra nodded as they moved from the floor. She had half expected Mister De Gray to baulk and stride away, much in the manner with which they had dealt with Scorpia. And yet the gentleman stood firm. Clearly discomforted, yet engaging with Catra.

Not the act of a cad or a blaggard. There was that stoic bearing, but a determination there.

"I will concede that the gentleman did not divulge overmuch. Merely that there appears to be an element of resentment there."

Mister De Gray shrugged faintly, "Our relationship was a transactional one towards the end."

"And yet he implied great friendship."

Mister De Gray fixed Catra with a disconcertingly intense gaze, "And he was not lying. But for a friendship to survive it requires honesty in its dealings and a clear determination of expectations. Such things do not readily survive when exposed to unhealthy influences and poor treatment."

Catra nodded, "Indeed. I do not have the full facts, of course, but I enquire in the name of our own acquaintance - can I expect similar treatment?"

The look of genuine consternation that passed across Mister De Gray's features actually made Catra feel a sudden flush of guilt, "Madame, what can I have done to have elicited such expectation from you? I admit my own countenance and bearing can be... brusque, but I believed we had an accord. If you are still concerned I have nefarious intent, then please understand that nothing is furthest from my conviction and my soul."

No one had ever spoken with such raw honesty in their voice, not to Catra's recollection. Not even Scorpia, professing her deepest apparent love came close. It made Catra wish that someone feminine would speak words of such intensity of feeling to her. Those blue eyes ached with pain - but not pain of their own.

Mister De Gray appeared devastated that *Catra* could be in pain. The young lady felt stunned for a moment as she watched the gentleman search her eyes for answers. She swallowed, "Sir, fear not… nothing… I… I am merely concerned. It has been a week of strange activity with this… engagement and I am doubting the intent and actions of all."

Mister De Gray seemed to relax, then looked away, "Regardless, if I have in any way overstepped, please inform me. You were correct to state that your actions were not my business and that I overstepped. Such concerns are for your family, not some gentleman you know only in passing. I… I do hope we are able to continue as acquaintances. If I am honest, Ms Moon… your conversation is refreshing, in a room where so little is often said for the amount of words put to the air."

"It will entirely depend on the good conduct of our lives, I feel, Mister De Gray. As long as that continues, perhaps we can indeed continue as such," Catra smiled, but felt the knowledge that this companionable contact would likely cease once Mr Archer's nature was revealed. Mister De Gray was Mr Archer's close confidant; his best friend. And whilst Catra and Mister De Gray had amiable conversations and a strangely close affinity, it would likely not last such a rift. Even if she did feel that strange compulsion and safety to confess all her sins and her worries to this frustratingly dour and enigmatic buffoon.

SHe couldn't quite puzzle that one out. She had never been so close to a man, beyond her own father. To trust such a person based on a few minor social contacts and a thoroughly pleasant dinner? It felt bizarre.

"Ms Moon, you appear distracted?" Catra looked up as Mister De Gray frowned at her. She waved a hand.

"Merely dizzy for the dancing. I do not dance often."

"And yet you do it well," smiled Mister De Gray, "But I fear I am monopolising your time. I will not trouble you further. Thank you once more, Ms Moon. Have a pleasant evening."

As Mister De Gray was about to leave, they were stopped by the arrival of another. Mr Archer grinned widely at the pair, "Ms Moon! Other Ms Moon I mean… a pleasure! And quite the pair out there. Such a shame she is *entirely* not into you, eh, Adam?"

Mister De Gray's jaw clenched as they regarded Mr Archer. Catra frowned at the strangely challenging look on the man's face and she felt oddly offended on Mister De Gray's behalf - Mr Archer was clearly not a good friend if he mocked Mister De Gray's apparent attraction (Even if it was futile). And Yet Mister Archer didn't seem to be mocking. It was as if he was urging something, given the raised eyebrows and intense expression on his face.

But it passed and the gentleman sighed and patted Mister De Gray on the shoulder, "Apologies to you both. I am just… glad to

see that you are both getting along. Ms Moon, I wanted to apologise for not being a better host the other day and also being far too self assured with regard to my wellness. The scales balancing taught me that!”

“Learn to not over exert yourself, Beauregard,” chided Mister De Gray.

“You are a fine one to talk, sir. If you are not in your estates beating yourself to better your tenants, then you are on some other crusade. I was surprised that armageddon itself had not started when I espied you on the dance floor!” Mr Archer gave Catra a conspiratorial wink, “My thanks, Ms Moon - Adam needs all the help possible to alleviate the tension. You are, perhaps, the best influence on my friend for the longest time.”

“Mister De Gray is certainly much improved from our initial encounter. Perhaps being saddle sore accounts for such a surly attitude?”

That drew a smile from the blonde, who nodded, “And what was your excuse, madame?”

“The lack of intellectual stimulation from a dandy on horseback.”

“Well, I can hardly be held accountable for Beauregard’s failings,” chided Mister De Gray. Mr Archer gasped in mock outrage and grinned. Catra arched an eyebrow and nodded.

“Such a lack of loyalty! Throwing your friend beneath the carriage.”

“The least the man deserves for such raucous behaviour,” smirked Mister De Gray. Something caught the gentleman’s eye and a frown ghosted back across those pale features. Catra looked briefly over her shoulder and spotted the strange blonde from earlier across the dance floor. She thought she caught a glimpse of Captain Hordak but the crowd moved and she turned back to Mister De Gray.

“Now you appear distracted, sir,” she remarked.

“Unfortunately it appears business from home has reared its head. Please excuse me… and thank you again for the dance Catra… I mean, Ms Moon,” Mister De Gray flushed, bowed, then moved away. Mr Archer watched them go with a frown.

“I fear I am needed also. Apologies for intruding, Ms Moon.”

“Mr Archer! A moment, if you please?” Catra managed. Suddenly she felt her heart in her throat. Was she going to do this? Now? Amidst the social to-do of the county?

“Ms Moon?” Mr Archer’s eyes were all concern. He appeared adept at showing this feigned amiability. Or perhaps it was genuine and he just had a weakness for women?

As she looked at him, Catra knew that this was far too public a venue; the risk of a back and forth, or of being interrupted and things being overheard - far too much. Glimmer's reputation would be sullied not by Mr Archer's actions but by Catra's. She sighed.

"I was hoping to gain some of your time. Tomorrow perhaps? I have a small matter I wished to discuss with you. Without my sister, present."

The gentleman frowned, "...without a chaperone?"

"Do you fear your own advances so much that I might require one?" Catra challenged. Mr Archer grinned broadly.

"Considering I know that you favour people entirely my opposite *and* my intentions towards your sister… you are quite right that one should not be necessary. At any rate, my fathers will be in the house. Of course, please call on me at your convenience. I assume it is to do with your sister? Am I to get a sisterly warning?"

Catra fixed her gaze on him and allowed herself a mirthless smile, "Truly, the men of the world are so perceptive that our womanly ways are as transparent to you."

Mr Archer laughed and nodded, his face slightly worried, “Has anyone ever advised you that you are a rather intimidating young woman? If not, let me be the first to say it is both alarming and also reassuring,” his smiled returned, “But please, call one me at your convenience on the morrow.”

Catra curtseyed and Mr Archer bowed. She smiled again, “I will do so, sir. Have a pleasant evening.”

She watched the man vanish in pursuit of Mister De Gray. The blonde gentleman had seemingly vanished, along with the odd individual. That was another mystery in a chain of strangeness around the gentleman. She was on uneven terrain with the gentleman - her heart appeared stirred; her soul intensely frustrated and yet attracted to the strange gentleman. And yet her logical mind knew that the attraction must be purely platonic, albeit intensely so. She could not be falling for a *man.*

Couple that with the behaviour of Mr Archer and the odd relations to the gentleman’s past, it all felt far too much. Either way, her conversation on the morrow would put things to the sword in a rather final way - a severing of these interesting acquaintances.

The thought of it drew a sting that she had not expected. But like Mister De Gray had said, duty was often paramount.

She turned and smiled as she spied her sisters, clustered around a flustered and smiling Mermista. The moustachioed officer from earlier stood next to her, an endearingly besotted expression on his face. Catra chuckled: tomorrow would bring awkward

conversation and confrontation. But tonight she could tease her sister for choosing so idiotic a paramour.

One had to take pleasure in the little things.

Chapter End Notes

I had hoped for MORE DRAMA - but the pacing did not sit well and felt rushed if I tried to squeeze it into the ball.

SO you get a flirtatious dance, Catra being SO OBLIVIOUS IT HURTS and Adam being PAINED.

(Also Bow just TRYING to get Adam to admit something... but poor Catra thinks hes being MEAN)

As ever, let me know your thoughts, whether you liked it, whether it WORKS.

Ready, aim.... miss?

Chapter Summary

A breakfast consideration of things.

A Reverend prepares!

And Catra makes her points known.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The morrow following the ball was tense. At least it was so for Catra. All others in the Moon household were aflutter with excitement and gossip; even Mermista, stoic and taciturn as she was want to be, adopted an air that was more girlish. At the breakfast table silence fell as the most sardonic among them let out an involuntary *giggle* of all things.

Angella stared and then smiled, "Well, my stars. It would see that our little sojourn was indeed a worthy endeavour last night."

Mermista attempted to school her flushed features and flapped a napkin towards her mother, "Like, well, not exactly but… ugh."

"Dearest, try not to try so hard? You know this back and forth is all rather pointless. Tell us! What of the gentleman?" Mr Moon grinned broadly and leaned forwards, "And when is the engagement?"

Mermista practically shrieked and sunk in her chair, " FATHER! Like, no! No engagement. The man is a buffoon! He just was… y'know… really good at singing."

Frosta cocked her head, "Was I completely distracted, or was he doing *shanties* by the pianoforte?"

“Uh, maybe?” Mermista shrugged. Glimmer cackled.

“Oh he WAS! And… actually rather good ones.”

“Never tell him that. It will only encourage him,” groaned Mermista. Mr Moon smiled wider.

“So, we are to expect further visitations from the gentleman?” he prodded. This drew yet another pained sigh from Mermista, who blushed once more.

“I guess…”

“He’s in the army. Why was he singing *shanties* ?” grumbled Catra. She pushed an egg yolk around her plate listlessly. The burden of her forthcoming task weighed heavily in her breast. And *other* things appeared to be making their best effort to unsettle her.

Notably espying Mister De Gray near that strange blonde before the evening’s end.

Catra had managed a few other dances, mainly out of decorum; even one with Scorpia. And then Perfuma! She had shed her inhibitions and preconceived ideas about a dance *meaning* something. After all, she had danced with a man.

It didn’t mean she liked him, or such rot as that.

Mermista glowered at Catra, “He says it’s because, like, he’s a free spirit at heart and that the ocean *represents* that. It’s a metaphor for his soul, or some rubbish.”

“Your bearing indicates that you approve of said metaphor,” cooed Glimmer with a grin that was most improper, “But… if he’s a free spirit, why the *army* ?”

“Apparently it’s for, ugh… inheritance. But he has plans to buy a ship afterwards, has a plan for some transport company.”

"He wishes to go into… *business* ?" Mr Moon wrinkled his nose, then sighed and shrugged, "Well, I suppose having a trade allows for a certain level of guaranteed income beyond an estate, especially if he is from only a smaller family."

"And, like, apparently the army is a good outlet for his propensity for fire-starting," Mermista drawled, then clamped up with a sudden click of her jaw. Mr Moon's head swung back in alarm and he was about to speak when Mermista then most unceremoniously flung Catra, bodily, under the metaphorical carriage, "Anyway, like, my evening was *nothing* compared to Catra! Setting up an ENGAGEMENT and dancing with the most eligible bachelor in the room?"

That snagged everyone's attention, but Scorpia, who was also in attendance, was first to the line. It appeared that she swallowed an entire hunk of bacon in order to do so, as her words came out a little hoarse initially, "Mermy has a point! I mean, I thought you were a friend of Mara, Cat-of-the-wilds! No judgement, of course, people are supposed to find their own way in the world and working out what you love is all part of god's great plan! Was that why you said no to me? If I'd known, well, shoot, all very embarassing *but* if I hadn't then I suppose I wouldn't have had cause to attend that ball, which was *amazing* by the way. My patron, Lady Shadow d'Weaver doesn't hold with them - frivolous and indulgent, she says. But having been to one, well, I have no idea what she means! It must be a mistake, or maybe she just has no desire to do something on a small scale. Was that Mister De Gray as well? A bit rude, if you ask me, but it takes all sorts to build a world, as Perfuma says! And wow, she is amazing. I mean, thank you Catra. It's weird, most queer, our circumstances - me coming here thinking you were into women, being rejected by you… which hurt, I won't lie, I've always believed we shared a connection, a direct line, you know? But yes, having that happen, having my heart crushed, then going to the ball and you stepping up and introducing Perfuma… I mean, um… Miss Lucas… um, yeah so, yeah she's amazing. I really should call on her. Today. Definitely. I mean, thank you Catra and congratulations with Mr De Gray. I mean, good luck there too - I haven't met the man

before but I know the family. Sort of. Via my Patron. So, wow, changes all round, huh?"

Silence befell the room as the Reverend tapered off. She smiled and set to with her eggs. Catra blinked and her jaw worked in a feeble way for a moment. Glimmer turned and cocked her head sharply, a mischievous grin on her dimpled features. Entrapta was far too preoccupied with a book to care; Frosta looked about to explode with glee. Mermista looked relieved and a tiny bit guilty, if the wince in her expression was any guide. Catra worked her jaw and managed a huff. But Micah was suddenly speaking.

"Three potential engagements, perhaps? My gosh! And, dearest Catra, your proposed paramour may be whomsoever your wish - your mother and I are entirely supportive of your decision, for if it is love, then it must be pursued."

"Hear hear! Even if it be painful!" cheered Scorpia through a mouthful of egg. She shrugged, "I mean, silver linings and all! No hard feelings, Catra? Ms Lucas is, wow… I mean I am a lucky gal!"

Catra managed to sputter and flung up her arms, "I am NOT marrying Mr De Gray! It was a dance! With an acquaintance! An idiot!"

"Oh… so is it Hordak?" Entrapta glanced up. Her expression was strange - she actually seemed *interested* in the answer. Glimmer looked at her usually quiet sister and frowned.

"Hordak?"

"Captain Hordak Wickham, formerly a ward of the De Gray estate. Rather interesting man, a fascination with engineering. Attached to the local regiment as their chief Engineering officer. We talked about the latest developments in Sterling engine designs."

Again silence fell. But Entrapta kept her gaze on Catra. It was unnerving. The brunette licked her lips and shook her her, "Not *him* either. He did have much to say on the topic of Mister De Gray, however."

“And yet you still danced with the gentleman? Are you sure…?” Angella prodded with a faint smile. Catra kept her gaze on Entrapta. Her sister seemed to relax, her attention going back to whatever paperwork she was engrossed in.

Very curious.

Catra looked back to her mother and harrumphed, “I can assure you, my attractions and intentions have not changed. Mister De Gray is merely an engaging sort…”

“Who could guarantee you a secure lifestyle and future,” murmured Mr Moon. He winced as Angella shot him an admonishing glare, a rebuke in silent form, “I know, but I am concerned for their stability as much as the preservation of their hearts!”

The brunette placed her cutlery down carefully and shook her head. She managed a guilty glance at Scorpia, then huffed again, “Father, as I said before and both you and mother entreated to me - what is life if compromised? I could not do that to Scorpia… nor could I do it to myself. Mister De Gray would be a compromise of myself and… ultimately to the gentleman. He appears to be a good man, albeit flawed. I would not subject him to such a lie as to bind myself for my own security. That would be heinous.”

Mr Moon relaxed and gestured to Catra, whilst smiling at his wife, “And there we go. Our daughter is more than capable of reminding me of my words and defending her moral core. Catra *always* tends to the right words, the right things. Our apologies Reverend, if that was painful. We mean you no discomfort.”

Scorpia waved a hand, “Think nothing of it. As I said, it was akin to having my still beating heart wrenched from my ribcage, for long have I imagined my future with our dear Catra. That, hooo, yep that hurt. BUT! BUT! I cannot fault her honest and integrity and forthright approach, even as a one-two emotional assault on my very being.”

Catra blinked and frowned at the Reverend, "I believe you have stated this. I am unsure what you now wish of me," her voice carried a very impatient edge to it and Scorpia flushed.

"Ah. Well. I do seem to be… um… over egging it. Apologies, but I *must* be honest as well… I say this to now convey how thoroughly enchanted I am by Ms Lucas. The anguish and agony," Catra growled and Scorpia winced, "Was fleeting and immediately salved. Perfuma, in a single evening put much into perspective - my infatuation, my focus, due to no external influences, no others to whom I could reach out - all this led to my idealised view of you, dear Cat-of-the-wilds. And to that end… I would ask if you would do me the honour of being *my* maid of honour at Ms Lucas and I's forthcoming wedding."

"W...what?" Catra blinked and Glimmer crowed, her hands clapping loudly.

"Congratulations Scorpia," she gushed, "You have proposed?"

"Well… I will do today. TODAY! Yes! I will not dilly dally. Oh! OH! I must choose a new dress. And my best hat.! Gloves! Oh gosh. I really didn't think this through um…"

Angella reached out to ring the small bell by the table, to summon the serving staff, "I feel breakfast is over. Girls, would you mind attending on the Reverend to prepare her for this forthcoming challenge. Scorpia, if you would permit me to attend with you, so I may also speak with Mrs Lucas?"

"I say, she's my sister! I should talk to her…" interrupted Micah. Angella gave him a smile and reached over to pat his cheek.

"And a very good brother you are indeed. But do you feel you could hold neutrality in supporting dear Reverend Collins? Of course you may come with. I think dearest Casta might be chagrined at just myself."

"She may be distracted by her new tenant," chuckled Glimmer, who bit her lip mischievously as Angella arched an eyebrow at her,

“What? It was both obvious and, frankly, heartwarming. The pair are clearly enamoured with one another. Even Catra noticed it.”

“Another word, Glimmer dear, and I will shred your favourite bonnet!”

“You will do no such thing Catra, oblivious as you are to all things. You don’t even know which bonnet is my current favourite.”

Catra fixed her with a deadly stare, “The purple one with the pink ribbons.”

Glimmer squeaked and shot up in her chair, “You wouldn’t!”

“Don’t tempt me, oh sparkling-one.”

“Girls! Quieten down. You may bicker after we have rescued the Reverent from her self-induced hysteria,” All eyes turned to Scorpia who seemed to have become mildly catatonic, “Glimmer, Catra, Mermista… please assist.”

The two girls nodded and moved to help the Reverend away from the table, whilst the staff cleared things. Catra rose also, watching as Frosta and Entrapta vanished off into the house.

They set to work, picking out finery for the Reverend. Angella moved about the room like a whirlwind, Glimmer and Mermista terrifying in their focus in identifying suitable wear. Catra mostly picked a decent set of gloves to offset it all and fetched the Reverend’s hat. As the others wandered out to let the woman prepare, Scorpia beckoned for Catra to wait a moment. The brunette paused by the bedroom door and frowned, “You aren’t going to try another attempt to guilt me?”

“Ah, um, no, that… that was pretty rough of me. I’m… I’m sorry about that Cat. Just, well. A lot changed in the last day. I thought I loved you. Well, no. I do love you. But I know it’s the love of a dream. Of an invention, y’know? But try telling one’s heart that?”

Catra snorted and shrugged, “I can understand that.”

"And well… I guess, maybe just watch that heart of yours as well. I'm lucky I met Perfuma, grateful you brought us together, but what if… if she is just… humouring me. Like you…" the Reverend trailed off. Catra rolled her eyes, then moved to sit on the bed. She took the Reverend's hand and sighed.

"Scorpia - I care. I do. I may not love you in the way you wish, but I am not a heartless beast. You are a good friend. And perhaps I should have been a better one to you. I know you and I know Perfuma - she is good and kind and has so much love to give. And I know she would *never* do that. She is as forthright as I am. Honestly, Scorpia, I never saw your letters as dedications of love because *you* never set it down as such. I would have tried to be honest if I had known," she scratched at the back of her neck for a moment and shrugged, "As I said, we could have been perhaps content… but I am not willing to settle for content. And nor should you. Now, enough of this wallowing, Reverend! Go forth! Have faith in your… Reverend-ness to entrance the lady!"

"Yes! I will! And… thank you Catra. For being honest. And for, well… not just walking away. You had the right to do so, the entitlement to reject and be excused. But you have done me two kindnesses. You… are *not* a bad friend."

Catra smiled then wheezed as the larger woman enveloped her in a bone crushing hug. She was released a merciful moment later, then managed to escape. As she was about to leave she paused and turned, "You said I should watch my heart…. Why?"

Scorpia grimaced, "I… I am not sure. But you know that Misterr De Gray is the nephew of my Patron, yes?"

Catra stared, "No. This I was *not* aware of. I… you said she was a family acquaintance? I heard that…"

"Ah, well. Yes. But apparently there is some relation. Aunt is… I think the easiest short form term. Great Aunt, something removed, maybe. But I understand the De Gray's have a somewhat odd history of late."

It was gossip, which Catra said she could not abide. And yet she was interested, "Captain Hordak vouchsafed as much…"

"Indeed. I understand that Adam… *Mister* De Gray was absent for several years. A venture to some overseas colony. There were rumours he was betrothed to some young lady there. That to marry would forfeit his inheritance. My Patron…" and for the first time, the mention of said personage drew a faint grimace from the Reverend, "has an interest in the De Gray holdings. But now Mr De Gray is returned and unmarried, the question of inheritance and ownership is no longer so murky."

"How do you know of this?" murmured Catra.

"Ah, well… A reverend hears much. And, well, Lady Shadow d'Weaver has a fondness for wine. Her… ward keeps her in good supply of an evening."

"Her ward?"

"Some waifish personage. I have only met them twice, on my visitations for tea. Or at least in the many occasions I have had to call upon her Ladyship, I have only seen them twice. But I believe she had planned to marry said ward to one of the De Gray twins. It is… more traditional in the north of the country. At least from the gentry perspective. And yet their ward I am uncertain… I have no idea to which of the twins they would be married!"

"Wait… twins? The De Grays are twins?"

"Yes, yes they are. Although Adora is a smidge younger, as I hear tell."

"And have you met this Adora?"

"No, I have not. I have not been invited to the Greyskull estates. It is several hours from her Ladyship's own holdings. Further north, too. But, as I say… be careful, should your heart have changed. The De Grays appear to carry heartbreak with them in their dealings."

Catra nodded absently. A very queer circumstance - Mr De Gray having been betrothed as well? And having abandoned it? And his sister having been withdrawn from Hordak? And a complicated and potential adversarial relationship over inheritances?

More mystery. She bade Scorpia farewell and wished her luck, then made for her own rooms.

She had another task, made no easier by this new round of complicated knowledge. Part of her wished to know more; but she knew that this acquaintance with Mr De Gray was equally likely to end in turmoil with her next move - to confront Mr Archer.

Part of her wished she had met this mysterious and absent Adora - if she were akin to her brother, then perhaps…

Such thoughts served no purpose and she dismissed them as idle, wanting fancy. Blue eyes that made her heart pang; her confused irritation at observing Mr De Gray with another in close conversation - these were merely the frustrations of a new acquaintance that she knew she would cut short.

Any desire to be in the company of the *man* , or listen to their light voice, or trade barbs and witticisms was because she valued their friendship. And that such friendships were rare and she did not share well.

It wasn't as if she *liked him at all* .

She had stated that already, she knew.

AS she muddled over these thoughts, she prepared herself with her most rugged of walking shoes and a suitably austere bonnet. Taking the carriage was not an option - it would both draw too much spectacle and be commented upon by her family.

Also, Scorpia was using it.

With her accouterments prepared, Catra squared herself in front of her dressing mirror and took in her features - frizzy, brown hair

pulled into a mane of curls; blue and amber eyes set with determination; olive skin flush with anticipation and freckles visible. A deep red and black dress and shawl, with bonnet and solid, sturdy boots. She yanked on some woolen gloves and nodded to herself.

"Armed with the truth, I have naught to fear."

She left, offering a wave to her family as she passed the drawing room, along with a *requirement for some solitude* . She got a few catcalls of *With Mr De Gray?* , clearly from Glimmer, but managed to ignore them as she set out.

The walk to Thaymor House was not long - a three quarters of an hour at her brisk pace. The weather had held, so the pathways and bridleways were not churned with mud.

As she drew closer to the stately home, her resolve wavered.

Her father's words echoed in her mind - the comment around *stability* particularly prominent in her reckoning of things. Mr Archer and Glimmer had appeared the picture of satisfaction and joy at the ball. Surely that was not false?

And yet things were never so clear cut.

Mister De Gray contained multitudes - secrets and scandal and societal intrigue. A charming man, to be sure; but a good one? She did not know. Could not know. Yet she would not judge until she bore witness to things. Only his association with the cad that was Mr Archer besmirched his reputation; and that threw more of his attitude into a disparaging light. Like mirrored like, did it not? Two gentlemen well acquainted with subterfuge and deceit.

No matter how taken she was with his acquaintance, this only served to reinforce the idea that Mr Archer was an ill-sort and, given the chance, would lead her sister to ruin and unhappiness.

What was stability if encased within shame? Security if it entailed misery?A future with no horizons to look forward to?

The memory of that blonde maid at the door to Mr Archer's room calcified her indignation into a spear.

Catra strode forwards, across the lawns. She spied Mr Archer on a patio, fiddling with something that looked almost like an instrument. It was only as she drew closer she realised it was a bow. Beautiful, it almost looked like it belonged on a piece of furniture - oiled to a mohogany sheen, beautifully sculpted, inlaid with brass and leather grip. The man seemed enthralled with it and startled as she ascended the steps to the patio.

"Ms Moon! Oh my gosh… apologies, you startled me. I am afraid Mister De Gray is away on business today. Called away last night."

Catra blinked at that, "Oh? Again?"

Mr Archer wrinkled his nose, "I am afraid so. An ongoing and frustrating concern. I do wish Adam would… just *stop* . All this," the man sighed and slumped against the stone railing against which he was perched. Catra frowned at the sudden wave of frustration from the man.

"Stop? You seem frustrated with your good friend."

"I apologise, Ms Moon. Adam is… a focused fellow. Always tries to do what is best, but does not consider the immediacy of things and perhaps how alternative arrangements might benefit the situation."

"Oh?"

"Indeed. If Mister De Gray were to expand the perspective with which the world is viewed, perhaps the actions taken would not

be so… abrupt or painful. But Adam is stubborn."

"Vexatious perhaps?"

"To a degree," Mr Archer chuckled and shook his head, "Either way, I am sorry you missed them. Adam was quite enthralled after the ball last night. A thoroughly enjoyable affair. I thank you for bringing some light into Adam's day. Sorely needed. And I hope something you can continue to provide… in whatever manner is acceptable."

Catra squinted at the man, her voice tinged with slight scorn, "You seek to marry me off to a *gentleman* ?"

Beauregard's grin was almost rakish, "Hardly. Merely to provide support to an acquaintance in a manner appropriate to yourself. I think you and Adam are a better fit than either of you realise. Even if it is just as sparring partners," he stood and moved to a nearby patio table, where he proceeded to wrap the bow in oiled leather, "I am sorry you had a wasted journey, though it is a pleasure to see you. May I offer you some tea?"

"I will not partake. But honestly, it was actually you I was intending to engage with you, sir."

"Oh, ho? Is this the dreaded sisterly visitation?"

Catra tilted her chin and looked to the house, "May we speak in private?"

Mr Archer's smile faltered and he nodded slowly. He finished wrapping the bow then led her inside, to the drawing room. He offered another bout of refreshments but Catra declined. She took a seat on the settee and settled her hands on her lap. Mr Archer stood by the mantle and watched her carefully, "Ms Moon, you appear distressed… should I call for…?"

"No. No. It is because the matter in which I must engage you is a delicate one. There are ramifications. And I will speak my peace

and then leave. Ultimately, however, sir, I feel you must consider your position with regard to my sister."

"Ms Moon!" Beauregard looked alarmed, and a little confused, "What do you mean?"

"I mean, I feel it is in the interests of all parties that you cease your dalliance and pursuit of my sister, Glimmer Moon."

Beauregard stared at her and blinked, "I… I do not understand."

"Honestly, I am glad that Mister De Gray is not here. This is such an indellicate topic. Vulgar, even. I am speaking of your chosen acquaintances alongside your intentions towards my sister."

"Excuse me?" Beauregard shifted and his face now sported an expression of surprised indignation.

"I feel you should be aware such things are not tolerated. Things may be more permissive in the city, but our family abides by more traditional approaches to matrimony and familial attitudes!" Catra tilted her chin. She *knew* that he now knew of her own awareness of his proclivities!

Beauregard stared at her and then stuttered, "Pray, madame, I may have misheard. You do not approve?"

"After witnessing such a display on our stay here, whilst you feigned illness, I can safely say that such acquaintance will not be tolerated."

"You saw…." Beauregard ran a hand over his face, his pallor now grey, "And you disapprove?"

"Of course! How could I approve? And I doubt Glimmer would be at all tolerant, no matter how enamoured she is. She would feel sullied, betrayed by such associations!"

Beauregard gripped the mantle and stared at Catra, "I thought you, of all people, would understand… I… that Mister De Gray…."

“Mister De Gray be damned, sir. Your associations may go deeper than discussed, your contrivances are not my concern, only the reputation of my sister and family. Did you even consider her future? Her standing? Her own shame and dishonour should these things come to light? Too much to bear, sir. Too much. The social circle may forgive a man, but a woman would be sullied beyond belief.”

“I would never dream to hurt her!”

“And yet your actions indicate precisely the opposite *sir* . I know what I saw and I know such things would be of immense discomfort and even heartache for my sister. It is my duty to inform you, now, in this manner, that your intentions appear perverse, dishonest and without merit. And I say that you should consider your next moves carefully. Currently this situation is becalmed, none are any the wiser. I am discreet and wish to remain so, if only to preserve my sister’s good name and honour. You may take your designs and proclivities for differing company elsewhere and ensnare some other poor woman who will tolerate such… debauchery.”

Beauregard stared at her with what could only be seen as shock and some faint hint of anger. It was, honestly, not surprising - did not men fall to indignation at being challenged? Especially if they could not protest their innocence; they would declare their honour challenged. But she was a woman - he could not call her out. He could claim that none would believe her, but honestly, his options would be limited.

Men could take action, yes.

But women could *talk* .

And often that was far more effective an evisceration in society.

Of course, if that happened, then Glimmer would be destroyed. But if it came to it, a divorce and settlement would be preferable

to misery. Or being in the family way with an absentee fiance tempted away by a stablehand or chambermaid.

“This is your honest opinion on the subject?” gritted out Beauregard.

“Indeed, sir. Honestly, I cannot fathom the intent, the attraction.”

“The attraction?” Beauregard blinked in surprise.

“Indeed. To such a lifestyle, in as much as the object. Perhaps a hope of better connections? Or of some more insidious intent, I cannot tell, nor will I dwell on it. So, sir, I have said my piece. And I will bid you good day.”

She rose and Beauregard blinked, then gave her a curt nod, barely a bow. Catra nodded in return, then stepped out into the hallway. Mr Archer followed, stiffly. He coughed and shook his head.

“I honestly thought you were a more open minded sort, Ms Moon. To judge Adam and I so.”

Catra paused and turned to glare at him, “By my choice of partners? That I should be more *open* to various dalliances? No, sir. Some things are just dishonest and debauched. And you, sir, keep good company with that regard. I hesitate to understand further. To even consider the relationship and possible depravity of Mister De Gray as well. Was I to be *Mister De Gray’s* plaything whilst you indulged? Was that the rude assumption made? I had not wished to believe either of you so wicked, and yet… here we are. And I must concede I am saddened by the loss. I was fond. Fond of you both. But I cannot abide this. And I will not let my sister be wounded by such association and company that would harm her heart and reputation. Good *day* sir.”

And with that, she departed, head held high, the fire of righteous indignation strong in her heart.

It was only as she was across the fields and the sky began to darken with impending rain that her fury began to ebb and she was left with the strangest sense of melancholy and a nagging concern in her head. Why had Mr Archer dragged Mister De Gray in at the end there? She had purposefully left him out, on the chance that he was unaware! Was Mr Archer admitting that Mister De Gray was complicit? Aware? That the man was an accomplice, or partook in such debauched fraternising with staff? Of course it would be more acceptable with Mister De Gray, as the man had declared no intention on anyone.

And yet why did the conceit of said gentleman making moon eyes at another young woman turn Catra's stomach so? Was it a shared disgust with the craven attitude that Mr Archer clearly displayed? Enjoying dalliances with impressionable maids? Was Mister De Gray a similar sort? And if so, why did the idea that such a pained, quiet, austere man being so inclined hurt her?

Had she become like Scorpia? Building an idea of a person within her head so that the reality was so jarring as to shatter it?

And about a *man*? Why was her heart so conflicted on this? It was if her soul, her inner self knew something, was convinced of *something* that her raging mind could not comprehend, so conflicted with righteous and frustrated fury was she. Such conflicting thoughts - of loss and firm satisfaction - warred within her on the walk home. It left her feeling tired, wrung out like a dish rag from the scullery.

Of course, it was likely the mere passing of her enthusiasm that left her drained and morose. An unpleasant duty, but one that had to be done.

But why did she feel she had done positively the wrong thing?

Chapter End Notes

> To quote MARCUS DECIMUS AURELIUS FATHER TO AN UNFINISHED FIC, HUSBAND TO A CONFUSED PLOT!

ARE YOU NOT ENTERTAINED?!

SO much MISUNDERSTANDING!

Yes. Yes. YES!

Please let me know what you all think ;)

Puzzle pieces

Chapter Summary

Glimmer is despondent

Captain Hordak reveals some tantalising information

A caller has an unexpected offer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Five days following that fateful meeting, Mr Micah Moon blustered into the drawing room, face red and demeanour flustered. Entrapta and Frosta trailed behind their father, peppering him with questions as to his reddened countenance - namely whether he had been on some sort of morning constitutional or had fallen into a patch of poison ivy or, perhaps, had witnessed a particularly disturbing interaction between livestock on his errands.

Ignoring the irksome girls, the man of the house stormed over to his wife and flailed a letter above his head, "Gone, madam! The bounder is *gone* !"

Glimmer and Catra exchanged a glance, from their seat upon the sofa; the more pastel of the sisters being mostly enthralled by a particularly challenging piece of crochet; Catra for her part mostly occupied with a small book on political agitation (Her mother did not approve, mainly because it was not *in depth* enough, but catra had no patience for the weightier tomes in the library at present. Her mind was rather distracted)

Angella signed and placed her own embroidery upon her lap and frowned at her husband, “Is this some new parlour game, dear? Are we to hazard some form of thrust as to what you mean?”

“Five days the man has ignored our dear daughter. Three days he has rebuffed our letters! Or requests to call upon him. And our invitations! The servants turning away our dearest at his very door.”

Catra had to keep her gaze trained upon the pages before her at that. The guilt in her chest was like a leaden weight; and yet she tried to measure it against the *good* of her deeds. Some ephemeral, longer term goal, to spare her sister’s honour and reputation.

But it did not shift. The recollection of Glimmer’s return two days prior after having gone to call upon Mr Archer, then gentleman having politely declined their other missives. And yet the butler had turned her away with an apology concerning Mr Archer’s sudden urgent business.

Glimmer smiled thinly, her chin wobbling as she tried to maintain a brave facade, “Gone, father? I.. is all well?”

“The man has quit Thaymor! It is to be rented once more!” Glimmer gasped as Micah slumped into a chair next to Angella, “Gods be damned that we should ever hear the name *Archer* again!”

“Dearest!” cajoled Angella with a stern frown. “Father!” gasped Glimmer as she tried to hold in her tears. Catra sank down in her chair and winced.

“So… I can’t use the workshop any more?” Entrapta, who had been standing near the door, stepped forwards. She had a grease-stained dress on and was worrying at the apron she had over the top.

“My fiance-to-be *leaves* and all you care about is your blasted *toys* and *trinkets?”* Glimmer turned on her sister, then threw her embroidery down. She stood and turned away. Catra sat up and reached for her.

“Glim, dearest, maybe it… it’s for the best?”

“The *best* Catra? The *best* ?” Glimmer’s eyes shone, “Oh go on, *do tell* .”

“If… if he fled, then it shows he was not the stalwart type, surely?”

“He was a man of honour! To leave…”

“Means that you did not know him as well as you believed?” Catra nudged. In truth, she felt conflicted once more. A cad such as Beauregard Archer committing to his word? She should be happy

that he had done so; yet his politeness, his measured responses and commitment to Catra's demands somehow *vexed* her.

If he truly loved Glimmer, he should fight for her, surely?

And yet, she had painted a rather bleak alternative for him. Was love not supposed to overcome such barriers? Caution to the winds and all that?

"Just because you feel that all men are the embodiment of sin and depravity does not make it *thus* Catra!" Glimmer's words roused the brunette and she stared in surprise.

"Excuse me?"

"I mean, sister, that you seem to feel him a villain. But that simply cannot be the case!"

"The evidence is before you!" cried Catra, and she felt the weight of her hypocrisy for a moment. Mr Archer was merely following her directive. But it was the *correct* decision. He must have a sliver of honour, Catra decided - for he had agreed to not embroil Glimmer in his sordid affairs.

Glimmer growled and turned to her father, "Is there nothing to be done?"

“The man has shown his hand, dearest. You must think no more on this and hope that the dalliance is not seen as some sort of… besmirching act. However, I gather from the contents of this rather *brief* letter that Mr Archer was called back to town due to family concerns,” Micah’s expression softened and he sighed, “Do not be disheartened, my girl. You are deserving of *so much* . And I find this churl to be unworthy of you if this be the manner of his approach.”

“Perhaps for the best then?” Catra tried once more. Across the room, Frosta huffed and Entrapta shuffled her feet. Glimmer rounded on the brunette.

“Not all of us are so hardened to be able to *traipse along* after such events, Catra. Not all of us are so emotionally *distant* or aloof to just… *move along* . To some of us this is not some *game* of win or lose, or some merry little dance. To *some* of us, this *matters. ”*

With a sniff, Glimmer strode from the room, almost shoving past Entrapta in her haste. Catra sat, rooted to the chair, and blinked. The words stung like a slap across the face. Micah winced and Angella gave him an expression that could only be properly described as *withering* , “Dearest, your penchant for tact and discretion is truly on display today,” she turned to Catra and reached across to clasp the girl’s hand, “Fret not, she is merely distressed. And when we are despondent, we do tend to lash out, I know.”

Catra knew - that had been the entirety of her younger years; as a ward of the Moons, she had been taken in. A daughter, yes, but not by blood. And to get to this heady height of acceptance and love had taken months. Not on the part of her parents, no - they loved without reservation. But for a child who had only know sadness and loss? It had been a road fraught with fear. A fear of potential loss and revisitations of experiences past.

So, of course she knew how Glimmer felt. But the guilt that gripped her compounded her paralysis and all she could do was smile weakly at her mother. Angella nodded, oblivious to the true source of her daughter's anguish, then turned back to Micah. She chided him gently and the man looked thoroughly cowed. And yet he still had that thin line of anger beneath his remorse.

"I know Angella, dearest. And it is awful for Glimmer… but that man… that *man* . To disrespect her so, to… to lead her on and then *flounce off* like some preening peacock to some *soiree* or *gala* , whilst having promised us his honest intent and approach? It just… it *vexes* me."

Angella's frown softened and she squeezed her husband's hand, "What Glimmer needs now is a stabilising force, not a whirlwind of recrimination. She needs her father right now - to show her that not all men are such charlatans. And are *also* capable of emotional stability…"

Micah winced, "Of course. You are right dear."

As she watched them, Catra felt herself shrink a little more. She coughed and tried for a smile, “Mayhap I should… try?”

Micah shook his head, “No, dearest. Best to let her cool and vent at me. She means not what she said, she just… it is difficult when you are in the throes of passion. You feel nothing will go wrong, nothing will falter. Few things feel so certain as love and few things are as precarious.”

That got a tender smile from Angella, who leaned from her chair to press a kiss to her husband’s cheek, “You should have written poetry, my love.”

“Pah! Why write when one can act!” he waggled his eyebrows at his wife and she flushed. Catra turned her face away, appalled at her parent’s rather overt display. Frosta looked like she was going to evacuate her stomach, whilst Entrapta busied herself with a sketchbook. Angella’s tinkling laugh drew Catra’s gaze back and she found the woman’s fond smile directed at her.

“When such a thing strikes you, my dear, you will not be so staunch I believe. And…” she cast about, trying to find the words as if the air about her head possessed some script, “whilst I know you have professed no preference to the masculine side… your expressions with Mister De Gray are… somewhat similar?”

Catra flushed, “We are acquaintances and… and he is just some charming oaf. And an associate of that cad! I imagine his whiles are similar, charming and yet without merit.”

That drew a nod from Micah, “Quite so. He seemed a stiff sort when we met; as if he were trying to hard to be something. I can tell a fake, you know. And Mister De Gray strikes me as one. And now we know why! Oh yes indeed!” he glanced at Angella - a frown had returned to her face, “Ah, yes… Glimmer. Right-ho!”

He stood, clapped his hands and then left. Angella huffed, then smiled and refocused on Catra, “I think perhaps a constitutional would do you well. Take the girls. I think Glimmer might require some space,” she tilted her head, “Do not take this as a poor omen. Engagements and courting… it is a fraught affair. I have seen many fall through from a lack of dowry, to sudden shifts in mannerisms, to simple transactional arrangements.”

“Transactional?” Catra asked.

Angella sighed, then shrugged, “Sometimes a better offer comes along,” she looked at the doorway, “I know that from personal experience.”

The girls in the room gasped, “You… what are you saying mother!” Frosta stared at the woman. Angella smiled and shrugged.

“We were all young once. Heads full of ideas. Dreams. Concepts. I thought I wished for something pragmatic. A safe and secure future to build my family from. That was not to be, once I met Micah.”

Catra leaned back in her seat, book forgotten, "You… broke an engagement?"

Angella bowed her head and nodded, then looked to her girls, "Indeed so. It is why I was so *proud* of you Catra, for standing for yourself. Not something I could say with the Reverend around of course. But, yes. And it was difficult for the young man to accept, but he did. Such things are *never* clean and easy, despite society looking to reduce the idea of marital bliss to a business arrangement at times. And it is why we will not force *any* of you into something less than ideal for yourselves. And why we will always, *always* , ask you to be sure. About ALL aspects."

"That was why you spoke of… futures," mused Catra. Angella nodded, then gestured to the door.

"Anyway, we can talk more later, when tempers have cooled. Off you go. And wrap up warm, there's a chill in the air."

The girls met Mermista on the driveway - she had been out on a walk of her own, but readily joined them as they walked into Brightmoon. The small town (though to call it such was stretching the definition) did have a small salon shop which showed some of the fashions coming out of Elberon. Admittedly they were also several weeks out of date and there were harrowing tales of a local girl who had attended a ball in the city while wearing some of the designs, only to find herself awful *out of season* .

It was a lesson learned by the country folk - the city was a harsh place, for all it's more accepting attitudes. Marry who you wish, just do not wear the wrong footwear.

The four women were also able to take in the small market that was currently running - mostly just produce but also some of the local wicker-weaver's new baskets and the stall of a passing peddler.

"Ah, Ms Catra Moon. A pleasure."

Catra paused in her perusal of the peddler's particulars (an eclectic collection of books, trinkets and other assortments) to face the greeter. She arched an eyebrow as she met Captain Hordak's impassive stare. He wore his uniform, but had a greatcoat over the top to protect it from the dust of the road.

"Captain. You appear to be getting your boots muddy in the local market."

"Not entirely my own choice," the man sighed, with faintly clenched teeth. He glanced over Catra's shoulder and shifted slightly, "And… I see your sister is with you?"

"Ah, several of them. Did you not have occasion to meet them at the ball?"

“Ah, no,” Hordak returned his gaze to her, “Your sister Entrapta was, well, most informative and I was not fortunate to meet any of your other siblings *properly* .”

They were interrupted by the rather flurried arrival of another man in uniform, who practically bellowed across the small space in a manner most uncouth, “MER-MIS-TAAAA!”

Catra recognised the gentleman - the moustachioed officer who had so charmed her sister. She glanced over at her surly sibling and saw her attempting to duck behind a stall. It was for naught of course, as the officer merely skipped past a flower stall, plucked a single rose, then rounded Mermista’s hiding place to accost her on bended knee. Catra looked at Hordak, “Not your choice?”

“The simpleton wished to peruse the market. I was told to *chaperone* the younger officers.”

“Well, one of them appears to have found some entertainment. Can you vouch for his honour?” Catra smirked at the clearly uncomfortable Captain. He gave a sigh.

“He is harmless enough.”

“Not quite a quality you look for in a soldier?” she quizzed. He gave her an unimpressed look.

“Socially. I have yet to witness his prowess within the context of combat.”

“Well, let us pray that such a requirement is not tested within the bounds of the county!” Catra affected a shocked air, then laughed. Hordak pursed his lips and nodded. He glanced around then huffed.

“I am given to understand that Mr Archer has departed the county?”

It took effort to not snap at the gentleman, but Catra managed a tight “This is indeed the case.”

Hordak nodded and clasped his hands behind his back, “In which case I am sorry.”

Catra felt a surge of surprise, “Oh, and what have you to apologise for, sir?”

“As you implied at the ball, there appears to be a similarity between Mister De Gray and his acquaintances. I perhaps should have campaigned for more caution, been more forthright. To spare your family’s embarrassment.”

“And why would you do that sir?” chided Catra. She managed to hold back the sneer, knowing her own hand in the affair. The

Captain shrugged.

"To be a decent sort. And perhaps to engender a sympathetic and honest connection with your good selves."

Ah.

"You have intentions, sir?" guessed Catra. Hordak shrugged once more.

"I am gentleman in want of stability and a guaranteed future, beyond the reach of my family and without a certain inheritance. It would be remiss of me to *not* make connections, at least in the form of beneficial social interactions which could further entrench me to potential eligible candidates."

Their little group had begun to wander the market, albeit idly. Mermista, full flushed with embarrassment and perhaps something else, hung onto the arm of the younger officer; Frosta and Entrapta busied themselves between stalls, peering at the newer items in the shop windows and generally being enthusiastic hurricanes.

Catra regarded Hordak carefully then chuckled, "Well I cannot fault you for your candidness. Truly, the world might be better if all were so up front and genuine, sir. Although it lacks a certain… style?"

“Why dress up intent in frippery, madam? State purpose and intent clearly… where possible.”

“Where possible?”

“Where possible. Some matters are delicate and cannot be so bluntly handled, despite my desire to be so forthright.”

Catra turned to regard the Captain, “Oh? Well now that is interesting. Please, speak plainly, sir.”

Hordak gave her a sidelong look and seemed to consider for a moment, “I feel that to do so will adjust your opinion of me and my position and presentation in society.”

Catra laughed, a derisive sound, “As if I am one to care! Few things shock me, considering my *own* rather public stances!”

“You make a valid point.”

“Hordak! Have you invented anything new this week?” Entrapta practically skipped over and beamed at the man. He seemed to flinch slightly and Catra sighed.

“You may interrogate the gentleman on your own time, sister. We have discussed *interrupting* ?”

“Oh… OH! Yes. Yes, observe, understand when is appropriate to intercede and partake in conversation,” Entrapta nodded seriously, “Like we are doing now?”

Catra couldn’t help but laugh, “Quite so. But the good Captain and I were discussing something, so would you mind…?”

“I… I do not object,” Hordak sounded gruff as he glanced at Entrapta. Catra arched an eyebrow, but Entrapta was distracted by something else momentarily, “But… perhaps a better moment might present itself?”

Entrapta looked at him, beamed, then dashed off again to inspect a watchmaker’s small stand, scattered with broken brass pieces and mended timepieces. Catra shook her head, “She means well and has a good heart.”

“She does? She does,” Hordak nodded slowly, “She was… most informative at the ball. A font of knowledge. It grants a unique perspective on things.”

“Oh? You were about to divulge your particulars, sir. Does Entrapta know of them?” Catra teased with some small snark. Hordak glared at the floor and huffed.

“No. My particulars are… unique, I feel. And were once rudely dismissed. I am… loathe to divulge them now.”

They had wandered across the muddy street to gaze into bakery's window, the small, warped glass squares giving a distorted view of the delicacies within. Catra turned to regard the man. She wasn't sure why she was intrigued - he had none of the strange mystery of Mister De Gray, but he was more open and less flirtatious. He was brusque and pragmatic and something of that appealed to her at the point. Considering the duplicity of Mr Archer and, potentially, Mister De Gray, such honesty felt like a welcome balm.

"Is this to do with… the De Gray's," Catra probed with a faint twist of her lips, an almost-smirk."

Hordak gave a derisive snort, then looked to the sky, "Astute. But hardly a difficult deduction to make. That family was a disappointment. It is not gentlemanly to partake in gossip, but their actions wounded me so that I find it hard to consider them in a fair light."

"We all have our burdens and our righteous fury - I know this well."

Hordak looked at her, as if considering. He appeared to arrive at a decision "As I say, I am in want of stability. And that engenders a family. However, I must impress upon you that love and lust are not in my bearing. I am not that way inclined," he glanced sideways and Catra thought she saw her sister's carreen between another stall. Perhaps he did not wish them to hear this.

Catra pursed her lips, mildly surprised. But then, she had asked, "That is certainly *not* what I was expecting. Perhaps that you dabbled in cards. Or had an urge for the clergy."

The Captain scoffed, "The clergy was my *intended* path, as part of the bequest from the Grayskull family. However, I refuted it when I did not take to the life of a man of the cloth. After studying with Adam, I found the hypocrisy of the institution too much to stomach. The church is a place to deposit the awkward intellectuals who wish to conform."

"And the military is such a bastion of free expression," mocked Catra as she folded her arms, "I can see you regaling your troops with raucous poetry, even now."

Hordak's smile was thin and fleeting, "A hierarchy is no bad thing; but an entire philosophy does not drive the military, beyond being part of a greater whole. The church asks much. The military asks only duty."

"And the rather fetching uniforms," commented Catra with a shrug.

"Honestly, it is pragmatic and purposeful."

"And what does this have to do with your… engagement to the Grayskull girl?" Catra probed once more.

“Adam and I… we were staunch friends. He wished his sister to be secure. Safe. The counties in the North are home to more unscrupulous negotiations on marriage. I was… a safe option.”

That furrowed Catra’s brow, “How so?”

“To explain that I have to elaborate on my earlier statement. To whit, I have no expectations on my partner. Beyond securing a marriage, I would intend for my spouse and I to co-exist, able to pursue our interests exclusively.”

The utter *frankness* of this confession left the young brunette speechless, albeit momentarily. She coughed and her eyebrows knitted together, “Sir, let me see if I have the right of this - you wish for a marriage, yet have no expectation of *anything* from it.”

“Quite so.”

“And… you expect, from the start, to lead *entirely* separate lives?”

“That is indeed the case.”

“To what extreme?” Catra cocked her head, fascinated.

Hordak regarded her impassively, "In all extremes. Why pretend? Any heirs would be… beneficial. Yet if there were none due to certain attractions then this would not be of concern. I am not one to restrict nor coerce… though that was my father's way. As such, a marriage to me would be a transactional thing. But one entered into with both eyes open."

This revelation felt overwhelming, also a slightly unnerving reality that Catra could scarce parse, "And this is what you… offered to the Grayskulls? *Why* ?"

"As I mentioned, Adam wished a marriage to ensure his sisters safety from the predations of other families and their desire to marry into the family."

"But... they can *refuse* the engagements, surely?"

Hordak shrugged, "I am not privy to Adam's thoughts. All I offered was an avenue to prevent the endless line of suitors. And it was agreed. It would have allowed Adora to… live the life she wished, whilst ensuring certain securities and obligations of the estate."

The information was truly a revelation and Catra reeled a little from it, "This is… not something…" Hordak held up a hand.

"And it was an equitable arrangement, one Adam felt in the best interests at the time. And then… well, some unpleasantness ensued. I had thought the arrangement agreeable - both parties

achieved their goals of stability and a guaranteed future, free from coercion. But the arrangement fell through after the *intervention* of *Mister De Gray.* ”

Catra stared at the man, as she processed his animosity and apparent caution, “So… you desire a match without ties of a truly marital nature, more a business partnership. ”

“That… would not be an inaccurate assessment of the challenge.”

Catra nodded as other gears turned, “And you would be amenable to the lifestyle choices of your partner?”

Hordak nodded, “I feel you should understand my motives, plainly, as well as my frustrations. And by being so open I hope to find an accord with someone. I desire a partner and a secured future. And I will *not* deny the proclivities or lifestyle of my partner, short of a breach of decorum.”

Something clicked for Catra, “Are you offering *me* this? Or is this a broader statement?”

Hordak pursed his lips, musing. He looked her up and down for a moment, then sighed, “Consider: a woman whose choice of partner is limited, with marriage prospects unlikely. Unwed, she is seen as a millstone, reliant on her immediate family, spinsterhood beckons. BUT! A marriage where she would be free to pursue her interests and also her own,” and here his lips twisted into that

ghost of a smile, “Entertainments? Without fear of recourse? That is the matter at hand. Whether you feel this applies to you is entirely within your own control.”

“Sir this... is most bizarre, you will forgive me for saying. And socially awkward,” Catra felt she should be appalled but was perversely intrigued. It was so far beyond the realms of her experience, the very concept was alien. And yet perhaps this was just a formal statement of what so many marriages devolved into; Hordak had merely put it front and centre. There was a twisted sense of honour there. It went entirely against her professed ideals of love, yet meshed with her concept of a partnership of *equals* . An arrangement such as this would not have worked with Scorpia - there were *emotions* there, albeit on one side.

Here? Security, but no obligation to the partner beyond some form of co-operative to secure societal standing. It had a strange appeal and would alleviate pressures. And would not prevent her… doing what?

The *idea* of it held an appeal. But the practicalities were suddenly mundane.

The Captain shrugged then actually smirked himself, “And I thought you said you cared not for such things. Truly, propriety dictates I normally would not consider this. And it is only because of your exposure to Mister De Gray and your already admittedly forthright nature that I am so forthright in return. I would trust for you to not be indiscrete about my intentions; instead, perhaps, you would be willing to assist me.”

That drew Catra up short, yet also relaxed her, “Assist…?”

Hordak nodded, “You have shown yourself to be adept at analysis and social observation. I had not, honestly, considered you a candidate as I believed you to be honestly searching for a partner to fit your choices. But this would still be advantageous to you, at least in securing you a position. Though, as I mentioned, I am not a man of means; it would still give you a platform from which to build. If this offer is not of interest to you… perhaps you would assist me in identifying eligible candidates who would be amenable to an arrangement such as this, who could guarantee such stability and long term security?” He trailed off, eyes going about the market as if distracted. His words were solid, but his voice seemed to lack *some* conviction.

“You seem certain of this course, sir? Are you truly immune to love?” Catra ventured that humour might allow her to rebalance her thoughts.

Hordak flinched almost imperceptibly, “I… have not experienced it, so would not recognise it. Truly I place more faith in honest dealings than some flushed-fancy and addle-brained interruptions.” But Ctara caught the faint blush on his pale features, as if he did not quite believe those words.

“Did you love Adora?”

That drew him up and he barked a laugh, the tension gone and genuine surprise on his features, “She *was* a fine girl, but no. And

certainly not now, given the *situation* ," his lips pursed and his jaw clicked as if he was forcing his mouth shut.

Catra felt her mind was awash with questions, absolutely and suddenly out of her depth. She was unsure where to proceed, the conversation suddenly thick and unclear. Her salvation came in a rather unexpected form, as a white charger cantered onto the street and slowed to a trot. Hordak stiffened next to her and looked up at the rider.

Mister De Gray reined in their horse a few yards away and stared at their party. The horse wheeled in place and the gentleman twisted in the saddle. Catra felt her heart stutter at the intense stare Mister De Gray fixed her with and she felt a flush of guilt in her gut - for what she was not sure. The proximity of Captain Hordak? Her actions with Mr Archer? Her consideration of the Captains rather unorthodox proposition. If it even *was* a proposition and not just a description.

Hordak reached up to the brim of his officer's shako. Mister De Gray seemed to snort and Catra watched the gentleman shake their head. The blonde then turned the horse to trot to the inn and Catra couldn't tear her gaze away as Adam vaulted from the horse, which they handed to a stable boy, before marching inside.

She turned to Hordak and marshalled her thoughts. Truly, the man had revealed a lot in a short span of time. It was scandalous, *almost,* but it was at least forthright. His intentions were clear, if strange. It presented her with a new potential avenue. And, given the recent fallout and distress she had seen from Glimmer over such insecurity as *love* (even if the sabotage was by her own

hand), she now pondered whether such an arrangement as Hordak proposed might not be a more secure option.

But then surely Scorpia's option was preferable, if this is your aim ? Her internal voice chided her.

Except with Scorpia, as she had already considered, there were indeed emotions involved; emotions that would have led to banal comfort or active resentment.

With this, one could indulge - there were no expectations, no demands save that securing of one's future. Perhaps that was what she required? A partnership of friendship in spinsterhood, or a comfortably passive marriage - two individuals who happened to share an environment?

After having protested so strongly for her own agency and desires, why did this now sound so intriguing? Or was it more that Adora De Gray, the mysterious sibling, had been offered similar and seemed initially amenable? Did that indicate what Catra now believed, that perhaps Mister De Gray's sibling was a *friend of Mara* and that Hordak had offered her a safe engagement? Why the rejection then? And why did that tidbit *influence* Catra in the slightest? She still felt as if she was missing a puzzle piece. Now she had context for some of the behaviours Mister De Gray exhibited - their stoic bearing; their honesty (or seeming honesty); their caution. The gentleman was a conundrum and this information added a new lens through which to view him. Perhaps *that* was it - not that this avenue appealed, but that it gave her more on the strange blonde.

But given her interactions with Mr Archer and his lecherous behaviours and her current belief in Mister De Gray's potentially similar motivations, she surely should *not* care?

And if that *were* the case, was it perhaps then better to marry a friend, or someone of standing, then perform some form of double life? Or was living honestly, as Spinerella and Netossa seemed to be the desired course?

"Ms Moon?" she blinked and turned back to Hordak. The man studied her for a moment, "I have made you uncomfortable. That was not my intent, I assumed that you would be more appreciative of honesty."

Catra sighed and waved a hand, "No… no. I do appreciate it. But it is such a surreal situation you propose! It is not something I had honestly considered."

"It is merely the enunciation of the reality of many marriages as they stand. But it has to be said that speaking the truth out loud often offends."

That, Catra had to concede, was the truth. She folded her hands and frowned, "You have given me much to ponder, sir. Fret not, I am discrete. And… I thank you for your honesty around your intentions and… habits, I suppose."

Hordak nodded and surveyed the market, "Whilst I prefer frank discourse I am under no illusion that my desired specifications are

seen as… unnerving.”

“Quite the understatement, sir,” Catra actually grinned at that and Hordak merely arched an eyebrow in response.

“I wish no ill will on my spouse and merely wish to ensure proper preparation and expectations. I will not have anyone surprised nor disappointed. To go into a relationship with unrealistic expectations is… “ he shook his head, “It is not something I wish to pursue.”

“If that is your aim, it is honourable then, sir.”

Another cadre of officers approached and greeted the ladies politely. With a sigh, Hordak turned to Catra, “My thanks for your company, Ms Moon. And your conversation. I must now usher my flock back to safer pastures.”

Catra chuckled at that and saw the ghost of a smile on Hordak’s face as she looked at her and her sisters. Entrapta blinked owlishly at him and waved, “Hordak!”

The Captain blinked and nodded, then returned her wave somewhat awkwardly. Catra glanced at her sister and sighed, “Come on, home now. Glimmer should be calmer.”

Mermista snorted, but Catra noted she was reluctant to relinquish her grip on the officer on her arm. The man, likewise, seemed

reluctant until a *harrumph* from Hordak summoned him. The man smiled ruefully, gave a theatrical bow, then scampered after the retreating officers.

The girls made their way home, Mermista dodging questions about her *young gentleman* from the more exuberant young women. Catra only half listened, her mind a flurry with thoughts of Hordak's bizarre concerns and offer. But more she wondered whether she should have gone to the inn, to see Mister De Gray, to demand...what?

Her unease persisted, but she shoved it aside as her sisters switched their questions to her and whether she had decided that men were now acceptable. Frosta in particular seemed particularly aggressive in this regard, but Catra handled that with aplomb and some sardonic commentary on Frosta's own tomboyish nature.

Entrapta however, seemed distracted, merely asking if Catra had an insight on Captain Hordak. It was endearing; the man was, after all, one of the few people Entrapta had bothered to engage with at the party, so perhaps she felt obliged to learn more. It was reassuring to see her forming social ties, even if it was with a most eccentric man.

She pondered at the future - Glimmer's, her own, the family as a whole. Mermista could perhaps be the one to secure a match, if the day's activity was an indication. For the first time Catra pondered her own decisions. Hordak's arrangement appeared so impersonal, so crude. And yet it was an avenue to acceptance and social stability. It raised questions.

In her heart and soul, she knew that it was not her option, not something she would commit to - she could not, in good conscience, partake in such an arrangement, for all the "freedoms" it could afford. And yet part of her mind, the part that had equally been intrigued by Scorpia's offer, stood at the edge and pondered.

Another part of her mind regarded the intensity of Mister De Gray's regard before they had entered the Inn: their demeanour and bearing being of one who was intensely frustrated. And again she pondered at that guilt she had felt. It concerned her, for she knew not its source. Had Mr Archer confessed all to Mister De Gray? Was Mister De Gray annoyed at their game having been spoiled? Or was it just the presence of Captain Hordak?

She *had* done the right thing. She was in the right.

She *was.* She had.

Hadn't she?

The next day was restless as the rain drummed an incessant beat upon the county. Glimmer had emerged from her room sullen and despondent, but was mildly apologetic when approached by Catra. So reconciled, if not still discomfited, they managed to find quiet companionship over a board game in the drawing room.

Catra decided that it was her duty to raise her sister's spirits, due to the weight of the situation upon her shoulders, but found herself unable to envisage a suitable resolution.

However, hopes of a peaceful day of coaxing her sister's smile once more were dashed with the surprising arrival of a caller.

"Mister De Gray," announced the butler. The family, gathered in the drawing room, all exchanged surprised glances and Catra swallowed. Glimmer actually *did* smile at that and gave her a look that bordered on *knowing* and *smug* . Catra tried to return one, but she felt she merely looked *choked* .

The gentleman in question entered the room and gave a stiff bow to the gathered group, "Ah, the Moons. Yes."

Angella rose slowly and crossed the room. Mister De Gray extended a hand, took one of Angella's, then placed a stiff kiss against the back of it. For her part, Angella seemed amused. Micah appeared to be torn between apoplectic rage and genuine surprise, "Mister De *Gray* . A surprise, to be sure."

The gentleman bowed stiffly to Micah, "Thank you for receiving me. I ah… I hope I am not interrupting?"

"Not at all," mused Angella, "To what do we owe the pleasure?"

Mister De Gray flexed their hands, "Honestly, it is… somewhat awkward. I have two pressing concerns. May I speak with Ms Glimmer Moon and Ms Catra Moon? I wish to… offer my support."

Micah's anger appeared to sputter somewhat, "Support, sir?"

Mister De Gray nodded, "I am aware that my dear friend has departed the county. I am… unsure why. I have just returned from a rather urgent meeting and was not privy to the cause of his departure. I was hoping to gain some understanding before I make for Elberon. APologies, I know it is not *done* to discuss these things so frankly, but I was concerned for Ms Moon's welfare. And I know her sister cares deeply for her, so I wished to reassure both of… my support."

Catra could have been knocked askance by a feather. This was *not* what she had expected. Glimmer looked hopeful and stepped forward, while Angella and Micah ushered the other girls from the room. Mister De Gray paced to the fireplace and shot the pair nervous glances. Glimmer settled herself back on the couch and Catra slowly moved to join her.

Glimmer coughed and adjusted her hands on her dress, "So, you have a suspicion as to why Beau… why Mr Archer has absconded?"

Mister De Gray flinched at that and sighed, "I am… confused. I returned to Thaymor to find the barest of messages stating he

had to urgently return and that it was a family concern. I can assure you, Ms Moon, that Beauregard would not up and leave unless it was something of the direst concern."

Glimmer sighed and opened her mouth. Then she closed it and sniffled, "But not a *word* ?"

Mister De Gray shook his head, "That part I cannot fathom. He… was enamoured, my lady. And I…" Mister De Gray made a fist and looked away, "To my shame I judged you harshly. But… I realised your true nature to be a sweet and kind one. After our sparring match, of course."

That made Glimmer snort and Mister De Gray seemed to have the ghost of a smile on their face. It gave the man an almost efete look - gentle, soft. Not the hard planes and scowls Catra had seen more often than not. She realised she quite *liked* Mister De Gray's smile.

But again, this could be some trick, some grander game? But the man seemed genuinely confused. And perhaps even *embarrassed* ?

Glimmer nodded to herself, "So what do you intend?"

"Was anything said? Did he give you an inclination that there was something amiss? I understand he was in fine form after I left, post the ball?"

“No… nothing, sir,” Glimmer sighed. She turned to Catra, “Did you notice anything?”

Catra bit her lip and shook her head, “No.. uh… I did not *notice* anything. At all. I barely spoke to the man. A passing comment at the ball, but that was it. I had intended to call but… well…”

Mister De Gray regarded her for a moment, then turned to face her, “Anything you can recall, Ms Moon.”

Catra. Call me Catra .

Catra blinked at the words in her head, but she shrugged them away, physically and mentally, “I… I am sorry. Is there anything in his bearing *you* know of that would cause him to flee? A… connection to the staff, perhaps? Some...scandal at home?”

The comment drew a raised eyebrow from Glimmer, “A connection to the staff? You think he found out… what… one of his siblings was sleeping with a serving wench?”

Catra managed a shrug, “I hear stories. Gentlemen are indiscrete!”

Mister De Gray sighed, “Whilst that is indeed true, it… is not something the Archers are known for. They are honourable, upstanding. It must be to do with the family, some tragedy I was not aware of. Perhaps a business transaction gone wrong. I pray it is that and not something more serious. It must be if he were to leave without even a passing *word* .”

This version of Mister De Gray appeared genuinely agitated, impassioned. Catra watched a flush creep up the man’s face; swallowed as she saw that jaw flex with frustration.

What the devil was happening?

Mister De Gray winced, “I fear that… he may not return, Ms Moon. That was the other thing I wished to convey to you at least. I will try to engage him in discourse. Ascertain whether he intends to return and if not, why not. This is unlike him, considering his passion for…. This place,” Mister De Gray grimaced and avoided looking at Glimmer.

She sniffled and nodded, “Please. Thank you, Mister De Gray. Your visit brings me hope, but I dare not indulge it. For if he cared he would not have gone so abruptly, surely?”

Mister De Gray fiddled with their cuff, “I am… unfamiliar with the workings of the heart, Ms Moon. So I fear I cannot advise. I will do what I can.”

Glimmer nodded and rose, Catra slowly moving alongside her, "Well thank you. And… do inform me of the situation. I would rather have closure and an understanding, so I may decide on my course of action."

Mister De Gray nodded, then glanced at Catra, "Of course. Um… if I may please have a moment alone with… the other Ms Moon?"

Glimmer blinked, then glanced at Catra with a raised eyebrow, then curtseyed and left the room. Catra stared at the gentleman, who now paced before the mantle. Apprehension crept into her chest - *does he know, was this a charade, some parlour game, what is his intention* .

"Ms Catra…"

She startled and sat back down slowly, then licked her lips, "Mhm?"

"These past few weeks have been…." Mister De Gray made and fist and placed it slowly on the mantle, "A torment."

Catra's eyebrows shot up, "Oh?"

"In vain have I struggled. It will not do. My feelings will not be repressed. You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you.'

She rocked back in her seat and stared at the gentleman. Mister De Gray moved away from the mantle and paced before the fireplace once more. Her silence was clearly considered encouragement enough for Mister De Gray to continue, flushed and wide eyed as they were. The gentleman stilled and a strange calm descended upon them as they drew in a fortifying breath. When they spoke, it was in a businesslike tone, with their gaze just above and to the left of Catra's seated position.

"I am of noble birth, a higher station. Our pairing would be unorthodox perhaps, yet no more so than some I have seen exhibited here. Your family is of an eclectic mix, not versed in manners but charming in their way. Eccentric, perhaps, but still amenable and tolerable. Your opinions are varied and changing, but you possess a conviction and determination that I ardently cannot fault. And yet I should not feel this way. Our situations are at odds, my own present demands of duty and obligation pull me away and I have *fought* with my very core to resist these temptations and desires. And yet I find myself willing to cast all these difficulties aside, these challenges and demands, ignore the stares and commentary of inferiority or potential social embarrassment."

Catra's surprise gave way to incredulity and a core of hot anger. And yet she stilled her tongue, unsure of the line this rant was to go. Well, one word had certainly impacted her ears with such force that it had almost made her deaf to the remainder of the monologue. And then Mister De Gray then confirmed her suspicions.

“Ms Catra Moon, I have felt and do feel a strong affinity with you. The strength of this attachment cannot be denied. My anxiety and apprehension of our meetings heightens daily, as does my excitement. And with this latest revelation I fear that an opportunity to see you if Mr Archer has quit the county would be difficult to maintain or manage, without a presence here to base myself from. So, to that end, I would wish to formalise an arrangement that would enable me the rationale to ensure a regularity of contact and affirm our bond.”

The young woman stared as Mister De Gray turned and fixed their icy blue gaze upon her.

“Would you do me the honour of marrying me?”

Chapter End Notes

Well.

HOW ABOUT THAT!

Apologies this one took a little longer. I hemmed and hawwed over the Hordak bits. And then the Adam bits. So, took a while. I think I've made it work!

So, as ever... lemme know whatcha think!

Next chapter has the last bit of OH GODS NOOOO CATRA. Then we can start the climb out. Reckon I can do it in 4 chapters or shall we end on an even 20?

Best laid plans

Chapter Summary

Mister De Gray meets their aunt

Mister De Gray Returns

Mister De Gray has a plan (What could go wrong)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The journey back South was always excruciatingly dull. It provided ample opportunity for *reflection* , which was something Adora did not appreciate. Reflection meant considering the state of play of matters around things such as *the estate* and *duty* and *things that could not be* .

Of course the journey South was markedly improved for the fact that Adora was headed away from her Aunt. Well, *Great* Aunt, however many generations removed or what-not.

Furthermore the carriage did not contain Dee, unlike on the trip *North* to answer the curt summons by the self-proclaimed matriarch of the territory. All fear and managed opinion and curried favour, of course; but reputation mattered to the Northern county families. Unfortunately.

The carriage ride North had been excruciating in a different way - handling the frankly overbearing conversation of Dee and their particular whimsy of the month.

Adora stared out of the carriage window, counting the miles before they would arrive at the coaching in where she had stabled Swift Wind. The Grayskull Estates were a good fifty miles in the *other* direction to Lady Shadow D'Weaver's estate. Rather than ride to *home* and then take a carriage, it had made more sense to rendezvous with Dee at the inn, then tolerate a day-long carriage ride to the estate.

Adora leaned back in her seat and adjusted her britches. She was *Adam* still but that identity wore and wore more against her. Ever since collapsing in Beauregard's rooms, she had found the burden to be just that - a burden most intolerable.

She leaned back and recalled the smirk on Dee's androgynous face; their blonde hair drawn into a lank ponytail. The words had issued forth as they had sat opposite her, with a cigarette holder clasped in their manicured hand. A silk dress and shawl in lime green, to offset those emerald and cold eyes.

" *Still thinking you wear the trousers in anything, darling? Surely you have ascertained by now that this is* my *speciality."*

"If that is indeed the case, then feel free to return to treading the boards in Elberon, to strut and promenade your evident expertise. Or the powder rooms of whatever gentleman's club would entertain you."

"You can't wound me with the truth, dearest. After all, we are to be wed, are we not? We must learn to trade barbs!"

"She is not still on with this ridiculous notion? Is that why I have been summoned like some common labourer, to pull my forelock and bow most humbly? To accept some ridiculous proposition like a cockamamy scheme from the dockland bars?"

"Well, since you've decided that 'Adam' is the way forward, well… maybe she wishes to compromise? I do turn out well in this dress, do I not?"

"I find it hard to countenance that you traded the vaunted stage for being the catspaw in her latest schemes? I am Adam so she decides to, what, meet me with the opposite? This strains her tolerance, surely?"

Adora pursed her lips at the memory of the exchange. Dee was a strange one - some minion and fawning being that Lady D'Weaver had, apparently, adopted as another ward. Except she treated Dee almost as an equal - not quite with civility, but not as dismissive as others in her sphere.

Dee, for they offered no other nomenclature or title to identify themselves as, had been around for a while. They'd observed the catastrophic implosion of Hordak's clumsy attempts and now, it seemed, they were continuing to act as some sort of agent of Lady D'Weaver.

Adora huffed and ran a gloved hand through her cropped hair. The gesture made her wince; some days she missed the feel of her tresses, a reminder of a more care-free time. She recalled the meeting with Lady D'Weaver. The wizened Aunt, beshawled and veiled, ever ready for a funeral that had yet to happen.

"You continue with this charade, Adora. It is juvenile in the extreme and most unbecoming."

"It maintains the integrity of the Greyskull estate."

Adora remembered her clenched jaw, her tilted chin. Lady D'Weaver had merely seemed mildly irritated behind her veil, the cold surrounds of her drawing room adding the maudlin air.

"This is a studied insult to your father's explicit bequests…."

"Bequests that, apparently, only you are privy to," she answered. Adora recalled the amused tilt of Dee's features. The catspaw in question had donned britches and something akin to a page-boy's outfit for the interview and had sat demurely beside the Lady, " *And yet I see you tolerate Dee's particular proclivities finely."*

"Dee is not fraudulently bringing a good name into disrepute. Dee fulfills a role. Something you are failing to do, Adora. You have a destiny, a duty to family and name. I do not do this out of cruelty, but necessity. Marriage and guaranteeing the line is all that matters. To someone of good name at the very least."

"And so, what, you proffer the hand of your valet here?"

"Dee, as nominated ward, would bind our estates. I would prefer with you as Adora De Gray! As intended! Not in this… fantasy you have concocted. BUT I am willing to… tolerate an alternative proposition."

"Adam would not tolerate this."

"Adam is not HERE. He has absconded. And yet he also had made arrangements! But, really, leaving a young, unmarried woman to run an estate, assuming she would make the correct choices. Hardly proper."

"Adam is *here. To claim otherwise would be scandalous, Lady D'Weaver. And might I remind you that you do the same, yourself, with your own holdings"*

"I have years of experience. I was wed. I have my ward. All is as it should be." The Lady had appeared chagrined, " *This invention of yours is shameful and the recourse of one with no options. You wish to end your days unwed, barren? This will be your fate."*

"And yet I am not fit to dictate my future according to my whim? I think not."

"We are not the Southern counties. We are tradition. Breeding. The backbone of this nation. Let them have their indulgences and whimsy - it will rot and fail. Such… modern fancies are temporary and flights of fancy! Women marrying women, what a foolish

notion? Whatever is the point! You get no calves from paired cows! No, Adora, you will eventually outgrow this petulance after you have seen the wastefulness of your indulgences."

"And yet Dee is…"

"Dee is whatever I require Dee to be."

"No heirs will be forthcoming from this."

"I will manage. Fret not, that will not be your place. As I have always told you, I will look after things. As I promised your father."

The meeting had concluded with Adora-as-Adam excusing herself from the house. D'Weaver did not approve of her particular choices, no; but she could not act against them, not publicly. The Dee situation appeared a last desperate push - to acknowledge Adora-as-Adam would hurt her pride, but the estates would be bound. Because D'Weaver could not, realistically, do otherwise - not if she wished for Adora to eventually acquiesce to the demands to wed whichever ward was placed before her and anchor the Greyskull fortunes to the D'Weaver's in such a manner.

Not for the first time she clenched her fists and bit back a curse to her brother's disappearance. The mess that it left with the inanity of her father's muddled bequest and documentation.

The carriage rattled to a halt and she dismounted, no longer Adora, but *Adam* .

The gentleman surveyed the yard and their gaze alighted on the white charger being led carefully from one stable. With a huff, Adam took the satchel handed over by the coachman, then approached the horse. A young man emerged from the inn and paused.

“Refreshments, m’lord?”

“No sir. I would rather not tarry and have a desire to see the back of the estate, somewhat.”

The young man nodded sympathetically, “Business up at the House? Never entertainin’, as we sees from them poor buggers come pleadin’ an’ borrowin’.”

Adam nodded curtly, “Indeed. No desire to incur any *debts* if it can be handled. For your trouble,” and they tossed a silver coin into the man’s hands. The fellow bowed and grinned broadly as Adam mounted Swift Wind in an easy bound, then wheeled the charger out onto the road.

The sooner they were back in Thaymor to reminisce with Beauregard, the better. And perhaps there would be an opportunity to engage in discourse with a certain lady with the mismatched eyes.

Riding was always a freeing sensation, stripped of the trappings of society and worries, it was an activity that allowed one's mind to completely clear. The countryside thundered past; a blur of greens and greys; stone walls and the interlaced branches of trees across cart-tracks and barely-there roads.

Moorland gave way to woodland and gentle hills, which then became open fields and soft breezes.

Swift Wind kept a good pace, as befitted a horse of his breeding. His stamina and enthusiasm was unmatched, a pride of the Greyskull stables.

As the sun began to set, the gentleman paused for the night at an inn on the edge of the county, to allow Swift Wind to water and rest. Secluded in a somewhat private room, Adam allowed themself a moment to remove their bots, but retained the majority of their clothing - best not to be discovered in such a public setting, even with the more permissive ideals that apparently abounded. Gossip was still a thing that the lower orders participated in and such a rumour could undermine their position back home, as these things would spread like weeds.

That was one good thing about Lady d'Weaver - she had no *desire* to spread those rumours as it would imperil her plans.

Sat by the small stove in her room, Adam was able to take stock, the ideas of the day a muddled swash of colour and impressions set upon their conscious contemplation.

They had dashed from the ball to the North, for what had apparently been yet *another* pointless demand to acquiesce to d'Weaver's ongoing attempts to secure the Greyskull fortunes. And it had denied Adora - *Adam* - more time with the true object of their fascination these past few weeks.

Catra Moon.

An enticing, fascinating woman. Fire and fury and not a hint of flightiness. Stubborn, confident and a completely unattainable individual. Potentially.

Some days Ador- *Adam* - envied Beauregard for the simplicity of their desires and mores. Even back with the brother around, life would have been a *lie* . Hordak had been a sudden surprise and an unwelcome one, even if the impression *Adam* had had was that it was a well-meaning attempt.

The ride and visitation had taken a toll and Adora, as she finally acknowledged whilst safe in the room, dozed in a high-back chair; her feet stretched out in front of her and the warm glow of fresh stew fortifying her from within.

The morrow she woke with a crick in her neck and a memory of listless dreams, fit to torment even the most ardent soul with concerns of impropriety.

Once more, *Adam* emerged into the early morning light and set forth towards Thaymore.

The ride was shorter, only a couple of hours now. As Adam cantered up the driveway, there was a faint wash of homesickness coupled with relief. They had not called in at their ancestral estate, which felt wrong. And yet this place had a welcome familiarity to it now. For all the critique leveled at Beauregard for his choice of venue, Adam had to admit that the initial view had been a churlish one. There was a charm and serenity to the surroundings.

That serenity, however, was somewhat disrupted by the sight of several carts arrayed before the house.

Adam reigned in the horse and trotted slowly around the laden vehicles, then nodded to the housekeeper. The woman seemed distraught as she took in Mister De Gray, "Oh, sir! We was told to expect you, perhaps. Maybe."

"This appears to be an exodus. Pray, is the gentleman within? I would enquire as to the agenda of the day."

“Beggin’ your pardon sir, Mr Archer has departed for Elberon. He has quit Thaymor, stating he has no further need for the property. He and his learned Father’s left the day before yesterday.”

Adam reacted with surprise and sagged in the saddle, “I had some small items still remaining within the house…”

“Packed sir, shipped with Mr Archer. We have not handed the writ to the lawyers yet, sir, so you may inspect the rooms to be certain your property has been collected?”

“Quite, quite,” murmured Adam, not actually certain of what they heard. The gentleman dismounted, then set to confirming the Housekeeper’s affirmation as to the state of the building - emptied, save the pre-existing library and house furniture.

Satisfied with the itemised list handed over by the Housekeeper and a small bag of loose items that Mr Archer had left for them, Adam remounted and turned away from the once-familiar house; now just a shell of memories. The second home they had grown to love, but now had to ride away from. It spiked a sudden fear - would Greyskull still be there upon their return? It felt a ridiculous notion, but circumstances felt less than certain. The world appeared all a kilter.

With no house, lodging became a pressing concern. To that end, Mister De Gray turned Swift Wind towards the small town to find suitable accommodations. Beauregard’s sudden flight from the county presented an unfortunate side effect: there was no rational reason to call upon the Moons moving forward. Prior to now there would have been local events, or perhaps even chaperoning a

young lady of the family as a favour. Or those *would* have been valid reasons, had Adam but taken the proverbial bull by the horns and made entreaties. But now, such excuses would be trickier to justify or consider - a gentleman not *of* the local area randomly calling upon young ladies would likely not be taken seriously. Even with such prodigious assets that the Greyskulls possessed, Adam would likely be viewed as a *cad* or a *wastrely* wasting the time of a family eager to ensure their daughters' futures.

Which meant in all likelihood that a social engagement with Catra was inherently unlikely.

This, for some reason, felt a most disagreeable possibility. Well, the reason was incredibly clear, but Adora - *ADAM* - refused to countenance future possibilities that had no realistic potential.

Of course, such broad internal statements are ripe for challenge and challenged it was as Mister De Gray cantered into town and espied the Moons promenading. Most of them - Adam could not make out Glimmer anywhere.

Catra, however, she picked out immediately. And then Adam's grip on the reins tightened as *SHE* spotted the individual with wom Catra was pleasantly conversing.

Hordak .

The catalyst for *HER* sorry state of affairs. And the miscreant was making Catra *smile* .

The bounder. The cad. The preening *poppinjay* .

Adora's thoughts shunted like carts at a busy market, but she managed to pull back her initial desire to drive Swiftwind into Hordak and trample the devious gent under-hoof. Instead *Adam* stepped forth and demanded civility, caution and *distance* .

So, they slid from the horse and handed Swiftwind off to the stable hand, before they chose to stalk away from confrontation. They did manage a hard glare at the promenading couple and, for a moment, believed a disappointed look had ghosted across Catra's face.

But mayhap that was wishful thinking - it was quite the distance across the muddy street after all.

The night was a restless one and left Adora a rumpled mess - she slept fitfully, her thoughts consumed with concern for Mr Archer and the rationale (briefly given by the valet at Thaymor House) for his departure. It sounded off and ill conceived.

And she was tormented by the strange expression Catra had been giving Hordak - contemplative and intrigued. Was, perhaps, the oaf propositioning Ms Moon in a similar way as before? Dangling the promise of some sort of *life* with options, if only one was to sacrifice choice?

Adora knew well that dance, that thrust of argument.

And as any good swordswoman knows, two can play at that game - a good way to defeat an opponent (for, surely Hordak *was* one) was to understand their style and, perhaps, to emulate it and perfect it? But for more *honourable* purpose.

As Adora achieved this conclusion, she was better able to settle in her bed in the inn, assured that her nascent plan was entirely foolproof as it satisfied the majority of concerns for all parties involved, save *Captain Hordak* .

Adam chose to call upon the Moons the day after. The conversation was abrupt, to be sure, but Mr Moon struck Mister De Gray as someone who enjoyed discourse and, frankly, time was of the essence. The primary interest was to assuage Ms Glimmer Moon’s clear worry - Mister De Gray surmised that she had been absent from the promenade due to her vexed state, clearly apparent in the flush of her skin and the mild intensity of her eyes. Also, the faint twitching in said eyes.

And so they made best to assure, how Beauregard was an upstanding gentleman, who would only leave under the direst of circumstances. Familial distress, most likely.

And then Catra implied something most distasteful - the idea of one of Beauregard's family committing an impropriety against their own staff! The woman did look shamefaced as she said it, but it was concerning if that was a thought in circulation. Mister De Gray studied the woman - she was observant, sharp, quick to defend others. To accuse the Archers so was surprising. But, then the lady commented on the state of *Gentlemen* in the round and Mister De Gray's concern made sense - she was putting forth potential ideas, casting about when no other reason presented itself.

This made Mister De Gray flush, as they considered the options. In truth *Adora* flushed purely because Catra regarded her with such intensity. The lady's stare was like the noon-day sun, full of heat and casting away all shadows. Truly, Adora struggled to maintain the facade, to hold back her ardent wish to follow through.

She managed to force such thoughts back and vouchsafed her concerns, as Mister De Gray, around Beauregards actions and future intent. Mister De Gray's discomfort was, in truth, based on fear. And while the claim of inexperience in matters of the heart was not a lie as they spoke it to Ms Glimmer Moon, it was somewhat couched in the truth of having had their heart protected and sheltered.

After vowing to pursue the truth of things, Mister De Gray finally found themselves alone with Catra. And it was a sudden moment

of clarity that spiked that fear.

This was a woman who had plagued their - *HER* - every thought. To think otherwise was to commit a grievous sin against her own mind. And Adora thought things through very carefully and deeply. It did not lead to the best decisions, but she felt it led to the most honest ones. It had led to Mister De Gray as an invention, which served well enough.

Beyond the confines of the reserved approach of Mister De Gray, Adora trended towards introspection and over-thinking.

And in this moment *Adora* decided to be honest. Which, of course meant that she was also thinking about the impact of everything to do with their lives and the future. The solution felt self evident, especially if Captain Hordak had laid the seeds.

She began with laying her heart bare: “These past few weeks have been….” Mister De Gray made and fist and placed it slowly on the mantle, “A torment.”

Catra’s appeared surprised, but not overtly flattered, as her surprised, “Oh?” attested to. Adora resolved to push her suit harder.

“In vain have I struggled. It will not do. My feelings will not be repressed. You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you.'

Catra leaned back, still clearly surprised and, with the faint quirk of her lips, amused. This was not a matter of entertainment. Perhaps she considered Adora to be being playful. *Mister De Gray* resolved that frank pragmatism was the best way to illustrate their depth of feeling, whilst also conveying the benefits of their proposal.

"I am of noble birth, a higher station. Our pairing would be unorthodox perhaps, yet no more so than some I have seen exhibited here. Your family is of an eclectic mix, not versed in manners but charming in their way…" in this manner, Mister De Gray continued, determined to cut to the heart of things. And, perhaps, just perhaps, reveal the truth of things. Perhaps.

She managed to put some emotion past her normal barriers, past Mister De Gray. She professed her desire to still *see* Catra, that by agreeing to this, their cordial relationship could continue! Not much would change, not yet, not until she, *she* finally stated something. But in public she could not do this. Of course, there was the matter of Catra's preferences, But *Adora* was sure that, once Catra was married and understood Adora's true nature, then it would resolve itself as a non-problem.

Finally, Mister De Gray managed to deliver the weighted question. It felt a completely sure thing - all the benefits laid out before the woman.

"Would you do me the honour of marrying me?"

Catra stared at Mister De Gray, at Adora. The look in those mismatched eyes was strangely cold. Detached. For a moment, Adora felt she may have misjudged the depth of feeling reciprocated. But that could not be - she had seen the glances, felt the charge in their exchanges.

And then Catra spoke. Her voice was low, akin to the growl of an unamused feline.

"In such cases as this, it is, I believe, the established mode to express a sense of obligation for the sentiments avowed, however unequally they may be returned. It is natural that obligation should be felt, and if I could *feel* gratitude, I would now thank you. But I cannot -- I have never desired your good opinion, and you have certainly bestowed it most unwillingly, initially. I believed you to be a different gentleman, one who understood my particular stances and views and, in doing so, respected them. I am sorry to have occasioned pain to any one, especially one I believed a friend. These torments will surely abate in the face of *certainty* I have no doubt."

Mister De Gray coughed, surprised and mildly concerned, "But… I do respect and admire your convictions," their features had paled in confusion and mild irritation, "Is this rejection all I can expect after confessing so abruptly? Might I enquire why I am rejected so abruptly?"

Catra positively flared to life. She rose to her feet, hands bunched into fists, "You prancing ninny! You high-falutin, preening cockalorum!" she began to count off on her fingers, "You stride in here to simper upon my sister about your comrade's abhorrent

and appalling behaviour! As if you are ignorant of his penchant for indulgences without regard for the lady who cares for him."

Mister De Gray frowned, "Now, I do have… and what indulgences?"

"You know all too well I am sure, as birds of a feather are likely to flock together. Perhaps you were involved, supporting his debauchery - you were, after all, prancing after that *person* at the ball; to declare for *me* after likely being rejected? Or did you enjoy a dalliance and decide to *turn* me?"

Mister De Gray attempted to interject but was forestalled.

"I am not *finished* . *Then* you declare your ardour, in spite of your knowledge of my own situation! You insult my family, my heritage, displaying a lack of decorum within *my* home. You preen over your standing, your provider tendencies. Yet, even were I mildly attracted to your *assets* in all the senses of the words, you did not regard *me* - little more beyond my having *tormented* you by my very existence!"

Mister De Gray appeared to be weathering the tirade ill - they gripped the mantle and stared at Catra with the gaze of the shepherd when the flock has scattered beyond their ability to corral. Catra continued:

"And we have not even gotten into your interactions as a man of *honour* . You have defamed a man, likely denied and interfered in the establishment of stability and security for your own sister!"

This caught Mister De Gray in a way most unexpected. They snarled and shot Catra a glare, "Oh, is that so? My sister's happiness cut short?"

"The arrangement with Hordak, which you cut short! A promise made, yet not kept speaks ill of a man."

"And yet you speak of emancipation and freedom for womenfolk? Are you merely a socialite with aspirations of fairness, lest they become *inconvenient* ? I would have thought you opposed to such ideas and trappings of convenience!"

"All can make their choices, but you denied them. And in doing so, denied Captain Hordak his own rights. He was like a brother to you! He offered an avenue of escape, of security, or so he stipulated you offered thus and initially supported, only to whisk it away! How can I take seriously the bearing and character of a *man* who keeps ill company and lacks the integrity to support family and friends?"

Mister De Gray moved, "This? This is your opinion of me?" their voice croaked and seemed almost an octave higher. In truth, they felt broken. It was Hordak and *d'Weaver* all over again. For a moment it looked like Catra was unsure, her eyes clouded with a confused frown. Mister De Gray moved their jaw, to marshal their turbulent reactions, "How have I so offended you thus? How have

my fellows made you think so ill of us. I admit my initial engagement with you was one of uncertainty and condescension and for that I am liable and rueful. But this bile feels unwelcome and unworthy!”

“If it is any consolation, *Mister* De Gray, there are no circumstances under which you could have offered your hand in which I would have felt in any way compelled to accept. The base reality is that you are a *man* . Add to that the litany of issues, errors and attitudes and you have your clear answer.”

Mister De Gray stared at her, mortified and confused. They licked their lips and nodded slowly. Every attempt to speak froze them, like a broken automaton at a travelling fete. Eventually they managed to move away from the mantle and made a strange gesture, then stared at nothing at all, “No… circumstance at all?”

Catra huffed, blushed, then looked away, “Not under present circumstances, with that pride and pomp, with your very *being* so aligned against me and my interests.”

Mister De Gray stared at her, then snorted. They dragged a hand down their face and muttered, “Adora….”

“And what has your sister got to do with *this* , aside from your interactions and interference.”

Mister De Gray laughed then, a sound of sadness and little more than a bark, "Adora, my sister? Adam the brother. Oh… oh the bitter irony. Who betrayed whom?" Blue eyes met amber and cerulean, "I offer you the same thing Hordak offered me. I turned it down. I suppose I should not be sad that you did likewise."

With that, the gentleman stood. Catra stared, brow furrowed and confused as several things clearly began to slot together. Mister De Gray, however, roiled with concerns and fears - mostly because to consider rejection by this woman, this beacon, was pain incomparable.

Mr Archer seen as a cad? How? Why? Was it Hordak? Had Catra, this bastion of moral certitude *witnessed* something?

Answers had to be forthcoming.

"I understand, Ms Moon. I am mortified to have put you to such distress today and to have been the cause of any pain my misguided and, frankly, clumsy attempt has engendered. I would like to wish you a good day and a healthy and happy future, where-so-ever that may take you."

And with that, Mister De Gray swept from the room, from the house itself until they were atop Swiftwind and galloping down the gravel path, toward Elberon, an attempt to outrun the shame and the pain behind them.

Behind her.

It wasn't until Mister De Gray had vanished from the Moon estate that the words they had spoken at the end sunk fully into Catra's mind, confused as she had been by their choice at first.

She'd sat alone in the drawing room, not vindicated but instead somewhat hollow - her own part in the flight of Beauregard hung like a stone; and that weight had increased as Mister De Gray had praised his friend. The Gentleman's confusion and affront seemed genuine. And their indignation came not from guilt, but from genuine anger.

Of course, the manner of things was insulting, but it really was akin to Hordak's offer.

She felt guilty, her anger at Mister De Gray's blunt approach having burned out and having left no residual sense of victory. She felt not like she had won; instead she felt insulted, disappointed and drained.

Right up until the *words* Mister De Gray had said finally settled in her mind.

She stared at the wall.

She bit her lip.

She swore. Loudly.

Chapter End Notes

....someone may have just worked something out.

OK! Sorry this one was later - I am moving house so things have been INSANELY stressful, which has impacted my writing and also my satisfaction with my writing.

I smashed this out (Finished it off I mean) whilst sleep deprived! Basically,the only way to get around my performance anxiety! SOOOO let me know if you spot any glaring issues and do pop some feedback in.

I love hearing from all of you and I hope youre still enjoying this weird take!

The art of writing

Chapter Summary

Catra considers the outcome of their conversation.

Correspondences arrive.

And things are revealed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Moon household was what one might call *in a tizzy* . Since the rapid departure of a distraught looking Mister De Gray the family had descended upon Catra with both concern and praise. Mr Moon had espoused his belief that *justice* had been delivered to a rake, whilst Glimmer had felt some form of trepidation - Mister De Gray had opined that they would ascertain the nature of Mr Archer's clandestine departure and current refusal to engage in, well, an *engagement* .

Catra's siblings were mostly delighted with this sudden surge of drama. At dinner it was the highlight of their conversation. Mermista smirked and stated that, in no uncertain terms, Mister De Gray had no *tact* . This, Catra felt, was an ironic statement and in hindsight was an unfair assessment of the gentleman. Especially from *Mermista* .

Frosta was delighted to have gossip, but saddened she had missed the, as she put it ` *throw down'* . It appeared she had been picking up terms from the young stable hands.

Entrapta, for her part, was mostly concerned with her current experiments and a small notebook that, from what Catra had spotted, contained words such as *interaction, social aspirations*

and *parallel interests?* She had offered her own opinion that Mister De Gray had exhibited trended and consistent emotional clarity regarding Catra - to whit, a clear and persistent fascination.

That had drawn most of the attention at the table, with Catra managing to request further clarity.

"At the last several social engagements, along with any outdoor excursions whilst the Archers were in residence *and* Mister De Gray was in their company, following the initial introduction…" Entrapta had paused at that moment to adjust something in her notebook, "The initial *public* introduction, which built upon *your* initial introduction to the pair…. Well, Mister De Gray spent the largest proportion of their time talking to you, Catra. At no function did they dance with any other women out of real choice, nor have they engaged in calling on any other eligible ladies. Or Gentlemen - I cannot discount *that* possibility."

The statement had yanked at Catra's still-fuzzed brain, several ideas and suspicions now competing for space. Not quite *clear* but now at the forefront. Which was why she felt confident stating: "I feel that gentlemen are not Mister De Gray's preferred audience…"

This had brought some commiserations, namely about how it was a shame that Mister De Gray was, of course, a rake; but also that he was a *man* . Catra weathered these reassurances but noted that her mother was more tight lipped on the topic.

And so, after much chatter, Catra found herself in Angella's study - a room she shared with Micah, of course, but in reality it was predominantly her domain.

As usual, Mrs Moon was direct.

"Are you satisfied, dear?" her voice gentle, curious and yet laced that underlying authority she possessed. Catra found herself sat in one of the room's formal chairs and could barely sit still. But she felt compelled to honesty.

“I am not. I feel….” she huffed and grimaced, then turned to face her mother, “I feel like I am regarding a puzzle, but a piece has suddenly appeared that I did not know was missing. I should feel vindicated, should I not? Asserting my independence and ensuring a gentleman with a potentially risque reputation was put in his place?”

Angella pursed her lips, “And you demand satisfaction by the destruction of others?”

“No! No… but… I should feel justified, surely? But instead I feel a sense of disappointment.”

“Anger is not a sustainable state, my dear. And were you really angry at Mister De Gray?”

“He treated Captain Hordak abominably!”

Angella smiled, “And you care for Captain Hordak?”

“Well, he is… a pleasant enough fellow.”

“A dear friend who you feel honour bound to avenge?” teased Angella, “A man whose own integrity is beyond reproach, for you to fight so devoutly on his behalf?”

Catra frowned at her mother and waved a hand,”I… I can judge a man by the company he keeps. And Mr Archer was *not* a good man.”

Angella took this in stride and nodded, “You know something more, I believe,” she sighed, “I will not press you for it, Catra. I trust your judgement, for the most part. But I know you to be one who will be a zealot in the protection of this family. I remember you, at six, challenging Mr Grizzlor over his comments when you felt he was trying to be rude, when he was actually passing comment on the rhododendrons.”

“To be fair, mother, he was disparaging your cultivation.”

“And that did not require my six year old girl kicking him in the shins, Catra.”

The brunette huffed, then smiled, “Still…”

“Indeed. But my point is… perhaps you are not satisfied because this puzzle you speak of is not truly solved. Perhaps it now contains more pieces that are yet ill defined? Did you speak with Mister De Gray…”

“Of course!”

“Let me finish, please dear. Did you speak with the man or did you harangue him?”

Catra pursed her lips, then folded her arms to hug her own bodice, “...I may have gotten a little bit *vexed* . Not to the throwing of the pewter, of course!”

“Of course,” Angella nodded sagely, “Which is why we keep the best china in the cupboards, not the drawing room.”

They bother smiled and giggled, then Catra ran hand through her hair, “I fear… I may have misjudged the context of Mister De Gray’s intent and… situation. But I am unsure. I was certain that they had wronged Captain Hordak, or at least betrayed their trust but…”

“But?” Angella prompted.

“But things do not marry up. There is a murkiness there and… I ascertain that I do not *know* everything about the situation,” the admission seemed to actually hurt Catra as she winced at it. Angella smiled softly.

“I know your mind is unparalleled at solving dilemmas, my dear. But you occasionally should step out of your own way, I feel. Perhaps the world will grant you an opportunity to answer these queries. Or perhaps we must accept that this sad chapter of our lives is closed and look to the future.”

Catra had spent the following day in a slight state of frustration - she now understood that she had been so eager to chastise, so intent on following her irritation, she had not engaged in active dialogue with Mister De Gray. Unlike when they had sat in Thaymor House and actually conversed in that gentle, familiar way.

Those little engagements, those moments in passing over the days. Catra found them fond, but also found herself reassessing them in light of her suspicions and her immediate *thoughts* after their separation following that fateful meeting.

Namely: was that really *Adam* ? Or was it, perhaps…

Adora ?

And if so, would that change anything?

Catra was smart - she knew this. But she realised, in reassessing the prior encounters that the 'Gentleman' had certain attitudes and expressions; certain ways in which they held themselves that were, actually, distinctly feminine. Of course, men could be efete, *of course* . But something about Mister De Gray, once you considered the possibility, made their encounters stick out more.

Others stated that the gentleman was striking; but was that perhaps because people detected that there was something *off* about their presentation? Something *askance* ?

And yet Catra found herself loathe to decry such a thing. She herself was a Friend of Mara, for goodness sake.

Her musings continued thus for a further day, leaving it two days since the event itself. Glimmer was still mostly ensconced in her room, brooding over the loss of so perfect a match (Which were her own words) in Mr Archer. Catra felt a pang of guilt over that still, as well as an increasing uncertainty - for if she was so wrong about Mister De Gray, then perhaps she had misjudged the situation regarding Mr Archer! Except she had seen the evidence with her own eyes!

Eyes that, clearly, were not as observant of nuance as she had believed.

But Captain Hordak's testimony was damning. That she could feel sure of. Save for her realisation that it was *of course* a biased assessment. And she, clearly so eager to think ill of Mister De Gray, had layered it as evidence, without understanding the issues as separate.

It was whilst in this state of mind that a servant girl found her and proffered the tray with a trio of letters atop it, "For you, miss."

Catra plucked the parchments from the tray and dismissed the girl with a curt smile. A smile which faded as she noted the wax seal on the back of one- it matched the ring on Mister De Gray's hand.

She regarded that seal for a good thirty minutes, mind a strange cycle of shunted thoughts and meandering possibilities. If it were another attempt at a proposal, she would surely toss it into the hearth; but then again it offered the potential for answers. Or at least the opening of relevant questions.

She placed the letter carefully on the side, then opened the first - clearly from Scorpia Collins. The contents caused her to chuckle - a wedding invitation no less! Dated for two weeks hence! She glanced at the contents and noted it would be held down here, local to Perfuma.

The next missive was from, of all people, Netossa and Spinnerella: an invitation to tour the Northern Counties, following on from Scorpia's wedding. Catra chuckled at that - they had clearly had their invitation early or were planning on a visit to coincide with Scorpia's return. They explained that they had rooms planned with Scorpia and Perfuma at the rectory, then intended to travel to the other parts of the Northern Counties, to take in the countryside.

The idea of a break after the past few days sounded positively delightful. Catra decided to be impulsive and to go with the married pair - a chance to speak with the more experienced

women and also to gain some small distance from her enthusiastic, well meaning (yet annoying) family would be welcome.

Catra set the letters down and then regarded the more serious of the missives. She stared at the sealed paper and frowned, then steeled herself. She plucked the letters and moved to her room, then locked the door. With a huff, she planted herself at her vanity to read the words of the enigmatic *Mister De Gray* .

Ms Catra Moon,

Be not alarmed, madam, on receiving this letter, by the apprehension of its containing any repetition of those sentiments or renewal of those offers which were so disgusting to you. I write without any intention of paining you, or humbling myself, by dwelling on wishes which, for the happiness of both, cannot be too soon forgotten: and the effort which the formation and the perusal of this letter must occasion, should have been spared had not my character required it to be written and read. You must, therefore, pardon the freedom with which I demand your attention; your feelings, I know, will bestow it unwillingly, but I demand it of your justice.

Two offenses of a very different nature, and by no means of equal magnitude, you last night laid to my charge. I here hope to expunge the fog of uncertainty, with the intent of clearing my name in your mind and laying to rest uncertainty -f not for my own sake, for the sake of my family name, to ensure lascivious rumour and gossip are laid to rest. I had my understanding of you and your aversion and enmity towards gossip, but our recent altercation has made me question the validity of that. I do not wish to impugn your honour, but for the sake of disclosure, this is how I now feel. Regardless, I must confess for my soul demands satisfaction and the assuaging of its burdens and, I believe, you deserve the right of it. I hope that in being so forthright, you will

do me the courtesy of understanding my motivations and pressures.

First, to address your concerns around my company and companionship; I am currently to call upon Mister Beauregard Archer, of whom you feel so slighted and aggrieved by. It is my intent to understand the nature of his departure and his abandonment of a woman who cared so deeply for him. Such actions are out of character for a man who I have held in high regard and who has long held my secrets and vulnerabilities in confidence, with no ill will nor agenda.You may reassure your sister that I will drag the truth from the man and understand the rationale. If he has truly been a man of dishonour, a gentleman who would vex a woman thus, then rest assured your own wrath would be naught compared to my own. I will correspond with your sister once I understand the nature and full context of this ugly business. If it is an unhappy conclusion, I believe she deserves the right and truth of it, to understand such machinations and to be able to operate in the light without any slight on her own honour and reputation.

I will do this to minimise our own interactions as I do not wish to burden you unnecessarily, as you have made your opinions clear. I wished to make you aware and that is the end of that involvement in the matter.

The second item which we must discuss is your view of one Captain Hordak Wickham. I am loathe to indulge in gossip, so I will not - I will, however, give you the unembellished truth of things, as the man himself has, apparently, seen fit not to do so. For this I am unsure if I should be grateful, for he is at least adhering to a stipulation I made on the secrecy of our arrangement. And yet he still seeks to undermine and sow an element of discord which I find alarming and, ultimately, disappointing.

You stated true when you said he was a close family friend. A ward to my father, a bastion to us - a surrogate sibling. His own father was a cruel tyrant, one who demanded his sons adhere to a

nigh identical discourse and career, down to fashions and inflection. He was always following us about the estate, a constant companion and a loyal and true member of our family. Our father, my father, sought only to do best by him. And perhaps he felt in his offer he was reflecting such kindness.

The sad reality of the situation was that Hordak was not as focused on his future endeavours as he claimed. An ambitious youth, once severed from his father's influence and taken under my father's wing, he excelled. His ingenuity with systems and numbers, coupled with a nature that allowed him to identify flaws and breaks, allowed Captain, formerly Mister, Wickham to improve on several aspects of our estate's sustainability and success. My father saw in him great potential and, whilst he would not inherit title nor land, he could profit well from his mind. My father enjoyed his society and having supported him at school, proceeded to sponsor this adventure in academia.

However, my sibling and I noted a change - for so removed from the world of the Greyskull estates, there was opportunity to observe the reality of things. Mr Wickham's burgeoning ambitions, couple with an environment as permissive and lacking in oversight as a university college provided ample opportunity for a descent into amoral attitudes.

Here again I shall give you pain- to what degree you only can tell. But whatever may be the sentiments which Mr. Wickham has created, a suspicion of their nature shall not prevent me from unfolding his real character- it adds even another motive.

My father died five years ago, leaving things in a settled state. However, there was some dispute over the nature of his bequeathments in his Will. A sum of four hundred guineas was promised, annually, to Mr Hordak Wickham, on the proviso he would continue on his studies and investments into the science of engineering and industry. This he did, but ended up abandoning his studies to establish a venture of his own to produce goods and contraptions. This was, perhaps, one of several indications that his word was to be taken with extreme care and reflection.

We wished him sincere, perhaps, rather than believing it, but granted the continuation of the allowance with some minor reduction, after the abandonment of said studies. Our connections were tenuous, due to his attitudes and actions during university; his unyielding obsessions and desire for gambling on uncertain things ran a risk that we could not countenance easily. As far as I am aware, he lived a life of near isolation, save for his frequency of gambling dens and certain functions required for investors. I understand his ventures failed, due to his designs never ending up quite finished his pursuit of perfection ever escaping him.

Here is the point in my narrative where things become complex in the extreme, as a series of events unfolded. This will clarify the circumstances of my nature and situation.

At the time of my father's death I had come of age and was set to be presented to society. However, with the death of my father there was a pressing need from my wider social circle to secure a marriage or partnership - if not with me, then within the family.

However, there was a complication. I find this next part difficult to put to the page, for doing so damns me.

Three years ago my brother disappeared: he eloped with the daughter of our local blacksmith. I was still unwed for my choices were somewhat similar to your own. In fact they were identical - I would not settle for a man. And yet the tradition of the Northern Counties is somewhat repressed and traditional.

The scandal would have ruined the family and, at the time, I could not comprehend the motivations behind such recklessness. I feel I have a better grasp of such emotional motivators, but the point is that this sudden departure left me in a rather difficult predicament. I believe Adam intended to return, yet was waylaid - to think otherwise is not something I can countenance, for it would cast my brother as a coward. And yet I am forced to consider this may be the case; the alternative is that he and his wife are dead, lost at sea on a ship that I never been able to identify.

With my father dead and the male heir apparent absent, I was challenged immediately. Due to a twist of fortune, such a challenge was not made publically , for fear that the scandal of an elopement would jeapordise a match for myself. A great aunt, Lady Shadow d'Weaver, impressed upon me the necessity for a match and that it was the only way to ensure the sanctity of the estates. Her claims are based upon an apparent writ of law pertaining to our counties and the succession to the male line. I have not seen this writ, but have been advised I can once I have come to my addled senses, apparently. And so she and I sit in stalemate.

And, coincidentally, it was at this point that Mister Hordak Wickham returned to the scene. A gentleman, full of vim and vigour, most concerned for the depredations I was sure to weather. He espoused a grand deal he had made with Adam, to secure my future and the estate. Aware of my inclinations and the direction of my affections, he constructed a narrative of cohabitation and acceptance. I will not bore you with the details, for I surmise you are aware of the broad intimations and implications of it.

I found the approach of both my Aunt and Mister Wickham disconcerting, as they both occurred within scant days of one another. This, it seemed, was correct - I was advised by Mr Archer, an acquaintance first of Adam's, then of mine, of Mister Wickham's patronage by my own Aunt and their own business endeavours. Endeavours that, it appeared, involved the formal acquisition of the Greyskull estates.

I disagreed most vehemently and concocted a strategem. It was simple, but not without cost: I became Adam. This is, of course, a paltry summary of the how of that dramatic event, but I feel the deception has functioned. Due to the lack of callers in recent years and Adam's own somewhat reserved attitudes, I was able to insert myself into his identity. I was aided most admirably in this by Mr Archer and his family.

It is by these means I have secured the sanctity of my family estate against predation by family and secured the safety of my tenants. A gentleman who accuses me of dishonesty, yet has operated under the whim of one who seeks my family's own lands and property is not one from whom I will tolerate critique. And I cannot bear to consider you would view me in that light; so I reveal my murkiest and most awful of truths, for you to judge me against.

This, madam, is a faithful narrative of every event in which we have been concerned together; and if you do not absolutely reject it as false, you will, I hope, acquit me henceforth of cruelty towards Mr. Wickham. I know not in what manner, under what form of falsehood he has imposed on you; but his success is not perhaps to be wondered at, ignorant as you previously were of everything concerning either. Detection could not be in your power, and suspicion certainly not in your inclination.

You may possibly wonder why all this was not told you that day; but I was not then master enough of myself to know what could or ought to be revealed. I find that distance has aided in this catharsis and I now realise that I am lighter. I tell you this not to engender sympathy, but rather to present my hope that you keep this in confidence. I have no hold over whether you will, but I hope my forthright attitude convinces you of my nature and intent.

If your abhorrence of me should make my assertions valueless, then I cannot persuade you otherwise.

I wish you well and a prosperous future.

Yours,

Adora De Gray

Catra read through the letter three times, her eyes agog. She stood and paced her bedchamber, mind awhirl with the cascading impact of such revelations. On the one hand it seemed so unbelievable, some plot from one of Mermista's terrible novels; on the other it gave her insight and a sense of *power* .

This was knowledge that could break a reputation and she felt humbled knowing it.

Also, she felt incredibly chagrined and guilty.

If it was true, then she had been bedevilled by Hordak's slow words and suggestive ideas. Far easier to be angry at Adam or Adora or *whichever* . But what motive had the man?

And yet, on further reflection, Hordak had not really attempted to engender any real ill will - he had offered answers and only exhibited minor bitterness. Perhaps his offer had been genuine, if hamfisted and entirely inappropriate? Or perhaps he was the defeated villain?

Either way, this presented a number of avenues of thought and Catra felt overwhelmed.

The foremost of which was: *Mister De Gray is not a man!*

That particular idea set Catra to near hysteria as she sagged onto the bed. It was good news, save that she did not care for Mister De Gray, not one jot, not one iota not one smidgen!

Which was a damnable lie of course.

Of course, she now had to consider the next actions, her intentions after this revelation. For what could it portend? What was her end goal now that she was aware of some of the more pertinent issues? How did she feel in light of all of this?

She could certainly feel her heart beat with less strain at the thought of Mister De Gray; that it, in fact, swelled with something

akin to fondness (If it had ever *not* done so, she was never going to admit such a thing in polite company).

The name itself was a strange one - to continue with the *Mister De Gray* ? Or to begin with *Adora* ?

The name Adora felt wrong, though - not until they had spoken properly, face to face.

A hammering on her door jolted Catra from her musings, and Glimmer's voice echoed through the wood panelling, "It's my job to mope indoors! Why are you hiding?"

Catra started, then grabbed up the letters and stuffed them into the drawer of her dresser. She then carefully hid them under several stacks of paste jewelery and brushes, before she stood up and opened the door for her sister. Glimmer glared at her, then grinned. Catra shook her head and huffed, "Alright my sparkling sister, what do you want?"

"Did you get Scorpia's invite?"

"I believe the majority of Brightmoon, Thaymor and several of the surrounding counties got an invite." drawled Catra. Glimmer snorted, then twirled in the corridor.

"Well maybe, but still! A wedding! The excitement."

Catra's mind drifted to the letter while Glimmer prattled; to Adora's own confessions of loneliness and patience - not spelled out, but implied in her choices, her decisions on her partners for the future. It was all so much to consider. For the briefest moment, she considered confiding in Glimmer, but balked at the idea as soon as it came. It felt *wrong* to discuss such a thing, especially after Adora had bestowed this gift of trust; especially considering the absolute diatribe that Catra had flung out earlier in the week.

Of course, Adora (or *Mister De Gray)* could deny it, should it get out or if Catra decided to be malicious; they could claim the letter

was a forgery, that Catra had ill motives. But, honestly, what would Catra gain by exposing them?

Such games were idle passing thoughts. The reality was that Mister De Gray- *Adora* - had chosen to reveal a painful truth, to just ensure Catra did not think ill of them - to keep the record clean. It was an olive branch, perhaps; a hand extended, if not in friendship, then maybe in acceptance. What was she going to do with *that* ?

Chapter End Notes

I have a confession - I may need ONE MORE chapter. We shall see how we go.

And with this chapter I didn't want to keep everyone hanging with MORE PINING. Or confusion.

So, yeah, had to squeeze in Darcy's letter somewhere (Some of the text is a direct lift)

As ever, please let me know your thoughts, any feedback ORRRRR just whether you liked it!

The journey begins with a single step

Chapter Summary

Introspection from one of our heroines.

A wedding!

The first step back from the edge.

Chapter Notes

WOW! Whata delay - thank you for your patience! A few things have impacted my productivity, but hopefully I'm getting back up to speed now! Gotta finish this off! Mountain is done, G&F and this to do! So many live at ONCE!

And yes, this is the slow build towards reconciliation. I am extending the chapter count as I want it to not be rushed (I COULD rush it... finish it off. But I think it'd feel... rubbish)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra read through the letter three times, her eyes agog. She stood and paced her bedchamber, mind awhirl with the cascading impact of such revelations. On the one hand it seemed so unbelievable, some plot from one of Mermista's terrible novels; on the other it gave her insight and a sense of *power* .

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What was she going to do with *that* ?

Catra was many things. Impulsive. Self-righteous. Determined. Rash, some might posit.

Indecisive was not a trait she readily subscribed to. She had moments of paralysis, yes, but it was usually only in passing until a great motivator gripped her - much like her moments with Scorpia, or her decision to confront Mister Archer. Of course, with the benefit of new information and perspective, she was now curious as to whether she had perhaps, in some small way, maybe leapt to yet another conclusion.

As she sat in her room, dressed in robust skirts and petticoats for a morning walk, her mind swept to her various options. It had been two days since the arrival of the missive. And now they were preparing for the whirlwind of Scorpia Collins and Perfuma Lucas's wedding.

With a huff, she stood and made her way downstairs, to join the party of women ready to promenade through the lanes.

Their party - her siblings, joined by the wifely pair of Netossa and Spinnerella, meandered through the woods and roads, taking in the early afternoon sun and clean air. Whilst Entrapta and Frosta chased one another, Mermista and Glimmer walked a little behind, in quiet conversation. Glimmer had come somewhat back to herself these past few days and, whilst not in full form, was at least stoic and firm. Catra could see the fragility in her smile and the brittle-ness of her expressions, however.

For her own part, Catra found herself drawn to the elder couple. Netossa was the drier of the pair, by far, making sardonic commentary as they passed by farmers atop their wagons, or offering the merest tilt of her head to gentlemen riders as they cantered through the fields. Spinnerella was quieter, but astute and eventually drew the conversation to Catra's closed expression.

"Catra, dear, you appear befuddled. I do declare I have not observed such a scowling countenance since my sister's baby was born!" the woman gently chided. Catra harrumphed and adjusted her bonnet.

"A woman is not allowed to experience the doldrums?"

"Not while Spinny is about; she prefers an open countenance, to see whether a problem can be surmounted. Also, it's a sunny day and you are bringing a cloud upon it!" Netossa winked at her, but her expression softened, "If it is painful, we will not press. But we learned that to exchange and converse is the best passage to alleviating one of one's burdens. If nothing else, it expedites the situation!"

Spinnerella shot her wife a fond glance, "Ever a woman of action, dearest. Always a plan?"

"Always, my love," smiled Netossa, as she pulled Spinnerella closer, to clasp their hands together. She looked back to Catra, "If you wish to share, of course?"

The younger woman took a moment to consider and sighed, “Part of my consternation is not for me to share. I have come to be aware that things were not as I perceived and I have wrought and unfortunate wrong upon a potentially guitless party. I am also unsure of the motives of two others. This uncertainty is galling.”

“Ahh, well, you are a woman used to being aware, are you not?” chided Netossa, “Ever in control, aware of the facts, correct?”

“This is… not inaccurate,” Catra managed as she attempted to suppress a rueful grin. Spinnerella gently pushed her wife.

“Not the time for you japery, dearest. Now, Catra, whilst specifics may be beyond your willingness to divulge, might we assume this pertains to one Mister de Gray?”

Adora .

Catra swallowed and gave a curt nod, “Indeed. I accused them of actions most duplicitous and implied they were without honour; that their actions, especially with regard to their acquaintance with the perfidious and lacking approach of Mr Archer, were of dubious intent… but I fear I may not have the entire understanding of things. This is not a position I am accustomed to.”

The spouses nodded to each other and Spinnerella offered, in a gentle tone, “You are faced with vexatious thoughts. What is your

ending intent? Do you desire truth, absolution or something else?”

Catra flung her hands up and exhaled sharply. Mermista and Glimmer froze behind them, but Catra paid them no heed, “I don’t *know* ! I dislike the unknown, dislike *uncertainty* . I was certain! I was in the right! And now I am not and I hate it!”

“That sums things up adequately,” mused Netossa with a small smile. Glimmer chose that moment to harrumph.

“I do not understand your cause for alarm, Catra. At least your frustrating paramour was not one to whom you were attracted! And at least brought visitation before their absconding!”

Catra winced and then sagged, “You… yes Glimmer. You are correct. But, I fear I may have misjudged Mister de Gray before I was aware of the full facts. And...” the young woman clenched her fists and shook her head, “I maybe, perhaps… wish to make amends.”

Glimmer blinked in surprise. Mermista’s jaw was, not to put too fine a point on it, a tad unhinged. Netossa nodded slowly, “That is a noble and bold step. How would you accomplish this?”

“I have no idea. I am… I do not… Mister de Gray has quit the region. I… But I need to at least write to express an understanding of their situation.”

Catra did not express a desire to ascertain more on the situation surrounding Mr Archer - that was a particular rabbit hole that she had no desire to go down at this stage - either to offer false hope, or to show herself to be a villain; at least not until she was certain she had erred.

The walk continued on in silence, the women lost in thought, until they returned to the Moon household. In the foyer, Netossa drew Catra to one side.

"Ms Moon, I trust you have seriously considered our offer for travel to the north?"

Catra nodded slowly, "I have indeed. And, upon reflection, I think it may be for the best. Distance from this place, a change of scenery, will most likely be beneficial. Also, some time with my cousin would not be as objectionable as it would have been, prior."

"Now that they no longer pursue *you* you mean?" teased the elder woman. She chuckled at Catra's flushed expression, then ran a hand through her silvering hair, "To that end, perhaps a minor adjustment to the schedule would be beneficial? I believe that Ms Collins and Ms Lucas could benefit from some… privacy for a couple of days…?"

Catra looked at the woman blankly, "Oh? Why would that be? Are there concerns?"

Netossa regarded her blankly for a moment, then bit her lip and beckoned for Spinnerella over, “My love, Catra is concerned over the disposition of Ms Collins and Ms Lucas.”

“Oh?” Spinnerella frowned, “How so?”

“Netossa mentioned they may require some privacy,” explained Catra. The two wives exchanged a glance and then Spinnerella nodded very deliberately, her eyes on Catra.

“Indeed. Well. Yes. Time. Time is very important for… newly weds to explore all new things in a marriage. To understand one another better. To, um….”

Catra cocked her head to one side and frowned, then her eyes widened, “Oh!”

Spinnerella and Netossa nodded slowly, before Spinnerella gently added, “I think some time in the, um, more intense moments following a wedding are to be cherished by the new couple.”

Catra nodded rapidly, “Yes, yes indeed. I,” her voice had a slightly strangled cadence to it for a moment. And for the briefest moment she pondered why in all the world she had an image of blue eyes seared into her mind.

“You appear flustered, my dear,” offered Netossa with a frown, “Do you need to lie down?”

“No! No… so, you, um… what was your, um… suggestion?”

“Ah, yes. Well, a detour, perhaps. To allow the newly married couple a couple of days grace. I would suggest, perhaps, Elberon?” Netossa smiled gently.

“Elberon?” Catra frowned, “Whatever for?”

“It is a short divergence,” mused Spinnerella, “And it may afford you an opportunity to pursue that closing of your unresolved concerns.”

Catra mused for a moment then nodded, resolutely, “I think that, perhaps, that would be most agreeable.”

Scorpia and Perfuma’s wedding was a small affair; the Moon’s and some of the local families, along with the Lucas family and their friends. As expected, it was a very floral affair, Perfuma expending no small amount of effort in decorating the chapel in Brightmoon to the best of her abilities. Castaspella was, of course, a tearful and expressive event all of her own, held in excellent check by the doting hands of Ms Juliet, who never once left her side. The

common belief was that a second wedding was not far off, given the fondness of the expressions which both women exchanged. Indeed, Perfuma was most agreeable with the new woman in her mother's life and a clear bond had been formed there as well.

Catra had one duty to perform for the duration of the event and that was to calm a hyperventilating Ms Collins who had locked herself in the chapel's vestry prior to the event. The Reverend was having what could generously be termed "jitters", but Catra recognised as full on terror. It took the form of doubt and worry that Perfuma would not arrive. As well as Scorpia's own inadequacies (Stipulating that, after all, Catra had not been interested and that Perfuma, being a singular woman as well would likely not be interested)

It took judicious use of Catra's limited ability at diplomacy and the threat of summoning the other womenfolk to make use of a chapel pew to batter the door down. Eventually, Catra merely commented that should Scorpia not emerge and cease her internal flagellation, then Perfuma would most likely be upset and liable to shed a tear.

Catra had read books where a hero cast a door aside so hard it was wrenched from its hinges. And the way Scorpia practically catapulted her not-insubstantial-frame, clad in a black frock and broad brimmed hat, she felt it would be the closest real-world experience of such dramatics she could experience. The hinges certainly looked like they could go either way.

Truly, Scorpia was a vision in her backless frock, almost scandalous in its cut and bearing. Hardly something one would imagine a woman of the cloth wearing, after all.

It was with a mild smirk that Catra had stood at the side of the altar, whilst Scorpia remained rigid, like a statue, eyes glued to the doors to the chapel. Perfuma had entered, a vision in white and pink, flowers clear in a crown about her head, her train a carefully woven cape of petals and cloth. The expression on Scorpia's face had shifted from nervous fear to wonder and adoration. Catra had felt the smallest amount of jealousy at that; perhaps closer to envy, rather than the possessive green-eyed emotion.

In that moment, she had known she wanted something similar; she had always aspired to love, but never believed it to be real. Observing the gaze between Perfuma and Scorpia, she found its existence hard to deny. It reminded her of the looks shared by Mr Archer and Glimmer; a fact that had sent a mild quiver down her spine. She had expunged the feeling, not to dwell upon it during such a happy day. But she resolved to examine the evidence of her thoughts for the journey following on from the wedding.

It would have been a lie to say that Catra had not looked among the assembled crowd in the chapel. Or that she had hoped to catch a glimpse of a stiff, blue eyed countenance. Or perhaps even the more relaxed bearing and darker complexion of a certain other gentleman, to perhaps pursue a new line of questioning.

But neither were in attendance and her heart felt heavier for that fact; as if she held herself, in some way, responsible for denying the presence of two individuals for whom her emotional perspective was somewhat skewed and clouded.

It had been picturesque, the two women framed by a floral arch; the local reverend all gentle verses and proclamations of love in the eyes of the First Ones.

And then the pair had practically skipped from the chapel, to bound aboard their carriage and depart to the north, home.

Catra had watched them go, waving with the gathered crowd, a grin on her face that felt genuine and she realised she was truly happy for her cousin and her dear friend. It filled her soul with joy to see such unrestrained happiness; she envied it, yes, but she did not begrudge it. No, in fact she *aspired* towards it.

The shadows of the letter, the realisation of her error cast her thoughts in a new light - so eager to see the worst, even with the best of intentions, she had leapt to the worst conclusions, rather than explore them with the clarity and honesty that Mister de Gray had chided her about those many weeks prior in the comfort of Thaymor House. She had befuddled herself with preconceived notions, failed to ascertain the truth of things in their entirety. To do so with Mister de Gray indicated she may thus be wrong about other things.

And so, with the wedding concluded, Catra had set off on her own journey, aboard a cramped coach, opposite the cuddled forms of Netossa and Spinnerella. The rest of the family had elected to remain behind, curious but not overly concerned with Catra's decision to holiday with the pair.

After several hours their carriage had trundled into the yard of a coaching inn and Catra had jolted awake to find the once-clear horizon now marred by tall buildings; the sky not a clear blue but rather a musty grey.

The rooms had been rudimentary, but cosy and Catra had slept, for the first time in many years, in a room beyond the comfortable environs of the countryside. The sounds of the city were ever present and, she had to admit, mildly unnerving. But when she finally drifted off, it was into the sleep of the truly exhausted - a wedding, followed by travel, plagued with concerns had taxed her mind and she fell into dreamless slumber.

At breakfast in the Inn's common room, Netossa had suggested calling upon the University where the Archer parents taught - as they did not necessarily wish to call unannounced on the family (Though Glimmer had, apparently, called upon them and been turned away - a most disappointing result).

Catra, however, disagreed with this vehemently; "To ambush a gentleman in his place of employ, to accost him in the execution of his daily routine feels invasive and presumptuous; it still is a calling without an appointment and likely will alarm and irritate, which is not my intent. I feel I must show I am unafraid to meet on their terms - in their place of comfort. And to announce myself properly."

Spinnerella nodded with understanding, "And that does you credit. My wife is one for dynamism and meeting a challenge swiftly. Though this is sometimes not the *best* of ideas?" her glance was quick, her purple hair bobbing with the movement. Netossa smiled gamefully and shrugged.

“I prefer to treat on my terms, but this is Catra’s particular challenge so I will, of course, defer. But keep in mind, should you be turned away, ambush tactics are still an option!”

That made the younger woman smile, to know these two women were here to support her. She paused for a moment, to compose herself, then frowned slightly, “Thank you, both of you. But I must ask, you are acquainted with Mr Archer; have taken tea and been his guests; why are you assisting me in this enterprise?”

Netossa dabbed at her face with a napkin, then reached across to pour out a small measure of tea from the chipped pot the Innkeeper had provided, “It is simple; we were also young once. We navigated the pitfalls of young love and social disasters. We have grown to love the county and see the stumbling uncertainty of young love - and that is not to say we feel you ill prepared! More that… it is challenging. And mistakes are made; be they in how we engage with our peers, or misunderstand the intention set out by those we wish to know better. And, in this engagement, we aim to assist you. After all, we knew you several days longer than Mr Archer!”

“So I am aided by dint of being merely senior in acquaintance?”

Spinnerella laughed, her voice soft and warm, “As good a measure as any! Also, we have only been able to observe you. Should the gentleman not be amenable, well, we can withdraw and you will know you have at least made the attempt. Do you seek restitution? Satisfaction in answers? Or forgiveness? Or something else?”

Catra stared into those shrewd, kind eyes and sighed, “I seek understanding and… depending on the context, perhaps assistance. Perhaps a chance to reset the scales, should things be as I suspect.”

“And what do you suspect?”

Catra was many things - indecisive was not one of them. Nor was she stupid. Her mind made connections well. And several had come to fruition over the past few days - suspicions, tenuous links.

A blonde figure in an embrace with Mr Archer. And the revelation of a certain gentleman’s true nature.

Could these things be connected? And if so, what did that mean for the nature of Mr Archer and Mister de Gray’s true relationship?

Catra squared her shoulders and then stood, “I must away.”

“Do you wish for us to accompany you?”

Catra shook her head, “No. I feel I must make this attempt by myself, at least initially. I may call upon you should my reception be… less than warm.”

The two women nodded, then stood to embrace the younger girl. She flushed, happy and flustered at their support, then departed the Inn.

A handsome cab (a simple two-wheeled carriage) conveyed her across town to a comfortable, well maintained town house. Vines and ivy covered the brickwork, giving the edifice something of a gloriously unkempt look, far removed from the more austere buildings that flanked it. With tentative steps, Catra advanced up the stone steps and squared her shoulders once more. Then, chin held high, she knocked. Then blinked as she realised there was a bell. Somewhat flustered, she rang and heard the distant clang from within.

A moment later and the door opened to revea not the expected bewigged footman, but rather the slightly concerned features of *George* Archer. The man still sported his hair cropped short and his moustache well trimmed.

"Miss Moon! Well this is… most unexpected and…" he frowned, a little unsure. Catra winced and nodded shortly.

"Sir, I, um… I am perhaps not as welcome. I am unsure what your son has conveyed to you about our last correspondence but… could I please request a few moments of your time? And, also… Mr Beauregard Archer? Is he in residence?"

George looked at her, took in her straight form and her set expression. He noted the pinch around her eyes and the faint tremor about her shoulders. He was uncertain as to the disaster

that had befallen his son, save that it had resulted in a melancholy that was akin to a fog that appeared to follow his youngest about; a miasma of emotion. He had only mentioned the barest of details, alluding to some implication of poor behaviour on the side of the Moon women, though that had been unclear, with no blame ascribed - it was not in Beauregard's nature to cast aspersions or find fault.

No, instead the man had become withdraw, despondent. He had refused all callers. *All* callers. That had made for an awkward conversation a few days prior with a certain Mister de Gray - Beauregard had received the gentleman, but their conversation had been terse, uncertain and satisfying (Not that George had eavesdropped. That had been Lance.)

George drew a breath, "I think that would be wise. Perhaps you can shed some light on the situation. I will… see whether Beauregard is willing to join us. Please, come in."

Catra nodded shortly and swallowed. Then she stepped inside. She was many things. Impulsive. Self-righteous. Determined. Rash, some might posit.

But she was not indecisive. And she had committed to finding the truth of things.

Chapter End Notes

I was thinking of leaving the Catra / Beau convo to the end BUT... BUT well, that would feel almost too much.

Also, Catra is not stupid and I feel she WOULD make the connection. Otherwise she is as dense as Adora ;)

Let me know your thoughts!

Absolution and Understanding

Chapter Summary

A conversation is had and the scales fall from the eyes.

A visitation to a reverend, with a challenge ahead.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Decor had never been one of Catra's interests; it was something that happened around her and was usually the responsibility of other people. Granted, she was not above passing commentary should said decor lead towards *garish* or, as the Salineans said, *nouveau riche* . Whilst she might comment on a lack of taste, Catra would not cast aspersions on aspirational individuals who obtained success. After all, nobility did not equate to the ability to blend colour or styles effectively.

Which is a long way of saying that normally Catra would not be drawn on her surroundings beyond a cursory examination. However, given that her nerves were at a rather high tension level, she found herself unable to ignore the house and its contents.

The hall was done in a tasteful style - dark oak half-panels, with bright, white walls above the wood. A low table with a silver tray, for letters and missives. Paintings on either side, depicting historical sites across Etheria.

The hall itself had a flight of stairs at the end, with a corridor leading to the rear of the house - most likely servants quarters and the kitchens. Catra took it in and blinked. Overall, the house felt airy and light, but also cosy. She had expected a town house to be more cramped or hemmed in. But then again, with the outgoing and enthusiastic attitudes of the Archers exhibited thus

far, she could hardly imagine a home of theirs being anything less than welcoming.

"If you would care to follow me?" George's voice held a hint of tension in it, which drew Catra from her contemplation. She nodded, then paused to remove her bonnet and shawl. George smiled and stepped forward to take the items, "Go on in. Lance is currently engrossed. We gave Wilson the afternoon off, thought we were in for a quiet one!"

"Oh, well, if I am…" Catra winced and took a breath, "I promise I will not impose."

"Ms Moon, hush," chided George, "I think it will do us all the world of good to clear the air. Blow open the emotional shutters, as Lance is want to say. Do not tell him I am dabbling in aphorism and metaphor, or I will never hear the end of it!"

In spite of the circumstance, Catra could not prevent the small curve of her lips as she smiled softly, "I will breathe not a word. Thank you, Mr Archer."

As George disappeared, likely to the cloakroom with her accoutrements, Catra took a steadying moment to compose herself, then pushed the door open into what she believed to be the house's drawing room. Whilst she was expecting a room for entertaining; perhaps a couch or two, maybe a table for tea, she was not expecting the sheer scale.

The room was imposing but in an almost aggressively cosy way; each wall was a bookshelf, floor to ceiling, with gaps for large, bay windows that overlooked the street beyond. High ceilings drew her eyes up, to reveal that the room had a mezzanine with *more* bookshelves. Another door to her left, under the mezzanine, led to another corridor, whilst a fireplace sat at the far end, flanked by three large settees in a "U" shape. Catra had a momentary image in her mind of the entirety of the Archer family, crowded upon these seats, revelling in their boisterous closeness. It was an image not so far removed from her own experiences.

A figure sat on the edge of one of the settees, a large book laid out on the low table before him. As he glanced up his glasses shone in the firelight. Catra still caught the momentary frown of confusion however and blushed faintly in embarrassment. She managed a short curtsey, uncomfortable with the formality, "Mr Archer. Your, um, husband directed me here. I trust I am not intruding?"

Lance's expression cleared, though the crinkles at the side of his eyes indicated a slightly pensive air, "Ms Moon, no need to apologise. I trust George is taking care of the niceties? That's normally my role, but the dear has indulged me on my dive down the proverbial rabbit hole. Tell me, have you read the philosophies of Madame Razz?"

Catra's brow furrowed, slightly taken off kilter by the line of questioning, "I confess I have not. I understand she was or… is… a rather eccentric author?"

"Ah! Author, natural philosopher, part time baker! A bit of a recluse, but she has graced the odd gathering we hold here now and then. Her almanacs are read across town and, well, she is a font of gossip! So, to what do we owe the pleasure? It does feel an age since we, well… since we saw any of your family. Your parents, they are well?"

"They continue fine, sir. I confess, they are not aware of my calling upon you. It is a tricky business."

Lance's eyes narrowed slightly. Whilst the softer of the pair, Catra had the impression he was perhaps the more formidable, despite his lack of military training, compared to his more reserved partner. Lance exhaled slowly, "I see."

"Perhaps sir. I… I hope I can beg an indulgence of your son's time to ascertain certain truths. I fear a mistake has been made and I wish to work towards mending that which might have been broken."

At that Lance relaxed somewhat. He led Catra to the settees and gestured for her to sit, “Most cryptic, Ms Moon. But I will not press things until Beauregard… ah, here we are.”

Catra flinched and turned, slowly, in her seat as George entered, followed by Beauregard Archer. The younger man looked tired, a fact attested to by the sallowness of his skin, now devoid of luster. His dark complexion was paler, with the bags under his eyes further confirmation of his doldrums. Catra’s heart ached for a moment as another small moment of confirmation settled in - no cad, no rake, would be so broken by the absence of a fling. One such as that would surely have moved to the next card game, the next buxom wench willing to indulge a man’s fancy. She fidgeted for a moment and managed a short nod as Beauregard frowned at her.

The young man sighed and adjusted his cravat - despite his rather unhealthy appearance, he was still attired well; a brocade, long-tailed waistcoat that buttoned to the middle of his torso, with a dress shirt beneath and a pastel-coloured cravat at his throat.

George made his way to sit next to Lance and managed a wan smile, “The maid will be in with tea shortly. Glad we had the sense to keep someone on duty. I have tendency to burn water if I’m not careful.”

“Oh hush, you. You merely singe it,” chuckled Lance, “Now, get him in a set of tools and this man can carve you a statue like no other!”

George huffed and waved a hand, then gestured to Beauregard, “Won’t you greet our guest?”

Mr Archer-the-younger gave a stiff bow from the door, “Ms Moon.”

Catra rose and offered a curtsey, which drew a surprised look from the young man, “Mr Archer. My sister… she, um… sends her regards. Or she would. If, uh, she knew I was here.”

Beauregard twitched, “Madame, I am a man of honour, patience and forgiveness, but you try it with such games!”

“Beauregard!” George sounded shocked. Lance just frowned and laid a hand on his husband’s arm, which calmed the other fellow enough for him to follow up with an, “What is… that is uncalled for.”

Beauregard looked at Catra and arched an eyebrow, “Is it?”

Ms Moon smoothed her hands down her dress then hugged herself and took a breath, “Mr Archer, on the evening we came to call, did you or did you not entertain a young woman in your chambers?”

Beauregard rocked backwards and blinked, “I… you…”

“Beauregard…” Lance’s voice was confused. George on the other hand coughed.

“Beauregard Archer! What… what… how?”

Catra swallowed, “I am trying to understand the right of things, Mr Archer.”

“You made it clear that you disapproved of… of things. And *people* ,” Beauregard managed. Catra nodded.

“So you did entertain a woman.”

Beauregard narrowed his eyes, but he didn’t seem angry. In fact his air was now defensive. But Catra could tell it was not about *him* . She swallowed as he spoke, “I did not *entertain* a woman, if that is your question. I comforted a guest.”

“Not a servant?”

“No, but you *know* that. Your disapproval of the circumstance was made abundantly clear, along with the disapproval of your sister.”

“I imagine my sister would disapprove of you carrying on with another woman whilst courting her, yes!” Catra winced as her mind rattled around the edges of an idea that had percolated over the past few days, one she had not *quite* landed upon. But there it was, “Who was she?”

“Your attitude and disapproval of my friend was writ clear, Ms Moon, why are you even asking? Why bother to darken my door, to further spit in the face of my family and my friends? You have already made clear your famiy’s disapproval and the pointlessness of my…”

“Was it Adora?”

Beauregard blinked again and his head cocked. Catra hunched slightly but did not meet his gaze. He paused and rubbed his hands together, then frowned once more, “E...excuse me?”

“Was it Adora?”

“You… wait, you know it was Adora.”

“Do I?” Catra felt unmoored for a moment as she looked up and took in Beauregard’s own confused expression.

“Well…. Yes. You said as much - that… that you disapproved of mingling with *such people* .”

The pair stared at one another as the reality of mutual misunderstanding slid together.

“You thought I meant that she was…”

“You meant a dalliance with a….”

Catra ran a hand through her hair and coughed a laugh out. Beauregard snorted and shook his head, then blew out a breath and planted his fists on his hips. George and Lance looked between them, heads ticking back and forth as if they were at a badminton game. George coughed.

“Would somebody please enlighten the aged parents?”

Catra inhaled and winced, “Sirs, I fear I have made a most… terrible mistake. Mr Archer…. Beauregard?” she beckoned to him, “I… I can only say that I acted in defence of my sister. That I believed you to be a cad, a bounder and a rake, who would see my sister as a conquest and then leave her to a life of loneliness and hopelessness whilst you carried on your dalliances. But I must know… are you and… Adora….?”

Beauregard had approached the settee’s but nearly tripped as Catra asked that last piece. He stared at her, then burst out laughing. George and Lance, too, erupted into chuckles. Lance waved a hand.

“Oh my dear, that is… furthest from the realms of potential possibilities.”

Beauregard waved a hand, then gestured for Catra to sit, before he too settled. He drew a breath, then leaned forwards, elbows on knees, 2You truly were not aware?”

“No. I believed you and… well, *Adam* … to both be gentlemen of the worst order. Charming but with ill intent. So, please,” she winced, “Can you.. Forgive my impetuosity?”

Beauregard sighed, “I think it is… a difficult thing. To me, you have revealed an awareness of my friend’s nature and indicated a desire to use it negatively, to harm them and I. And now here you are… apologising for it? I fail to see the transition, though I feel that was not your original intent? You truly believe it was a maid?”

“Truly. And my awareness of Adam… *Adora’s* situation only just came to light. After she… revealed it to me. By proposing. As Adam.”

Beauregard groaned and massaged his temples, “This should not come as a surprise. It really should not. I am glad she finally took my advice, but I can imagine it was executed in the most… hamfisted of ways?”

"In… yes. Yes it was."

Beauregard gave a rueful chuckle whilst George and Lance nodded. It was George who continued the questioning, "Pray tell, what… awareness do you have? Beyond the basics?"

"I am aware of the arrangement proposed by Captain Hordak? And also the unfortunate circumstances around the real Adam's departure."

"Ah, so the majority, yes," nodded George. Beauregard shook his head sadly.

"So, what do you intend to do with this knowledge, Ms Moon?"

Catra paused as a maid entered and set down a tray of tea. The quartet waited until it was served, then looked back to the brunette as she raised her cup and saucer, hands trembling only slightly. She stared into the dark liquid and sighed, "I wish to find Adora and… talk. But I also wish to make amends here. Hence the reason for my visit. I wished to ascertain your true motivations for that evening - the truth of it, to confirm that either this situation with Adora was separate from you as a villain…" Beauregard gasped and raised a hand to his chest. Catra arched an eyebrow in return, "Or to establish your true nature. I have now achieved this and I realise I am beginning to sound like *Entrapta* ."

She sighed and shook her head, then sipped at the tea. Gently, she placed it back down on the table top and looked at Mr Archer with a thoughtful expression. He returned it with equal care, "So, my innocence no firmly established in your mind, your curiosity sated and your apparent decision that my actions were not *cruel* or *unusual* , I say again, what is your intention?"

"As I said to your father, I intend to mend fences. And to start with - do you love my sister?"

"Wholeheartedly," replied Beauregard without hesitation. He frowned, "Does she, however, hold that opinion I inferred - her disapproval of those who live under difficult circumstances?"

“She attended the wedding of Scorpia Collings and Perfuma Lucas and has been practically fawning of Mrs Lucas moving her lodger into the main house. She does not disapprove of *alternative* ways of living in the least.” Catra’s expression was bordering on a smirk at this stage. She looked to the parents in the room, “Sirs, might I trouble you for a quill and parchment?”

Lance nodded, then stood and moved to one of the desks at the side of the room. He returned and placed an inkwell, quill and stack of paper before Catra. She smiled at him, then bent forwards to quickly jot down a note. She smiled, then folded the paper carefully and looked at the men once more. Beauregard frowned, “And that is…?”

“It is in need of a seal. Might I trouble you for some wax?” Once more, a pot of sealing wax was offered, along with a candle. Catra melted a blob to seal the letter, then fished out a hairpin from her tresses, which she pressed into the wax itself trapping it within. She then handed the letter to Beauregard, “My advice, sir, is to make haste to Brightmoon House, ask for Miss Glimmer Moon, then present her with this letter. And then ask my father and mother for permission to marry her forthwith.”

Beauregard leaned back in shock, “I...what?”

“I have explained what I can in the missive - notably, that you are a man of honour merely acquiescing to the impetuous and ill-thought-out whims of an overprotective sister. I have *not* mentioned Adora, if that is of concern. That is… for Adora to decide. Which brings me to a request, which I know I am in no way worthy of asking.”

Beauregard smiled faintly, “Go ahead, Ms Moon.”

“Where… where is she?”

The three men shared a glance and shook their heads. Beauregard managed a shrug, “We don’t know. After I left

Thaymor House I… I had expected Adam… *Adora* to at least visit on their return from the north."

"Adora said she would call on you, to find out the reasoning as to why you had… left," Catra winced at that, "Perhaps… did she come by at all?"

Again they shook their heads, "No. She may have gone to her club, Adam's club rather…"

"How do they not *know* ?" Catra shook her head, "Surely there are… communal areas…?"

"Did you notice?" chided Lance and Catra blushed.

"We never *changed* near each other!"

"And neither does Adora, when attending fencing or what-not. A simple matter of most individuals not seeing what they do not expect to see anyway. The very idea that a woman would attend a gentleman's club is so preposterous…" the husbands chuckled, "Though the world is changing, thankfully."

Catra hung her head and winced, "So… she is gone?"

Beauregard shrugged, "Perhaps back north. Or… well, you could correspond with her estate. A message may get through. Or… you could visit?" he leaned forward as he spoke and Catra flushed.

"That would be… most forward, surely?"

"Didn't stop you and Ms Glimmer making a call upon us, now, did it?" chuckled Beauregard. He shook his head, "For whatever it is worth, I hold you in no fault for my circumstance, Ms Moon. If anything, I hold you in awe for the ferocity of devotion you show your family.nI hope to prove worthy of the faith you show. I would, however, ask that perhaps you act in a plainer manner when levelling accusations?"

Catra scoffed, then rolled her eyes, "Duly noted, Mr Archer. So, um… now that is sorted…?"

George huffed and leaned back on the settee, "Finish your tea, Ms Moon. Take a moment. You are among *friends* here. No rush, fear not. And perhaps we can take a moment to just catch up? You mentioned Ms Collins and Ms Lucas had *wed…?"*

The next hour passed eventfully - conversations and news missed, now brought up to speed. Catra relaxed, once more at ease, although her guilt still weighed upon her - perhaps it would not be truly salved until she had met with Glimmer, to explain herself fully. And to accept whatever consequences might be forthcoming.

She bade the family farewell and could not hide the smile as she saw Beauregard dash off with a yell of "I must find my riding britches, post haste!" - she had a feeling the man would ride through the night.

She met up with Netossa and Spinnerella at the inn and found them ready to travel, with a coach standing by. The pair saw her relaxed expression and smiled knowingly. Netossa nodded and chuckled, "I take it things are smoothed over?"

"Well, I may have just guaranteed another wedding in the more immediate future. Provided Glimmer does not torture the poor man overmuch. It is entirely my fault, of course so I imagine I am just prolonging my own execution…"

Spinnerella smiled as the pair led Catra out to the coach. Their sparse belongings had already been loaded, "She is your sister. Whatever transgressions will surely be forgiven now you have made amends?"

"You do not know Glimmer. She holds *grudges* ."

"Well, after the wedding night she may be more forgiving," sing songed Netossa. Catra cringed and tried to bury herself in her shawl.

“Please, please be quiet.”

The carriage rattled away, with Netossa’s laughter mingling with the jangle of harness and rumble of wheels on cobbles.

The journey to the Northern counties took a little over a full day - with a three hour stop over at a coaching inn for food and to change the horses (And rest the coachmen) Catra, for her part, dozed in the corner of the inn’s common room, having found it difficult to settle properly in the rocking carriage. The road quality had dipped somewhat as they left the southern counties, with roads becoming rockier and little more than cart-tracks as they moved from the farmlands and forests into more moorland environments. The place had a desolate beauty about it that could not be denied - grass and gentle rolling hills, interspersed with the odd valley filled with trees that flanked the myriad narrow waterways.

The trio eventually roused themselves as the carriage pulled into the gravel driveway of the small vicarage in Huntsford. Catra groaned as she stepped from the vehicle, only to be swept up into an embrace by an overenthusiastic Mrs Scorpia Collins, “AHHH! My Cat of the Wilds has graced our humble abode! Perfuma, dearest! Look who it is!”

“I can see that, my love. Perhaps she would like to be afforded the opportunity to breathe? It does help balance one’s humours, of course.”

“Ah, an excellent point! And Mrs and Mrs Telae!” Scorpia released Catra who sagged with a wheeze. The young woman shot Perfuma a grateful smile, then approached the blonde for a genteel hug.

“How does parish life feel, Mrs Collins?”

“I have been here but a scant few days and, well, I am already *well versed* in the gossip and scandal of the area. It might fascinate you to know that a Mister Roderick has left his beehives too close to the garden wall adjoining his property to that of Mister Berwick,” perfuma arched an eyebrow in mock-conspiratorial tones, as she threaded her arm through Catra’s, “And Mrs Proust and Mrs Chantry are the best of friends, save when one takes tea alone with *either* in which case neither has a good word to say about the other. It must be love, I swear,” and then she tsked with a grin.

Catra laughed and shook her head as Perfuma led her into the vicarage, “And married life?”

Perfuma’s expression softened, “I hope it remains as it is now. Scorpia tends her garden well, but we now plan to do so together. She keeps bees, you know? Fascinating *and* exciting,” Perfuma paused in the hall and turned to Catra. She slid her hands down to clasp the shorter woman’s own and smiled softly, “Is it wicked of me to say I am glad you denied Scorpia?”

Catra shook her head, “No. It was not my partnership to make. I knew that and, really… I think Scorpia did too. You seem so happy, Perfuma, how could I see that as wicked in any way?”

“Well, I hope the universe sees fit to reward you for such a selfless act,” grinned the blonde.

“So, it has been a joy since the wedding?”

Perfuma moved to lead her into the small drawing room, while Scorpia babbled in the background about *fitted shelving* or something. The new Mrs Collins frowned as she gestured for Catra to sit, then reached over to pour the tea, “Not… entirely. I had to present myself to Scorpia’s benefactor. Like a prized horse.”

“This would be…”

“Lady Shadow d’Weaver. Yes. And, I am afraid Scorpia made mention of *your* visit in that and we have *all* been requested for a visit upon the morrow.”

“Oh. Wondrous,” Catra pursed her lips and sighed, “Perchance you have anything stronger than tea to hand?”

Perfuma giggled and shook her head, “A problem for later. We will merely be expected to listen, nod, ask questions for a half hour, then be dismissed.”

Catra studied her friend, “And you think it will be as simple as that?”

“As simple as what?” Scorpia asked as she bustled into the room, Netossa and Spinnerella in tow. Perfuma smiled indulgently.

“I was just explaining to Catra that there is an expected appointment tomorrow.”

“Oh. Yes. That. With my patron,” Reverend Collins huffed and adjusted herself in her armchair and smiled thankfully as Perfuma handed her a cup of tea, “Thank you, my love. So, um, yes, I made a promise to her Ladyship that I would, well, bring you along and introduce you. She is, well, fascinated…” the word came out slightly strangled. Perfuma picked up immediately.

“I think you mean shocked, dearest.”

“Well, she is an older woman from a more traditional time and, well… she was very accommodating of…”

“She spent the entire time referring to me as your *lodger* , dearest,” Perfuma smiled sweetly at Scorpia, who sighed.

“And did I not reiterate that we were more than that?” Perfuma nodded slowly and leaned over the grasp Scorpia’s hand.

“You did indeed. It is so perplexing, considering the oddity of her… acquaintance.”

Catra raised an eyebrow, "Oh? This Lady sounds positively *delightful* the more I hear about her. And I have heard a fair bit. Who is this acquaintance?"

"Her… well, I believe they are related in *some* capacity. A ward, or somesuch," mused Scorpia, "Her ladyship is a patron to many, very generous and… well," even the reverend sounded doubtful about things, but she pressed on, "But she is set in her ways. But this ward is… I believe I saw them at the ball at Ms Lucas', that first time I visited?"

Catra furrowed her brow, "Blonde, perhaps?"

"Not thinking of *someone* else, are we?" chided Netossa, but Catra waved a hand dismissively as she adjusted herself and her dress. She smoothed the cloth down, then reached for her tea.

"No, not… them. No, someone I saw talking to… *Adam* , briefly. I know that Mister De Gray is affiliated with Lady d'Weaver in… some capacity? And I believe they may have been talking to this acquaintance."

Scorpia clapped her hands together and smiled broadly,, "WELL! Yes, that will be… a thing we will certainly raise. I would advise we not mention Mister de Gray however? It is something of a strange topic and… yes, well…"

Catra chuckled, "You did rather… overstep when you introduced yourself to them."

"What a rude gentleman he was!" exclaimed Scorpia. Catra shook her head.

"There are… protocols, Scorpia. You know this. And, well… as you mentioned, Lady d'Weaver does not like to talk on Mister de Gray; perhaps the inverse is true as well?"

Scorpia deflated and nodded as Perfuma patter her wife's hand. The Reverend nodded slowly, then gestured about, "You are

correct, of course. I am… I think getting better at it? But, well…. It's a *lot* ."

Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged a glance and sighed, "So, we will definitely have to fortify ourselves before meeting the dragon then?"

That drew a tinkling laugh from Perfuma, who rose smoothly and smiled at the group, "I believe this calls for a decent bottle? We did receive one from her Ladyship. Or rather, from her ward. I think the words were 'she won't notice it's gone anyway, and well done'. I will fetch some glasses."

"But dear it's… not even four!"

Catra snickered, "Well, do you see any gentleman trying to kick us out of the smoking room? It's your house, Scorpia… your rules?"

The Reverend looked about then grinned, "Well, it's hardly a sin and I'd be a poor host if I did *not* entertain…"

A few hours later, after a simple meal of cold meats and fresh bread, along with another helping of wine, Catra settled herself into bed; the rectory was quite substantial, it had to be said, with four bedrooms. There was a servants accommodation, but as yet that was vacant - Scorpia had insisted she was fit to look after her own affairs, as servant of God.

Perfuma, of course, disagreed, noting that whilst the reverend was good with a hot iron to press her shirts and linens, she was slightly lacking in the dusting and general housekeeping department. That had led to a round of cackling and teasing from the gathered women.

It was a different sort of social engagement, Catra found. With her sisters they had a practiced informality and glee, but their ages meant they were often somewhat too focused on either marriage or, in the case of Frosta, more childish pursuits.

In society, at balls, conversation was often too formal, too staid, to really express *anything* beyond platitudes or thinly veiled gossip.

But here, with the women in this house, it was oddly *freer* . That four were married, to one another no less, seemed to add to that. As if there was some unspoken rule of *no secrets needed* ; they had crossed a supposed societal boundary and thus were freed of chains of propriety. Or the assumed chains, at least. Their conversations had hardly been scandalous, just more open, more teasing.

It was liberating.

A similar event had occurred with the Archers - free of secrets and assumptions, her preconceptions of the situation shed, Catra had felt able to engage on a level she had not felt prior.

Now she wished she had been able to be as open with Adam. With *Adora* . Now she saw that reserved attitude for what it was - a shield, a barrier to letting anyone in. And yet Adora had come so close, had *tried* . How scared must the woman have been, yet also so hopeful.

Catra sighed as she tossed and turned in the bed. She glared up at the ceiling.

She would find Adora and at the very least set some things straight - tell the woman that she did not feel affronted by her; that she had resolved the situation with Mister Archer and…

And?

Catra blinked and blew out a breath.

"First things first. Lady d'Weaver. And then, provided I survive that particular encounter… we can ascertain what the devil is going on with *Mister de Gray* . Maybe."

Catra was many things. Indecisive was not one of them. She knew exactly what she aimed to accomplish with *Mister* de Gray. She just had yet to admit it to herself.

Yet.

Chapter End Notes

SOME catharsis - we're getting there. But WHERE IS ADORA?!

Is she near a convenient body of water? because there's a scene we are NOT missing out on next... ;)

A day in the sunshine

Chapter Summary

An audience with the Weaver.

A trip to a stately home.

And a wild blonde emerges.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The morning brought with it a pleasant cast to the skies, with nary a cloud to be seen. This was certainly a boon, as Reverend Collins' own carriage was more an open-topped cart. Catra Moon eyed their intended conveyance with barely restrained surprise.

"I thought you had a carriage, Scorpia?"

The Reverend looked mildly embarrassed and heaved a weary sigh, "I am permitted to make use of her ladyship's carriage for matters concerning the Parish. It would not do to be seen as a pauper when she is my avowed patron, after all."

"Oh heaven for-fend," came from Netossa, her expression carefully schooled, "But when calling upon her, you make use of your own?"

"Well, yes. And it's a reminder of my own humility, a valuable thing for a Reverend to maintain."

"Save when visiting parishioners?" ventured Spinnerella. Scorpia winced and nodded.

"I will grant it does not always look… the best. But it does mean I am able to make my rounds more quickly *and* convey items to the needy! It is a very grand and large carriage after all."

The three visitors exchanged glances, but just nodded. Perfuma looked faintly resigned and offered her guests a weak smile. It was clear that *her ladyship* wished for her Reverend to understand they worked for *her*. As Scorpia fussed and helped the other two into the cart, Perfuma held back with Catra and sighed, "Her ladyship is certainly a woman of solid opinions. I say this now, Catra, do not be perturbed by her. I found her to be abrupt, although," the blonde sighed once more and shook her head, "There is a terrible sadness there. And I fear it has become something ugly. But far be it from me to gossip."

"As if you did anything else," chided Catra with a very unlady-like smirk, "Why, the happenings of Brightmoon are in disarray without you to marshal the rumour mill!"

"Oh stop," Perfuma swatted at Catra and tutted, but then offered a grin of her own, "We take tea with her ladyship, or apparently we will do so, weekly. She seems to believe Scorpia is a font of useful information and that she keeps her abreast of the ghoulish goings on of her tenants."

Catra shot her host a shocked looked, "What? And Scorpia…?"

"Oh no. Scorpia worked it out a while back. She values Lady d'Weaver's patronage *but* she does not fling her parishioners under the cart, as it were. When I was introduced well, let's just say I found out that my wife is a rather skillful storyteller!"

"She… lied?" the revelation practically knocked Catra on her rear. Perfuma giggled in response.

"Oh not at all. She just doesn't *tell* her anything. You have heard Scorpia speak in general, you know. It's rather amusing watching a member of the senior gentry glaze over after fifteen minutes of minutiae. And all of it is true, except for the parts Scorpia omits. That she carefully classifies under *confession* and thus feels no obligation to divulge."

"Oh?"

“Yes. Hardships, things that would harm reputations that are of no real consequence.”

Catra nodded slowly, then stepped into the cart. She regarded her cousin, the reverend, carefully, with more respect. Not just a befrocked social climber; no, someone stalwart who seemed to truly stand for their people. She had seen her as some patronised grabber, with nary a sense in her head. But behind that beaming facade worked a determined and, ultimately, *kind* heart.

Their journey was only an hour and the landscape shifted from gentle fields to manicured lawns. They turned down a boulevard of tall, thin trees, as the cart rattled over gravel. As they neared the mansion, Catra picked out flower beds amidst slightly dishevelled topiary. The beds themselves looked barren, until she realised that the plants were all rather noxious looking things - black flowers and stems; thorns; purple blossoms and sickly looking vines.

“She certainly has… a defined taste,” muttered Catra. Spinnerealla nodded.

“Not quite as welcoming as your home, Perfuma dear.”

Mrs Collins nodded with her lips pursed, “On visiting I did offer my assistance. I was rather pointedly turned down. In a rather… abrupt manner.”

Scorpia winced from the drivers bench, “Dearest, we both know she is not well versed… but cannot *show* that she is not well versed.”

“Poppycock,” announced Perfuma with an arched eyebrow. Scorpia sighed and rolled her eyes, but smiled.

“Yes dearest. But we must endure such trials and tribulations. For the moment.”

The cart pulled up in front of the home - a grand thing of granite pillars and tall, narrow windows. It was done in a style not

dissimilar to some of the architecture of the continent, particularly the Eastern countries, who favoured tall towers and minarets. Grey was the preferred colour, rather than the sandstone of around Brightmoon. The place *looked* cold.

A gaunt servant opened the large double doors and announced them with a small grimace, especially when he mentioned *Mrs and Mrs Telae.* Catra merely gave him a simpering smile that dripped with insincerity and then followed the other women into a drawing room that was apparently themed after drab olive green. The drapes, the walls, the cushions - all the same, uniform colour.

Two individuals waited for them and Catra recognised one of them immediately. She had felt a flutter in her chest at the sight of blonde hair, but it sank when the figure turned from the window.

The last time she had seen the individual in question, they had been in a rather risque ballgown. Now, however, they wore a waistcoat, high-waisted trousers and boots. Boots which still had rather a good heel on them as well. Amber eyes regarded her curiously for a moment, before a strangely calculating grin split the elfin features. Androgynous to the extreme, Catra felt both puzzled and threatened at once.

"Ah. Reverend. And guests," the second figure, still seated, had a distinctive voice - it was deep, almost a purr, but with bite. The woman sat, wrapped in crimson shawls, with a black veil over her face. Her eyes seemed white beneath it, staring out intently.

"Your ladyship, may I present the Telae's and my cousin, Catra Moon, of Brightmoon."

Lady d'Weaver's eyes locked onto the new trio and she huffed, "Ah, I see you have seen fit to demonstrate true grandeur to those less fortunate. Take a seat. Tea will be served shortly."

The androgynous figure hummed and practically skipped over to a small chair that sat next to her ladyship's. They flopped down into it and crossed their legs, the very image of a provocative dandy,

"Ohhhh, I think I know you all. I do remember seeing you at that wonderful little party that Perfuma dearest put on. Such a quaint little gathering. Not at all like those in Elberon."

"Your tawdry dalliances are of no concern to polite company, Dee," scolded lady d'Weaver. She shifted in her chair, then glanced at the women, "But do introduce yourselves properly. You, sisters? I see no familial resemblance."

Netossa flushed slightly, but Spinnerella's hand came down gently on her wife's. The fuller woman leaned forwards and smiled, "We are sisters after a fashion. But only in the bonds of universal sisterhood. In truth, we are married."

"As is proper for women of your age and, I presume, station. Are your husbands engaged on business elsewhere?"

Netossa looked fit to bursting. Perfuma had a serene expression on her face and Scorpia looked mildly ill. Catra watched, fascinated, as Spinnerella smiled gently and raised Netossa's hand, clenched in her own.

"Allow me to clarify further, your ladyship, we are married… to one another. In the sight of Mara. And, may I say, your generosity in welcoming us in does you credit and truly speaks to the magnanimity that Reverend Collins has frequently mentioned. I will be ever so happy to convey these sentiments to our esteemed friends in the south, as well as our clients in Elberon."

Catra watched as Lady d'Weaver seemed to puff up, as if to erupt. Then the woman stilled and seemed to squint at the women.

"Telae. As in the *tailor* ?"

Netossa preened, "The very same, your ladyship."

Dee took a turn to lean forwards, their eyes agleam with wonder, "Oh my goodness. Your designs last season were to *die* for. I heard that Lady Winterson looked divine at her presentation. It caused quite the stir."

“Yes, I was rather proud of that one. Of course, I am always looking for clients who appreciated the work *and* are of an understanding mind. We have had to deny service to several who were, quite simply, ungentlemanly and unrefined in their commentary about our union,” opined Spinnerella. Her smile was still soft, friendly, but Catra caught the glint of steel there.

And she had always considered Netossa to be the scarier of the pair. It turned out that Spinnerella knew how to wield influence and reputation like a rapier.

Lady d’Weaver coughed and straightened her shawls, “That sounds positively dreadful. I will admit some difficulty adapting to the changing times; I am a firm believer in *tradition* , but I can see how those without titles and a need to preserve a lineage are able to indulge in such things. Of course, I do not visit the South much these days, so such things do tend to pass me by.”

Spinnerella nodded and Lady d’Weaver glanced at Dee, who jumped in, “I would simply *love* to make an appointment for when I am next in town.”

“It would be a distinct pleasure…?” Spinnerella let the question hang and Dee grinned widely.

“Just Dee. I am a ward of her ladyship. I may have cause to enquire about a wedding dress, as well. Or suit. Depends on how it all goes, I suppose.”

Catra stiffened and then realised Dee had been watching *her* . The smile on the androgynous individual’s face flicked to one of mild triumph, but settled back. Lady d’Weaver seemed not to notice, but did turn to look at Catra.

“And you, girl. Are you a handywoman as well? Some form of *auteur* perhaps?”

“No such thing, your ladyship. I am family to Reverend Collins, her cousin in fact…”

“Ah. One of the Moon brood, eh? Of the Brightmoon Moons? Yes, I recall your family. Angella is your mother, yes?”

“That is so.”

“You don’t look like her at all.”

“I… am…”

“Ah. Is it one of *those* situations?”

“One of… what?” Catra bristled, “My lady, I am an adopted ward and a member of the family.”

Lady d’Weaver chuckled, “Indeed, quite so, quite so. Spirited too. Not ladylike at all… but would serve you well should you desire a role as a Governess. I have assisted many a young lady, struggling to find a partner, move into such circles. It sets them up for a *profession* that is not… beneath them and establishes them should they wish for spinsterhood or a more… attainable match. I note you are not married. A paramour perhaps?”

Catra blinked and composed herself, “I… no, not at this time.”

“I understand that the question of your estate’s entailment is in question?”

“That is not the case. It will pass to my eldest sister who… will be married, provided things have gone well.”

“Things?” prompted Lady d’Weaver with a bored huff, “Speak plainly, madame.”

“An engagement that was curtailed due to a lack of information now hopefully repaired,” offered Catra, unsure as to why she did so. She felt off balance with this woman.

“A concise answer. Good. I admit a certain intrigue, but not enough to delve, seeing as it matters little. You have siblings?”

“Yes my lady.”

“Ah, they must be impatient to present, seeing as you and your sister are not yet wed.”

“Oh they attend the parties, ladyship,” purred Dee, “Quite rambunctious, too!”

“They are out! Before you are wed!” Lady d’Weaver sounded shocked, “A handful indeed. The governess must be beside herself.”

“We have and had no governess, your ladyship.”

Lady d’Weaver rocked back, “But your education! And bearing!”

“My mother and father did well; we have always been encouraged to read. And we have made ample use of tutors when the need arose. Opportunities for betterment have never been turned away.”

This drew a sniff from the elder gentlewoman, “Well then, I find myself appalled and impressed in equal measure. Pray, what is your age?”

“Your ladyship, with three sisters all grown up, I can hardly own it.”

“You are adopted. Own it,” challenged the woman, a hint of irritation in her honeyed words, “You cannot be more than twenty, surely.”

“You flatter me, your ladyship. I am older than I appear and younger than some assume.”

“Daring and bordering on insolent.”

“A woman must maintain some mystique, surely, your ladyship? Much is assumed from such facts, from such appearances. Misjudgements can occur with just base facts and assumptions.”

Dee watched Catra carefully, and Ms Moon glanced their way briefly. The look on their face was certainly more calculating, perhaps even assessing. Lady d'Weaver huffed, but nodded.

"Those are pithy points but I will not press the matter. I feel it is time for some bridge, however."

The group moved and a card table was set up. Catra and Perfuma moved away from the table to allow Scorpia and Lady d'Weaver to play against the Telae's. Perfuma and Catra took a turn around the drab room and paused at a window, where the enigmatic Dee joined them.

"Well done, Kitten. Held your own against the witch."

Catra startled and shot the stranger a look, "I beg your pardon, but… what?"

"Oh, hush. She's a craven, socially pompous hag and we, all three of us, share this. I am bound by contract, but my tongue is not. I think you and I will get along *famously* , Kitten…"

"If you please, refrain from calling me that," Catra bit back. Perfuma regarded Dee carefully and then tilted her head.

"Contract? You are beholden to her ladyship?"

"Oh, hardly. We have an arrangement. A service. Everyone ends up happy."

"You mentioned a wedding dress," Catra glanced out of the window to take in the bleak gardens beyond, "Is this service related to that? You appeared almost disinterested."

"Well, marriage is a business and business can be rather dull. And why do you ask? Do you intend to visit?" Dee flashed a smile that did not reach their eyes. Catra stared back and smiled in return.

"Perhaps. Who is the lucky… person?"

Dee studied their fingertips for a moment, “Oh, well, that has yet to be decided. I don’t think they know yet.” Catra managed to suppress a twitch and redirected her gaze out of the window once more.

“Are they an acquaintance of Mister de Gray perhaps? I did note you speaking to the gentleman at the ball.”

Dee’s eyes flashed back to Catra and a faint expression of uncertainty crossed their face, “Acquainted with the gentleman?”

“Only from what Captain Hordak has vouchsafed to me. I believed Mister de Gray to be a man of honour. The gentleman was the primary reason for that aforementioned… issue with an engagement with my sister.”

Catra kept her face schooled, but let herself smile faintly. The best lies had a grain of truth to them after all. Dee leaned closer, “Oh really?”

“Yes. I was most upset with the gentleman. Of course things are confusing but, well…”

Dee nodded sympathetically, then glanced about, “And what did Captain Hordak have to say?”

Perfuma glanced between the pair, at a loss, but saw, from her angle, Catra’s hidden wink. The young Ms Moon heaved a sigh and turned to Dee, “I do not know you. I feel I could not betray the Captain’s confidence. He and I did form a rather… close relationship after all.”

“Indeed?” prompted Dee.

“Yes. I understand Mister de Gray broke an arrangement between the family and Captain Hordak! Quite the scandal. I fear it has rather tarnished the gentleman’s name in the eyes of some.”

“Oh yes?” Dee nodded sagely, “That… is interesting. And terribly tragic. Tell me, did the gentleman proposition anyone? When I

spoke with Adam, well, the gentleman seemed very out of sorts. I was under the impression th-... *he* had a paramour."

"Hardly. The gentleman was incredibly standoffish and difficult," Catra responded, perhaps a tad too quickly. She managed to furrow her brow, "And then the ugly business with my sister and Mr Archer, well. At least that misunderstanding was mitigated. Captain Hordak set us all straight."

"Did he now," mused Dee, eyes locked on Catra, "Well, I have to say you are a fantastic actress then."

Catra huffed and turned an arch expression to Dee, "Please, explain?"

"Well, you certainly seemed to be *enthralled* by Mister de Gray at the ball."

"Indeed. I am *well versed* in providing the impression of enthralled attentiveness to unwelcome advances. One must be always prepared as a woman *in want of a man* and all that."

"But you do *not* want a man, do you?" mused Dee, "Oh, I listen, Ms Moon. Quite a few of the elderly contingent at that ball were very free with their opinions."

"You dabble in gossip, do you?" mused Perfuma. Dee shot her another signature grin.

"Darling, I revel in it. It is my life blood. My muse and my instrument."

Catra actually laughed at that, "You are quite the character, Dee," she even tapped them on the chest, gently. Dee preened and Catra continued, quietly, "So, is the rumour I hear about you true? That you intend to wed *Adam* ?"

Dee smirked, knowingly, as if they knew something Catra did not, "Oh no. I have it on good authority that I will be betrothed to Adora. Adam will likely not be an obstacle. My last conversation

indicated he will likely quite the field. Far too trying a time for him, I fear."

"Indeed so?" Catra mused, her heart thumping, "What makes you think that?"

"Oh, rejection by a certain someone probably did him in," grinned Dee. Catra shrugged.

"The gentleman was aware of my intentions and my leanings. I can honestly say i have no interest in *Mister* de Gray."

Dee's grin was *very* knowing. They turned away and Catra caught a barely whispered, " *If only you knew…."*

"Now, Adora de Gray…." Catra mused, "Well, if I had ever the occasion to meet her, well…"

Dee twitched and looked back, eyes narrowed, "That would be…. Inadvisable. I understand her brother does dictate…"

"But as you said, he is likely no longer an issue. Ah but how would I even engineer such a thing. She doesn't know me. I have never met the woman! And… well… just walking up to her home and stating an intent… well, that is the providence of gentlemen, is it not?" Catra sighed and shrugged, "I suppose it is just an idle fancy."

"I have always said you read overmuch," Perfuma chipped in, doing her best to keep her face set, though her smile looked more indulgent than the clear mirth she wished to express, "You are a romantic, Catra dear. The real world does not deliver these things readily."

"But you and Scorpia!" exclaimed Catra, perhaps with a bit *too* much gusto. But she was enjoying herself. Perfuma shrugged.

"Perhaps the exception?"

“Maybe I *should* have settled for Mister de Gray. Dee, do you think I should? Should I perhaps change my stance? Or Captain Hordak? Oh…..” she clasped her hands together and sighed, “No. No, I must stand firm. I have my beliefs, after all.”

Dee looked perplexed and then smiled, “Quite so.”

The conversation was curtailed as the bridge game came to a close. Reverend Collins announced that they had Parish duties to attend and Lady d’Weaver bade them a curt farewell. Dee followed them to the entrance hall, a faint frown on their face and waved the five women off with an attempt at a knowing smirk. Catra just gave her own little wave in response and turned away.

Perfuma gave Catra an askance glance, “That was….”

“Most entertaining,” chuckled Catra.

Scorpia glanced over her shoulder and Perfuma made the universal sigh that conveyed “I will tell you later”, understood by spouses universally. Netossa and Spinnerella however had no such need to be reserved and listened to Catra recounting her entertainment.

“But why, dear?” asked Spinnerella.

“Because… that Dee was far too smug for my liking and also… it keeps them unaware of my own actions. I believe Dee was trying to ascertain my intent and I will not be so crassly manipulated.”

Perfuma grinned, “And just what *are* your intentions?”

“None whatsoever. It is not as if I am fond of Mister de Gray, after all!”

“Bravo,” nodded Netossa, “A welcome effort. That d’Weaver is *not* a fun sort. Her entire conversation over bridge was about *superiority* and *familial ties* . Dull stuff. So, if you can throw a cart’s axle on their scheming, make them off balance, all to the good. I do believe her ladyship was faintly impressed with you.”

“A very peculiar way of expressing it though,” huffed Catra.

The ride continued as they mulled over the events of the afternoon and soon they were returned to the Rectory. Being as it was later afternoon, an early meal was decided upon before the company retired, as they intended to depart early for their visit across the county.

The following morning Catra and the Telae’s departed by their own carriage, bidding a fond farewell to the happy couple and a promise to drop by once more on their return south. The intention was a sojourn of a few days to the other end of the northern county, to enjoy the moors and forests. This leg of the journey was relatively short - a half day to navigate across wondrously bleak landscapes and through damp and dark woods.

They arrived in a small town named Ruckstown. A market town, it boasted a sizeable coaching inn and welcoming locals, something Catra was immediately grateful for after the stuffy confines of Lady d’Weaver’s estate, even with the perpetually sunny Scorpia providing a beacon.

They dined that afternoon in the inn and Netossa commented to the barman on the excellent fare. The man, more a youth, with tousled blonde hair and a rather excitable disposition, nodded vigorously.

“Aye. My husband is the chef!”

Catra blinked in surprise and looked at the young man in surprise, “Husband? I thought such things were… frowned on in the north?”

The man immediately looked guarded, but then noticed how Netossa and Spinnerella held each other’s hands across the table. He relaxed immediately and elaborated, “Well, in *some* corners. But that is more a rumour put about by some of the gentry up here - a ways of, well, keeping another lead on us, begging your pardon.”

“But you own the establishment and thus are free to…?” led Netossa. The young man laughed.

“Oh ma’am, no. Our landlord is most kind and forward looking. Can’t says as I blame them, tough times what with the family dramas. But they always say *for love* . That’s the way they look at it. Kindness, fairness. Can’t ask for a better landlord - rents are low, we keep the profits, they look after us.”

The three women nodded in agreement and Catra carefully sliced into her roast beef, “So, not Lady d’Weaver then?”

The barman laughed, a squeaky noise, but full of mirth, “Oh bless me no. Lady…. *Lord* de Gray is our landlord,” he adjusted his shirt absently, covering his slip, “Speaks their mind, is forthright with us. Hosts the annual fair in town, judges the ‘best sow’ contest and everything.”

Catra coughed and looked about, “Mister de Gray is your landlord?”

“That they are,” nodded the barman, “Didn’t you know you were near the Greyskull estate?”

“We were aware it was in the area but… we were not aware the holdings stretched to the town.”

“Oh here, plus at least three other villages. And some sizeable tracts of land,” nodded the barman, “You can head up there, have a look. My wife is housekeeper at the main house. Keep it open for visitors. Her ladysh- *lordship* says it’d be a waste otherwise.”

The trio nodded, slightly overwhelmed and it was only as the man bustled off to the kitchens that Netossa did a rather abrupt double take.

“Wait, *wife* ?”

After a relaxing evening, the trio set off early. The Telae's seemed the most enthused by the prospect - a chance to see a stately home in its entirety, rather than just one doudy drawing room was a clear plus from their perspective.

Catra wasn't quite sure what she felt. She felt strange visiting the home of the mysterious *Mister de Gray* without their tacit permission. Or their company.

She wanted to talk to the gentleman. No, not to *Adam* .

She wanted to talk to *Adora* . The woman she'd glimpsed behind that mask; the blonde who had seemed to yearn to break free; who apparently had genuine emotions for Catra. And, well, Catra would be lying if she was not intrigued herself.

Their carriage rattled down a lane and then found itself under a thick canopy. The trees on the boulevard towards the house were closely entwined, forming a tunnel of green that felt welcoming and secure, wrapped in nature.

They emerged and Catra gasped at the view - several large ponds, almost lakes really, were spread across the grounds, trees and copses between them. They led to solid, well manicured lawns, which in turn led to raised gardens and neatly maintained floral displays.

"Well now. I can see why Dee is so enamoured with the idea of marriage to the de Gray line. One could do very well with this," mused Netossa idly. Catra didn't note the woman's grin as she stared at the opulent estate.

"Yes… yes one could," she murmured.

Honestly, she had not been sure what to expect - a grey, dank mansion? A place of overgrown gardens as befit the loneliness she'd felt from the letter? But this seemed so *alive* .

The carriage drew to a stop at the front of the house and a woman emerged from the front doors. Her dark brown hair was

done up into corn-rows and her dark skin showed signs of weathering from hard work in the sun. She wore an apron, but seemed to have a set of trousers on as well as a labourers shirt. The woman folded her arms and watched as they stepped down.

"Ladies. How may I help you?"

Spinnerella smiled widely, "Ah, we were directed her by a charming young man at the *Fright* inn? He mentioned that the house was open to visitors? Is that the case, might we impose…"

The woman cracked a half grin and unfolded her arms, "My Kyle been boasting has he? Lonnie, pleasure to make your acquaintance. I'm afraid the Lord of the manor is away on business, but that just means no one getting under my feet!"

Catra blinked at the rather forthright delivery and just followed the other two women in.

The house was a study in contrasts - grey, like lady d'Weaver's; but the windows were wider and the pillars seemed less plain by comparison. Carvings etched the walls under the guttering and a tiled mural of a figure raising a sword sat above the entry doors.

Inside, the whole house felt light and open - the entryway had a single large staircase rising to the top, with corridors branching off to each wing.

Lonnie led them through the rooms, pointing out various interesting items of furniture, collectibles and antiques. They paused, briefly, in the library and Catra nearly fainted from the sheer number of tomes on display - several were piled up on a desk, which had the remains of a candle burned down on it - clearly the room was well used.

"Ah yes, the Mistress lets us staff use the place. When she isn't using it of course. Likes her privacy."

Catra twitched and looked at the housekeeper with a frown, "Her ladyship?"

The woman looked back at her, blankly, then smirked, “Yes.”

They followed Lonnie back out, through more rooms, taking in the art on the walls and the statues - one showed a cat with green fur and stripes; another a man at arms with a young girl on his knee; one statue was a rather strange rendition of a skeleton, but it appear to have been appropriated as some sort of target, with the amount of scuffs it sported.

“Ah, that was a gift from Mr Hordak,” Lonnie mused, her lips drawn into a faint sneer, “Her ladyship likes to use it as a tool to contemplate her frustrations.”

Catra looked about the room - intended as a dining room perhaps, save for the fact it lacked furnishing aside from the side table and a few rather broken looking statues, “She… makes use of the room?”

“Oh yes. Better this than letter her near a musket. No matter how much Mister Archer keeps trying,” Lonnie sighed and shook her head.

“You are acquainted with Mister Archer?” asked Spinnerella.

“Oh yes. He’s been a good friend to her ladyship. And to his lordship,” again Lonnie smiled that faint, knowing smile. Catra watched her and then shook her head. They followed her back out, but Catra paused at the door when she spotted a painting propped against the wall.

“Is this… her ladyship?”

The painting was half covered in a sheet but showed a woman in a flowing white dress, blonde hair like a cascading waterfall behind her. Her face looked serene, at peace; her smile was soft, her eyes crinkled in mirth. And *oh* those blue eyes.

Eyes Catra had seen before. Had felt burn into her.

Absently, she tugged on the sheet. It fell, just as Lonnie darted back into the room. The housekeeper frowned at Catra's rather assumptive act, but paused as she saw the young woman regard the painting with what seemed to be wonder.

"Yes… that's Miss Adora."

"And that is… Mister de Gray?" Catra frowned at the man in the picture.

"Can't be," mused Netossa, "Looks nothing like him."

"Well, the canvas does add a few pounds," offered Spinnerella.

"But he looks like an *ox* . Mister de Gray doesn't look like *that* at all, unless life has been stressful, recently. Perhaps he is more vain than we realised and wished to be immortalised as a form of livestock?"

Lonnie looked between the three women and arched an eyebrow, "You know his lordship, eh?"

Catra blinked and waved a hand, "In passing. In truth, I didn't get to really know the gentlemen as much as I thought."

"A shame. Of course I prefer her ladyship. She's a kind soul. Life's been unfair. But she's been good to us. Her tenants, us in the house. Gave us all a place to be when other estates were turning people out for not being *proper* ," her eyes fixed on Catra, "The family has it's sorrows, but I won't hear a bad word said."

Catra smiled and looked at the housekeeper, "I doubt I could manage a poor opinion, compared to my view of myself. A shame, I had hoped to meet the lady of the house. Given her brother is… *absent* ?" she arched an eyebrow at Lonnie. The housekeeper's own smile was challenging.

"Well, they are very busy. She does like to receive guests. Perhaps another time?"

Catra nodded slowly and looked at the floor. She felt a strange wave of melancholy wash over her and managed a quiet, "I doubt that," she looked back up and gave a curtsey to Lonnie whose eyes widened in surprise, "Thank you for letting us look around. Truly this is a wonderful house… nay, a *home* . Please, pass our compliments to the family."

They left the house and Lonnie headed to get their carriage and driver from the stableyard. Netossa and Spinnerella moved around the drive to study an ornate statue of a rearing horse with stylised wings, while Catra ambled around to the side, near the edge of one of the ponds. She stared into the water as the faint images of fish darted beneath the surface.

A rustle from the bushes nearby drew her gaze and she jolted in surprise as a figure practically stumbled out of the greenery.

A very damp, half dressed figure.

A very damp, half dressed, clearly *feminine* figure.

A very damp, half dress, feminine figure with blonde hair down to her shoulders and wide blue eyes.

Catra blinked and flexed her fingers. She managed a slightly cracked half grin and croaked out a slightly high pitched:

"Hello, Adora."

Chapter End Notes

Yes. Yes.

I managed to get the words in there.

As ever, I hope you are enjoying! This one took a while and covers a LOT compared to other chapters. I didn't want to dice it up either.

So, here you go!

To wash away our burdens

Chapter Summary

A chapter increase.

An accord.

And a reunion of hearts - at least the start of it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had been a most unpleasant period for one Mister Adam de Gray. The gentleman had departed from the small township of Brightmoon with all due haste after the shameful rejection by one Ms Catra Moon. And not all of it entirely undeserved, it appeared. A litany of excuses and misunderstandings and, most of all, a contrivance of fate to imply that, should their situation be *different* there might have been a chance at reconciliation.

If Adam had not been a *man* : That bitterest of ironies.

Adora de Gray rode Swift Wind hard, heels driving into the beast's flanks with single minded determination - to quit the county, to quit the countryside, to quit *Catra Moon* with all due haste.

The duo made fair time across rutted fields and dappled tree lines. At the end of the first day, they drew into an in whereupon *Mister de Gray* handed off the sweat-slaked beast to a fawning stableboy. The gentleman retired to a room and gazed at the candle for a good hour before a sense of outrageous zeal overtook their soul.

That sense of imbalance, of the scales of the world being *wrong* .

Adora had spent her life sheltered, then dictated to. Her father, a kind man; her brother, a worried and forthright man, with the soul

of a boy; d'Weaver, with her grasping ideas of *propriety* and *family* , which translated into a desire to keep all manner of property firmly aligned to *her* interests; Hordak, with his stuffy ways and ideas of traditional fortitude.

None evil, but misguided and petty perhaps. No foresight. No real vision of Adora as *Adora* . She had been a key to the lock that was Greyskull. Some wanted her ensconced, others placed into the palms of others.

And Adam, with his departure to *secure the family future* - his was perhaps the most irritating blunder. Leaving her to handle the inept predations of Hordak. But in such secrecy had Adam absconded, things had been left in disarray. And it had been that dismissive comment from Aunt d'Weaver, about her lacking the requisite *definitions* with which to manage the estates - the fact that d'Weaver ran *her* own estates was a niggling point. Adora had stipulated that she could delegate *just* as well as d'Weaver. Oh there were implications of the estate only being able to be inherited down the *male* line, but Adora had not found hide nor hair of any *documented* framework to that effect - it appeared to be an assumption - but those held water in some of the stuffier legal circles.

That had led to a rather chilly argument. But it had brought Adora to a realisation - as long as she operated under the assumption that a man was *required* , she would never be free. And as the majority of the various estate businesses were unaware that Adam had absconded, well, there was no real reason to disabuse them of that notion.

And so it had been that she had adopted the moniker of her brother. She hadn't tried all that hard to begin with - the majority of her business interests had never really *met* Adam, so she was able to maintain the ruse. And then those that realised thought it a *jolly good wheeze* ; or were so embarrassed that they dared not challenge her. The idea that a woman would be so brazen! So overt! And that, perhaps, they had been bamboozled… well, it

would not do for the news to get out that they had been outfoxed by a woman!

So they carried on. And Adora's future became secure. After a fashion.

Instead she was trapped in a chain of a different sort - unable to be *herself* , save within extremely specific circumstances.

And with the knowledge of that bitter irony coursing through her, Adora put quill to parchment and poured out her despair, her anger and her very soul.

Catra might despise her for myriad reasons, but Adora would be damned if she did not at least set things out. Catra could mull on *that* . And, frankly, Adora wanted some form of last word. She understood Catra's perception, but the idea of the woman holding an opinion so skewed, so wrong - it screamed at Adora's sense of *right* and *wrong* . She had watched her neighbours tenants, as they laboured under unfair rents, or punishing work practices. She had been incensed at the unfairness she'd observed in Elberon when she had visited the city; at the poverty and inequality.

And so, even before Adam had left, she had done her part to improve the lot of those who worked for her; had started projects and plans. And as *Mister de Gray* she had continued these things. To keep others safe, to improve their lives.

This, of course, she did not mention - such base vanity was alien to her. More, it was self evident that one *should* aid one's fellow person. To do otherwise felt abhorrent. It was one reason why she did not outright despise Mr Hordak Wickham: the man *had* tried to aid, albeit with a leaning towards personal goals.

At the end of the day, the gentleman had been a friend.

After what seemed hours, Adora slumped in her chair. The candle had burned down and the room was dim. She dragged her cravat off and rang a bell for a maid. The woman who arrived seemed

shocked at Adora's mingled attire, but clamped her mouth shut at the icy gaze levelled her way.

"Dispatch this missive, post haste. And ah…. For your troubles and discretion."

The five shillings that were pressed into the maids hand likely did much to enable commerce in that inn for several days after - along with bringing a genuinely *helpful* smile to the maid's face.

"Yes'm, sir… ma'am. Sir."

"Quite," Adora snorted and waved the maid away. She did not bother with dinner that evening and instead sank into a restless sleep.

The following morn she was on the road early. Her journey took her south, initially, back to Elberon. She tarried only briefly - for two days. During that time she found time to call upon her dear friend, Beauregard.

She had expected to find him in his cups, but instead he had transformed a ballroom into an archery range. Together they commiserated, although Adora kept her counsel on the reason why, save that it was to do with the Moon family. That had drawn a bitter snort from the normally effervescent gentleman.

His dark complexion looked grey as he espoused the sense of loss, the implied slights.

"And you no not why?" Adora had asked. She was dressed in more feminine attire whilst at the Archer household - a simple dress, with sturdy shoes. Some days she appreciated trousers; others she found gentlemanly attire far too restrictive and claustrophobic.

"I have an inkling, but I fear it would poison your opinion. A distinct disapproval of us as *gentlemen* ."

“I was given to understand you were perceived as a bounder and cad!”

“To try to understand the rationale of that family is beyond me, much to my chagrin! I wished to know them well. They appeared reasonable, kind. *Good* . But I believe they would not understand *us* .”

“What is there to understand?” Adora chuckled, “We are a pair of charming individuals, without compare! Their loss, I believe,” she nodded, in a clear attempt to lodge said conviction firmly within her breast. It did not, however, settle so.

Beauregard loosed another arrow, which thudded into a straw target. He shook his head, “I wish it felt so. My fathers have already begun to talk of alternative arrangements. A young officer in the Capital Regiment. He seems a decent sort but, really… if I wanted a uniform I would have enlisted myself, purchased a commission!”

“Well, you have the aptitude for it,” mused Adora. She peered at the targets, “But I doubt you have the patience for the drudgery of military life. Marching in particular, requires a certain level of co-ordination…”

“Oh you wastrel!” Beauregard laughed and tossed a balled up towel at his friend. She laughed, then exhaled heavily, their mirth brief but needed.

“I must away to the north. I feel I have neglected my estates over long.”

“Rot! Stay! We can partake of the pleasures of the club!”

“Bridge is not a pleasure, it is a chore.”

“Well then, perhaps…”

“And the cabaret? Really?”

“I mean… it might be distracting? Or how about a boxing tourney! I hear there are several newcomers…”

“I have already watched enough of that to last a lifetime. And they wouldn’t let me continue!”

“Only because you insisted on the gentleman’s tourney and… they were upset.”

“If they didn’t wish for their champion to be embarrassed, he should have put up more of an effort!” harrumphed Adora, “Honestly. A jaw made of glass.”

Beauregard chuckled, then replaced his bow into a nearby rack, unstringing it prior, “Are you sure you won’t consider it? A few days to collect your thoughts, aid me in my own doldrums?”

Adora shook her head, “I would… but I fear I will be of no assistance. I have… to understand myself. And you have your fathers to attend to your moping!” Adora smiled fondly at her friend, “I require… the solace of home.”

Beauregard nodded, “This I can understand. In which case, at least stay until the morrow - have one last dinner before you become a lovesick hermit. I am… sorry she was not what you expected. I…” he winced, but merely offered a shrug, “I am sure, in another life, things might have been different, were she to adopt a different attitude. I honestly believed her to be more accommodating.”

“So did I. But! Let us… enjoy ourselves,” Adora tried with false cheer. That evening, she was able to forget for a little while.

Her business kept her in Elberon for a few more days, but she was able to ride North not long after. She rode hard once more, across heath and brook, revelling in the clean air. Atop a small hillock, Adora inhaled and closed her eyes. Her shoulders, tense for so many days, relaxed as she took in her *home* .

Many disparaged the northern counties - the truth was that it was mainly the landowners who were the miserly, prejudiced sorts. The *people* were kind, understanding and wholly open. And she loved them for it.

With a breath, Adora undid the collar of her shirt, and whipped away the neckerchief, which she stuffed into a saddlebag. A collar in more ways than one, she revelled in the cool breeze, before she spurred Swiftwind into a canter down the slope.

She rode with ease, as she crossed onto *her* property. The heath gave way to carefully maintained woodland and slight gulleys - timber sites and waterways that she ensured were carefully managed. Unlike her neighbours who had run several of their own estates to near ruin.

She brought Swift Wind to a stop near a lake and smiled at the view - she could see the house in the distance, flanked by manicured gardens and tall trees. The sun was high in the sky and she felt the dirt of the road clinging to her very skin. The frustrations and disappointments of the past week (Had it been a week? Or longer? Adora honestly had lost track)

With a laugh, she dismounted and yanked away at her clothes. The jacket and waistcoat went first, followed by her boots and socks. She pulled away her britches, leaving only a binding for her chest and a set of rather unflattering undergarments (Which she often had to pack with *padding*). For today it was mercifully empty.

Swift Wind watched as Adora took a running dive into the lake. The blonde pushed herself under, revelling in the refreshing feel of the cold water as it washed away the dust and sweat. Her mind cleared under the icy flash from the water and she surfaced with a joyous gasp. She began to crawl, arms flashing with strength born of hours of development - when she had adopted her role as *head of the manor* she had made a point to assist and to get involved.

Some of the labourers had been shocked, nearly appalled; but she had flummoxed them with her intensity and determination. Protocol be damned; the idea of lines being crossed being *bad* was something she would not brook. And so she helped carry hay bales; wrangled livestock; chopped wood.

She powered through the water, then turned and sprinted back. The burn in her muscles helped sooth the burn in her mind. After a few laps of the lake, she swam to the middle and rolled onto her back. She floated there, weightless and blank-of-mind as she regarded the clouds above.

For that moment, she felt contentment; a faint form of acceptance.

Here she was supreme; safe and secure. Her staff, her tenants, all knew and understood the reality of things. They knew her fortune was bound to theirs and that to risk their lady was to risk themselves. And, truth be told, they were all in similarly scandalous situations. Some of which would not draw a glance in the south, but some of which were still unusual.

Adora cared not - only that they were safe and that no harm was being done to others. With those goals met, she welcomed any and all.

With a sigh she swam to the edge and laughed as she noticed a figure next to Swiftwind.

"Huntara. I see a brace of pheasants at your hip - poaching again?"

The woman was tall - taller than Adora. She had her hand on Swiftwind's bridle and had a bemused expression on her face, "Hardly poaching on my own estate, now…"

Adora snorted, "Careful. You're getting *airs* ."

The big woman shrugged her powerful shoulders, "I look after the game… counts as mine, right?" her deadpan expression twitched

ever so slightly and Adora laughed.

"Possession being four fifths of the law, is that it?" Adora rested an elbow in the palm of her hand and tapped her chin, "But then… I own your house so…. By that extension…."

"Bah! Bringing *legalities* into it…. And I thought you were fun, blondi- *my lady* ."

Adora snorted, "Formality ill suits you. And how is the wife?" Adora arched an eyebrow and Huntara actually blushed.

"She… is well. Um…"

"A year now, correct?"

"Yes… my lady."

The stifled formality and the deepening of the game-keeper's blush made Adora laugh, her chest light for the first time in days, "It does me good to see someone's happiness continue unabated. I envoy your courage. And your success, 'Tara."

The taller woman quirked an eyebrow and saw the lines around Adora's eyes; the tension which she still held around her shoulders, even with the aid of a relaxing swim. Huntara nodded slowly and sighed, "Well, I am glad you pushed me to, well…. Swallow my pride."

Adora quirked an eyebrow and slapped Huntara's arm. The taller woman didn't even flinch, "Then all is well. Come one, back to the house."

After Adora had collected her discarded items they walked around the edge of the lake, between the trees, idly conversing, until Huntara turned Swiftwind towards the stables, "I'll get him sorted, ma'am. You away back to the house. Lonnie will likely have missives galore for you."

“Oh joy”, deadpanned Adora, as she adjusted her bundled clothes. She nodded as her gamekeeper led Swiftwind away.

She smiled and shook her head, then pushed her way through a narrow path between hedgerows, onto the main lawn. Her mind was elsewhere, covering off potential upcoming audiences and likely tenant meetings she would have to attend when her eyes caught something on the ground - a shadow.

It was feminine and it drew her eyes up. She blinked, unsure of whether the image before her was real. She stared as heterochromatic eyes stared back at her. The woman in front of Adora had an expression on her face that Adora struggled to identify initially - unused as she was to seeing it on that beautiful profile. Then she realised that the woman was pensive, affecting a demeanor of confidence.

She watched as Catra smiled and then spoke.

“Hello Adora.”

Her name on those lips made the blonde freeze. There was no mockery, no sneer, no judgement. Just a gentle and tentative greeting. Catra’s voice had a rasp to it, a throaty squeak. The woman had her arms folded in front of her, her head slightly bowed; but she also had a faint smile, her lower lip held between white teeth. Adora noted, as she always had, that Catra’s canines seemed a little more pronounced, giving rise to that constant comparison with her near namesake.

Adora swallowed and blinked as Catra’s expression became more worried. THe blonde coughed and then bowed. Her boots slipped from her grip and, as she tried to grab for them, the rest of her clothes cascaded away. Adora grimaced, then looked up and flashed a grin. It was lopsided, embarrassed but also open.

Catra blinked and gasped, her own expression shifting to open wonderment. Adora scrambled for her clothes and straightened, then coughed. Her smile was still there, albeit with an additional

blush, “Ms Moon… um… Catra… hello, yes. So. Hi. I am Adora. Hello!”

The brunette stared at her and giggled, “You, madame… are an idiot.”

It was said so softly, so kindly that Adora flushed even more. She coughed and looked about, “So, um… you are here. At my house. I trust you didn’t have to walk and, um…”

“No, I did not walk,” smirked Catra. She seemed to be regaining her footing, “We um… I … we were in the area and, perchance, a person in the inn recommended we visit.”

Adora cocked her head and laughed, “Kyle?”

Catra nodded in surprise, “You… know his name?”

“Of course. He and Rog are my tenants. And Lonnie talks about him so much I would be hard pressed to exercise his name from my mind. Though there are days I wish I could…”

Catra laughed and nodded. She quirked an eyebrow as her eyes travelled up and down Adora’s form, “So… did your noble steed toss you into a puddle?”

“You cannot contemplate the possibility that I was, perhaps, embroiled in some noble struggle and instead default to the idea that I was tossed clear by my horse?”

Catra cocked her head and smiled wider. Adora shook her head and scoffed. She shivered for a moment then flashed Catra an apologetic look. Catra blinked and then shifted, “Oh um… do not… let me keep you.”

“Please, Ms Moon. If you would just…. Hold a moment?”

Catra blinked as Adora moved around her, then darted off towards the house. The blonde dashed up the stairs and burst into the building via the patio double doors. She practically flung her

drenched clothes at a shocked Lonnie and took the stairs three at a time, with a shout of "Don't let her leave!"

She practically knocked her own door off its hinges as she barrelled into her room, whereupon she hauled out a white shift, then a dress. She looked at it, then discarded it in favour of a clean set of grey britches and a loose fighting white shirt, with a scarlet waistcoat. She decided to forgo the neckerchief or cravat, then hauled on a new set of boots and then darted back out of the room, tucking in the shirt as she went.

The woman nearly tumbled down the stairs in her haste, uncaring that her normally-carefully bound hair was now more mo-like. She kept it shorter, but mostly just well-hidden and combed - many men wore their hair in a slightly longer style anyway - she just avoided braiding it. Now it looked like a more feminine bob.

She skidded down the front stairs of the house just as the stable-boy brought around a cart. Catra stood, waiting, along with two familiar faces. For the briefest moment Adora pondered her guise - she had been unaware that Catra had company.

However, she was committed now and, really, this was *her* home. She would not hide here.

Catra gawped at her as she came to a halt, her grin still plastered on her face. She gave Catra a small wave, despite being only a few feet away. Catra, for her part, returned it with a dazed expression. The other two women glanced between them, then looked at Adora in surprise, doing a slight double take.

The blonde focused on them and extended her hand. Her mind clicked as she recognised them as the Telae's - the surprising couple she had briefly encountered around Brightmoon and Thaymor. Surprising because they were openly *Friends of Mara* - something she had only really encountered in Elberon. To find people living so openly in what she had assumed would be more conservative environs had been refreshing.

“Mrs and Mrs Telae. A pleasure to see you again,” she smiled warmly at the pair. For their part, they seemed shocked. Understandable, really.

Netossa was the first to regain her senses, “Mister...de Gray?”

“After a fashion. I take it by your surprise that Catra has not explained things?” Adora looked at Catra and flashed another excited smile at the woman, “Thank you, by the way.”

“No… issue,” managed the brunette. Her gaze seemed fixed on Adora’s arms - the blonde had rolled her sleeves up as she’d walked down the steps, revealing her tanned and toned forearms.

“My apologies for the confusion. I tend to conduct business as Mister, due to the ease with which it can be done, for continuity’s sake. Allow me to formally introduce myself as Lady Adora de Gray. Are you in the north for long?”

Netossa, too, seemed to be a little bit enthralled by Adora’s appearance and jolted as Spinnerella gave her a nudge. The other woman was smiling though when she did so, so matricide was an unlikely possibility. Netossa cleared her throat, “No, um… we are, were just about to head back to the inn. We had intended to spend a few days here, enjoying the countryside. Perhaps a walk, or… a chance to indulge in some outdoor activity.”

“Ah! Do you ride? Fish?” Adora’s smile broadened.

“I… do. I do fish. Yes,” Netossa nodded quickly.

“Wonderful. Well, we have a rather well maintained trout pond on the estate. If you require rods my brother kept… keeps a sizeable selection. Please feel free to avail yourself of their use and the pond as well! I do enjoy the odd afternoon drawing a line, and you would be welcome.”

Spinnerella chuckled as Netossa immediately and clearly decided she was very much aligned to the pro-Adora campaign for

whatever was likely to occur. Adora looked to her next, as Spinnerella leaned in to whisper, “Remember, I am still your wife.”

“I understand you wish to be off but…. Would you all care to stay for dinner? I have only just returned myself and would be thankful for the company.”

Catra coughed and looked, helplessly, at the other two women. They smiled back at her, then looked at Adora, “We would not wish to impose.”

Adora gestured to the house, “Please… I am very likely to lose you in there at some stage. You are most welcome. It is I who do not wish to impose…. But you would be welcome. All of you,” her eyes settled on Catra, who blushed.

The Telae’s indulged in that time-honoured tradition of spouses everywhere - the silent communication. Then they looked to Catra and nodded, before returning their joint stare to Adora, “We are hardly attired for dinner.”

“Well… then I insist your return to your lodgings to prepare. And then, please, return for dinner.”

Another silent conference later and the trio nodded. Adora waved them off as they left, eyes on Catra until the cart rattled around a bend in the drive. As soon as they were out of sight, she sprinted back inside to find a cantankerous Lonnie waiting for her.

“Ma’am, I am not accustomed to being used as target practice for *wet britches* .”

“Lonnie, you have two husbands, I think that surely you would be well versed in that by now,” Adora riposted. This appeared to send Lonnie into a tongue-tied huff and the housekeeper pivoted to storm away, “Hold a mo! Um… please inform the kitchen staff we will have… um… three more for dinner tonight.”

Lonnie froze and turned back. Her brow furrowed, “You are…. Entertaining?”

“Yes.”

“Those three who just took the tour?”

“Correct.”

Lonnie stared at her mistress for a long moment and then harrumphed, “Why?”

Adora met her gaze and arched an eyebrow, “Because one of them means a great deal to me.”

That made both of the housekeeper’s eyebrows rise. She gave a short nod, then headed off towards the kitchens without another word. Though she did have a rather smug grin on her face.

Adora fretted for the next two hours. She paced all through the vast house, studying long-forgotten items, paintings and books; she lounged on furniture, but never found herself comfortable. She even did a speed walk around the rose garden twelve times. Suffice to say, this did not calm her one iota.

It wasn’t until she heard the jangle of harness and the clatter of cart-wheels that she was able to focus clearly. And when the three women descended from their conveyance, her heart was fit to burst. Netossa and Spinnerella were done up in neat finery, as befitted calling on a gentleman at his home.

But Catra had gone all out. Her hair was done in a style that made it look shorter and less like her normal wild mane. She had on a dress lined in crimson and dark browns, which highlighted her figure; and she had on the same elbow gloves from when Adora had first seen her.

She was a vision. Adora almost fell down the steps as she went to greet the trio. For her part, she had changed again; this time into a white dress, with a jacket over the top. Some days she could never quite settle on a style. Her mixed appearance seemed to confuse the Telae’s but delighted Catra; or at least the woman’s mischievous grin indicated it was so.

Adora led them to the dining room, where she'd insisted on a smaller table being set. It made for easier conversation and felt more intimate. The setup drew a curious look from Spinnerella and Adora responded to the unasked question, "I am alone here; a large table is an awful thing to sit at by oneself. So, when an opportunity to engage with others arises, I feel something that enables communication to be preferable!"

"But… you barely said a word in Thaymor!" blurted out Netossa. Adora shrugged.

"That wasn't really me. And also, what was there to say? I did not live there, did not envisage having much to do beyond Beauregard…"

Catra sighed at that, her gaze on the soup before her - the staff had prepared a rather lavish spread on short notice. The brunette looked up and gave a faint shrug, "We did call upon the gentleman. Before coming north… we stayed in Elberon."

Adora frowned, "Oh? And… how is he?"

"Well. I feel I have resolved one issue at least. There is a strong likelihood that the engagement with my sister will go ahead."

Adora perked up, "That is excellent news! What... what changed precisely?"

Catra blushed once more and focused back on her food, "Maybe we can… discuss it in, um… a more private setting?"

Netossa chuckled, "Come now, Catra. We are all aware of things are we not?"

"Netossa!" hissed the brunette, "Please…."

Spinnerella reached across the table and swatted her wife's hand, "Behave."

For her part, Adora watched the interplay with interest, then focused back on Catra. She studied the brunette for a moment, then nodded, "I take it you received my letter, but did not divulge its contents?"

"That is so. But it is also why I wanted… to talk with you. I am making amends."

Adora nodded slowly, "Amends," Honestly she felt slightly disappointed - for amends did not mean anything more than correcting a mishap. That being said, Catra was here, in Adora's ancestral home. And that felt like a victory in itself. Perhaps, at least, their acquaintance could be rekindled. Perhaps. The conversation continued - Scorpia and Perfuma's nuptials, which Adora was actually disappointed to have missed out on; the ongoing gossip of Thaymor; the joys of Elberon; and their rather icy visit to the estate of d'Weaver.

Adora scoffed at that last one, "Her ladyship is a woman of singular tastes, most of them poor. I trust Dee was…. Not overbearing?"

Catra fidgeted for a moment, then took a rather large bite of the lamb she was eating. She swallowed and huffed, "Apparently you are to be wed?"

That made Adora laugh, loudly, "Another d'Weaver ruse to draw me in. No, I have no designs upon any… currently."

Catra shot Adora a look that was part confusion and part hurt, "Oh? I thought you might… be having to hide from the potential suitors?" she managed, albeit a little lamely.

The blonde leaned back in her chair for a moment and watched Catra. She took in the flush of the woman's face; her nervous disposition; her breathing and tiny movements. And Adora couldn't quite puzzle out the intent. She shrugged, "I am not lucky in that respect, Ms Moon," the Telae's watched the back and forth carefully and Adora continued, "Dee is… a means to an end for

my Aunt. An olive branch to my particular situation," Here, Adora gestured to herself. Even in gentleman's clothing, she exuded a femininity, now that she wasn't adopting the stiff air and carefully crafted exterior of *Mister* de Gray. "I am... I became *Mister* de Gray for several reasons. The avoidance of constant attempts to secure my hand, for one; for the other, the ability to prevent contests of issue around the inheritance. My own associations with the fairer sex, of course, feature in both scenarios. Lady d'Weaver wishes the estate to remain in familiar hands. Dee is a way of compromising with me, but not one I am willing to countenance. When I... well... when it happens, it will be done for the right reasons. Not... not for transactional purposes."

Adora blushed at that and Catra recalled the woman's rather abrupt proposal. And yet, viewed in the current light, she could also see where it had come from. Adora, a woman trapped by duty and circumstance had been forced to take a nvoel approach to secure her future; Catra was unsure of the wider ramifications, but she was gaining more insight in this one sitting than before.

To Catra it was a wonder to see Adam - no: *Adora* - in her element: shorn of pretext and Catra's prior preconceptions. Adora laughed more freely, gestured more broadly, smiled more softly. That coldness that had been in the eyes of Mister de Gray was wholly absent here. Oh, they still held an intensity that Catra found herself actively seeking, her own gaze meeting Adora's several times during the meal.

It was a wonder to watch Adora with her staff as well - every course brought an avalanche of thanks from the Lady of the manor; ever servant was quizzed on their family, their health, their general wellbeing. And all answered with a smile, a gesture and a grateful nod.

Adora was just *kind* . She was thoughtful.

Catra realised her disposition towards Adora and, really, towards whom she had thought Adam to be, was a lot clearer cut than she had initially allowed herself to believe.

Adora supped at her wine and carried the conversation - asking the Telae's of their business and interests in Elberon. She quizzed Catra as to the health and well being of her family - a topic they had avoided at the start of the conversation beyond that mild hint of improvement in the circumstances of Ms Glimmer Moon and Mr Beauregard Archer.

As the conversation wound on Catra dabbed at her mouth with her napkin and sighed. She interjected with an "We aim to return south in a few days, but I would be… honoured to carry your greetings and best wishes to them," she fidgeted for a moment and drew a breath, then winced, "Might you be intending to visit the area? I remember you were not over-fond of it."

Adora watched Catra over the top of her glass, then set it down. She studied the surface of the table for a moment, then gave a half shrug, "I have no pressing business in the area, no cause to visit," she offered, before her eyes met Catra's. She arched an eyebrow and a small smile tugged at the corner of her mouth, "Might I find occasion to do so?"

"I would say, madame, that were you to call, I know that it would be a welcome surprise," responded Catra.

"A gentleman, or lady, should not go where they are not welcomed; to drop in unexpected is fine when one is to call and to introduce oneself. But to simply avail oneself of another's hospitality, well, I would feel I was imposing."

Catra narrowed her eyes, "Even to call upon a friend?"

"I have a friend in Brightmoon?" queried Adora. Her smile was a little more teasing now, "I was under the impression that one such as I was not fit company?"

Her voice was soft, chiding. There was no rancor there. Catra sighed and adjusted her cutlery. She fixed Adora with a near glare, but it faltered at Adora's soft smile and the gentle nature of her expression. Catra swallowed, "I…. wish to convey my

apologies. For several things. And I would like to say that… Mister de Gray is welcome. But perhaps…. Adora would care to visit?"

Adora's smile widened and she nodded rapidly, "I think that could be arranged."

Eventually the meal wound down and the trio declined a nightcap, albeit with reluctance. Adora chattered as she led them out to their cart and helped each aboard. She grasped Catra's hand for perhaps a little longer than propriety would allow for. They gazed at one another until Catra coughed and glanced away. She flushed and managed a small, "Again, I apologise for my conduct."

Adora inclined her head and shrugged, "And mine also. I can only state that I acted from the heart, but without much recourse to my brain. A common failing, I am afraid."

"Well, I…. yes," Catra sat and smoothed her dress, "Thank you, Adora… for a wonderful day."

"The pleasure was mine. Shall… shall I see you tomorrow?" her voice carried such tentative hope that Catra's heart both broke and swelled at once. She adopted a distant air, but could not mask the grin that broke across her face.

"I am residing at the inn… and we have no pressing engagements…"

"Until the morrow, then," grinned Adora. She practically bounced on the heels of her boots as she waved them off. With a happy sigh she turned and re-entered the hall where she was met by a bemused looking Lonnie.

"Huh," offered the housekeeper, with only the faintest arch of an eyebrow. Adora adjusted her waistcoat and smiled.

"Speak your mind, you are clearly itching to do so."

"Are we about to… end the whole charade then? Or you, I mean, ma'am?"

Adora's expression faltered and she chewed her lip, "One step at a time, Lonnie."

"Because the supposed legalities your Aunt keeps harping on about, you know it's bunkum and balderdash, don't you?"

The blonde ran a hand through her cropped hair and winced, "And yet we have no documentation that says otherwise."

"Well, either way, you know my opinion on the matter, ma'am."

That made Adora roll her eyes in a far too familiar expression. She made a shooing motion, "Be off with you, wicked woman. Get thee hence to your husbands. I'm sure they have… needs or whatever it is men require."

Lonnie cackled, "None so pressing as my own, as is the prerogative of a woman! Keep that in mind; this Ms Moon seems a decent sort. A tad restrained, but I feel that is perhaps due to other issues of which I am not privy!"

"And nor shall you be! Get away with you!" Adora laughed as Lonnie gave a curtsy that *somehow* conveyed sarcasm, then departed. Adora strode to her study - it had been her father's, then Adam's, but now it was undeniably *hers* .

She had removed the hunting trophies, the boorish busts of noble men, and replaced it with books and charts - maps of her lands and holdings, lists of her various interests and ledgers of the various estates and transactions. She sat and plucked a quill from its ink stand and set to checking against her accounts - she was far too buoyed up to sleep. To be honest, she felt as if she were walking on clouds.

The only niggle in her mind was the reality of Catra's invitation - she couldn't attend Brightmoon as simply *Adora* , could she? She had inhabited the shell that was *Mister de Gray* for too long, surely? There were too many fibres, connections, and constraints?

And yet, even at its height, Lady d’Weaver had never exerted control, never enforced her vaunted claims of ownership. Adora’s scheme could have been easily overturned, surely? Of course, Lady d’Weaver would have been scandalised; that was what Adora had banked on - family pride, then the sheer arrogance of the individuals she dealt with, and their desire to avoid being humiliated. To reveal her at the start would have brought embarrassment to d'Weaver, at least on some level. And the businesses wouldn't wish to be embroiled in such a revelation, not after having engaged with Adora for so many months.

But now? Now could she cast off that cloak of deceit? What of the repercussions? The implied threat that only a *man* could own the Greyskull estate. Could she risk all that for an unknown future with a woman who had already spurned her? Risk the security of her tenants?

Adora sighed and leaned back in her chair. She smiled faintly - the thought didn’t vex her nearly as much as she expected. Catra *knew* and didn’t *care* . She seemed actually contrite and still interested. A friendship could blossom once more, perhaps. And then, well - there was no real rush. The morning would bring more questions, more considerations.

But a corner had been turned. And, for the first time in years, Adora felt *happy* .

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, I have increased the chapters to give myself some leeway. And we'll get the Beauregard / Glimmer moment SOON.
>
> AND we'll be getting some explanations of why Adora is Adam, beyond wanting to avoid being married off. THere's SHENANIGANS!

Rivers in deserts

Chapter Summary

> Catra receives a caller, words are exchange and opinions are fought against!

Chapter Notes

> PHEW! Wanted to get this shorter chapter out - I could have added more in BUUUUUT I think this is a nice little snifter as everyone has been VERY patient with me.
>
> Thank you for waiting!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was, to not put too fine a point on things, in a tizzy. A happy one, yes, but a tizzy nonetheless. Her heart was aflutter and she was not accustomed to such experiences. Her emotional range stretched from idle indifference to sardonic amusement: to be eagerly anticipating a rendezvous with an individual whom, until recently, she had held in rather low regard was alien to her. Catra wasn't sure how to particularly card through these new feelings, though she had the wherewithal to recognise that they were an amplified expansion on the feelings she had projected upon *Mister* de Gray - although those emotions were muted, near platonic, with a frisson of confused attraction.

Now, shorn of all misapprehension, she was beginning to realise that she might actually be experiencing a whole new gamut of emotional cues. To acknowledge them and put a name to these stirrings would, of course, be sensible.

Which was why she was adamantly refusing to do so and was, instead, pacing the open floor of the inns main room whilst Netossa and Spinnerella watched with an amused air.

“After all, we covered all the salient matters yesterday. I hardly think Adam… I mean Adora. I mean Mister… is it?” Catra folder her arms and spun on her heel to pace back across the room, “And we must have exhausted all topics of pertinent conversation, barring the weather and perhaps livestock husbandry.”

“A topic of interest, Catra?” offered Netossa as she sipped at a simple cup of tea.

“Hardly! But you saw her - she’s… horsey. Or he was. DO… should I….? Is it Mister de Gray here? Should I carry on the farce? The charade? Do I indulge? What… agh! This is vexing in the extreme!”

Spinnerella made an amused noise, a sort of hum mingled with sigh and placed her cross stitch into her lap. She gently smoothed her dress and smiled at the distraught young woman, “What is the preferred outcome for you, dear?”

Catra paused and frowned at the older woman, “What do you mean?”

“What would you rather happen?”

“I… don’t see….”

“Yes you do. In the round, what do you want out of this, at the minimum?”

The brunette offered a shrug, which in turn drew a scoff from Netossa, mocking the mildly petulant act. Spinnerella tutted and gestured for Catra to expand. The brunette smoothed her own dress - a white, ankle-length thing with scarlet pleats. She gave the question due consideration and paced once more, “Honestly I… well…. I came to make amends. Those have been made so, really I should be satisfied with the outcome?”

The married couple arched their eyebrows in unison, clearly practiced at such marital subtlety. Catra flung up her arms and

Netossa chortled, “Really, Catra? After the courting we were forced to watch yesterday?”

“It… that was *not* courting! I was making polite conversation and re-establishing a communicative approach after a terrible error on my part. And now it is rectified and… well.”

“So you wish for me to inform Adora that you are unavailable when she calls later?” mused Spinnerella as she returned to her cross stitch.

Catra blanched and managed to stutter a rapid “I did not say *that* . Just…”

“What do you want, Catra?” nudged Netossa, her normally brash demeanour softer now. Catra chewed her lip and hugged herself for a moment.

“...More time?” she offered, then blinked in surprise. She nodded slowly, “Yes. Time. With her. To, um… rebuild. Yes. I suppose that is it. To form a friendship, a better one. A more *honest* one. Yes.”

Spinnerella chuckled as she threaded her needle carefully, “Friends then, dear?”

“Yes. Friends,” nodded Catra.

“Um, ma’am,” came Kyle’s croaked voice from the doorway. The trio turned to look at the scraggly man. He bobbed a curtsey, then blinked and tried for a bow, “Uh, there’s a, well… I wanted to say, I got your letter to the mail coach. Should be with your family by the evening I surmise! Best coach times in the country, proud of it.”

Catra nodded slowly, “Um… thank you, uh, Kyle.”

“And uh, you have a caller. Can… I show them in?” he fidgeted and looked dazed. Catra frowned and exchanged a glance with the other two, then nodded. Kyle grinned and stepped into the

room and straightened,then coughed. He managed to clear his throat and squeaked out, “Her ladyship, Miss Adora de Gray!”

The look on his face was one of pride and, strangely, relief. Catra noted the expression and realised that, perhaps, these tenants had more than just a little bit of admiration for their lady. And perhaps a certain element of protectiveness. However, that thought was dashed away by the arrival of the woman in question.

As mentioned, Catra’s emotional gamut was normally muted - she could rival her sibling, Mermista, for her taciturn approach - her pithy observations and sarcastic fencing in dialogues. Her joy rested in books or a solid exploration of the wilderness. Emotional highs and lows were rare, aside from her temper.

Which was why she was shocked at her inability to articulate words at that precise moment. Her very soul seemed eager to vacate her corporeal form and her skin felt like it had warmed to a strange degree.

Adora was wearing a riding gear, naturally. Except unlike the attire worn by *Mister de Gray* , this particular ensemble was very much cut to fit Adora in her natural state. The trousers were grey and fitted well, with no fake bulge to mimic the masculine display, the white shirt was more akin to some sort of bodice-blouse that accentuated Adora’s clearly feminine profile, with the neck unlaced revealing just the hint of the woman’s throat; a cravat, golden in colour, was draped around her neck, but untied. The ensemble was completed by a scarlet riding jacket, which fell to the tall woman’s hips and framed her shoulders well.

Never had Catra encountered a woman so handsome, yet also refined and seemingly delicate. Now that she could observe the woman with eyes un-marred by false perception, she noted the cut of Adora’s jaw, her bearing, the quirk of her face; how the woman held herself here, without pretence or an attempt to adopt the swagger of a man.

Adora was here, in her element. Free.

And she had a rather cocky smirk on her face, to boot.

Catra heard Spinnerella giggle and shut her mouth so fast her teeth clicked. Flustered, the brunette spun and managed only a mild harrumph that came out as a bit of a raspy squeak, "Uh… Adora, um… I wasn't sure if…"

"Catra," the tone of the woman's voice was so soft, so tender, it spun Catra right around again, her face flushed. She blinked at the blonde, who had such a gentle expression on her face it almost *hurt* . Adora laughed, a tinkling sound with a light snort to it and her smile moved into a happy grin, "I wondered if I might interest you in a ride? Or even a walk? The county has much to offer and… well…"

The blonde faltered, but her smile remained, plastered to her face, even as she flushed to match Catra. The married couple between them glanced from one to the other, then exchanged a glance of their own. Netossa turned to Adora and smiled, "We will be taking in the town. I am sure Catra would love to accompany you."

Catra shot the woman a look, but it was mostly just embarrassment that spurred her. She coughed and then nodded rapidly. "Yes. A… ride would be most invigorating. When?"

"Now?" Adora offered with a slight croak to her voice.

"Now?" responded Catra. She nodded again, vigorously, "Now… works. Yes. So. Now," she smoothed her dress once more and looked down, then back up, "Will this...?"

"YES! Um, I mean, yes, that will suffice. So, please… um… this way?" Adora crooked her arm and offered Catra a smile both questioning and full of hopeful optimism that it nearly forced the brunette to put a name to those roiling emotions in her gut and her soul - those butterflies and shudders that brought naught but a smile to her face.

She stepped forwards and hooked her arm in Adora's, pausing only as Netossa stood to hand a bonnet over. Catra grinned and grasped it with her free hand, then allowed the tall blonde to practically tow her out of the inn. In the coach yard she found Adora's steed, Swift Wind, waiting with a large, bald man. The gentleman had the reins in a tight grip and just nodded to Adora.

Catra glanced at the blonde and offered a chuckle, "And where is my steed?"

Adora, for her own part, just gave a shrug, "I felt that, perhaps, we could share a mount - I wasn't aware of your proficiency and did not wish to assume competence and thus push you onto an unruly beast…" her grin was teasing, "As I know you do not suffer those well."

The brunette narrowed her eyes then smirked, "True, I do not approve of my ride's having undue opinions, particularly in regards to their rider or the direction in which they go."

Adora met her gaze and Catra had to swallow as those icy orbs fixed her in place. The blonde managed to get out the words, "I shall keep that in mind, Miss Moon," though she herself seemed to be struggling.

The moment hung, then Swift Wind snorted. The pair flinched then shared a laugh, the tension gone. Adora helped Catra up to sit side-saddle, then vaulted up to sit behind her. The blonde held the reins gently, arms partly looped around the smaller girl. She coughed and managed an embarrassed smile, but Catra just grinned at her, "Rather… close, Miss de Gray?"

"I fear I have perhaps assumed too much…" winced Adora, "Let us make for my stables and I can…"

Catra took a breath, then reached out to clasp one of Adora's wrists. She turned her head to meet the blonde's gaze, "No. This…. This works rather well. And, frankly, I would rather view your lovely county - I am not here for much longer."

Adora’s expression seemed to cloud for a moment, but it then brightened as the blonde woman smiled, “Well then, let us away. I know the perfect vantage to observe the moors!”

And with that she wheeled Swift Wind and kicked him into a trot out of the coach yard. As they hit the main track out of the village, Adora spurred him to a canter and then, once beyond the last house, into a gallop. Catra shrieked as the large white charge barrelled ahead, then shrieked again as Adora steered him to leap a fence. The brunette gripped at the blonde, who laughed as they picked up speed.

Catra clung on, and realised she had buried her head into the crook of Adora’s neck. And, to be honest, it felt like the most natural thing in the world.

She was, however, not one for riding - she knew how to, of course, but it had never struck her as a pastime worthy of particular focus. Not when carriages and carts were a *thing* . But now, arms wrapped around Adora’s neck, body nestled against the blonde’s front, she thanked the gods and stars for the invention of the *horse* .



Several hours later, Catra breezed back into the inn, eyes wide and smile etched to her face. Spinnerella was sat at one of the tables, perusing a stack of cloth - clearly a purchase from her own excursion. She looked up and smiled at Catra with a knowing air, “A pleasant outing?”

“It was… wondrous.”

“The views were good?” prodded Spinnerella.

“Views?” asked Catra, then she started with a chuckle, “Yes… the view was… was certainly good.”

“And was Miss de Gray on her best behaviour?” prompted Spinnerella once more. Catra flushed and coughed, but her smile was dream-like as she drifted to a chair to slump down. She had a wistful look to her for a moment.

“Adora… Miss de Gray was the perfect gentleman…. Gentlewoman. Though I cannot imagine why she would, well, be anything but. We are friends after all.”

“Yes. Friends,” responded Spinnerella with a dry chuckle, more reminiscent of her wife than her own gentle demeanour, “So, where did you go?”

“Adora showed me a view from the heights of the Wastes. That’s what they call it up here - a heath-land, but so patchwork in colour it is like an oil painting. Bleak and beautiful. And then we rode to a small stream and a pond up in the rocks, where a waterfall streams down. It was like something from one of Mermista’s fairy tales. I half expected some goblin or gnome to emerge from behind the waterfall!”

Catra folded her hands in her lap and sighed. The door creaked and Kyle popped his head in once more, “Anything to eat or drink, ma’am? We have cold cuts left, along with a mild ale? Or water?”

“The water will be fine, thank you. And some cuts with bread would be wonderful. Who knew riding would work an appetite…?”

“You sure it was just the ride?” grinned Spinnerella.

“Oh hush. I have not the faintest idea to what you allude,” Catra huffed, whilst also blushing like a rose. The other woman just shook her head. Catra sighed, then glanced about, “Where is Netossa?”

“She retired early. I wanted to inspect our new stock haul. There seems to be a good supply of wool and potential linens from here which I was not aware of! This could be a worthwhile trip for more than just relaxation!”

Catra's only response was to roll her eyes. When Kyle returned with the simple fare, she wasted no time on ceremony and devoured the meal. Spinnerella hummed as she worked, then glanced up at the other girl. Catra looked up from her last morsel and swallowed, before asking, "What?"

"Any plans for tomorrow, dear?"

The brunette sighed, "I am… unsure. I do hope to hear from the family, but they haven't received my missive, so I imagine a day or so before a return correspondence."

Spinnerella nodded and Catra continued to sigh to herself as she reminisced about the day. The older woman smiled, but left it alone - Catra would work it out in her own time. Or admit it to herself, perhaps.

After she finished her meal, Catra rose and turned to leave. She paused at the stairs up to the rooms and turned to look at Spinnerella. A look of uncertainty clouded her face for the merest moment and she gripped one arm tightly. The older woman noticed the tension and smoothed the piece of cloth she had unfurled before her, then smiled at the brunette, "Something irks you, dear?"

"I…. should I go call upon Adora tomorrow? I… I am unsure of the protocol and, well, she may not have the time to call tomorrow. And, not that I *like* her overmuch, but I am enjoying touring and inspecting the countryside and she does have a vast array of knowledge, this being her tenanted land and…"

"Catra, please take a moment to inhale," chided Spinnerella. The brunette huffed and managed an abashed smile. Her curls flicked as she shook her head.

"I am… I do not know *what* I am."

"I think you do, dear. But perhaps do not dwell overmuch on things. Should you awake early… a cart trip to the estate wouldn't

be amiss, perhaps?" the older woman's smile was mischievous and made Catra blush.

"It is for nothing improper! I am merely… rekindling a friendship."

Spinnerella nodded with mock seriousness, "Of course. Admirable."

"Yes."

"Which is exactly what I said when I called upon Netossa for the fifth time. Just to discuss a dress. Then fabrics. Then to comment on the weather…" she flicked a glance to the brunette and hummed innocently, "Merely to rekindle a friendship. Quite so."

Catra moved her jaw, then raised a hand, but it dropped to her side. With a huff she spun and stalked upstairs. She paused at the top, "I do not *like* her!"

The door to her room clicked shut and Spinnerella chuckled to herself quietly, "I am quite sure you don't dear."

Chapter End Notes

> Why yes, we are going to be going full on with the flirting, cutesy and ridiculous stuff now. I can promise that the angst is pretty done and now we are moving fully into ROMANCE.
>
> CREDIT to Tara: https://www.tumblr.com/blog/view/taracandycorn or @TaraCandyCorn on twitter! Hit her up and enjoy her fantastic work!
>
> Tara does some amazing work and we have a little more for the LAST chapter :D

Summer days and Setbacks

Chapter Summary

Catra makes an innocent housecall, with no ulterior motives

Letters are received

News of elsewhere is conveyed!

Spinnerella and Netossa demonstrate that they are horrendous teases.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra awoke to birdsong and the faint light of dawn through the inn's drapes. Her heart palpitated with anticipation, but of what she could not readily ascertain. This was, of course, the most feeble of lies: her innermost self was well aware of the reasoning behind her excitement. Her mind, however, was determined to remain objective and focused on rudimentary tasks. She rose, she dressed, she combed her hair in a most perfunctory manner. She then spent several long moments selecting a matching bonnet.

Kyle was, of course, awake and seemed to be tidying the various benches and tables in the main common room of the inn. He appeared startled by Catra's early appearance and also her ready attire. This was reinforced by his stuttered utterance of, "G'mornin' miss?"

"Yes, it is," Catra drawled with an easy smile. She gestured towards the kitchen doors, "May I please have a basket put together? I fancy a venture into the wilderness. Is there a cart available?"

"O...o' course miss. Though erm… where'd you be wishing to go? Takin' the cart out… well, can't be sparing the…"

"I thought I might take in the views around the Greyskull estate. I, well, I really enjoyed them. And, I noticed some, um…" Catra fiddled with her skirts for a moment. Spinnerella's words were at the forefront of her mind for the scantest moment but she brushed them away with an exhalation fit for a frustrated mare, "Well I believe there are some rather pleasant walks from near the house."

Kyle stared at her. And then a grin spread across his features. Catra frowned at it, for it appeared to be a rather knowing expression, as if there was some jest that she was unaware of. The man nodded rapidly, "Right you are miss. Give me a moment to pull a basket from the cutlets we have. I trust cold meats might suffice?" Catra nodded and Kyle continued, unphased by her frown, "And might I recommend apples. Her ladysh… I mean, the *estate* produces some fine crops and we get some bushels. Lady Adora swears by them."

"That would be… most agreeable."

"Right you are miss. Right you are. Let me put it together then I'll bring the cart around! Best you catch the morning mists, too! Don't want you fussin' and mussin'. My lady wife will arrange a return journey, should that be required."

And with that he was gone, expression positively gleeful. Catra felt mildly perturbed, but a glance out of the narrow windows of the inn raised her spirits - it was a beautiful morning.

A short while later she was in the back of a cart, trundling through the manicured forests and lanes that led towards the manor. Her heart hammered in her chest and her mind was circling through rationales and reasons.

She was merely attending a solitary picnic. She was just going to call on Adora to let her know that she would be on her lands. It

would be a courtesy. That was all. Nothing more. It was polite. And friends were polite to one another. They made one another aware of their movements. They might, should the opportunity arise, invite one another to attend functions or wanderings or even, might the occasion present itself, entirely unplanned, a picnic.

She jolted from her musings as the wheels crunched on gravel and the cart rattled to a halt. Wide eyed, Catra stared up at the pillar-flanked entrance to Greyskull Manor.

Manor was doing it a disservice, really. In the cold light of day, it was more akin to a mansion, bordering on a palace.

Rather nice, all told.

Kyle turned on the drivers bench and made a show of tugging on his cap, the innocent grin still in place. It had been etched onto his features since they'd departed from the inn, "As promised, your ladyship."

Catra huffed and adjusted her skirts, then attempted to deliver a glare, "I fear you are mistaken. I am gentleman's daughter but not a *ladyship* . That is reserved for the vaunted *high society* ."

Kyle gave a shrug, the grin not shifting a single inch, "Maybe not yet, your ladyship. Who knows, eh? Thought I'd take the Shilling and end up in some muddy field scraping nasty bits of some other poor bugger off my boots with bayonet in hand. But instead I've got a husband *and* a wife and I run my own inn! SO, never count them chickens before they're close to hatchin'."

He gave her a wink, then hopped down to help her from the cart. Catra felt dazed as she wasn't *quite* sure why she was there. Of course she had decided to go to the estate. But just to walk, of course. To take in the gardens and the woods. Of course, that was the intent.

That was derailed by the brown-haired woman at the entrance, whose countenance appeared to be warring between irked and

amused. Her arms were folded across her chest, her green-and-brown dress only mildly rumpled - probably from having been hastily donned.

Lonnie harrumphed and nodded at Kyle, “Dearest.”

“Ah, clearly I’ll be paying later. She wanted to be a-bed a bit longer I fear!” Kyle managed in a stage whisper. On the steps Lonnie harrumphed and rolled her eyes. She gave Catra the once over and smirked.

“Mistress Catra, wasn’t expecting you back so soon. Here to gander and purview our noble portraits? Or are you intending breakfast?” her manner was brusque, arch but with a potential hint of something else. Catra couldn’t quite read it, so befuddled was she with her own thoughts.

In response, the young Ms Moon raised her basket and managed, “Just, um, considering the grounds for a picnic. Should that be permitted.”

Lonnie nodded slowly, “Well I am sure that will be quite all right. Allow me to raise the Mistress.”

“Oh that won’t be nec-”

“Come now, don't dally! You may use the yellow drawing room. Barely gets used these days. Lady d’Weaver prefers the *scarlet* room. Better for her vapours or some rot. Not seen her in an age, thank the stars.”

Catra felt Kyle gently nudge her forwards and turned as the young man scampered back to the cart. With a crack of reins the vehicle trundled around and away, back down the path. Ms Moon blinked and then jolted as Lonnie coughed meaningfully, then let herself be steered into a rather airy room, “This really is not necessary. I was just… calling to…”

“Yes, well, wait a moment and I will fetch some tea. Can’t have your ladyship wandering the morning without a fortifying brew.

My husbands wouldn't let me hear the end of it, that I can assure you."

Catra sputtered at her not being a formal *lady* , but it was lost as Lonnie bustled out. A bell rang in the distance and Catra frowned, then froze as she heard a distant grumbling and huffing. Feet scuffed on tiles and a figure stumbled past the door with a petulant yell of "Lonnie!"

A muffled response that could have been *"Yes?"* returned from elsewhere, likely some nearby servants room for tea making.

"Who the devil is calling so early? Do they not know what time it is? I frankly think it's rather uncalled for!"

Catra stared at the tousled figure of Adora, clad in a night-dress and little else. The woman's hair was a mess of blonde frizz, quite unkempt. Of course what really drew the young woman's attention was the form of the woman. The rather defined form. Her mind flashed back to the glimpse she had caught, many many weeks prior, at Thaymor Manor, at the start of this debacle.

Of course, as Catra stared, Adora turned. Lonnie's muffled voice could be heard uttering *Drawing room* or something similar, which made the blonde pivot like a surprised spinning top.

The yelp she let out was endearing and surprising. Adora stepped hastily back from the room's doorway and Catra heard a thud and a curse as something collided with something markedly wooden. Carefully, Catra craned forwards and allowed herself a small smile, "Hello, Adora?"

Slowly, a blonde head peered around the corner, flushed and bleary eyed. Then Adora's face broke into a lopsided smile that made Catra's own features flush. That only deepend at the fond utterance of "Catra," that came from the woman's smiling lips. Then Adora blinked and coughed. She averted her eyes, yet her smile did not fade, "Miss Moon. I am… I did not expect you. I

was… I was considering, perhaps, calling upon you and well, seeing if, well you…"

Catra tapped the basket on the floor next to her, voice temporarily lost amidst the flush of thoughts. Adora, for her part, took in the wicker receptacle and nodded rapidly. Then, with a sudden cry of *one moment!* She vanished.

Lonnie entered through a second door and set a small tea set down on the low table in front of Catra, "Here you are miss. I trust her ladyship has promised to show you some interesting sights and vistas, beyond that which you have not yet experienced?"

Catra's gaze flicked to the housekeeper, but Lonnie's face was that of neutral curiosity and professionalism. Catra narrowed her eyes, "I believe so."

"Indeed miss. And your mothers are not joining you today?"

Catra nearly choked on her tea as she supped from the dainty cup. She shot Lonnie another look, then grinned widely, "Oh I shall tell them you said *that* ."

"Please do convey such. I hope to look so good when I am a mother," Lonnie smirked ever so slightly.

"They are not my mothers."

"Ah…. companions?" the word came out with a suggestion and a hint of suspicion. Catra huffed.

"Not in the slightest. Confidants, perhaps. Support. Friends. I have no need of… companions."

"Indeed not, I'm sure, Mistress," Lonnie nodded and then curtseyed, "But need and want, well… I know how they can be confused."

Before Catra could riposte to the presumptive woman she was interrupted by the rapid-fire clatter of boots and the arrival of a near breathless Adora. The woman wore a set of britches, covered in a split riding skirt and a jacket. It was a grey ensemble, feminine in its cut. A mixture of male and female styles that Catra had never seen the like of. Overall it suited the blonde. Adora gave a short bow, then extended her hand with a faint smile, "Shall we?"

Catra nodded and plucked the basket up. As the pair made their way out of the mansion and onto the gravel path, Lonnie watched from a window. She smiled to herself and blew out a breath, then nodded to herself, "She'll do. She'll do *very* well."

Their picnic was a quiet affair. Yet it seemed not much needed to be said. They spoke in terms that led to the other finishing the thought, pointed out notable sights - trees, birds, trails. Companionable silence prevailed, no attempts to fill the void.

They settled down at the edge of a lake and Adora couldn't help but remember the day she had emerged from the bushes, soaking, to find Catra awaiting her like a dream. A glance to her side showed Catra's blush and that made Adora consider that, perhaps, their minds were as one on the topic.

"Will you be staying much longer?" Adora prodded. Catra nodded slowly.

"A few more days. I still have not received word from my sister. I do not wish to miss her communique."

"Indeed. Though I imagine a letter from said sibling might require a carthorse to deliver, given her predilection for conversation?"

Catra huffed, then nudged Adora's shoulder playfully, "That, *Miss de Gray* , is a rude and mean spirited commentary."

Adora hummed and shrugged, “And?”

“And also not without merit. However, she is family and I must defend her honour.”

“Quite so. And you do so admirably. But who will consider the plight of the horses?”

After their picnic the pair returned to the house - the hour was drawing later into the afternoon, as their meanderings had clearly taken them longer than anticipated. Adora glanced up, then back at Catra who hugged herself out of a sudden shift towards uncertainty, “I suppose I must beg an indulgence? Have you a cart or carriage I might make use of to…”

Adora reached out tentatively and touched Catra’s shoulder, “Ask and it is yours, Ms Moon. But would you, perhaps, permit me to provide you with conveyance on Swiftwind? I would beg a little longer of your company. It is good to have companionship.”

Catra gazed at her, the concept warring with a deeper, more entrenched idea, which itself was mired in a stubborn fear. But Adora’s kind eyes and soft expression forced a nod from the young gentlewoman, along with a smile, “That would be… most kind.”

Once more Catra found herself perched atop the mighty steed, enveloped in Adora. The ride was over far too soon for Catra’s liking, though such thoughts she did not readily admit. The idea of being in the inn vexed her suddenly.

Adora slid from the horse first, then helped Catra down. As the smaller woman landed, she stumbled forwards and found herself pushed against Adora’s taller frame. It felt natural to be within those arms, hands against Adora’s collar. Their faces mere inches from one another. Such proximity was scandalous; even at a dance, this would be seen as familiar in ways seen only by the common folk; to gentry it was a possible step into impropriety.

And yet Catra could not summon the will to care. She stared up into blue-grey eyes that bored into her own amber and cerulean orbs. The emotion therein was strong - not an echo of what she had seen weeks prior, but an affirmation. Were that look a declaration it would rattle windows and send birds to the sky with it's vehemence.

"There you are! We worried you'd elo- OH!" Netossa's bark of a voice carried across the yard, but cut short. Catra jolted backwards as if pinched, while Adora just stared. Even as Catra pulled away, Adora's hands never lost their touch and just trailed down from Catra's shoulders, then her arms, to rest against her wrists. Not a tight grip, but a reminder of her presence.

Catra would have bolted. She was prone to flights, she knew. But now she had no desire to. That touch stilled her shock, her natural inclination to scoff and dart away. She glanced across at Netossa; the woman look chagrined and offered a sheepish smile to the younger woman - clearly aware of what she had just, potentially, blundered into.

Adora coughed and then released Catra's hands. The loss of touch felt like an ache and Catra's gaze flashed back to the tall blonde. Adora offered a smile, soft and genuine, "Thank you, Ms Moon. A truly wonderful surprise."

With a breath Catra managed to get out, "Would you please join us for dinner?" Netossa made a faint noise that could have been a suppressed yelp. Then the older woman nodded and backed into the inn, positively vibrating. Adora did not appear to notice - her lopsided grin had returned.

"I would be delighted, provided I am not imposing."

"Not. Not at all. No. Not at all, please. Yes. Dinner!" Catra managed with a curt nod. She turned to the inn, then paused, turned back to Adora, "Thank you," she turned back, then turned again, "Do you need to…. Change or…?"

Adora arched an eyebrow, “Would you, um... care for me to join you for…?”

“Cards. We have cards. Also a book. I brought a book.”

“You appear to have lost the gift of verbosity, Ms Moon.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed - banter and cajoling were where she was most comfortable, “Are you afraid you might lose? Or be bested by one of the lower orders?”

“Mr Beauregard is not here, so no,” quipped Adora, “And I see only equals,” she added softly. Catra flushed again and harrumphed internally. *Adora* appeared much more gifted at charm than *Mister de Gray* . She tilted her chin back and adjusted her bonnet.

“Well then, I suggest you decide whether you wish to change and return or risk being bested.”

“I believe my staff have a saying for this. It goes, *you are on* .”

“On what?”

“I have no idea. Shall we, Ms Moon?”

The following day dawned and Catra sighed happily. Her heart felt lighter than it had in weeks. A thoroughly pleasant day, followed by an evening of amusing conversation and hearty food. And she had handily beaten Adora at cards as well. She had taken Adora’s jacket as a prize and the other woman had handed it off with an eye roll so exaggerated it could have only been for show.

Was this what her stories were about? This giddy feeling and sense of knowing?

She jiggled in the bed and grinned broadly, then caught herself and harrumphed. With an arch air and her chin cocked, Catra sat up and smoothed her night dress. Then she caught a glimpse of herself in the mirror and grinned again.

"Maybe… maybe I can, potentially… it may be that Ms de Gray is not quite as boorish as I had initially surmised."

A knock on the door drew her gaze and she slid from the bed to pull on a robe, "Yes?"

"Beggin' yer pardon Mistress, letters for you."

"Oh! My thanks. I will take them over breakfast, if you would be so kind."

"Yes Mistress," Kyle sounded chirpy, clearly possessed of a buoyant mood. And Catra felt a kinship in that moment. Of course he had two hearts to echo the beat of his. She never needed one, she had always believed.

But mayhap she did *want* one?

A few moments later, dressed in a dark brown dress, she descended to the main room. Netossa and Spinnerella sat, already making the most of the generous spread of eggs and toasted bread. Spinnerella smiled at Catra s the young woman seated herself, then dabbed at her mouth.

"We were just going to head out to inspect one of the linen shops. Would you care to join us?"

"Ah, well, while that does sound oh so very entertaining, I have some letters to catch up on."

Netossa chuckled over her teacup, "Yes. It *is* fascinating. But I will not try to teach a heathen who cannot grasp beauty and wonder…"

Catra gave Netossa a flat stare and sighed, "Forgive me if I cannot find the entertainment in a yarn ball. I am not some… housecat that plays with a dangling string."

"Ah it is so much *more* ," hummed Spinnerella. She shrugged, "But one cannot force entertainment nor fascination. We can but lead you to it. Your deft hands might have a talent for it, but I think the quill is, perhaps, more your implement of choice?"

Netossa arched an eyebrow, "Let us not talk of deft hands, my love. We would not wish to give the young lady ideas!"

Spinnerella clucked and swatted at her wife with a napkin, "Incorrigible, beastly woman."

Catra glanced between them, bemused, "I can assure you I have no need to weave threads. I cannot fathom why tangling ones fingers up, even with such wondrous creations as a result, is in any way enjoyable."

Netossa stared at her then bit her lip to hide some snort or other. Catra frowned as the older woman wheezed for a moment and then fanned herself. Spinnerella stared at the ceiling, eyes wide and lips pursed as she shook gently from suppressed giggles. Then the pair fell against each other laughing. Catra glared, then folded her arms.

"Sorry, dear, sorry. Forgive us our, *ahem* , private jokes. Maybe one day, you and Adora can be in on it too?" Netossa gave Catra rather intense stare, then arched an eyebrow. Catra just waved her off.

"You are both insufferable. Begone! I will, I am sure, dine with you later."

Giggling, the married pair departed, leaving a thoroughly confused Catra at the table. Idly, she picked up her stack of letters - a good FIVE. Several were stamped with other regional marks, meaning they had clearly been delivered elsewhere. She noted Scorpia's handwriting on the earlier ones, indicating her determined Cousin

had redirected them. That gave Catra pause and she smiled fondly. A good woman, that one.

The first letter was a missive from the family, wishing her well and denoting some idle gossip. Captain Hordak and some of the other officers (Notably one Lieutenant Hawk) had called upon the house and taken the young ladies for a walk, under the supervision of Mr Moon. The village remained quiet, though Aunt Casta was now apparently a regular visitor to the house, much to Mrs Moon's consternation. Or rather, the fawning Aunt Casta and her new lodger did over one another caused some mild irritation. Mainly because Mrs Moon believe the pair should take the bullock by the horns and become a formal couple.

Mr Moon concurred and had had a quiet word with his sister. An update would be forthcoming!

The second letter was a well-wishing one from Scorpia and Perfuma, as well as a thank you for visiting. Catra folded it away carefully and made a note to respond - she was notoriously bad at following through but she felt she owed her cousin.

The third letter was an update - Aunt Casta and Juliet were to be wed! Also, a mention that Mermista had spurned Lieutenant Hawk's advances. And also that Mermista had then sought the gentleman out at the tavern after he had begun singing, notably about her and her particular honour and virtue as a woman of unsurpassed nobility. Also, several women had commented to Mermista that none of them were able to begin courting the gentleman as he refused all conversation.

Glimmer believed a wedding announcement was very likely.

Catra chuckled at that and folded that one away - she would respond to the latest.

The fourth letter was a much more intense affair:

Dearest Catra,

A fortuitous and most welcome state of events has occurred! I am a tizzy and agog. I am bewildered and flabbergasted and suffused with joy that I must appear to sparkle to any who take a view of me.

Today, I was ready to walk the village and consider the young gentlemen there, or perhaps even to the Court in Elberon, as my duties as eldest demand. However, our weather took a turn for the particularly vile. Thunderstorms the like of which we have not seen since our younger days! Truly, we are fearful for the harvest, but that is a story perhaps for an almanac!

Suffice to say, we were ensconced within the hall. A dreadful night to be out - either in a carriage or, perhaps worse, upon horseback. Well, as you can no doubt imagine, our consternation when the maid entered announcing a visitor! Of course, she appeared concerned but asked for Mr and Mrs Moon only. This, in turn roused our curiosity! So, naturally we hunkered close to the door.

A gentleman caller no less! I am sure you cannot guess who it was! Well, I must say that neither did I!

Of course we had to move with haste back to our seats, but so rushed were we that Frosta accidentally sewed her embroidery into the arm of mother's couch. Mermista had her book wrong-side up and I ended up drinking from the milk jug. Truly without your co-ordinating presence, we are at a loss!

I must admit I nearly had a momentary faint when the gentleman walked in! Mr Buearegard Archer!

When I roused from my momentary stupor I was both intrigued and incensed! This gentleman, who had so rudely departed, now back in our home!

The gentleman in question was spared a particularly heavy tea set to the forehead, however - I must admit I was rather emotional at this juncture, as you can well envisage! Indeed, I felt

your very spirit charging me to run this gadabout from the house. Your words about his character and standing fired me to me core.

Catra groaned at that and rested her head in her palm for a moment. She bit her lip and continued on.

However, he then knelt on the floor before me, soaked to the bone, shivering. He asked for a mere moment of my time, then promised he would depart if that was what I wished.

Honestly, Catra, I am afraid you might be ashamed of me - for I granted him his wish. His visage was a man so full of desperate hope and fear. It melted my armour.

He conveyed that he had met with you, which surprised me! I had thought you would journey straight to the North, but was advised by Mr Archer that you called upon his family. That you were entertained when I was not was a point of discomfort, but he stated that you had come under a banner of truce to discuss his actions. He has said, however, that what was discussed is something I should engage direct with you, which is most intriguing and also mildly vexing! What promises did you extract or threats convey?

I believe we are overdue a conversation, dearest sister!

Catra's eyes widened at that. Whilst she was sure it was written in jest, she was most unsure of her own reception on her return home.

My suspicions of his intent were allayed on his admittance that he had ridden straight from Elberon, not even pausing to rest, post his meeting with yourself. I must thank you for your words, even if he has been less than straightforward. All he has said is that there was a grave misunderstanding and that you had conveyed a hope that his intents were pure. He misconstrued this as you disapproving of the pairing, he has said, but would not elaborate on the words. He has subsequently apologised for his hasty

withdrawal and ungentlemanly behaviour, for he felt ashamed and unworthy!

Unworthy! A fine as gentleman as he, and he considers himself unworthy of me! Catra, my heart is aflame with joy.

I must admit that mother and father looked perturbed and perplexed. Of course, Mr Archer stood and reiterated an apology to them for his behaviour, but once again stated that it was done out of a concern that he was seen as unsuitable and was in grief that he would be unable to be considered as husbandly potential!

Well, you can imagine father's reaction - a shift from terrifying protector to reassuring and encouraging paternalism!

Mother, of course, asked his stated intention and you will not guess his words!

Perhaps you will. You are aggravatingly perceptive at times.

"He proposed, Glimmer?" cackled Catra.

He proposed, Catra! He requested permission, there and then, to wed me and said he would quit if he was not required, with an apology for bothering us at such a time, but that he would respect our choices. That he had only space in his heart for me and that he had already delivered a message to the county agents to ensure Thaymor was once more leased - but that he would endeavour to purchase it should I agree!

I bet you cannot guess my answer, because of course mother and father asked me!

This gave Catra pause - had she hardened Glimmer's heart overmuch? Poisoned the well? With a frown, she soldiered onwards.

I answered in the affirmative! We are to be wed!

Truly, I am the happiest I have ever been, dearest sister. I do not know by what angels you managed this, what whims and arguments you employed, but you have done me the greatest of services. You have returned a man I thought lost to me. I fervently hope that one day you can experience joy like this. You are so deserving of it, my dearest, kindest and most selfless of sisters.

Now, I must go, for unfortunately it appears Mr Archer has once again caught a cold from staying in the rain. We appear to have former a habit!

Best wishes and much love,

Your faithful sister,

Glimmer Moon

Catra exhaled heavily and sat back in her chair. A weight had lifted that she had not been aware she was carrying. She chuckled to herself and set the letter down, then paused as soft cough announced a presence at the door. She glanced up and could not help the smile that split her face. She rose, rapidly, almost stumbling in her haste.

"Ms de Gray!"

Adora smiled from the doorway, her wide lopsided grin enhanced by the twinkle in her grey-blue eyes, "Ms Moon. I trust I am, um, not interrupting? I can return at a more convenient time?"

"No! I mean, yes, always, please always return, but no, not interrupting," Catra flushed and beckoned Adora in, then gestured at the table. She frowned at Adora's smug expression, "Hush."

"I did not make any utterance!"

"You, you were thinking something!"

"Was I? So, I may join you."

“You may. And please, help yourself, I am merely catching up on correspondences.”

“Breakfast? You must hold me in high regard.”

“I… I do not! You are merely a frustrating individual whom insists on my company, whom I tolerate!” Catra tried to hide the quirk of her smile. Adora nodded slowly.

“Indeed. You are fond of me. How vexing for you.”

Catra just scoffed and brushed her hair over one ear. She studiously ignored Adora and opened the final letter. She glanced at the blonde who was *trying* to appear dainty in her inhalation of the breakfast meal. However, Adora had demonstrated she was a hearty eater. Not messy, but certainly enthusiastic. It wasn’t repulsive - it was endearing - this was a woman who enjoyed food, enjoyed experiences and, here, seemed unabashed in demonstrating thus.

Catra turned her gaze back to the letter and frowned. Her face paled and her ears began to ring. A voice came through, muffled as her breaths hitched.

“Catra?” Ms Moon looked up sharply and her heart twisted in grief - hopes dashed by this news.

“Adora…” Catra’s voice was broken. Ms de Gray immediately rounded the table and pulled a chair up next to Catra.

“What? What is it?”

Catra waved the letter, but her throat felt constricted. Eventually she managed to gasp out the words, “Entrapta! She… she has eloped!”

Adora’s eyes bulged, “What? May I?”

“It’s…” Catra limply handed the letter over, her amber-and-blue eyes meeting with Adora's grey-blue, “It’s…. *Hordak* .”

Chapter End Notes

OH NO! A cliffhanger! From Jezmatron? HOW UNHEARD OF!

What could this elopement mean? WE SHALL FIND OUT!

however, I will be deviating from the novel's beats a tad - mainly because the ANGST was ratcheted up for most of this work so far. And I think I want to demonstrate how these two are going to be a PAIR.

Also, Catra as Lizzie has more gorram AGENCY here. MORE TO SHOW SOON ;)

AN errand of urgency

Chapter Summary

Communication is the bedrock of any relationship.

An errand is run.

And a twist observed in the tale.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra felt particularly discombobulated. The repercussions of such a foolish act would ripple beyond the simple reality of Entrapta absconding. There would be consequences, reputational impacts, circles of society would ever change with regard to their standing.

Against her will, Catra's eyes found the noble countenance of Miss Adora de Gray. The woman had a thin vertical line between her eyebrows, indicating the intensity with which she scrutinised the letter. Adora's fingers flexed and Catra noted how the woman's throat tensed as she took in the meaning.

A sick feeling, not unlike dread, began to settle across Catra's body - it began within her gut and spread to her fingers, which she clasped tightly together. It was a sense of loss, but of something she had not yet had. It was perplexing, given their tentative friendship. Of course that was now likely sundered. Yes, Adora had her own difficulties, but a scandal such as this would only draw more scrutiny. And Adora worked hard to maintain the name of the de Gray lineage, that she knew.

Catra would be tainted by this and, in being so tarred, would taint others.

A sudden movement from the taller woman jolted Catra's attention. She watched as the blonde began to pace, listened as the blonde muttered to herself.

"Preposterous. To… this will...No, this… this is shameful. Outrageous. I cannot. Cannot…"

Catra's fists clenched, "Please, *madame* , I would beg you depart now, for… this unseemly dalliance appears to have now run its course and…"

"I must go. Yes. I must," Adora nodded, her face set, jaw hard. She pivoted And Catra could not help but let out a scoff. In spite of herself, her knowledge of Adora's own circumstance, she couldn't help but feel hurt.

"And like that we are done…"

Adora paused at the door, then turned, her face a mask of confusion, "Ms Moon?"

"I mean, I understand the impropriety and…"

“Ms Moon, do you mean to say you believe I am absconding due to some… *infectious* social disease this news would imply?”

Adora’s tone was arch, level, not quite cold. Catra swallowed as she saw those blue eyes, those oceans of intensity, bore into her. She opened her mouth but could not quite muster words. Adora stepped back into the room a pace and cocked her head. Catra managed a simple, “I believe that, yes, my family will be… embarrassed by this and… I am sure you would…”

“Ms Moon, do you wish to have the possibility of marriage in your future? Let us put aside the personages involved, but the possibility, the *potentia* ? To persons unknown, yes, but the probability? Do you wish for this in your future? Yes. Or. No.”

“I… I now do… wish for the *possibility* . On my terms,” Catra felt befuddled. Adora took another step closer.

“And this recent act, as we both understand it, threatens that, does it not?”

“It… it does. My family’s reputation would be… ruined. Sullied. It… Glimmer’s nuptials would be threatened.”

“I thoroughly doubt that,” chuckled Adora, “Bow is not so easily dissuaded, only on matters of honour that could impact those he loves. If anything, this will merely make their union a sure thing, for it will insulate your sister from reputational harm. Also he usually cares not a whit for that sort of thing. But you distract me

from my line of enquiry."

Catra had stood as Adora advanced and now backed up as the taller woman strode across the room with a determined air, "Ms de Gray, I understand what you are implying and you need not lay out my tribulations so… coldly."

"Pray indulge me, madame," Adora announced. Catra swallowed as she felt her back touch the wall. Adora loomed above her, not quite crowding her in, but thoroughly in her orbit and a focus of her attention, "You wish to get married, as discussed, to persons unknown at some unspecified point in the future. I am sure said personages would appreciate the simplest options available and would like to see you happy, contented and unburdened by scandal that could engulf your family. This incident impedes such a happy event from occurring. As such, as your friend and someone to whom you matter a great deal to, it is incumbent upon me to aid in resolving this issue that could cause you strife in your stipulated goals of attaining a contented future."

Catra blinked, "That… I'm sorry?"

"My lady, Miss Moon, I am to set off for Elberon, to resolve this debacle. *Mister* Hordak is a demon from my own past. As such, I feel it is upon me to deal with him as I failed to adequately do so before. I failed, as your friend, to protect you and yours from his influence, though aware of his character was my perception. I will seek to correct this error. I know that our communication, or lack therein, has caused friction and misunderstandings, perhaps beyond what I know already. I do not wish for that to be the case going forwards. I see that you believed I was about to abandon you, to fly into the morning and never speak to you again?"

Catra nodded, “That… is not an inaccurate assessment of my beliefs, indeed.”

“Then I hope I have disabused you of said notion and instead convinced you of my sincere belief that your future happiness, either via marriage to persons as yet unknown, or into a happy spinsterhood of writing and indulging your sisters, is my sole goal at this juncture. And it would be my main priority, of that you can be assured, on many fronts. Without expectation or reserve. I assumed you would wish to return to your holdings to be with your family, hence my intent and speed - this is an unpleasant event and I believe that the security provided by loved ones and those close to you will be a balm.”

Adora stepped back and smoothed down her jacket, then adjusted the riding skirts she wore. Catra watched as the woman gave her a half bow, half curtsey, then blinked as Adora turned away to the door once more. Her mind finally clicked into motion and she lunged forwards. Her hand gripped Adora’s wrist and she yanked back. Her strength was not sufficient to pull the woman back, but it did arrest her withdrawal.

“Adora, wait.”

The blonde turned, her face slightly flushed. Her eyes dipped down to Catra’s grip - not in an accusatory manner but almost with tender surprise. Catra swallowed once more and straightened up. Her hand slid down and her fingers entangled with Adora’s. The blonde licked her lips ever so quickly and blinked, “Ms Moon?”

“You are headed to Elberon?”

“Yes.”

“To confront Hordak and my sister?”

“Indeed.”

Catra jutted her jaw out, “And knowing my character as you do, in what particular life did you envisage I would not wish to accompany you on such an errand, to confront this beastly man myself and levy a particular judgement upon him?” she arched an eyebrow and tossed her head, her brown curls bouncing momentarily.

Adora arched an eyebrow of her own and a smile ghosted across her face, “I see. As we can observe, this communication proactivity is clearly bearing fruit.”

“So, you will not dash off, like some knight of yore, with naught but a hairbrained plan. This is *my* family. And my responsibility as well. And, quite frankly, Ms de Gray, your companionship is more than balm enough,” this last was delivered while Catra studiously stared at a patch of wall to her right and, pointedly, not at Adora. All the while her cheeks burned.

Adora coughed and nodded, “May I please have my hand back? I am enjoying this, but it is impeding my requisitioning of a

carriage."

"Not a bother ma'am!" came an enthusiastic exhortation from the doorway. Kyle leaned into the room and waved, "I'll get right on that from the big house! If you and the miss wouldn't mind ridin' up, it'll be good to go when you get there!"

Catra, surprised, tried to pull back, but Adora's grip was firm. She flushed once more and looked down at their entwined fingers, "You wanted your hand back," she managed in a dazed voice. Adora pursed her lips and nodded.

"True," she released her fingers as Kyle sprinted away, "But the delay was most welcome. Are your companions awake?"

"They are afield, I am afraid. Sprightly, though I think their sleep was a troubled one. A lot of creaking and discontented noises from the rooms last night."

Adora's face appeared studiously blank and she nodded, "Indeed. Indeed. *Indeed*. So. A carriage. I feel perhaps a note left with Kyle and Rogelio might be in order. I would not wish to… interrupt. Or disturb. No. No."

Catra nodded, "Of course. Shall we?"

"A cart to the house, then we will take a carriage."

And with that, Catra bolted from the breakfast room, body aflutter with emotions she could not quite pinpoint - relief, certainly, but coupled with a giddy excitement and anticipation. Her packing was best compared to an enthusiastic gale and within moments her cases were in the main room. For a brief moment she panicked that Adora had taken the opportunity to flee, that the words were a pretty distraction; a means to disentangle with noble intent and nary a plan to follow through.

And then Adora was there, hands plucking the cases from the floor, an easy smile on her face, "Your note? For the ladies?"

Catra nodded and set quill to parchment, notifying her friends of her whereabouts and promising to make up for her abrupt departure. She paused as she noticed Adora had moved beside her, "Yes, Ms de Gray?"

"If I may be so bold, they are at liberty to visit the house and take tea. I have asked Kyle to inform Lonnie. They are also welcome to dine and take in the settings for as long as they are in the area. I can have a bed made up… in a larger room. Inform them it is a discrete location."

Catra frowned at that, "I will do so. Though I am unsure… well, it is your gift to offer. Thank you… Adora."

The blonde's smile was akin to a smirk, "I am sure they will take full advantage."

Shortly they were away - the cart journey in the early morning mists a strangely quiet affair - muted sounds and the call of wood-pigeons gave it an ethereal quality as the wagon creaked over gravel. The transition to a comfortable carriage, with plush seats, was a welcome change. Catra, buoyed by anticipation, found herself watching the countryside whistle past as their driver set an aggressive, but not unreasonable pace. Adora had boarded straight away, not even pausing to change, a fact that raised itself in Catra's mind an hour into their journey.

"Adora, your attire!"

The blonde glanced down at herself and frowned.

And then she shrugged, "A matter of priorities. It cannot be helped now."

"But… your reputation, your…"

Adora's blue eyes once more locked onto Catra, "I stated my set priorities, Ms Moon. And I am a woman of my word."

And with that, Adora pulled out a notebook from within her jacket and began to thumb through it, face a mask of intense scrutiny. A nub of charcoal was also produced and Adora set to scribing annotations. Catra noticed that the woman poked her tongue out as she did this.

It was remarkably adorable. How apt.

"What are you doing?"

"Refreshing my memory as to known acquaintances, debtors and locales where Hordak is known to spend his days. *Captain* Wickham may be attending a mess function, visiting the barracks or perhaps idling somewhere. But he is not an itinerant sort - no bar room debauchery for him. Would your sister have a preferred venue? They will likely make for a more relaxed and permissive arena within the city, or for shores anew should their goal be to wed."

"Frankly I am surprised Entrapta even considered it. She has expressed no romantic affiliations. The closest she has intimated is whether someone is in possession of a functional workshop."

Adora raised an eyebrow, "That… is interesting. Perhaps you are not as aware of your sister's inner thoughts as you believed?"

Catra bristled but saw that Adora was merely curious, raising a point, not delivering snide commentary. She exhaled, "Perhaps. But this would be a breach of habit never before seen."

The other woman nodded, then made a note, "Well then. Let us hope opportunities present themselves. After all, much hangs in the balance."

Catra met her gaze and licked her lips, “Yes. I am quite sure it does.”

Several hours later Catra awoke as the carriage rattled across an uneven set of cobbles. She grumbled, then glanced up and blushed.

During the journey she had moved to sit next to Adora as they discussed notes and formulated a potential plan. As the hours had gone by, both had felt the dwindling effects of excitement and slipped into a gentle slumber, lulled by the rocking of the carriage.

Now she sat, propped against Adora’s shoulder. The other woman had draped a blanket across them both, then wrapped another about the pair of them, her arm across Catra’s shoulder.

It was two women just sharing the warmth as the air had cooled. Two friends, dozing together.

But as she looked up at Adora’s sleeping face, uncreased by worry, unmarred by expectation, peaceful, she knew the lie for what it was.

She understood her own mind and her feelings. Where with Scorpia she had felt affection and some measure of tolerance, here she felt a sense of kinship. Where with Perfuma she had an amused friendship, here she felt observed and understood.

They had danced around it, of course. Catra had damn near torched it to the ground. But Adora and her bumbling approach, her dogged kindness and exuberant, welcoming approach: it had wormed its way in. Even when Adora had been Adam to her, that underlying intrigue, that confident approach had reeled her in. She had sensed the depth, noted the intelligence and *honour* beneath it.

Which was perhaps why she had reacted so poorly to those misunderstandings - her disappointment had been vast. Her confusion, immeasurable. She always prided herself on being able to take the measure of any and all, so to have gotten it (To her mind at the time) so wrong was a slap akin to the challenge to a duel.

But now she felt naught but relief and hope. Perhaps there was something here that could grow. Adora appeared amenable - she had, after all, proposed even before Catra had been aware of circumstance. She idly pondered how Adora would have, inevitably, broached the topic. She was sure it would have come up at some point. Maybe when they needed to take ablutions? Or perhaps if there was an incident with clothing being damaged.

She did not feel any urge to pull away, of course. Instead she just reached up to tap Adora's draped arm. Sleepy blue eyes fluttered open and a dozy smile spread across Adora's face, "Hello."

“Hello, Ms de Gray. You snore.”

Adora’s eyes widened in shock, then settled into mildly irritated mirth, “I do not.”

“ANd how would you know? The driver was complaining the whole way that there was a wasps nest within the carriage.”

“You are an insufferable little thing, are you not? And I believed Glimmer to be the obnoxious one. Clearly, I was under a misapprehension.”

“Oh she’s obnoxious. I am just an irritant.”

“Well I should apply a salve. AS I am, apparently, a balm to you,” again that sleepy smirk graced Adora’s face.

Catra flushed, “Hush. Lest your caterwauling wakes the neighbourhood.”

“It is but early evening. And I doubt our hosts will be bothered by our attendance.”

“Hosts?”

“Indeed. While I own property in the town, none is set up for me to dwell within. Rents and all that. No… no… I believe the Archers will be content to host us.”

Catra blinked and nodded slowly, “Oh.”

“Oh?”

“I did call on them before we made our way North… are… well, I hope they won’t mind us merely arriving unannounced.”

“Lance and George are most tolerant. Being the parents of their brood, they have developed remarkable coping skills with regard to unannounced arrivals.”

The carriage rattled to a stop and the driver dismounted. Moments later the door opened and Adora stepped out, then turned to help Catra alight. Lamplight from the gas-lights that lined the streets made Catra blink owlishly and she looked up at the entryway to the Archer abode. Adora spoke briefly to the driver, who then unloaded their cases. Already the door was open and Lance was there, long hair braided and spectacles gleaming in the iight.

“Adam… wait…?” he looked surprised and then overjoyed, “Adora?”

The blonde woman smiled, although slightly nervously, “Hello, Mr Archer. May we come in? My apologies for imposing, but it is a matter of import.”

“You don’t even need to ask. And… Catra?” a strange look passed across his face - not hostile, but rather the look of a man rapidly trying to follow a thread. Then he beamed, “You are *both* very welcome. We shall get a room... “ he paused and grinned, “Sorry… *rooms* set up for you.”

Catra was doing her best impression of a prize beetroot at this juncture. It appeared Adora was in the same competition. Their pair nodded, jerkily, at the same instance. Adora, however, did not hesitate to grab Catra’s hand and lead her up the stairs and into the house.

What felt like mere seconds later, but was perhaps more likely minutes or half hours, the senior Archers were sat in their library, with Adora and Catra opposite, brandies in hand, as Adora laid out their conundrum - finding the erstwhile couple within the city.

George leaned forwards and steepled his fingers, “As you can no doubt surmise, we do not exactly circulate in circles where such insalubrious events occur. Perhaps try the less scrutinised religious venues?”

Lance sighed, “Or the harbour, to quiz the potential passenger manifests?”

Adora sighed and tapped her lisp as she leaned back on a chaise, “Perhaps. I will be vetting my business contacts - they will know if Wickham has attempted loans or to make use of his stipend paid by the estate.”

Catra sipped her drink and grimaced, “A shame there is no engineering locale. I would bet Adora’s income for the year that Entrapta would attend such a place, marriage be damned,” sipped again then noticed George looking at her strangely, “What… am I not drinking this correctly?” she looked at her bulbous glass, “Should I…”

“Engineering?” queried Lance. George nodded slowly.

Catra shrugged, “She is fascinated with all things mechanical. ANy opportunity….”

“The university has one of the premier colleges of engineering and scientific knowledge under its purview. They are holding an exhibition this week. A world fair on progress and innovation.”

All four exchanged glances. Adora quirked an eyebrow, “You think that perhaps?”

“Even if Hordak has plans to elope, there is no way he will be able to pry her away from such an opportunity.”

“Then what are we waiting for?” Adora stood, at the ready. Lance laughed.

“For the place to open. Adora it is nine in the evening.”

“That is an excellent point, well made and I… think I need a rest not gained from an upright seating position,” Adora nodded, curtly, with a faint blush. Catra giggled and shook her head fondly.

“You are a buffoon. But an endearing one. You sure you wouldn’t wish a promenade about the room to give your mind something to do?”

“A promenade with you, my dear Ms Moon, would wake me up and I have no desire to be at anything less than my peak if we are to nip this in the bud on the morrow,” the blonde smiled, “After that… I may indeed whisk you away for a rotation around the room.”

“And on that note, I think we should all retire.

Sleep was slow in coming for Catra - anticipation and nerves gripped at her. And her mind was not just plagued by images of her erstwhile sibling. No, a damnable blonde of goddess-comparable proportions invaded her dreams and insinuated herself into every setting and scene. That tantalising glimpse at the lake and the slight touches and proximity had left Catra a

confused mess as her body sent her signals she felt ill equipped to translate, perceive or handle.

Catra wondered if there might be a book somewhere to aid in her extrapolation of all this.

She managed to rouse herself, haggard and excited, on the morrow, and changed into an austere grey and maroon dress, with a steely bonnet. Adora, it appeared, had a similar idea; her attire was not the normal garb of *Mister* de Gray.

No, Adora had gone for a rather more blended approach - a white dress, with a golden trim, topped with a jacket of a more masculine cut - white again, but with red and gold inlay. Her had was a short top-hat, off-white with a red band around it, matching Catra's own colour, surprisingly.

"Miss de Gray you look…" Catra's words failed her. For her part, Adora blushed and managed a shrug.

"It is past time I approached the world on my terms. This endeavour feels the natural tipping point. The Archers have a hansom cab waiting. Shall we?"

Catra took the proffered arm and the pair left the house. Catra had a short umbrella with her, while Adora had a walking cane - purely for affectation, though Catra did wonder if she was about to observe Hordak on the receiving end of a trouncing.

She wouldn’t object overmuch if he was.

The cab took them through Elberon, past stalls and wide-windowed shops; through bustling markets and busy side roads. Adora had an itinerary, presented the night before, should this attempt be fruitless. It involved a lot of walking and talking. Catra was not enamoured of the idea, but would commit if it came to it.

The University was a hustle and bustle - men and women moving with purpose, scrolls and satchels of books clutched to them, robes a flutter as they dashed across college greens between sandstone buildings. The quartet alighted and the Archers pointed the way to the exhibition hall, while they set off to the administration wing to make enquiries of their own.

Ms de Gray and Ms Moon promenaded past the throngs of milling students, all engrossed in their conversations or studies in the open air. They meandered past the crowds that surged in and out of the glass-domed exhibition hall, beyond the temporary gazebos of the wealthier attendees and the chattering minor nobility.

Inside was a wondrous collection - contraptions ranging from vast, gas filled fabrications that look fit to rise, baskets beneath suspended as if by magic; rotating engines belching smoke and steam; quadrupedal devices that clanked and staggered under some strange power.

The mass of people seemed insurmountable - a wave that could not be easily navigated. Catra felt the first helpings of despair - they would not find the errant pair in such a morass. And if not here, how could they find them in the haystack that was the city?

Of course that is when the shouting broke across the throng. Adora and Catra turned as one, drawn by the exchange - a masculine voice raised in agitation, whilst a more feminine voice argued back with a recognisable cadence.

They pushed through the crowd to a display where a man was attempting to dissuade a diminutive woman from further dismantling his automata - except it was no automata, but rather a cleverly designed puppet - the hollow beneath it had been revealed, showing a rather bemused young man gripping to several cables with a faintly embarrassed expression.

Catra sagged with relief as she noticed how Entrapta was actively explaining to the man how an *actual* automata could, potentially, be created, albeit in theoretical terms.

And standing to one side, eyes wide and body rigid, stood Captain Hordak Wickham. Catra's fists bunched, but Adora's hand on her shoulder stilled her. The taller woman gave her a squeeze, then linked their arms once more. They approached the man and Adora coughed loudly.

"Captain?" her voice dripped with disdainful command. The man stiffened, then turned.

His expression shifted from shock to surprise, to abject confusion.

And then to something unexpected.

Joy .

“Adora?” his voice was filled with surprised wonder. Not the usual coolness and aloof detachment. Adora actually startled at it - a tone she had not heard for so long. A fondness that had been lost after Adam’s disappearance.

Hordak’s gaze flicked to Catra and his smile quirked. Not into a sneer, like she expected, but almost *relief* ? Catra harrumphed, confused, “Captain Wickham.”

“Ms Moon, it is a pleasure to see you. And… Ms de Gray! I was unaware you were also interested in the mechanical arts? I believed this to be a purview of your delightful sister.”

Catra blinked, confused, then looked to Adora, “I am feeling adrift.”

“Likewise,” murmured Adora. She rolled her shoulders and gestured around them, “We received notice that you had eloped, Hordak. After our history I feared you had slipped and…”

“Eloped?” Hordak’s brow furrowed, “With whom?”

Catra and Adora blinked, then both gestured to the animated form of Entrapta. A pair of burly men were carrying her from the stage, where the fraudulent exhibitor was also being escorted off, though in a far less gentle manner. Hordak blinked and nodded slowly. Catra’s frown merely deepened, “So you deny it?”

“Honestly,” Hordak sounded distracted, “I had merely extended an invitation for the Moon family to attend… but I delivered it via Entrapta. I believe that, perhaps… it may not have been conveyed in full.”

Entrapta was gently deposited next to their little group and turned. She blinked owlishly at Catra, then smiled broadly, “CATRA! I have seen so many amazing things! They have balloons! Also, some falsified attempts at automation which I have debunked. Also a workshop! And huh, who are you? You look familiar.”

“Entrapta, dearest…” Catra managed through a jaw that felt locked in place, “You do not look worse for wear, “Are you… why are you here?”

“Because there’s an exhibition?” Entrapta sounded genuinely puzzled, “Why are you here? I mean, the fair seems the most logical choice, but you have never exhibited a fascination with any of my interests prior…”

Catra blinked, "You… have not eloped."

"Elope-ed. Elo. Ped…." Entrapta mulled over the word, "I'm not familiar with the term? I think I heard mother use it once. Oh, wait! Yes! She mentioned it relating to someone who had gone away and wouldn't be returning for a while."

Catra glanced at Adora. For some reason the blonde looked stony faced, her mouth barely twitching. She took a breath.

"So, why does our family think you have eloped?"

"I… may have left a note? Explaining I was going away. I didn't have much time to write it, as we only had a short amount of time."

"Entrapta… I told you a week ago," Hordak sounded as surprised as Catra.

"Oh. AH! Yes. Yes," Entrapta nodded, "I forgot. Too much planning to do. Had to get things arranged," she smiled at Catra and nodded.

"And I asked if the family would be interested…" Hordak managed. Entrapta nodded once more.

"I surmised they would not be. They have a passing tolerance for my habits, I decided that an executive decision would be for the best."

Adora managed to get a word in, "You did… why?"

Entrapta narrowed her eyes at her, "I think I know you. Though I think you had trousers on before."

"Yes, you are quite correct."

"Oh, that's ok then. I was worried my observable data needed updating for new points and individuals. So, yes, I made a decision because, well, it meant I could spend more time with Hordak as well."

That made the other three blink. Hordak sputtered and looked at the other two women, "I… I…"

Adora's mouth twitched again. She looked at Catra, "Ms Moon, I fear we may have jumped to a conclusion. Mr Wickham has not absconded with your sister. It appears your sister has rather done the opposite."

Catra nodded, slightly bewildered, "I am, I have to say, markedly impressed. Also surprised. Disappointed."

“Well, it isn’t as per my predictions have surmised,” mused Entrapta, “Captain Wickham has failed to produce even a single proposal.”

The other three stood, stunned. Surprisingly it was Hordak who broke their mini-silence.

“Would…. Would you care to… elaborate?”

Entrapta nodded brusquely, “HAving analysed the data, our interactions and our shared interests, I note we have at least 53 comparable points of compatibility. A pairing between us would be optimal for future planning. We have shared disinterest in specific physical activities, an affinity for the natural sciences and mechanical intrigue and comparable intellectual pursuits. Our conversations are engaging, enjoyable and I always have a strong desire to continue them after their conclusion, which I find an aberration but also… nice?”

“I see,” said Hordak, “So… you would be amenable to a longer term pairing? I am… a flawed individual, as Adora here can attest.”

“Your imperfections make you a specimen to be admired. Nothing in this world is unblemished and from analysing a fragment, we can extrapolate beauty, can we not?” Entrapta sounded oddly soft now, almost shy. Catra gawped - a strange awareness suffusing her sister, the like of which Catra had never observed before. The

shy, almost detached girl who found emotional attachments almost alien, anathema; and yet, she had latched onto Hordak as a kindred spirit.

But perhaps that was not so surprising, starved as she was of peers of intellect. She socialised with Frosta, but again that was rudimentary. To be challenged, engaged with? They tried, as a family, supported her. But did they know her? Maybe Adora had had a point there, unwitting as it was.

Opposite them, Hordak managed a nod.

"Then… pending the approval of your parents, I would like to extend an offer of marriage to you, Ms Entrapta Moon. And… to you, Ms Adora Gray, I have a favour to beg."

Adora frowned and drummed her fingers on her walking cane, "Indeed, sir?"

"Indeed. I was a flawed friend. I acted in haste and without forethought. I find myself again at the mercy of fate and chance. But with an opportunity to do things correctly, for someone I am immeasurably fond of, but had no true belief I could attain her affections or attention."

"If you had looked at the evidence, I feel it would have been patently obvious," interjected Entrapta. She rocked on her feet and offered a small smile. Catra blew a breath out of her nose, then glanced at Adora, who was staring at Hordak with an expression of curiosity.

"Ask, then, sir."

“Adora de Gray…. Would you do me the honour… of being my best man?”

Chapter End Notes

YEP! Turns out Entrapta is not quite aware... and yet can read the room OCCASIONALLY when she likes something. A logical conclusion. Though not 100%.

Also, as I said... we're making Catra and Adora a TEAM here. In the original novel, Darcy heads of to solve the problem, but Lizzie thinks he's abandoning her as a prospect due to the stigma of the elopement.

Nah. Adora be SOLVING PROBLEMS. Because this problem... means she might have difficulty marrying Catra... not that, y'know, she's assuming anything. But. y'know. KEEP THEM OPTIONS THERE.

As ever, let me know your thoughts. This one feels a bit rushed, maybe? I could have stretched the elopment thing voer another chapter, but I think it'd have felt like filler. SO, I hope you enjoy!

Questions and answers not forthcoming

Chapter Summary

> Bells toll out in celebration, blushes are seen and a question is asked.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Weddings are most peculiar things - a pair of individuals of negotiable intellect make a pact to honour and care for one another in the sight of friends, family and, occasionally, a deity might be involved. Occasionally money, property, livestock or similar are in some way involved with the transaction. Deals are brokered, nations built and lost, families conjoined, by a simple exchange of words and the dirge like playing of an organ.

This was the opinion Catra had held - one of arch superiority. However, exposure to the matrimonial extravagance and joy that swirled about dear Perfuma Lucas and the irrepressible Reverend Scorpia Collins on their particular day had shaken Miss Catra Moon’s particular view on things.

Of course, she also held the belief that weddings were gargantuan affairs - tents and extravagant meals, coupled with garden frivolity and dancin. String quartets and well designed dresses and the pomp and ceremony that seemed to have little to do with the actual emotion of the day. She had perceived it as yet another unnecessary trapping that was demanded of them when they were foisted off to another.

But now, as she was towed down a street by a babbling Entrapta, a mere hour following the rather sudden situational adjustment she had experienced, she felt rather lightheaded and, perhaps, anticipatory.

Following the exuberant exchange, their little quartet had made for an avenue of boutiques. Entrapta, not one given to sartorial extravagance, did feel that there was a proper methodology to encapsulate the theme. Otherwise it was not a *wedding* .

This she espoused in a continuous babble as she dragged Catra over cobbles. Behind the pair, Captain Hordak and Miss Adora de Gray walked briskly, but at a less haphazard pace. The pair were engaged in a quiet, but friendly conversation.

Catra found herself surrounded by myriad blocks and rolls of fabric, the common theme being *lace* . It was all rather fashionable and as such she felt immediately out of place. Entrapta then proceeded to push a bonnet onto her head, which was a size too small.

“These are the fashion, are they not? I think so. Ah, measurements, that’s what we need!” Catra’s errant sister moved like a whippet as she began scouring shelves, much to the consternation of the bewildered tailor who babbled as she set off in pursuit.

Catra tugged at the tight-fitting headwear and grunted in frustration as she pulled it free. She found Adora giggling at her

predicament, her tinkling voice interjected with the odd unladylike snort.

It was saccharine to the core and, of course, sent a bubbling warmth through Catra's very soul.

She blushed, then rallied and stuck her tongue out in response. This seemed the mature thing to do. Adora's giggling just increased and ended with a contented sigh as the taller woman wiped a tear from her eye. Hordak glanced between them and then smiled. It was an oddly soft expression, alien on his features, but also seemingly fitting.

He seemed more relaxed, less austere now. As if a weight had been removed. Indeed, anticipation appeared to thrum through him. Catra, however, frowned.

"Is it not poor form for a groom to see his betrothed in her gown before the event?"

Adora arched an eyebrow and then turned to Hordak. The man looked panicked for a moment then shrugged, "I… this is not precisely something I have practice in!"

Both women exchanged a glance, then arched their eyebrows with perfect synchronicity. Adora's voice was liltingly sweet, "And

yet you have proposed to both of *us* . That would indicate a practiced hand?”

Hordak’s jaw unhinged, then shut with the clack of teeth. He winced, then responded with, “I would posit that I merely managed the preparatory phase and not the practical execution.”

“So, you mean to say you entered into an arrangement without a longer term concept of the endeavor itself?” mused Catra.

“Precisely!” Hordak nodded then paused, with a frown, “Wait…”

“No, no it is perfectly clear,” Adora intoned, voice full of dour seriousness, “It is clear. You are simply bad at this,” she nudged him and the man heaved a sigh.

“I am… not practiced at the romantic arts, no.”

“Well, we are hardly connoisseurs, but we are able to assist the eager object of your affections in some capacity I do not doubt. Now, perchance you should find a tailor to fix… this?” Adora flicked a finger up and down Hordak’s ensemble. He coloured.

“This… this surely..?”

"No. It surely does *not* ," Adora quirked a critical brow, having learned what particular facets of masculine attire were important and which could be discarded, "I would advise tails, perhaps in navy, with purple inlay to match Entrapta. Also, I would advise… jewelery. A matching set of something. Here," Adora fished into her jacket pocket and pulled out a crisp, large note. Hordak's eyes goggled and he flushed.

"A...Adora I could not, not after…" he looked almost ashamed; face a conflict of guilt, happiness and misty emotion.

Adora reached out and thrust the note into his hands, "You can. I will not have Catra's future brother in law marry her sister without looking his best. Look upon this as a gesture of *trust* ."

"I… thank you, Ms de Grey," Hordak took the note and swallowed, then gave a curt nod and slowly walked from the boutique, his destination a shop opposite. Catra huffed and slunk to Adora's side.

"What was that?"

"Oh, just another little test… to see if he would pocket the bank note and make a dash."

"So you would be willing to field Entrapta's disappointment by providing him opportunity? Because I would let her clip you about

the head for a stunt like that," Catra blinked as Adora's eyes met hers.

"I would rather she learn disappointment now than years into a marriage based on falsehood. I protect those I care for Catra. Sometimes that involves accepting their judgement. I think you understand this?"

Catra shifted uncomfortable but relaxed as Adora's hand found hers and gave it a squeeze. She sighed and looked back up into the penetrating stare of the blonde, "A discomforting comment, but a valid one. You are clearly not as ignorant as I took you for…"

"Well I am full of surprises fair and foul I am sure," Adora winked, "Shall we track down your sister before she redesigns the entirety of the seamstresses art?"

"I dread to ponder…" sighed Catra.

The quartet had retired to the Archer's abode, Catra deciding to chance a possibility of hospitality. The gamble was rewarded, with both of the Senior Archers welcoming the four of them back with open arms - they themselves looked a little haggard having been on the case of the missing Moon sister and unaware of the change of circumstances.

Suitably educated on the reality of things, the pair had insisted the engaged couple remain at theirs rather than some tawdry inn. Hordak, for his part, appeared speechless, unused to such flagrant demonstrations of welcome. Catra found it amusing that his pale features could flush to such a deep crimson.

Luckily, for all four of them, the extensive size of the Archer family meant that there were surplus rooms for utilisation. After a sumptuous meal of roasted meats and a rather pleasant wine, all retired to the drawing room for a final confirmation of activities, where Adora revealed she had sent a runner to confirm a suitable venue for the morrow.

Catra, in her usual fashion, had rolled her eyes, "And who will cover the fees? My father isn't even aware!"

Adora simply waved a hand airily, "As I am a woman of independence and means, I shall cover the deposits and… well…"

Hordak blanched, "Ah, yes, I do believe I have failed a step, in that, well, I… I appear to have neglected to guarantee the approval and…." he grit his teeth and his hands bunched into fists on his lap.

Entrapta, who was engrossed with a globe nearby, perked up and frowned, then practically bounded across the room. She paused in front of Hordak and coughed gently. He looked up abruptly and she offered her hands. Jerkily, he placed his into hers and she

began to run her thumbs across his knuckles. Slowly she rocked back and forwards, his movements an echo of hers. She hummed under her breath, eyes moving across his face as he studied her in turn.

Adora and Catra watched, while the Archers smiled softly at one another. A moment later and Hordak let out a slow breath. Entrapta nodded and released his hands, then sat abruptly on the settee next to him and stared at the company, "The problem?"

"Is not a problem," offered Adora, "Catra… will Mr and Mrs Moon… object?"

Catra winced, "I… honestly? Only if she's… unhappy. They might find the order of things rather untoward but…"

"And if I vouch for Captain Hordak?"

Again Catra's expression was more uneasy, "I may have been… a little disparaging about you? A tiny bit?"

Adora's face quirked into an arched expression of hurt, but then slid into a smirk, "Really. I was on your mind then? Bothering you?"

"Hush," Catra tilted her chin up and looked away.

“Well, I must show them I am worthy of their trust and that my word carries meaning. Hopefully Beauregard will stand by me on this. But I feel that, to ensure your family’s reputation is maintained, we ensure this pairing is displayed, to prevent untoward rumours. If they return unwed, then it carries a hint of scandal. Wed, it is then just enthusiasm.”

She looked at the engaged pair and nodded, then glanced at Catra. The brunette caught a glimpse of something in those deep, blue eyes before Adora looked away, face flushed. She pushed an errant worry away, then smiled at Entrapta encouragingly. The other girl blinked as if not quite sure what was going on. She simply shrugged, “So, no problems then?”

“None,” said Catra and Adora simultaneously. Both glanced at one another and blushed.

The gathering broke apart shortly after. On the landing, candles in hand, Catra and Adora paused and regarded one another. For a moment Catra’s mind went back to where this fated encounter had, arguably, begun - an ill timed observation outside a bedchamber. She sighed and shook her head.

They had discussed, briefly, her mistake. Adora had taken it in stride and, of all things, forgiven Catra. That, in itself, was a fantastical thing for her. The depth of compassion Adora possessed, her resilience, was astounding.

“Well. So. Sleep well,“ Adora nodded, eyes fixed at a point above Catra’s head.

“Yes. And you. Also. Yes.”

Adora’s eyebrow quirked, “I promise to not invite Beauregard in. Or his fathers. Lest we set tongues wagging.”

Catra hissed and tried for a glare, but failed in a most dismal fashion. Adora laughed and the tension dissipated somewhat. The brunette sighed, “A good thing NEtossa or Spinnerella are absent. Their tongues would most certainly get wagging.”

For some reason Adora’s eyes went to saucers and she sputtered. Catra frowned, but the blonde waved her off with a wheezed, “I am positive they would be. So, um. This is me.”

It was Catra’s turn to fire a condescending look at the other woman, “Indeed. Spoilt for choice are we not?”

“Indeed.”

“Indeed.”

They milled about on the landing, neither eager to depart. Their indecision was interrupted briefly as Entrapta raced past, headed for her own room with a yelped “NIGHT!”

Hordak traipsed up the stairs, flanked by the Senior Archers who seemed keen to bestow all sorts of fatherly advice as they escorted him to a room at the *other* end of the corridor from Entrapta's room.

AS the trio bade them good night Adora scurried into her room. Catra retreated herself and made ready for sleep.

She found it took a while to come, her thoughts a whirl with a blushing blonde and piercing blue eyes. A warmth in her body that she could not explain nor get to settle. Eventually, splayed, uncomfortable and frustrated, she slipped into a dreamless slumber.

The wedding itself was a rapid affair, inasmuch as Weddings could be. The quartet, accompanied by the Archer parents, found themselves in a small chapel, near to the Archer's home. The priest, a young man with an unfortunate lips, seemed unbothered by the rapidity of things. Perhaps the donation to the church roof fund had aided his expeditious attitude.

Catra had to admit that Hordak looked rather well turned out in his navy coat-tails and purple shirt, the glimpse she had caught as they had made their way to the small chapel (Separately of course). His starched collar and velvet top hat stood stark against his pale complexion, but he was a perfect match for Entrapta - a practical whirlwind of deep purple and greys. Her bonnet barely

contained her rebellious tresses, which appeared to have a mind of their own in the preparation.

The Archers sat apart, one on on either side of the aisle. Catra, of course, stood next to her sister. The other girl seemed wide eyed, almost overwhelmed and Catra leaned carefully into her view to get her attention.

"Are you well?"

"Isn't there meant to be music? My research said mu-" and as if on cue an organ struck up from the rear of the chapel. Entrapta nodded, "Ah, good. It wouldn't have been right without music."

Catra smiled and gently reached out to give Entrapta's shoulder a squeeze. Her sister beamed at her as they watched Hordak make his way up the aisle, escorted by Adora.

Adora who, of course, looked stunning. Her dress was a deep grey with a white top inlay across her bust, with what looked like a waistcoat across it. She wore that same red jacket from up in the North, pressed and ready, topped with a dark grey top hat. Frankly, it was almost galling how good she turned out in such a combination.

Catra's own burgundy attire was not to be mocked, however, inlaid with deeper scarlets and ribbons of near-black. A tad dark

for a wedding, but convention was to be bucked that day it appeared.

She managed to tear her eyes away from Adora as a thought crept into her mind - what would their wedding look like?

She banished the dream, the fancy. After all, she had made it clear to Adora she was not interested and, well, such rejection was impossible to come back from, no matter how much she wished it, surely. Adora had not broached the topic and, indeed, seemed only set to ensure Catra had options in the future, elsewhere.

It was a melancholy contemplation but she steeled herself - she was fortunate to have regained a friend and aided in her rediscovery of herself. And to have atoned for her sins in the running, as well.

The priest attempted to give the proceedings their due decorum, but Entrapta's enthusiastic declarations that interrupted him pushed it ahead. Hordak tried to be more reserved. And yet also failed as he almost bit the priest's head off with an almost shouted "Of course I do!"

Finally, the priest finished with a final, "I now pronounce you… in the eyes of Mara and all the Stars, married."

Catra swore that the church was the dustiest she had ever been in as Hordak twirled ENtrapta back down the aisle, whilst the bells of

the chapel rang out the celebration of the union below. Adora, on the other hand, appeared to have lost her stoic demeanour entirely and was fanning herself as her face went blotchy from the exertion of it all.

"That was… oddly wonderful," mused Catra as she regained control over herself. Adora just nodded rapidly, then, without preamble, looped her arm through Catra's and towed her from the Church. The smaller woman did not object in the least. And hints of a smile on her face would be a slanderous accusation.

The group had decided to spend a little time with the Archers that afternoon, but had agreed that it was probably in their best interests to make haste back to Brightmoon, lest scandal and rumour wash over things in their absence. Entrapta had, perhaps inadvertently, rather let the fox into the henhouse of repute.

The Archers had their staff prepare a light lunch and tea; hardly a reception of grand proportions but it felt strangely fitting for the odd pair, who seemed to eschew any trappings of society. Catra, considering her conversations with Hordak, found that curious and she raised this to him as they sat in the dining room of the Archer household.

"Indeed, I am… chained by my obligations, I fear. The shadow of my family, of… to not put too fine a point on it, the family of Ms de Grey."

Adora inclined her head and grimaced, "Quite so. Duty is… a burdensome thing. Mostly necessary. But Hordak has also… for his

faults… been burdened by obligation.”

“And meagre finances,” the man offered. His tone was resigned and his expression guilty, “It drove… my less considered options in the past. And for that, Ms de Grey I can only… only offer my apologies. I thought you trapped and wasting and not seeing the simple, *logical* and expeditious solution. But I would be lying if there was not an ulterior action in that it would have guaranteed my own future. And that… that is a shame I will live with.”

Adora nodded slowly, “This is true. But you recognise those flaws. What was it you said, Entrapta?”

“Your imperfections make you a specimen to be admired. Nothing in this world is unblemished and from analysing a fragment, we can extrapolate beauty, can we not,” Entrapta parroted, glancing up from her plate briefly. Adora smiled.

“Yes, that. As your wife so eloquently puts it… your acknowledging and facing of your flaws is… to be admired,” she shrugged, “I understand it was also, likely, a plan suggested by my dear aunt, from the kindness of her heart? Framed in such a way that you would be preserving the good name of the family?”

A silence settled as Hordak nodded stiffly. Catra snorted quietly and shook her head whilst the Archer’s exchanged a glance. Lance coughed and gave a grin that appeared lopsided before offering, “Well, she sounds like the height of entertainment and decorum!”

Adora’s laugh echoed across the table and Catra relaxed as the blonde shook her head, “Oh she is simply a delight. The most effusive conversationalist and erudite individual.”

“And so keen on sharing opinions and understanding viewpoints,” mused Catra. Adora, mouth full, nodded vigorously, before swallowing and speaking.

“Quite so. Very much the philanthropist. Or the reverse of one.”

The conversation settled into a comfortable back and forth. The lunch drew to a close and, as the Archer’s servants hauled various belongings and trunks to the pair of waiting coaches outside, the elder couple bade the quartet a fond farewell. They extracted promises to call upon them as well, Hordak seemingly having been taken on as if an errant stray - he nodded rapidly as George took him to one side to offer some sage advice, before he stumbled when the elder man laid a hefty slap against his back to encourage him on his way.

Adora helped Catra aboard the carriage then clambered in. She settled in next to the brunette and then, without preamble, absently drew her closer with an arm across Catra’s shoulder.

They waved to the Archers as the carriage pulled away, following the married couple’s own conveyance. Only then did Adora notice her position. She startled and made to pull away but Catra gripped her wrist and harrumphed. Adora stared down at the other woman, whilst Catra kept her gaze trained on the empty

seats opposite them. A small smile graced Adora's lips and she settled back, Catra nestled, comfortably, against her side.

It was several hours later, while the sun set, that Catra startled awake. She felt warm; safe. Adora had wrapped her other arm across Catra, cocooning her in an embrace. It sent a throb of affection and an almost painful lump into Catra;s throat: embraced, tenderly, by a woman whom she cared for.

That particular thought sparked something and she blinked in surprise, shocked she had not considered it, given the conversations prior.

It also hit at the same moment she felt the wheels of their carriage crackle across the gravel of Brightmoon Manor.

Adora startled awake with bleary eyes and a slightly slackjawed expression. It was, Catra felt, entirely too enamoring. She felt she might combust on the spot. However, she rallied, "Adora."

"Yes?"

"We may not have given thought to this."

"To… what? Entrapdak… Doctor?? Hordak and Entrapta I mean?" the blonde blinked away her drowsiness: she was far more

comfortable riding between her destinations - carriage rides left her bleary eyed and unprepared."

"No I mean… how should I introduce *you* ? The… I mean… I go away for Adam and get… Adora?"

The blonde stared at her then and Catra realised the words she'd spoken - the implication, the revelation and sudden exposure. Yes, Adora had traipsed along and gone with it, but there had been a sort of momentum, carried by circumstance. She stared as Adora swallowed. For a moment, she wondered, would she see *Adam* re-emerge - all stoicism and quite coolness. In a moment of impulse she reached out with a hand and cupped Adora's face, mouth open to speak.

The blonde blinked at the contact, eyes fixed on Catra's gold-and-blue expression. Catra felt weighed, scrutinised and measured in that moment. Adora nodded slowly, cheek brushing against Catra's palm.

"Yes. You get Adora. And we will field questions if they arise," her hand came up and gently held Catra's palm against her face for a moment, "I have spent too long in the shadow of my brother, though it was not his fault. I have felt more free these past days than years prior. So… let us see, shall we?"

Catra swallowed thickly. She had an inkling that she might be a tiny little bit enamoured with this being before her. Perhaps. She felt she needed Entrapta's mindset for a moment, to accurately

weigh and measure her experiences, so new was this feeling, so subtly had it crept up upon her.

The pair practically fell apart as the carriage rattled to a stop and the door was practically torn open. The glittering visage of Glimmer filled the space, eyes wide and almost-furious. She practically exploded with words as she half shrieked, half yelled, "WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN?! You didn't write back and now Entrapta is in a… a… dress and Hordak is there and they have *matching lapel pins* and… oh, um… hi?"

Glimmer stared at Adora. Adora grinned back and cocked an eyebrow, then gestured to the door. Glimmer blinked, then stumbled backwards, which allowed Adora to alight. She turned and offered a hand to Catra, who took it while studiously trying *not* to make eye contact with the blonde.

The rest of the Moon family were gathered by the door to the house, the late-afternoon sun casting long shadows from the hedges along the drive and framing them in the light from the interior of the house. Micah looked half perplexed, half consternated. Angella appeared cautiously optimistic. Mermista looked bored, though she was also firmly attached to a mustachioed gentleman who was staring at her with moon-eyes. Frosta appeared to not be paying attention at all, staring daggers at one of the carriages instead, as if it had personally insulted her.

Hordak was stood next to said carriage, hands folded behind him, back ramrod straight. Entrapta was next to him, all smiles.

It was Mermista who broke the silence, “So, are we…. Accepting of whatever, uh, this is?”

Glimmer, who was staring at Adora with a confused frown, glanced at the family, then at Hordak, then at Adora again, “Uh… well, I would venture to ask, then, what *is* this?”

Adora, raised her top hat and gave a half bow and curtsey to the family and then gestured to the couple, “May I present Mr and Mrs Hordak Wickham, newly of this parish. I wish to apologise in advance, we wished to ensure there was no assumption of untoward behaviours as we had made all due effort to investigate the rumoured elopement.”

“Rumoured!” coughed Micah, “They’re married! Of course they eloped!”

Adora nodded quickly, “Indeed so, Mr Moon, but that was not the intent, so to speak, of Mr Wickham. Rather, I believe it was Ms Moons?”

Entrapta took up the proverbial baton, “Yes. He is an excellent laboratory and workshop partner, excels in understanding the vagaries of our conversation and is also a fascinating object of study,” this last was delivered with what *could* have been a rather intense expression, directed at Hordak, but it could also have been the expression a lepidopterist gives a particularly interesting butterfly they spot in passing.

Angella blinked, “Married? But… what of…”

Adora smoothly interjected, “My apologies, Mrs Moon. I understand this is rather untoward and, well… a little bit out of sorts. But I wished to ensure the preservation of the good name of the Moons and to guarantee the sanctity of any potential or extant engagements that might be tainted by unfair and untrue rumours… so I expedited things a little, just a little!”

The family stared at her, while Adora smiled broadly. She even pointed at Glimmer and *winked* . Catra felt an urge to cover her eyes with her palm for the barest moment.

Micah rallied, “Pray excuse me but… we have not had the pleasure?”

Adora’s smile faltered, but she straightened, “My apologies… um… well, you see you *have* . Ms Adora de Grey, at your service. We have met before,” her voice had risen slightly, her words a little faster, “A ball earlier in the year. And I have called upon the house…”

Angella’s eyes widened but Micah seemed confused, “I… I think I would recall that. Wouldn’t I dear?”

Mermista was now gawping and managed a quiet, “No. Bally. Way.”

Glimmer seemed as slow on the uptake," Adora? OH! So you know *Adam* ? Oh wow, well, Beau will be so happy you're here, he's back at Thaymor, sorting out the purchase and establishment of the house, because, well, we need a house and…"

Adora coughed and her smile was a little forced, "Well… yes I should say I know Adam. Being his sister, but well… I…" she rolled her neck then planted her hands on her hips, "I am also Adam. Sometimes. Until recently," silence fell. Adora wicked and spread her arms, "Surprise?"

Angella snorted and covered her mouth, which was clearly split in a happy smile. Catra took a couple of quick steps and grasped one of Adora's hands, "Well done. Even if that was a little bit… dramatic?"

"Well, I suppose… one way to make an entrance, no?"

Micah glanced between them, Hordak and Entrapta, then back at them. His eyes tracked to their clasped hands and a smile twitched at the corner of his lips. He clapped his hands together and harrumphed with mock bluster, "Well, it takes all sorts to make a world! I believe some explanations are in order! So, brandy, the lime green drawing room and a chance for our lovely staff to unload the boxes while you all take a load off. Come on, inside!"

Glimmer seemed struck dumb as she trailed Catra and Adora inside, followed by Hordak and a beaming Entrapta. The family gathered in said drawing room and began their grand inquisition, albeit gently. Questions, mostly directed at Hordak and Entrapta came thick and fast until the facts had been established. Angella raised a glass to her daughter's particular ingenuity. Mermista applauded. Frosta groused at having lost her playmate.

Glimmer stared, mostly fixated on Adora and Catra, who perched on the same sofa, hands still clasped together.

The questions turned to Adora, who gave a faint potted summary, but steered the conversation towards her desire to ensure the Moon's were not disgraced - unnecessarily it seemed.

"And, of course, I will be assisting Mr Wickham in establishing a presence here."

Hordak jolted, "You… you will?"

"Of course. I doubt you wish to whisk Entrapta from her family. And you need a basis for which to establish a business. You never seemed much for soldiering."

"That is, you know, rather true. Seemed a bit on the stiff side, old boy," came the voice of the fellow with the moustache-most-oiled. Mermista swatted the gentleman and he beamed at the attention she had just lavished upon him.

Hordak seemed taken aback; Angella just studied Adora carefully, "And… why? A dowry is our duty to cover."

"Indeed. But I would not wish Mrs Wickham to be saddled unnecessarily with distraction. I am… fond of this family. This area. I have means to assist - I would be a poor friend if I did not assist, no?"

Angella nodded slowly and smiled, her own gaze following Glimmer's to the clasped hands. Her smile was a smirk, "How… altruistic."

Adora just nodded enthusiastically, "I… well, thank you."

"You can relax, you oaf," Catra nudged Adora, "You are among friends."

Adora turned a soft gaze on her, "Yes… I rather think I am."

Angella and Glimmer both had to bite back a particular urge to make a fond noise - it seemed to do so would have, perhaps, unsettled things. Conversation went on, but Adora eventually rose and said she would endeavor to find lodgings and that she should meet with Beauregard to catch up.

Catra waved her off from the door, that lump of emotion back in her throat as the carriage pulled away, then turned to find the entire family in the hall staring at her.

"W...what?"

Their grins were, frankly, infuriating and entirely too knowing. So, with a frustrated shriek, Catra fled upstairs, masking her own grin with her huffed flouncing, while behind her the Moons did a little jig of excitement. Even Hordak got pulled in, much to his surprise.

In her room, Catra found herself cornered by Glimmer who, with a grin, flopped onto the bed and asked, "So, tell me *everything* ."

And so, Catra did. *Mostly* . She decided perhaps explaining the error that led to all this was something to perhaps be covered at a later juncture. With Adora and Beauregard in the room. And furniture between her and Glimmer. Or a wall.

She flopped onto the bed herself and stared at the ceiling and sighed as she finished. Glimmer glanced at her and Catra met her gaze, "What?"

"SO, what's next?"

Catra bit her lip, "I fear… my rejection may have… tarnished a future happiness there."

“Poppycock. Absolute codswallop. That woman stares at you like…. Like Beau stares at *me* ,” Glimmer blushed, then reached out to clasp Catra’s hand, “And… what’s to stop you asking?”

“What if she says no?” Catra bit her lip.

“And what if she says… yes?”

After Glimmer left for her own room, Catra slid into an exhausted, but hopeful slumber.

That restfulness was not to last, however. The following morning, whilst at breakfast, the family was roused by the clatter of many horses in the driveway. Hordak and Entrapta were absent, having left early to meet with Adora in the village regarding their potential future accommodations, as had been agreed the evening prior.

A grand carriage rolled onto the property, pulled by *eight* black chargers. Scarlet clad footmen alighted and opened the door allowing a spindly and hunched figure, wrapped in a scarlet shawl, to descend.

In the breakfast room, the butler announced the arrival of one:

"Lady Shadow d'Weaver, madame, sir."

The family, en masse withdrew to the drawing room, exchanging confused glances. Catra felt a ball of anxiety bubble up within her, as the family seated themselves and the senior aristocrat was escorted into the room. Despite her frail form, she seemed to occupy all the space available. That is, until Angella stood with a smile and extended a hand.

"Lady d'Weaver. This is a most unexpected surprise. Our thanks for gracing us with your presence. Would you care for a seat?"

The elderly woman surveyed the drawing room as the family all stood, then strode to Angella's seat and sat down. She stared in silence, surveying the gathered company, then fixed her gaze on Catra, "That woman, I suppose, is your mother."

Catra met her gaze unflinchingly, "Yes. Mother, this is Lady Shadow d'Weaver."

"Charmed," managed Angella.

"And that, I suppose is your father?"

“Indeed, madame,” Catra offered back. For some reason she felt a smile creep onto her face. She felt oddly unintimidated by this crone. WHere before she had seemed a presence, a thing of dread, she now knew her to be a scheming thing. Vacant. A thing that had harmed Adora in myriad ways. It made her not fearful but angry.

“And these, your sisters…?”

Angella stepped up, “Yes indeed. My youngest and second youngest. My other, Entrapta, is lately married, whilst Glimmer here is due to…”

“Yes yes. All fascinating for the stock books I’m sure. I note you have a very small garden.”

“It… does us well enough,” Micah interjected, face a near scowl now.

“I am sure it does, as I can see from your disposition and bearing. I am here to speak with Miss Catra Moon on a matter of some urgency and import. Come, child. Walk with me.”

The Moons exchanged confused looks, but Catra merely nodded, “Indeed. Let us.”

The pair walked stiffly out of the door and into the walled garden, adjacent to the house. Mist hung in the early morning air as Lady Shadow d'Weaver stalked ahead, cane tapping harshly against the gravel. She swivelled and levelled a withering glare at Catra.

"You cannot be at a loss as to understand the reason for my journey, Ms Moon?"

"Indeed you are mistaken, madame. I am quite unable to account for the *honour* of seeing you here."

"Miss Moon, you ought to know I am not to be trifled with. And however insincere you are, you will find me not to be. In short, I am here as I have been in receipt of reports that you, Miss Catra Moon, are to be engaged to my *niece* , Miss Adora de Grey. I could not believe this to be so. So, as you can understand, I felt it necessary to undertake this expedition to seek you out."

"If it were so impossible, I wonder you took the trouble of coming so far."

"To hear such a report contradicted, Miss Moon."

"Your coming will surely be such a confirmation, *if* such a report existed."

" *IF?"* Lady d'Weaver's voice was a near shriek, "Miss MOON, do

you then pretend to be *ignorant* of it?" she pulled herself up straight, her form surprisingly more flexible than it initially appeared. She levelled milky green eyes at Catra and glared, whilst with a voice of ice, she asked, "Has my niece made you an offer of marriage?"

Chapter End Notes

AH HA! Not what you were expecting?

I have decided to split the confrontational scene here! So you all get some epic moments and then a cascade of FUN for the final chapter.

We're almost there, folks. I may also add an epilogue as, well, we do have a few loose hanging threads, along with a buff, blonde, elephant in the room whom is still in absentia!

Let me know what you think - this is a rather MEATY chapter with a fair few things covered!

Full circle

Chapter Summary

A confrontation is had, a shadow banished.

An agreement is reached.

An event is held.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stared at the woman, initially perturbed by this unwarranted interrogation. And then she tilted her chin up and quirked an immaculate eyebrow at the aged harridan.

"Niece, your ladyship?"

Lady d'Weaver paused, her jaw suddenly stiff and tight, "One of my kin, have they…"

"Pardon me your ladyship, I must be proper about this, in order to answer your queries to the best of my efforts. It would be *impudent* of me to do otherwise. Do you refer to Lady Adora de Gray, your Ladyship?"

Lady d'Weaver bridled, "My *neice* , Adora de Gray, has… *she* … made an offer of marriage to you?"

"I am under the impression that such a proposition would be anathema to you and of no legal standing in your eyes. Is this not so?"

"Precisely my point! An abominable act in the eyes of all."

"And yet you wish for your own ward to be courted by *Adam* de Gray, I believe? This was touched upon when we spoke last."

"That is indeed the case."

"So a marriage between Mister de Gray and… another is not an abomination?"

Lady d'Weaver paused and straightened. She eyed Catra carefully, her bearing suddenly that of a cobra that realises it may have cornered a mongoose, "This… is not what we were discussing, Miss Moon."

"But what if Adam, I'm sorry, *Mister* de Gray was to propose to another?" Catra's mouth twitched into a smirk, "There are eligible opportunities…"

"I am well aware of the… advantageous upcoming bindings due for… your *elder* sister."

“And Entrapta. Captain Hordak is a fine fellow.”

Lady d’Weaver’s eyes appeared to widen to dinner plates at that, surprise evident for a fleeting moment on her face, “H...Hordak? But… no well, this… your family are clearly mobilising in an unseemly speedy many.”

“But surely it is the duty of daughters to find advantageous matches, as is our role in society?”

This comment caused Lady d’Weaver to recoil and huff, “Miss Moon, I am unaccustomed to such brazen language!”

“And should one of your *kin* have elected to engage me in such a way?” Catra’s smirk was clearly not appealing to the elderly woman before her.

“Miss Moon, this is *not* to be borne! I insist on being satisfied!”

“That is an unlikely state of affairs, unless you clarify your particular query, Lady d’Weaver.”

Once more the elder woman reared, once more her countenance flushed with affronted irritation, “Ms Moon, do you know *who* I am! I ask again, has my Neph… *niece* , made an offer of marriage!”

“You have declared it to be impossible.”

“It ought to be so! But with your… allures and commentary and arts, should my reports be to be believed, you may have drawn her in! Made him… *her* forget what she owes to the family, to *duty* .”

“Well if that were the case, I would be the last person to confess such a thing, surely?” Catra mused, her gaze flitting to the sky above.

“Miss MOON! I am very nearly the closest family that he… *she* …. Has.”

“Or they have? Madame, we are rather covering all of the stumps, are we not?”

“I AM ALMOST VERY NEARLY the closest relation of the de Grays! I am entitled to know their closest business as it affects their interests.”

“But you are not rightly entitled to know *mine* ,” Catra’s voice went from lilting amusement to steely challenge in a single sentence. That brought the elder up short, “And nor will such behaviour encourage me to be more explicit.”

“Let me be rightly *understood* then, Miss Moon,” hissed Lady d’Weaver, “”This match, which you have the *presumption* to aspire to, will not go ahead. Adora de Gray is engaged to *my* ward.”

“Then if that is the case, then you have nothing to fear of her engaging me in such a way, now do you?” Catra’s voice took on a simperingly sweet quality, molasses and confectionary. She studied her nails for a moment, hen smoothed her dress, and gazed curiously at the woman, “Although, speaking with Dee, I was under the impression that they were betrothed to *Mister* de Gray, so surely this impacts your plans little?”

Lady d’Weaver’s eye twitched and her hands flexed, as if she wished to cuff the woman before her. She swallowed, “Their… engagement is of a complicated nature. It was… always intended that a de Gray would belong to the d’Weaver line.” At this, d’Weaver began to pace, making to circle Catra.

“Well you have the pick of two, seems selfish to deny the courts and balls the prospects of both because you are indecisive…”

“How dare you, Miss Moon! You are not… you are not aware of the *facts* . Your… alliance would be a disgrace! Their union was *planned* , mapped! And to be undone by a woman of… no wealth and no connections? A family of no prospects? Is this to be endured? It shall NOT be so! Your *name* would not be mentioned by any of us.”

“That would be a horror to endure, I am sure,” Catra delivered in a deadpan voice.

“Obstinate! Stubborn! Headstrong girl!”

“Do you refer to me or to Adora, your Ladyship? I do need to be clear on these matters as you yourself are clearly not so well versed.”

“How *dare* you! I am not in the habit of brooking disappointment!”

“That is most unfortunate, for it will make your ladyship's situation all the more pitiable, but it will have no effect on *me* .”

“Do not interrupt me, girl! If you were aware of your own GOOD you would not be so eager to quit the layer within which you dwell and...”

Catra continued, unabashed, “Lady d’Weaver, in marrying your niece, which I would see as a *privilege* … or even, perhaps your nephew, for well, they do seem rather *interchangeable* in your eyes…” d’Weaver blanched at that and Catra’s grin became cat-like in its malevolence, “In marrying Adora I should not see myself as *quitting my layer* . She is a gentlewoman, I am a gentlewoman’s daughter, thus far we are *equal* .”

“But what of your *connections* , your family, your aunts and uncles! Your *cousins* !”

"You are rightly familiar with them, your ladyship and thus far do not seem to find them lacking. In *spite* of your predilections and posturing. Whatever their *condition* or *connections* , if your niece… or *nephew* … does not object to them then *neither can you* find fault."

D'Weaver drew herself up once more, bringing Catra to mind the image of a blacksmith's bellows preparing for a might exhalation, "MISS MOON! I entreat you once more, has my niece made you an offer of marriage?"

Catra eyed the woman, pondering how she could string this out further - mayhap cause an unfortunate souring of the heart in this cruel crone. But she realised such thoughts were unworthy and exhaled, "She has not."

Lady d'Weaver deflated and nodded, "That is… good."

"Your nephew asked, of course…"

That got a wondrous reaction of a shriek from the elderly woman. Catra splayed her ands and shrugged, while d'Weaver snapped, "WHAT!"

"A messy affair, it was not accepted," Catra was amused by the sudden crimson on the woman's features as she pivoted from rage to confused relief but also clear bemusement.

“W...you… what? And… can you promise that you will not enter into a...”

“Lady d’Weaver, I must go, and I ask you not to importune me a moment longer. I will make *no such* promises for you have not earned the *right* to demand them of me in my own home. Good *day* madame.”

“Not… not so hasty!” growled d’Weaver as Catra spun and walked away, out of the garden. The crone hobbled behind her, fleeter of foot than Catra had expected. She flinched as a bony hand grasped her about the wrist and spun about, “This… dalliance with Hordak! I know it all! Your sister’s *elopement* it…”

“Lady d’Weaver,” Called a voice from across the driveway, strong and clear and of a tone that set Catra’s pulse to beating with anticipation, “What an… unwarranted shock to see you.”

The pair turned as Adora, clad in a full suit, with a skirt instead of britches, approached, top hat at a jaunty angle, cane cracking on the gravel. Behind her, a white charger was being held by a groomsman, whilst Dee of all people loitered nearby. The strange individual clutched what looked like an envelope in their hands, whilst Adora had one of her own in her grasp. She bee-lined for the stunned pair and smiled a wolfish grin at the elderly d’Weaver.

For her part, the senior aristocrat appeared dumbfounded, agog at this apparition before her. She worked her jaw and managed a hoarse, “Miss… de Gray?”

“Indeed so, Great Aunt. Indeed. I see you are taking in the Moon’s hospitality. A fine family of kindness, understanding and excellent standing in this area, you know?”

D’Weaver blinked then flinched as Adora’s gaze snapped to where she held Catra’s wrist. The elderly woman released her grip as if a hot iron had been pressed to her arm, “Indeed. I had a matter of import to discuss with the… young Miss Moon. But it would appear my concerns were for naught. You are… much changed.”

“Indeed so,” Adora’s voice was clipped, “And I am, oddly, satisfied at your presence. We can now put the past behind us and move forwards with arrangements.”

D’Weaver shot Catra a victorious and smug glance, but then she regarded Adora more closely, “Your attire is… unbecoming of one with your station.”

“As compared with Dee’s? Hardly,” Adora scoffed and waved a hand. Her voice had taken on a tone more akin to when she was *Adam* . A slightly deeper register, a more rigid bearing in her stance. Her gaze was cool, a reminder of when Catra had first met this alluring, intoxicating specimen.

The change clearly unnerved d’Weaver. Catra wondered if perhaps the woman had expected Adora to be a cowering waif; or whether to just see the vision of *Adam* - a mask that she could play off of. But Adora, standing tall? This seemed to throw the severe woman.

It showed in the uncertainty of her voice,the slight adjustment of her shoulders. A woman ill-at-ease in present company, "Now now Adora… where is your *brother* ?"

The attempt at condescension fell flat as Adora simply snorted, "Really? I think we may dispense with frivolity and unnecessary deception. It has been rather a bother for some time. Gets in the way rather," At that, Adora turned her head and offered a small smile at Catra, who could not help but offer a grin of the cockiest variety in return.

"I do believe that to be the case, Miss de Gray," replied the shorter woman. She glanced back at d'Weaver, "And I do believe that Lady d'Weaver is a woman who appreciates directness," Catra was uncertain what Adora had planned. Indeed, she doubted Adora had even been aware of the arrival of the belligerent aristocrat. And yet she seemed somehow prepared. Eager, almost.

"Quite so, Miss Moon. I see you are in the company of the Moons, then, Miss de Gray. I was questioning Miss Moon on the nature of your companionship."

"Oh, Miss Moon has made it quite clear to me where she stands on certain issues," Adora looked sad for a moment, but straightened. Catra's mind flared to her conversation moments ago, the implication of *Adam's* query and a certain clarity kicked its way to the forefront of her mind. An impulse seized her, an urgency she did not know she possessed. In a moment of inappropriate momentum, she grasped Adora's arm, the movement jolting the blonde for a moment, who looked at her quizzically.

“I would like to discuss and reframe certain matters, Miss de Gray, in light of changes in circumstances and context.”

Adora blinked. Her forehead creased in confusion and then, like a sky clearing after a storm, her face split into a smile, “Indeed… well, um… well, shall we… shall we take a walk?”

“That would be agreeable, yes,” Catra smiled and nodded sharply.

“Excuse *me* , we are hardly finished, Miss Moon - you have not yet elected to acquiesce to my demands!”

“And what demands would they be?” Adora’s head snapped to stare at the older woman.

“To… to ensure you are in a position to carry out your duties according to the family,” d’Weaver rallied and adjusted her shawl, “AS your father’s will and adjusted docu-”

“Oh these?” Adora raised the envelope in her hand and offered d’Weaver a brittle smile. D’Weaver blinked and her mouth gaped in a most unlady-like manner, “And whilst I am unsure as to the precise nature of your conversation with Miss Moon, I surmise that its outcome would have very little bearing on any decisions vis-a-vis a nuptial arrangement between Dee and myself. Nor any

planned such arrangements between the house of d'Weaver and Grayskull."

"Wh… but… the arrangement agreed… and Adam organised with… with Hordak…"

"Oh flim flam and frippery!" Adora huffed and smacked the tip of her cane into the gravel, "Dee has been *most* enlightening. I see you, my lady, for what you are. A parasite. A woman with no name who beguiled her way to high office, via marriage. WHo has no power of her own but belies it in others. Who uses shadow play and falsehoods to make her way. There was no such *amended* documentation. No *tradition* or inheritance line. You merely wished to use Adam's absence to shackle me to one of your catspaws."

Catra blinked in surprise, shocked at the sudden bile in Adora's voice. She flinched as the tip of Adora's cane flashed up to point at d'Weaver. She laid a hand on Adora's wrist to try to calm the woman, "...Miss de Gray."

"One moment, Miss Moon," Adora's voice was calm, gentle even, as she glanced to her side. She arched an eyebrow and gave a small wink, then looked back to d'Weaver, "Adam had asked Hordak simply to *protect* me. You twisted that promise with your puppetry. I am *well* aware. I am unafraid. I have felt more alive these past few weeks, living out from the shadow of the fear *you* put in me. Labouring under a misapprehension simply because I *believed* an opinion and did not query it. And I have been open, honest and *true* … and seen no dire consequence for my actions."

"I… you *cannot* ! The estate must be tied to the male line as is *right* ! Insist on your own play-acting if you must but it must…"

"Be to one of *your* choosing? I think not."

D'Weaver snarled, her facade gone suddenly, "Your name will be naught but *shame* and the Northern counties will shun you. You will be a pariah, a mockery! I will see to it!"

Adora laughed. She tipped her head back and let out a breathless cackle. Catra was impressed - it was similar to her own exuberant excess when in full mocking flow. The blonde reached up and wiped a tear from her eye then smiled a broad, toothy smile at d'Weaver, "Then so be it. I shall let it be known that my tenants and labourers are to be relocated to the south. The investments of the Grayskull estates will be retracted and reinvested elsewhere. And I will extend offers and relocation to any and all tenants of *other* estates who wish to enjoy better treatment and rents elsewhere," she gave a broad shrug, "And then the chips may fall as they must."

D'Weaver's snarl had fallen away to be replaced by naked fear, "You wouldn't. That… that would bankrupt…"

"Hardly. But it would rather force the lacklustre gentry of the Northern counties to bother investing, would it not? Rather than relying upon the wise investments and planning laid down by my family. I believe, Lady d'Weaver, that you have miscalculated in a most unwise and gross fashion. You believe you have sway, authority. But your power depends on individuals believing it to be

true. Challenge it, if you must. We shall see who has more resources to bring to bear, more allies to call upon, more *friends* ."

Adora wafted the envelope in her hand. Lady d'Weaver looked as if she wished to snatch it away, but decorum demanded she remain still. Instead she twitched and flexed her jaw, "Is this to be your final decision? To deny Dee, to deny your *duty* ?"

"My duty is to my family. You are *not* my family, if you choose deceit and cajoling. Family stands tall and proud - paying obligation with loyalty. You *demand* obligation but have displayed *no* loyalty, save to your own interests. My *duty* has always been to the Grayskull estate and I have executed it. And I will continue to do so, in a manner I deem fit. For I *am* Grayskull, and I will always fight for its honour. As for Dee… I deny them only one thing, but welcome them otherwise. They have chosen their path," Adora smiled, then glanced at Catra, "Perhaps due to some timely advice a while ago."

Catra recalled her conversation from weeks before. Clearly the avaricious individual supposedly in service to the bitter woman before her had rethought their allegiances. Honestly, she felt a tad overwhelmed by this sudden confrontation, this turnabout. And yet it felt inevitable. Adora had not just cast aside the shadows of her past, she had set a solstice firework to it and let rip.

"You.. I…"

"Lady d'Weaver, you were once a friend to the family. Perhaps with some circumspect assessment and an appraisal of where you

stand on matters you can become one again. I bid you good day madame. Miss Moon?”

Catra smirked, still rather overwhelmed, then took Adora’s proffered arm. They turned to walk away, as d’Weaver cried out, “This will not be an end to it, Adora.”

The pair stopped and Catra turned, a frown on her face, “Lady d’Weaver, your outburst is most unbecoming of a woman of breeding, sounding like a fishwife in the market. Adora has said *good day* to you madame and I, too, wish you a *good day.* A good day I say!”

And with that, the pair marched back towards the house, whilst d‘Weaver floundered. The elder aristocrat huffed, then stalked to her carriage. Dee, standing nearby, offered a jaunty wave, then scampered away from the vehicle towards the Moon’s front door. With a crack of whip and the baying of footmen, the carriage rattled away down the drive.

Within the hallway of the mansion, the Moon family stood, stock still and wide eyed, as Catra and Adora paused at the threshold. Dee stepped carefully around them and gave a half curtsey and a half bow, “Charmed, hello and greetings. *Lovely* place, I must say. A lot more… *homey* .”

Catra stared at the interloper then chuckled, “How… fortuitous your timing is. And yours, Miss de Gray.”

Angella made a small noise to draw their attention; the noise made Adora flush, suddenly aware of the rather rambunctious scene that had just occurred. She inclined her head to the lady of the house, "My apologies, Mrs Moon. May I please introduce… Dee. Of currently no fixed abode, I imagine?"

"Oh, darling, no imagination is necessary. Even though you bring so much to the table… and no need to glower at me Miss Moon. Miss de Gray has made her intentions upon me *per-fect-leee* clear. Now, what does an aspiring savant of the social stage have to do to to be hosted, if I may be so bold?"

"Are you anything but bold?"

"I would hardly be myself otherwise. I apologise, Mrs Moon, I am weary from spending a rather trying time with an overbearing harridan and beg your hospitality."

Angella arched an eyebrow then sighed, rather theatrically, "This way. I feel we have missed a chapter, Miss de Gray, in this story. Would you care to enlighten us?"

Adora nodded, then led Catra, along with the rest of the family, into the drawing room. Suitably ensconced, she smoothed her skirts and removed her hat, which she grasped in her lap, "There is not much else to elaborate upon. I had elected to inform Lady d'Weaver of my… intentions to not be harangued further with regards to her machinations and intentions upon my family's estate. Long have I suspected it was based upon a lie or some trickery, but had not the evidence or surety to combat her; nor was I sure of my standing, of how I would be perceived in society

at large. I have… come to realise my error on that front. Too long had the doubts she spread in the wake of my brother's disappearance impacted my path. Well, no more."

Angella nodded slowly, but Catra interjected, "And Dee… what is in the papers? This seems opportune to say the least."

"Oh this was simple good fortune! I had hoped to convey the documents to *you* my dear, to give you some potential leverage in your own quest!" Dee's grin was positively salacious, "Though I imagine that such leverage is no longer required? Either way, when Adora here cantered up the drive I saw an opportunity. As you so eloquently put it when we last met, better to be on the side of true influence."

"How mercenary of you," muttered Micah with a sigh.

"Oh why *thank* you!" Dee grinned and clapped their hands, "Flattery will get you everywhere, dear sir."

Angella coughed loudly, "Only *so* far…. Dee."

"Just Dee. I am still working on my *nome de plume* - I had pondered on Peekablu, but I understand there is a playwright with that name already… but honestly, I haven't heard from them in months so perhaps it is a possibility."

"Are we, you know, not getting rather off track here?" grumbled Mermista from a chaise, "What's with the papers so handily deposited?"

Dee huffed, “As I have so clearly explained, I saw an opportunity - what better chance to handle intelligence to the foe of my former benefactor? For foe you are… or were. Adora seemed rather keen to expedite things. It’s just deed confirmations, correspondences… a written missive denying any actual alliance or commitment between the d’Weavers and Grayskull. That sort of guff.”

Adora nodded and regarded the envelope she clutched under her hat, “Mostly from… from Adam, it appears. Denying the d’Weavers another source of wealth. Either way she will no longer be an issue. I intend to instruct my lawyers to snarl her in so much litigious string and kerfuffle that she will be forced to acquiesce.”

Dee adjusted themselves in their seat, skirt sliding to one side to reveal pantaloons of all things, “And myself?”

Adora regarded their unlikely ally, “Well, you have availed yourself well and I am in your debt. I do have need of an aide for my Elberon interests, should you feel up to the task?”

“Oh you trust me that much?” Dee crooned.

“Hardly. But I intend to ensure none can bribe you. You are a creature of transactions. And in Elberon, I am sure we can find ample opportunity for you to explore your artistic merits alongside any duties?”

“Oh *glorious* . You picked a winner here, Miss Moon.”

Catra blushed and coughed into her hand, then glanced at Adora, “Are we to… um... “

“Perambulate, meander, um… yes, walk. Walking was on the agenda. Yes,” Adora practically shot up from the settee, like a shot from a musket. Of course, Mister Archer chose that moment to burst in through the door. His arrival drew a small squeal of delight from Glimmer.

“Adora, I espied d’Weaver’s carriage retreating post haste and fear- oh, um… hello?” the young gentleman paused as he surveyed the gathered throng. He winced as the door creaked on its hinges behind him and the butler pointedly stepped up to say:

“Mister Archer, your ladyship.”

Twenty minutes later, Adora and Catra slowly promenaded along a cart track near a copse of trees, not far from the house. Ahead of them, Mister Beauregard Archer and Miss Glimmer Moon strolled, hand in hand, laughing at some private joke. Their air was that of two people very much in love.

Behind them, Hordak and Entrapta strolled, busy investigating the natural world around them - Entrapta taking cuttings of plants or interesting pebbles, while Hordak drifted in her wake, a lazy smile on his face, giving him the air of a dazed farm-hand beguiled by a nymph.

Adora and Catra, however, walked in the silence of apprehension and expectation. They had exchanged small smiles and their hands had brushed as they strolled, only to be pulled back with murmured almost-apologies.

The six of them paused at the copse then turned to regard the view across the fields. Catra turned as Entrapta skipped up, "We are going to the village."

"O-oh.." Catra managed, but Entrapta continued on, unperturbed.

"My observations indicate that you are both attempting a discourse but it appears to have not commenced. I had hoped to observe the courtship in detail, except perhaps that I surmised that *by* observing I was also *influencing* . Thus I will sacrifice my own scientific curiosity to enable your own progression."

The smile she gave Catra was wide, genuine and happy. Then she managed a side hug to her sister and hauled Hordak away, the strangely disbelieving smile still etched upon his features.

“We need to… walk… over there. For reasons,” came Beauregard’s voice, which caused the pair to turn. The man gestured vaguely down the track, “I spotted an interesting… thing which requires our immediate attention and possible… investigation.”

Adora arched an eyebrow, “Do you need a hand?”

“Definitely not. No. Not at all,” Beauregard seemed to be trying to stare Adora down, then glanced meaningfully at Catra, then back to the blonde. Glimmer, for her part, just leaned around her fiance and huffed.

“PLEASE just…” she waved at the pair of them, “agree? Yes? One of you say yes? Thank you. We must be off.”

And with that, the pair practically skipped away, their voices disappearing as they rounded a turn on the track. Adora exhaled and then grinned at Catra, “A most subtle exit?”

“Very much so,” returned the other woman with a smile.

They turned towards the copse and walked slowly towards it. Adora gestured to it and chuckled, “And so full circle.”

“Oh?”

“Our first meeting. There,” she pointed with her stick, to near where a patch of berry bushes stood. Catra gasped and laughed.

“You remember such a trivial thing?”

“It was not trivial for me,” murmured Adora, “Nothing about you is trivial.”

Catra stopped then, her arms folded. She hunched her shoulders then drew a breath, “I… I don’t think I thanked you. Properly,” Adora turned and cocked her head, but waited, “For… the possible elopement. For rushing to save my family’s honour. They, we… we are indebted to you. For enabling Entrapta her happiness, for ensuring a future with your kindness. I wanted to thank you on their behalf. I know they have expressed surprise and joy but perhaps not the depths of gratitude for your intention - the outcome was more than satisfactory, given the truth of the situation. And yet, in spite of it all, you still sallied forth for them, to preserve our honour should the worst have been true.”

“If you wish to thank me, please do so for yourself. I am honoured to have aided your family, I respect them greatly. But I did it for you. To…” Adora swallowed, “To ensure your happiness, that was my first instinct.”

Catra looked up and saw, for some reason, an expression of distress on Adora’s face, “What.. what ails you?”

“Please.. I… I had a grain of hope in my bosom for when you spoke in front of d’Weaver.Perhaps you were simply playing up the part to further unbalance her, for I am still unsure of your dialogue with her. You.. .you are too generous to trifle with me. If.. if your feelings are unchanged from my time as… as Adam, then please tell me so at once. My feelings for you… my affections and wishes are unchanged. But one word from you will silence me on this subject forever.”

Catra swallowed, here gold and blue eyes fixed on the suddenly vulnerable woman in front of her. Stoic Adora, trying to maintain her upright posture, her jaw set as if prepared to receive news of the worst kind.

“My feelings…. Adora…” she stepped forward, a single tentative step, “I am… ashamed of my feelings back then, I can scarcely abide them. Formed as they were from a misunderstanding, a misperception.”

“Of my own making, however,” managed Adora.

Catra hummed a mild assent, “Only insofar as how you presented yourself in public. But… I was drawn nonetheless forwards. No, it was as we discussed in the North… a misunderstanding of what I observed that evening that led me to some terrible conclusions, entirely unfairly. And I very nearly brought a dire conclusion to many based upon my hubris.”

“My behaviour, my words, though.. .they were unpardonable. I can scarce blame you…” Adora looked away and licked her lips, “Your words, earlier, stoked such hope. I imagined that… had Lady

d'Weaver accosted you in the manner I suspect she did, that were your feelings still the same you would have outright stated a rejection. Her agitation implied otherwise. I hope that with such a display there was a possibility of… of…"

Catra took another step forwards, within arms reach now, "Of?"

"Of… us?"

The smaller woman quirked a grin, "Knowing as you do of my brash demeanour and surly countenance, seeing as how I had no scruple in abusing you to your face, I should imagine you believed I have no scruple abusing you to your relatives?"

"Indeed so. Your reproove I shall never forget... *there are no circumstances under which you could have offered your hand in which I would have felt in any way compelled to accept. "*

Catra winced, "To be fair… I was under the impression you were a gentleman. A gentleman propositioning a known *friend of Mara* ."

Adora nodded slowly, and winced, "Yes. upon reflection that was hardly the wisest approach."

Before Adora could continue, Catra interjected rapidly, "And my opinion was soured, most poorly, by Mr Wickham's own poor ideas. Also I believed you an accomplice to the devilish

machinations of Mr Archer and his womanising ways..” Catra winced, “Which were poor views to take. Hasty. Arrogant.”

“And yet your words struck true. Made me question my approaches. My words were not of charm, but of duty, of obligation and *plans* . Not of kindness and truth. Honesty and openness. This… this guided me. *You* guided me once I saw you upon the estate. I knew then i… I could not so easily escape your orbit.”

Cara stepped forward once more and grasped Adora’s hands firmly. The blonde’s cane fell away, forgotten as the pair gazed into one another’s eyes. Catra looked up at this woman, this creature who had suffered loss and stood tall; who had been accosted by avarice and judgement and had stepped out of fear and into hope.

She saw in those blue depths the determination she had recognised in the man known as Adam; the beauty there so confusing to her, now revealed for the truth it was. Duty. Not to a name, or to some dusty relic - to her people, her *family* . Adora took the burden, the potential shame, to help others. And she had taken another risk, another chance for Catra. To be seen, unafraid.

How could she not love this woman? How could she resist any desire? How could she deny it? WHY would she deny it?

“You are a buffoon of the highest order,” Catra smiled up at Adora, then brought the other woman’s hands to her breast, “But then

again, so am I. I said there are no circumstances under which you could have offered your hand in which I would have felt in any way compelled to accept. So what if… I offered mine?"

Catra slowly dropped to a curtsey whilst Adora stared at her, wide eyed, "Catra?"

"Brave, fearless, Adora de Gray. Will you do me the great honour… of becoming my wife?"

The days hence were a cavalcade of visitors and whirling activity. Tears were shed as Netossa and Spinnerella called upon the Moon household to cajole, tease and cry with joy as Catra updated her friends on the activity of the prior days. The pair left, promising several things which left Catra highly confused - apparently, books were involved, along with pictures, except the two women refused to elaborate. Adora had been stone faced the entire time, although she had nearly burst out laughing at one point during the reunion.

Adora, for her part, was staying at Thaymor Manor with Beauregard. Or at least she said she was. In reality, she and Catra were inseparable, both involved in the planning and execution of their planned *double* wedding, whilst also exploring the countryside at a leisurely pace. Their courtship in the North continued, their bond strengthening through shared moments and whispered words. Catra's teasing at Adora's lack of agility andAdora's admonishments of *cheating!* Showed they were a pair

not easily separated. They found ease within one another's company; be it walking a field and trading jibes, or sat in a conservatory, quietly taking in a book between frantic meetings with friends and family.

The family had asked Mermista if she was due an engagement, but the feisty sister had stated she was not, at present, engaged and that any commentary to the contrary was scandalous lies. This report, however, seemed to change by the hour, to the point the family simply ceased enquiring. Which appeared to vex Mermista even further.

There had been a minor moment where Angella had sat with Catra to discuss her certainty on the arrangement. However, it had boiled down to a simple question: "Are *you* happy?" Catra's effusive *Yes* closed the discussion, happily. Adora had gone to confirm their blessing, of course, but had also stated that she felt it was ultimately Catra's decision - she just hoped that the family would support her, *whatever* course she chose.

True to her word, Adora made arrangements for the purchase of a vacant home near to the Moon estate, with sufficient land to construct a workshop of a comfortable size. Entrapta received the deed with a nod and a mumbled appreciation. Adora merely smiled in return, but shook Hordak's hand and asked them to limit any explosive tendencies as the offered insurances would likely not cover an excess, despite her good relations with the bank.

All of it seemed surreal to Catra. Surreal and yet joyous. She could hardly comprehend her emotions. They were only mildly tempered when she decided to confess her sins to Glimmer, and indeed the entire family, over a post dinner brandy one evening.

Suffice to say the diminutive and more sparkling of the Moon sisters was unamused and borderline hysterical for a good hour, but Catra bore the tantrum well and with good grace. Glimmer did not choose violence, nor retribution. She did choose to embrace her sister and muttered a heartfelt *I knew you loved me really* , which caused a reaction of tears and mutual encouragement across the board. Micah, perhaps, was the most emotional in his effusive praise of his daughters.

Angella had just smiled and embraced the pair, with the softest of kisses to their brows. A whispered *I am so proud of you both* .

It also did not hurt that Beauregard stood in defence of Catra. His heartfelt forgiveness and own gentle praise was likely a rather large contributor to the mollification of the sparkling firecracker that was Glimmer Moon. adora, for her own part, had held Catra after the outburst - and such a gentle display further simmered any tempers.

And so it was that Catra found herself standing, bedecked in white, before an altar. She glanced behind her to spy her family, bunched up and smiling. Tears flowed, even from gruff Frosta's surly eyes. Mister Archer's own extensive family were gathered on the other side of the aisle, interspersed with Adora's own family - her staff, her tenants, who had all made the expedition south over the previous days.

Catra exhaled and turned when a hand enveloped hers. She looked up into blue eyes so full of adoration and love it almost

broke her in the best way. To be regarded in such a way, as if she were the sole thing of import in the world.

And, were she honest with herself (Which she was, more often than not) she returned the sentiment tenfold. She could not envisage a future without the woman beside her. Clad in white and blue, Adora was the vision of confidence, poise and command.

"Welcome, one and all, in the sight of the stars, the moon and whatever gentle gods grace us with their gaze today," Scorpia's kind voice cut through the air as the organ music in the temple died away. Behind them, Perfuma removed her hands from the instrument's keys and smiled towards the front of the temple. Catra watched as Scorpia blushed, clearly making eyes at her wife, but the priest rallied and here countenance became *almost* serious, "We are gathered to recognise and celebrate the unions of two wondrous pairings today. In the sight of Mara and her attendants, we are here to bear witness to the bonding of Miss Glimmer Moon and Mister Beauregard Archer; we are here to bear witness to the bonding of Miss Catra Moon and Miss Adora de Gray…"

The service was wonderful - a binding of rope about the wrists and an exchange of paired items - earrings for Glimmer and Beauregard; a wing-like brooch for Catra, affixed to a sash at her waist (Once a belt buckle of Adora's), and an adjusted scarlet bonnet sash that was now twined about Adora's hat.

"And now… in the eyes of all here, the stars above and each other's hearts… I pronounce you man and wife and wife and wife!"

Scorpia practically cheered as soon as she finished, as did the gathered throng who surged to their feet. Catra rather surprised Adora as she pulled the taller girl into a heated kiss, almost dipping her in the intensity. They broke apart, eyes wide. Adora opened her mouth and managed a faint, “Goodness.”

Catra giggled, “Don’t ruin it, silly.”

To the cheers of the crowd and descending confetti and petals, the quartet excited the temple into a cool but bright afternoon. Carriages awaited them, one apiece, and they scrambled up and aboard. At the rear, bags and boxes were loaded, ready for their impending journey home.

Catra clutched at Adora’s hand and stared at her. Adora smiled back and quirked an eyebrow, “Are you ready?”

The other woman took a breath, “For?”

“The rest of our lives?”

Catra pulled the blonde closer, “As long as we remain together… nothing can assail us. So…. yes.”

Adora pressed her forehead to Catra's and smiled. They closed their eyes and basked in the moment. Then the blonde tilted her face to lay a soft kiss on Catra's lips. She turned briefly and rapped on the roof of the carriage, "Home, Kyle!"

Catra curled up against Adora, full of a warmth she had feared she would never experience. But through education and openness she had come to learn about herself and this glorious woman next to her. She had overcome adversity and built an understanding. She was forever grateful to the Telae's, Netossa and Spinnerella, for aiding her in her journey, convincing her to make the expedition that brought her to the North. For in doing so, she had been united with the one person who completed her in ways she had not anticipated.

As she fell into a gentle doze to the rocking of the carriage, she pondered the future and, for the first time, found it one not filled with uncertainty. As Adora's arm curled about her to draw her into a gentle embrace, she saw it with anticipation and eagerness.

Whatever it held, they would face it as one. United, without fear.

Only love.



Chapter End Notes

And so it ends!

Thank you SO MUCH to Tara for producing such a wonderful piece to close out this story. And thank you to ALL of you for joining me on this little indulgence! I truly hope you enjoyed and you feel I have done this justice.

...a separate "educational" epilogue might be planned as Catra learns a thing or two ;) After all, perhaps Finn needs to make an appearance.... somehow.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!